Information

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1: Chapter 1 : Aiden

Beeep…

Beeep…

Beeep…

The rustle of a mattress broke the silence. Someone shifted in their bed while, in the background, the alarm kept blaring its shrill call. Then…

"Aiden! Wake up, you're going to be late again!" someone yelled from downstairs.

"I'm up, Mom!" the young man sighed, his voice still thick with sleep.

He hauled himself up, rubbed his heavy eyes, then shuffled toward the bathroom like a zombie. Passing the half-open bathroom door, a deeper voice called out to him:

"Finally up? I thought I'd have to drag you out of bed myself!"

Aiden pinched his nose and immediately shut the door, grimacing.

"Dad, seriously… every morning? You spend hours in there…"

A muffled laugh echoed behind the wooden panel, followed by: "Hurry up anyway!"

POV Aiden

I came down the stairs, nose buried in my computer science study notes. It was the big day: a crucial exam where I had to have concepts like IP addresses, MAC addresses, and how software like Wireshark worked down cold.

As I sat down at the table, my mom set down a plate of buttered toast. Seeing that I kept studying instead of eating, she gently pulled the papers out of my hands.

"Mom…" I protested.

She shook her head with a warm smile.

"Honey, you need to eat. Studying's important, but you need your strength. Eat."

I let out a resigned sigh and took a bite just as my dad walked into the kitchen. He affectionately ruffled my hair which had taken me ten minutes to style before asking:

"Lily still not up?"

My mom sighed in turn and raised her voice toward the hallway:

"Lily! If you're not down here in two minutes, I'm coming up to drag you out myself!"

"I'm up!" my sister's voice shouted from upstairs. "But where did you put my sweater?!"

My mom went up the stairs, rolling her eyes. My dad and I exchanged a knowing look before going back to our plates, tuning out the usual chaos.

"So, ready?" he asked between bites.

"A little stressed, I'll admit."

He gave me a small smile.

"That's normal. Just remember you can't do worse than we did. Your mom and I both went through it we know exactly how heavy that kind of pressure gets."

A faint smile tugged at my lips. I was studying computer science, but my dad had a degree in architecture and my mom in psychology. Their years of studying hadn't exactly been a walk in the park either.

My mom came back down at that moment and slipped in softly behind him.

"Your dad's right. Just remember he was sweating buckets and stammering like crazy just to hand me a sad little bouquet of flowers on our second date. It was adorable."

"Are you seriously going to bring that up for the rest of my life?" my dad sighed, feigning despair.

She laughed, kissing his cheek before sitting down.

"That's why I married you, isn't it?"

I made a face, watching them lost in their own little bubble, but our moment was interrupted by my little sister's arrival.

"Ugh, seriously, it's like watching some cheesy old romance movie…" she said, plopping down next to me. Without a hint of shame, she swiped the toast I'd just finished buttering, sticking her tongue out at me.

Even if everyday life was chaotic, I loved these moments deeply. That was the warmth of family, wasn't it?

As I finished packing my bag, my dad caught my shoulder and looked at me seriously.

"Aiden. Even if you fail, no one here will hold it against you. Don't go in there like it's the end of the world. An exam can be retaken. What matters is what's in your head. You're not stupid today, you're a champion."

Then he tapped my forehead twice with two fingers, smiling.

I touched the spot, puzzled.

"Seriously, Dad?"

He shrugged, a little amused.

"I watched Naruto with your mom last night. I loved that thing Itachi does, wanted to try it." His face softened, and he added sincerely, "Whatever happens, know that we'll always be proud of you."

Those words… I'll remember them forever.

A few dozen minutes later, I was pacing outside the exam room next to my best friend, Leo.

"I'm exhausted…" Leo grumbled. "My dad slammed my bedroom door shut last night, can you believe it? Me, the great Leo, treated like that…"

"The great Leo who spends all his time daydreaming?" I teased him. "Or the one who stares at girls more than his notes?"

He shrugged with unsettling confidence.

"Not my fault. You know my philosophy: if we're allowed to admire works of art in a museum…"

"…then why not admire beautiful women, who are works of art themselves?" I finished for him with a sigh. "You say that to every girl who talks to you, no wonder they run off."

"They don't run off!" he corrected, feigning offense. "They just have a hard time handling my intense, admiring gaze."

I couldn't help but laugh. Leo was the kind of loyal friend who'd help you hide a body without asking questions, but when it came to girls, he was a natural disaster.

Suddenly, he nudged me with his elbow and nodded toward a group of students a little further off.

"Look… Emma won't stop staring at you."

"Zero subtlety, Leo…" I whispered, gently pushing him away.

I glanced at Emma. She was tucking a strand of hair behind her ear, a shy smile on her face. As we moved toward the door that had just opened, she walked right past me and murmured in my ear:

"Wait for me outside… I know a great café nearby."

She walked off at once, smiling with her friends.

"A real ladies' man, my guy!" Leo said, thrilled, slapping my shoulder.

The hours of the exam dragged by in heavy silence. As soon as we saw the questions, it was clear things were rough: lines of Proxmox configuration, Python scripts, C++ bugs to fix, SQL injection vulnerabilities… Leo was sweating buckets a few tables over from mine.

When I finally got up to turn in my paper, Leo looked at me like an abandoned puppy.

The proctor collected my papers.

"Sign next to your name, please."

I picked up the pen. But just as I touched the tip to the paper, a wave of dizziness hit me with startling force. Sounds grew muffled. The proctor's voice became a distant echo. I

felt something warm and wet trickle under my nose.

Reaching up, my fingers came away red. And without any warning, my legs gave out.

Total darkness.

Beeps. Steady. Cold.

Beep… Beep… Beep…

Sometimes, sobs pierced through the fog of my consciousness. I could make out my mom's blurry silhouette at my bedside, my sister asleep in a chair, and my dad, his face worn with exhaustion. I had no strength left at all. Even opening my mouth felt like an impossible mountain to climb.

POV Leo

My hands were still shaking, stained despite three washes at the hospital sink. Aiden was the only real friend I'd ever had. We'd known each other since middle school. Ironic, really: I was a die-hard gamer, and he couldn't care less about any of it. I'd tried everything to get him into my world, without success.

When he collapsed in that exam room, everything stopped.

All I could do was watch him convulse on the floor, drowning in his own blood. I dropped everything to rush to him, screaming at the others to call for help. I didn't care about the chaos around me, didn't care that my hands were covered in his blood. I didn't even realize I was crying my eyes out.

"Come on, Aiden… You're strong!" I stammered, gripping his hand. "Don't leave me alone, damn it…"

When the paramedics carried him away on a stretcher, I stood frozen on the front steps of the building. I stared at my trembling palms, stained with the blood of the person I considered my own brother.

A brother that… I might never see again.

POV General

In the hospital room, the heart monitor set the pace of the silence. Aiden's mother gently stroked her son's pale face as he lay in a coma. His father held their daughter tightly, holding back his own tears.

The door opened, and the doctor stepped in. The father straightened immediately, his voice breaking.

"Doctor… What's wrong with him? Tell me he's going to make it…"

The doctor lowered his eyes, hesitated, then said heavily:

"I'm so sorry… Aiden has acute leukemia. It's an aggressive blood cancer: his bone marrow is producing abnormal cells uncontrollably, crowding out healthy blood production. His immune system isn't responding anymore, and the risk of internal bleeding is serious… We're doing everything we can, but…"

A cry of pain tore through the room. The girl collapsed into her mother's arms, who broke down crying as well. Standing, the father closed his eyes, crushed by the news.

Only the mechanical rhythm of the machine and the grief of a shattered family remained.

POV Emma

"Did you go see him?"

Leo's text had been sitting on my screen for an hour, unanswered. My fingers couldn't bring themselves to type anything. And yet I was already there, standing at the window, watching that boy lying in his hospital bed, unable to see me. He probably didn't remember, but years ago, he was the one who'd stopped me from doing the unthinkable.

Flashback POV Emma

As a teenager, I'd had severe acne that covered my cheeks in red, painful patches, and I'd had to wear thick glasses after eye surgery. I still remember the nickname a girl in my class gave me the first week of eighth grade a nickname that spread through the whole school in a single day and followed me for two years.

Every recess became a nightmare. One day, someone took a photo of me from behind in the locker room, without my knowing, and passed it around with a cruel caption. I

remember going home that night and spending an hour wringing my hair under scalding water, as if I could wash away something that wasn't even on my skin.

That particular night, it was pouring rain. I'd missed the last bus, and the same girls cornered me at the stop, in front of everyone. One of them grabbed me by the hair, another dumped my bag into a puddle, laughing. I didn't even try to pick up my things. I just walked, soaked, all the way to the bridge overlooking the river a few streets away.

I remember the sound of the water, dark and churning below, and the strange stillness inside me in that moment no more tears, no more anger, just an enormous emptiness. I just wanted it to stop. I put my hand on the cold, rain-soaked railing.

That's exactly when two arms grabbed me around the waist, almost violently, and pulled me back. I remember screaming, struggling, throwing elbows into empty air to get free.

It was Aiden.

He didn't let go right away. He held me against him, on the wet sidewalk, for what felt like an eternity, until my screams turned into sobs.

"Stop lying!" I'd finally screamed that night, trying to break free from his grip, tears burning my cheeks already soaked with rain. "Look at me! I'm ugly, Aiden! Everyone says it, everyone makes me live through it every single day! No one will ever want me!"

He kept holding my shoulders firmly, his eyes locked on mine, without a trace of disgust.

"If it's not just some pity lie…" I'd choked out through a desperate sob. "…prove it. Kiss me. You're not even capable of it…"

I was certain he'd pull back. That he'd look away, like everyone else. But without a second's hesitation, Aiden leaned in and pressed his lips to mine a clumsy kiss, rain-soaked, lasting only a few seconds, but long enough to make me forget, just for a moment, the cold railing and the black water below.

end of Flashback

POV Emma

The phone buzzed again in my hand. A second text from Leo: *"Emma?"*

Thinking back on that memory, I pressed a trembling hand to my lips, on the verge of tears.

"You saved me that day…" I whispered through the glass. "At the café, I wanted to tell you everything. To tell you how much I love you… And now you're going to leave me…"

Slipping quietly into the room while the staff kept the family away, I leaned over Aiden's face and pressed one last kiss to his motionless lips.

"You'll always be my one and only love… We'll see each other again, I'm sure of it."

I stayed bent over him a moment longer, breath shallow, before footsteps in the hallway forced me to pull away and slip out of the room without a sound.

POV Aiden

Somewhere, far, far beneath the surface, something had stirred. A fleeting warmth on my lips, barely there, a memory that wasn't quite my own. Then nothing.

Beep…

Beep…

Tears? Faces? Everything was nothing more than a distant, blurry haze.

I'm so tired… I just want to sleep.

Sleep…

Sle…

(Hey everyone, your author is back! I'm rewriting this fanfic because the previous version had way too many issues, and I was still pretty much a beginner back then. This time, I'm taking it slow and writing purely for fun and passion.)

2: Chapter 2 : The Fight for Survival

(Warning: this chapter contains disturbing content and actions that may be upsetting to some readers)

POV Aiden

Where am I?

I blink and try to sit up, but despite my efforts, I feel extremely weak and can only manage to prop myself against a wall.

My senses come back little by little. First hearing: I hear crying, but not sad crying crying born of despair.

Then comes the smell, a mix of urine, blood, and semen.

Then, finally, sight. What I find in front of me is a cage, in some kind of dark room lit by only a few torches. Looking inside the cage, I see several people curled up, their faces empty of life, and above all painfully thin, as if gnawed by hunger.

But what nearly makes me throw up is the smell of decay coming from the bodies piled up in this same cage where we're being held. There are so many bodies, all different people women, children, men, old and young.

I also feel an overwhelming exhaustion and intense hunger: touching my own body, I realize I'm in a state of extreme starvation myself. I'm nothing but skin and bones.

At that moment, a door opens. I see two guards dragging the corpse of a young naked woman, fluid leaking from her body but it's her face that's the worst part: a face completely emptied of life.

General POV

The men began to speak casually, as if having a normal conversation. "Don't you think the younger ones are better for sex?"

The other man laughed and said, "Not at all. Imagine you want to beat or strangle her a child wouldn't be able to put up a fight. Plus, I'm sure their pussies are too shallow."

The other man opened the cage and tossed the woman's body discarding it like trash onto the pile of corpses, even though she was still alive. He continued, "You have no taste; I really prefer little girls. When they call out for their mom... mmm, I love forcing their mothers to watch."

The other man laughed and said, "You're a monster."

One of the men looked into the cage and spotted a small girl curled up. She looked young, but what stood out most were her ashen hair and her fierce eyes, full of hatred. He walked up to her, slapped her, and pulled her by the hair with contempt "Stop looking at me like that, you royal bitch; if the chief hadn't said you were sold to a rich merchant, I'd have already fucked you in my bed."

The girl spat in his face, shouting: "Bastard!" In response, the man threw her against me, slamming her back into the wall and making her cry out in pain. As he was about to continue, the other man stepped in:

"Stop it if you damage the merchandise, the boss won't be happy."

Then he looked at a young couple, grinned with yellowed teeth, and grabbed the woman by the hair she screamed in despair toward her husband. The husband tried to intervene, but the other man seized him and beat him to death in front of his wife, with extreme violence, smashing him against the bars of the cage until pieces of brain matter flew out. He threw the man's body onto the pile and rejoined the other man as he shut the cage.

"Let's take her together, I feel like unwinding," he said.

Then the two of them left the room, leaving nothing behind but the woman's despairing screams, fading further and further away.

POV Aiden

I'd closed my eyes and was trying to hold back my vomit, even though I had nothing in my stomach only stomach acid would have come up.

Everything I've just witnessed… Am I in hell?

Am I a coward for pretending to make myself small?

As all these self-deprecating thoughts echoed in my head, a pained whimper from the girl beside me pulled me out of my thoughts. In an extremely strained voice, I said:

"Are you okay?"

The girl looked at me, and the first thing that caught my eye was her bright green eyes and her ashen hair falling over her face, damp with sweat and blood from the shock. She tried to smile and said:

"I'm fine, I've had worse. I always sneak out of my castle by climbing, so I've fallen more than once."

She sat down next to me and said weakly, but with a hint of desperation:

"Do you think we're going to make it?"

I couldn't answer. After all, I was still disoriented myself: in my mind, I'd gone from my classroom, in the middle of an exam, to the hospital, and now here, in this warehouse that reeked of corpses and every kind of horrible smell. Ironic, really we were already starting to get used to it.

Seeing that I said nothing, she gave a small, bitter laugh and said weakly:

"I know your answer… I'm scared of dying, you know. But mostly I'm scared I'll never see Grandma's tears again, or Uncle Mousesack's."

Trying maybe to reassure her after all, she must have been about my little sister's age I said, my voice still weak:

"I'm sure your grandmother's already looking for you. After all, like the other man said, you're someone royal, aren't you?"

She nodded weakly, her gaze still fixed on a wall, her head resting against it, and said softly:

"I hope I can believe that… You know, sometimes I wonder if she wouldn't rather I just disappeared."

I shook my head and answered gently:

"I'm sure that's not true. Whatever the family conflicts, anyone would be ready to help family."

She smiled slightly and said, looking at me:

"My name is Cirilla Fiona Elen Riannon, but call me Ciri. I still don't get why I have such a long name…" she said, pouting slightly.

I smiled slightly and said:

"My name is Aiden, I'm…" true, what was I? Was I even alive? Was I in hell? Where was I? Still thinking it over, I finished my sentence with:

"I'm… a traveler?"

She laughed softly:

"Why aren't you even sure what you are? You're weird."

She looked at the pile of bodies and said, in a mix of anger and hatred, but weakly:

"We're the last children. The others were either sold, raped, beaten, or killed in front of their parents' eyes. I can still hear their voices, you know."

I couldn't remember if I'd heard them myself honestly, I didn't even know how I'd ended up here. I said simply:

"My brain must have just wiped that part out to keep me psychologically stable, I guess."

Then, for a while that seemed to exist outside of time, we talked about everything and nothing. Ciri loved galloping on horseback, or secretly practicing swordplay her grandmother refused to let her train, since according to her, a proper princess shouldn't do that kind of thing.

I laughed a little watching her pout as she told me this, and little by little, she rested her head on my shoulder. Despite everything, I gently stroked her hair to comfort her I saw her a bit like my little sister. She said softly:

"If we make it out, what do you want to do?"

I thought about it, but I honestly had no idea myself I didn't even know if I was still in my own world or not. I shook my head and said softly:

"I don't know."

She looked at me, smiling:

"Then you'll be my personal servant!"

I laughed lightly and said kindly:

"So I've been promoted to servant? Should I call you 'Your Highness'?"

She shook her head, laughing:

"Only when Grandma's around, otherwise she'll cut off my dessert. Otherwise, just call me Ciri."

Then she told me all sorts of things, like a little girl dreaming out loud about activities we could do together wandering the capital, training with swords, and so on.

Out of the corner of my eye, I noticed we were the only ones talking like this. Judging by the looks from the few survivors, seeing two children talk seemed to ease their hearts a little. After all, I think a little gentleness is sometimes all it takes, in moments like these.

After a while, as we kept talking about everything and nothing, we heard shouting and the clash of metal. Ciri looked toward the door and jumped up like a child, saying:

"That's Grandma and the guard, I'm sure of it!"

Just as I was about to say something, the two previous guards came running into the room. One of them took an arrow to the knee, crying out in pain, and a woman in armor arrived with two guards. She beheaded him without a moment's hesitation, then went after the other guard, who was fleeing toward the cage.

I was trying to hold back my vomit seeing already-dead bodies and witnessing a death happen right in front of you are two different things. But I didn't have time to dwell on that thought: the guard rushed in and took Ciri hostage, a knife pressed to her throat. He'd dropped his sword behind him, right where I was, since a sword would have put him at a disadvantage while holding a hostage.

General POV

The man shouted: "Back off, or I'm taking her with me!"

Ciri fought back like a lioness: "Let go of me, you bastard, you piece of filth!"

The man struck her to keep her still: "Shut up, you little brat." Then he looked at the woman who had stopped along with her guards and said, desperately:

"Promise to let me go, and I'll let her go!"

Ciri shook her head and screamed: "Grandma! Don't do this, he rapes children!"

Ciri's grandmother looked at the man coldly:

"Let go of Ciri, and I'll promise you a quick death. But I will never let you leave."

One of the grandmother's men began casting a spell, but the man's knife nicked Ciri's throat slightly.

"You bastard, I see you, mage stop that incantation!"

Ciri screamed: "Uncle Mousesack, do it! I can take it!"

With a wave of her hand, the grandmother signaled Mousesack to stop. As she was about to continue negotiating, a figure picked up the sword the man had dropped behind him.

POV Aiden

I saw everything. I wanted to get up and defend her, but I felt my strength was completely gone. What could I do?

Why should I get up?

Why?

What could I possibly do?

Honestly, I think I'm a coward… The girl I'd been talking to, and I didn't even want to defend her. I was scared, that's normal, right?

But…

But when I saw the blood running down Ciri's neck, I don't know…

Everything went blank…

I'd already gotten up with difficulty, without even realizing it. I'd picked up the sword without thinking, and I was already running at the man, the blade pointed at his side. In one motion, thanks to my speed and the element of surprise, I drove the sword into his side. He fell backward onto the pile of bodies, dragging me down with him, and dropped the knife next to me, freeing Ciri.

I picked up the knife, and before the man could even react, I plunged it in again…

Again…

Again…

Blood splattered across my face, my hands, as I sat on that pile of corpses. One of the queen's guards pulled me back, tearing the knife out of my hands, and said urgently:

"Calm down! He's dead, it's over!"

Little by little, I came back to my senses. My body started to shake, and this time I couldn't hold it back: I threw up stomach acid, since there was nothing else in my stomach.

I had killed someone.

The noise around me faded away slowly, just like at the very beginning, when my senses had come back to me one by one in that cage. I stayed sitting there, on that pile of corpses, staring at my own hands. They weren't even shaking anymore, really they were just red, foreign, as if they no longer belonged to my own body. Every time I think about it, I…

Footsteps approached me. I looked up and saw Ciri, still out of breath, a thin line of blood drying along her neck. She stopped dead a few feet away from me.

Her eyes moved over my face, my hands, the blood that was no longer the guard's but truly real on my skin, and for a moment just a moment something froze in her green eyes. She, who had barely trembled with a knife at her throat, suddenly looked just as lost as I did.

Then she threw herself against me, both arms wrapping around me, and I felt her cry against my shoulder, repeating broken thank-yous between sobs.

The grandmother sheathed her sword and approached me with Mousesack.

"Thank you for saving my granddaughter."

I shook my head, wanting to say: "I didn't…"

The grandmother cut me off:

"No need to be modest. You saved her, and judging by the vomit on the ground, I'd guess this was your first time. What do you want?"

I didn't really know. I watched Mousesack directing the guards to help the last survivors, and Ciri answered for me, arms crossed after pulling away from me but her smile, this time, trembled a bit too much to be entirely happy:

"He'll be my personal servant, we promised each other!"

The grandmother froze slightly, sighed probably out of habit and said:

"Ciri, you don't get to choose for…"

I cut her off. I didn't really know why I said it maybe just to have something, anything, to hold onto after what I'd just done:

"I would like to be her servant."

(Hi everyone! First time writing a darker chapter, I hope it turned out okay! Feel free to leave comments, and by request, POVs will now always be shown!)

3: Chapter 3 : A Daily Routine

POV Aiden

A few weeks after Queen Calanthe's escapade at the warehouse where I'd been held with Ciri, my request to become Ciri's servant had been granted a way, at least, to have some kind of anchor in this foreign world.

Because yes, I'd finally accepted that I wasn't really in my own world anymore. After all, watching Mousesack cast spells to make trees grow, or taking in the technology level of this medieval era, I understood more and more that I must have fallen into one of those fantasy worlds you hear about in video games or whatever else.

For now, having taken up my duties as the princess's servant, I'd been taught proper court manners. Ciri openly mocked me whenever I still couldn't manage a proper bow, or didn't know how to eat "the right way."

Justice had eventually been served, though: I'd deliberately left her alone to face her governess, despite her best abandoned-puppy look. She had only herself to blame for mocking me her governess was an elderly woman, and terrifyingly strict, to put it politely.

A few days earlier, I'd also made a particular request to the queen, during an audience.

Flashback

POV Calanthe

I studied the young man kneeling before me in the throne room. Honestly, I wasn't even sure myself yet whether I wanted him at my granddaughter's side. That damned destiny already tying her to that witcher irritates me to no end; I couldn't help thinking it was destiny itself smirking at me again, sending this young man my way.

But even with my doubts, I couldn't let my paranoia about fate alone decide his future. I spoke calmly, seated on my throne:

"I'm listening, Aiden. Mousesack tells me your studies in potion-making, and in general, are going well but he also said you had something to ask me."

Aiden nodded, lifted his gaze slightly, and said respectfully:

"Your Majesty, I would like, if possible, to be trained with a sword."

I studied him in silence for a moment, then simply said:

"Why? You could live your whole life without ever fighting. My granddaughter is already well protected by our guards why would you need protection too, given your position?"

Aiden nodded, but answered sincerely:

"I know that, Your Majesty, and I truly appreciate that Her Highness Ciri gives me so much importance, but…"

I saw him lower his head slightly, then answer in a tone so direct it caught me off guard especially when he raised his eyes to meet mine again. For a moment, he reminded me of my late husband, the day he told me he would defend Cintra against Nilfgaard.

"But I want to be able to fight, to protect what I want to protect, and never again find myself in that state of weakness starving, unable to defend myself. Her Highness is right: if I have to die one day, it's better to die with a sword in hand than to beg my enemies for mercy."

I studied him after those words. Honestly, he kept surprising me. He couldn't have been more than two or three years older than Ciri still just a child. It's in moments like these that I regret we don't live in a world where children's innocence could simply be allowed to last.

I sighed and said:

"Very well. You'll be trained as a soldier, but you'll continue to fulfill your duties as my granddaughter's servant, and continue assisting Mousesack he speaks very highly of you."

End of flashback

POV Aiden

Remembering that, I sighed softly as I finished my potion a mix of ghoul glands and wolfsbane, meant for a wound-healing balm following Mousesack's recipe book laid open beside me.

Then his voice came from behind me, in that teasing, uncle-like tone he often used:

"Brooding like an old man now, are you? Keep that up and you'll grow a beard like mine before your time."

I laughed lightly, finished the potion, and turned to face him:

"No, I'll be fine, Mousesack. I think I'll manage I've still got plenty of years ahead of me, unlike you, right?"

He laughed in turn and examined the potion:

"Teasing me about my age, you little brat? Anyway, your potion's not half bad. You let it simmer a bit too long and the fire wasn't hot enough, but it's not bad at all."

I sighed, a little frustrated, and Mousesack ruffled my hair, saying:

"Stop sighing, you sound like an old man." Then he stepped away for a moment, picked up a sword wrapped in cloth, and came back toward me. "I know you're starting training with the soldiers this afternoon, so I made you a little gift."

I froze, feeling the weight of the sword in my hand a one-handed blade and said, uncertain:

"Mousesack, you didn't have to…"

But he cut me off with a smile:

"Don't thank me, I mean it, it's my pleasure." Then, more softly: "Honestly, I'd have preferred you stay a simple assistant, live a peaceful life at Ciri's side. But we live in dark times, unfortunately, and if this sword and this training can help you survive and protect Ciri, then that will be thanks enough."

I looked at him I knew he meant it and fastened the sword to my waist, saying with conviction:

"I promise to protect Ciri."

He laughed softly:

"That's good, but protect your own life too, all right? There are people who care about you now, Aiden. Goodbyes are easy to say farewells never are."

A few hours later, under pouring rain, I kept working through sword drills alongside the other soldiers, paying no mind to the wind or the downpour. I was entirely focused on the swing of the blade.

My hand ached terribly and I was exhausted after the laps around the field, when Commander Albert shouted:

"Halt, recruits! Real combat drill pick up the blunted swords. Aiden, get over here!"

I froze for a moment I'd only just started training today then nodded and ran to grab a blunted sword before taking my place in front of the commander. He had an imposing build and a scar on his chin; he was from Ard Skellig, an island to the north, and, from what I'd heard, a sworn brother-in-arms of the queen's late husband.

Commander Albert took his stance; I did the same. Without warning, he struck with his sword. I tried to parry, but between the strength of a boy who, just weeks earlier, had been nothing but skin and bones, and the strength I had now, there was no contest: I ended up flat on the ground, the blow landing on my arms, my body driven into the mud. I spat out the dirt that had gotten into my mouth, my body caked in mud, and the commander, unmoved, simply said:

"Get up."

Paying no attention to the other soldiers' stares, or to the queen watching from her study window, alongside Mousesack and Ciri the latter having snuck out to watch me, wanting to intervene, held back just in time by Mousesack.

POV Ciri

Sneaking out through my bedroom window, I landed in the laundry room, eager to see Aiden! We'd soon be able to train together in secret. But when I opened the door, I froze, finding Mousesack there, an amused smile on his face.

"Sneaking out again? The queen won't be pleased."

I pouted:

"I don't care about Grandma! You're not going to stop me from watching Aiden train!"

He shrugged:

"I'm not stopping you I'm coming with you."

Surprised, I'd expected him to force me back to my room for my sewing lesson or whatever else. A little embarrassed, I simply said:

"Then follow me!"

Arriving at the training grounds, I saw the soldiers practicing in the pouring rain, Aiden among them. I pointed at him:

"Mousesack, look!"

He nodded, but his gaze drifted instead toward the other soldiers, and he sighed. I couldn't understand why he was sighing like that. I kept watching Aiden until the drill with the commander began and when I saw him violently thrown to the ground, into the mud, I wanted to rush forward, shouting:

"Let go of..."

But Uncle Mousesack stopped me:

"No, Ciri."

I glared at him, furious:

"But you can clearly see it's a massacre! He just started!"

He shook his head:

"No. Albert isn't like that. But he's seen, same as I have, the looks on the other soldiers' faces."

I didn't understand, and looked at the other soldiers myself all I saw was contempt and jealousy, but I couldn't figure out why. He was just a child, after all…

As if he'd heard my thoughts, Uncle Mousesack went on, his eyes still fixed on the fight as Aiden got back up:

"To become one of the queen's soldiers, you have to go through countless trials and years of experience. And here comes a simple child, asking to be trained, and getting it right away. A lot of them see that as favoritism as unfair."

I looked at him, furious:

"But he saved my life!"

He looked at me gently:

"For many of them, that's not enough. They see it as a child's whim. It's up to Aiden to prove his determination that's exactly what Albert is trying to show the other soldiers. And besides, Ciri trust Aiden. Even if it doesn't always show, that boy isn't simple either."

POV Aiden

I spat blood after the sixth fall, my face pressed into the dirt. I was filthy from head to toe, and the other soldiers' contemptuous stares hurt worse than the blows themselves. As I tried to get up, the commander said coldly:

"Stay down. Soldiering isn't for you, kid."

He was already moving to restart the drill with the others.

I was still lying in the filthy mud, under the pounding rain. And what if it was true?

Was I just a fool for thinking I could be some kind of hero?

I laughed bitterly. *You think you're a hero just because you saved Ciri once?* I looked at the commander and, without quite knowing why, I smiled, then flung a handful of dirt in his face. The whole courtyard froze. The commander stared at me. I got back up, wincing in pain, and said:

"I don't care what you think, you bastard!"

An even heavier silence fell over the yard, the other soldiers frozen like silent spectators. I didn't care. I dragged my sword toward me, picked it up, and said:

"I don't care if you look down on me! I don't care if I have to fall a thousand times! You're right I'm not a soldier. But I will become one. And I'll prove to every last one of you sons of bitches that even a kid can do better than you!"

I sprinted at him, sword ready.

Honestly, I was completely lost in the fight itself, letting pure instinct guide my movements. The commander knocked my sword aside with a powerful strike but that wasn't really my plan. The instant he thought I'd try to parry again, I deliberately let go of my weapon, slid under his guard through the mud, and snatched the knife strapped to his leg on the way.

Once behind him, I lunged, trying to stab him between the shoulder blades. But he spun around sharply and sent me flying with a kick. I still had time to throw the knife, which grazed his cheek and drew blood. Then I felt darkness take me, right as a blow landed on my chest.

POV Albert

Without quite realizing it, I was smiling as I felt the blood trickle under my fingers, along my cheek. A kid had just managed what no soldier in training ever had: made me bleed. I saw the princess dash across the mud, her dress soaked, rushing toward Aiden. Mousesack arrived a moment later and lifted the boy up with a spell, then nodded in my direction with a smile as if to thank me. I understood he'd realized what I'd done.

Honestly, I didn't enjoy handling it that way, but it was necessary. It had also been the queen's request ironically, she wanted him to forget his own heroics from the rescue. After all, arrogance is common enough in the young after they pull off something heroic. But this kid… he had real talent. And that look in his eyes, burning with determination I was going to genuinely enjoy training him.

I turned to the other soldiers, all frozen in place, and said coldly:

"What are you all still standing around for, you bunch of cowards? A kid just outdid you all by making me bleed how does it feel, being outclassed by a child? Back to training, now!"

The soldiers resumed their drills with the blunted swords. I hoped it would at least wake them up, and that they'd remember a child, even a young one, could prove

dangerous. As I sighed, rubbing my back, I froze: my tunic had been sliced open, a thin trickle of blood seeping through.

That kid had managed, in a split second, to drive his knife slightly into my back, despite what was probably a broken arm and even after that, he'd still had the strength to throw it.

Brilliant.

4: Chapter 4 : Prelude to the Harvest Festival

POV Aiden

The years passed without me really noticing, to be honest. I was slowly getting used to this world.

Even though, deep down, I missed my family immensely, and goodbyes have never been easy, I at least hoped their tears had dried by now.

Aside from that, I had grown. When I first arrived in this world, I was barely ten years old yes, ten and over the years of intensive training with the commander, who had clearly taken me under his wing.

Truth be told, I felt like a disciple, and he my mentor. He gradually taught me the art of warfare, and he was the one who made me kill consciously for the first time. Sure, I had killed back when Ciri and I were locked up, but that was more instinctive than deliberate. This time, I had truly taken lives of my own free will: bandits preying on a neighboring village.

When I turned twelve, the Queen gifted me a foal descended from the line of Ciri's mother's horse a beautiful mare with a jet-black coat and a white-braided mane. I still remember the times Ciri wanted to ride her; I believe it was for her ninth birthday, in 1262.

Flashback

POV Aiden

I sighed as I let myself be dragged along by Ciri, who was pulling me by the hand, and said with an amused smile:

"Where's the fire, Ciri?"

She shook her head without slowing down, still tugging me toward the paddocks, and said, brimming with excitement:

"No! You don't understand! It's so rare that Grandmother lets me go riding, and I've always wanted to ride this horse!"

Arriving at the enclosure, she let out a little girlish squeal and stroked my horse's head. I smiled faintly it was in moments like these that you could still see her as a child, despite all her efforts to act grown-up. Whenever Mousesack asked her questions about mathematics or botany, she would pout and give me those puppy-dog eyes, begging me to help her.

But I always looked away. To each their own troubles, right? A bit petty, maybe.

She turned to me with a bright smile:

"By the way, Aidy, what did you name her?"

I walked over and stroked the mare's head, and she rubbed against me like a dog. I smiled at the sight of Ciri pouting, a bit jealous that my horse was showing so much affection toward me, and said:

"Honestly, I don't know yet, but I'll figure it out. And don't be jealous you'll have a horse of your own one day. What would you name yours?" I added, lifting her by the waist to help her mount before climbing up behind her.

I guided the mare out of the paddock, and Ciri said, clinging to me from behind:

"I'm thinking... Swallow? No, wait, I know: Kelpie!"

I smiled as we rode out of the castle grounds, heading toward the open plains:

"Kelpie, like the sea monster?"

She nodded sadly, resting her head against my back:

"It's also to remind me of how Mother and Father vanished at sea. Like they're still right here with me."

I smiled gently:

"Ciri..."

But before I could comfort her, I felt a few tears fall against my back, and she said mournfully:

"Tell me... do you promise we'll always stay together? You're the only one by my side who puts up with my nonsense."

I was about to pull up on the reins to comfort her, but she kept going:

"I know I'm not the perfect model of a princess. I love swords! I love hanging out with the common folk and fighting in the mud! Grandmother hates me, and I'm sure Uncle Mousesack only puts up with me, I..."

I cut her off, lowered her down in front of me, and wiped away her tears with my gloves, saying softly:

"Ciri, I've told you before: Her Majesty doesn't hate you. Do you really think Mousesack merely 'puts up' with you, when he treasures every single moment he spends with you?"

She looked at me, her eyes still wet, stammering:

"But... but..."

I shook my head calmly:

"Ciri, do you truly believe that if Her Majesty hated you, she would have agreed to let me become your servant? That she would have granted your every request? That she would have been so distraught when we were rescued? Need I remind you that she couldn't tear herself away from you the entire trip back while you were crying?"

I brushed a strand of hair from her face and added:

"Ciri, Her Majesty lost her daughter, her husband. All she has left is you, and she is terrified terrified of losing the only thing she has left. She's strict because she knows how wonderful, brilliant, and talented you are. She's made mistakes, true, but everyone makes mistakes. What separates growth from failure is knowing how to pick yourself back up and that's exactly what she did."

Then I chuckled softly and added:

"And Mousesack is a cheerful old man who adores you. He still keeps the little wooden horse you gave him for his birthday in his room, and he has a portrait of you hanging right near where we secretly practice swordsmanship."

I smiled, taking in the vast plain stretched out before us:

"Ciri, this world is cruel and relentless... but it's also fabulous, mysterious, and incredible!"

With that, I shouted, "Giddyup!" and nudged the mare into a full gallop. Ciri scrambled to hold on to me, her tears gradually drying as she gazed at the landscape bathed in moonlight. I laughed as we flew across the plain:

"Ciri, don't go looking for the negative! If you run into it, turn it into a lesson. If someone looks down on you, become stronger, smarter, rise above them and above all, live your life! Never let anyone tell you that you're useless, because if you accept that, you've already lost!"

I kept galloping across the plains, unaware that Ciri was staring at me, bursting into laughter, her tears of sadness transformed into tears of joy.

End of Flashback

POV Aiden

I sighed as I recalled that memory. If it could make her smile, that was enough. I watched the moon cross the sky and quickly drifted off to sleep to avoid waking up late tomorrow. It was the Harvest Festival, a rather special celebration.

But just as I expected to sink into my usual dreams, I found myself standing in a realm swallowed by darkness. As I tried to walk, I realized something was wrong: looking down, I saw that scales had covered my hands, and sharp claws had replaced my fingernails.

Suddenly, a raven with amethyst eyes perched on my shoulder. A cat with a gorgeous, jet-black coat purred, rubbing against my legs. Then, a magnificent swallow with emerald eyes landed on my other shoulder. All at once, the nature of the darkness shifted: a wave of intense cold surged through me, followed by a violent blizzard. I covered my eyes, shielding the animals behind me, without even noticing that wings had already unfurled from my back to shelter the cat and the raven.

The swallow then transformed into a woman whose face was blurred, save for her piercing green eyes. She took my hand and said something I couldn't understand, and together, we stepped forward into the apocalyptic snowstorm.

Suddenly, I snapped awake.

I was breathless, exhausted, my heart hammering against my ribs. I saw Mousesack and Ciri standing in front of me, looking deeply anxious. Before I could say a word, Ciri wrapped her arms around me, her voice trembling with concern:

"You wouldn't wake up! I came in, and there was ice everywhere around you! I ran to get Mousesack to help, and you're finally awake!"

Looking around, I saw that the entire room indeed seemed encased in frost. Without taking the time to offer explanations, Mousesack placed his hand on my head and uttered a few words in the Druidic tongue before speaking:

"Your body is completely fine, and yet even I cannot understand what is happening here. You aren't like a witcher who has awoken... I detect no core of that nature inside you..."

I looked at Mousesack while stroking Ciri's hair to reassure her, and told him what I had seen. His face turned pale, and he said gravely:

"Listen to me carefully: do not repeat this to anyone. I must discuss this with the Queen and my fellow druids." Perhaps trying to lighten the mood, he added: "At least you and Ciri are starting to look alike look at your hair, there are a few white streaks. It's like you're aging right before our eyes."

I gently pulled on a lock of my hair, and he was right: though mostly dark brown, a few white strands had appeared. Perhaps worried about how I'd react, Ciri dried her tears and beamed at me:

"Don't worry, welcome to the white hair club! There aren't many of us, but we stick together!"

I gave a soft laugh and ruffled her hair, making her jump back:

"Stop it! I did my hair for the festival!" Then, realizing she still needed to get ready, she dashed down the corridor: "The governess is going to yell at me again!"

Mousesack and I shared a quiet laugh. He placed a hand on my shoulder and said gently:

"Go enjoy the festival, alright? If anything feels off, like this morning, come see me right away. I'm going to speak with Her Majesty; for now, don't worry about a thing. Your body is doing remarkably well exceptionally well, I'd say. So rest easy, okay?"

He turned to leave, adding over his shoulder:

"Bring me back a souvenir from the festival, will you? A bottle of spirits will do nicely the Queen is going to make me work late again. What tyranny! I'm an old man!"

I chuckled softly and took a deep breath, trying to calm down, though a quiet anxiety still lingered in my chest. I ran a hand through my hair. Had I seen my reflection at that moment, I would have noticed my eyes briefly turn snow-white before returning to their normal color.

Then, I set off to get ready for the festival.

POV Calanthe

I frowned, resting my arms across my desk as I watched the capital city prepare for the festival. In truth, this celebration meant a great deal to me: it reminded me of my late husband. It was during these very festivities that that idiot, covered in blood after fighting off all the other suitors, had asked for my hand. I sighed, still amused by the memory, my heart torn between grief and tenderness. But I had no time to dwell on the past; I turned to Mousesack after what he had just disclosed to me and asked calmly:

"Do you have an explanation?"

Mousesack sighed:

"Honestly, I've never seen anything like it. It's as if Aiden carries something dormant within him a sword not yet drawn, as if he lacks the necessary strength, or something else entirely. I've never encountered a case like his."

But that wasn't what truly mattered to me. I had grown fond of the boy, despite his grand airs. In all honesty, I know this isn't a matter of destiny, and even if it were, I wouldn't care anymore. Ciri is thriving; he is someone trustworthy, sharp enough to discern truth from falsehood, and possesses real military potential, according to Albert. It seems she already excels in strategy without even realizing her own talent with a sword or her clarity of expression. We still have time ahead of us, so what matters most to me is this:

"Mousesack, spare me the detailed explanations. I only want to know one thing: is he in danger?"

Mousesack hesitated:

"Truthfully, I don't think so, based on what I could analyze. In fact, it seems quite the opposite it appears to be immensely beneficial for him. I wouldn't even be surprised if he could wield magic one day. What made me hesitate, in truth, is that the moment I tried to probe deeper, I felt as though something inside him stopped me dead in my tracks—like a sword suddenly pressed against my throat. Had I pushed further... I couldn't tell you what would have happened. But one thing is certain: he is in no danger. Of that, I am sure."

I sighed, spotting Ciri skipping alongside Aiden as they headed toward the festival, and smiled softly. At least she could still enjoy her childhood. I cast a glance at the portrait of my daughter holding Ciri in her arms, then turned back to Mousesack:

"Where do negotiations with Ard Skellig stand? Can they send their warriors against Nilfgaard? According to my scouts, they have no intention of stopping especially now that this new emperor intends to make Nilfgaard the sole ruling power."

Mousesack nodded:

"In memory of your late husband, they will send ships, men, women, and resources for the war."

I breathed a sigh of relief. Those damned Northern kings would love for me to sell off my granddaughter to consolidate their power. In their dreams I'd rather watch them rot, and break the limbs of every single bastard who dares even imagine I would hand over my granddaughter. But I kept those thoughts to myself, sat back in my chair, and said:

"You may be dismissed, Mousesack. If you learn anything more regarding Aiden's condition, report to me at once."

He nodded and took his leave. I turned my gaze toward the window, and without realizing it, began spinning my wedding ring around my finger. Closing my eyes, I whispered a sorrowful sigh, alone in the quiet office:

"I miss you..."

And a grand firework exploded across the sky, illuminating my office just after those words left my lips.

5: Chapter 5 : The Harvest Festival

POV Aiden

I walked through the lit-up streets of the capital, Ciri by my side, but my eyes kept getting pulled toward the fireworks. Way better than back in my world after all, even these fireworks were made of magic.

A huge firework suddenly shot high into the sky, shifting into the shape of a lion that could actually move through the air and pretend to roar, before fading out. Even having seen it a few times already, it was still incredible every time. I felt Ciri's hand squeeze mine, practically vibrating with excitement, and she said:

"Did you see that one? That's supposed to be Grandma! I mean, they do call her the Lioness of Cintra!"

I laughed a little.

"Of course I know that, Ciri. You think all those times I got tortu..." I coughed lightly, "I mean, *educated* by Mousesack, were for nothing?"

She burst out laughing and pulled me toward the music and the traveling performers. The street was already lit up with little fireflies and hanging torches, and stalls stretched out as far as the eye could see but what stood out most was the crowd itself.

There were people of every kind, all mixed together: humans, dwarves, and even among the performers, elves. It was incredible.

Ciri dragged me toward a meat stall and called out to the vendor:

"Ma'am, two skewers, please!"

The woman laughed and handed us the skewers, still steaming hot. I paid with the purse the queen had given me before we left I still remember that whole scene: I wanted to refuse and pay with my own wages, but when she gave me that teasing smirk and said

something about how I dared refuse a gift from Her Majesty, and that she'd just have to ask Mousesack to keep "educating" me further…

Let's just say I ended up accepting.

Ciri ate beside me as we walked through the streets. Even though the area was secured, she still had to keep her hood up, unlike me. I kept Mousesack's sword strapped to my waist regardless, just in case.

Once she'd finished her skewer, Ciri handed me her stick I'd just finished mine and wiped her mouth with her sleeve, which made me sigh, amused: she genuinely had zero table manners, even with napkins literally right there. But I guess that's part of her charm.

Ciri suddenly pointed:

"Look, Aiden! A crossbow shooting contest!"

I smiled and looked over: an elf was aiming his crossbow at a man strapped to a spinning wheel, several targets fixed around it. He started firing at each one, the last target sitting right below the man's crotch the whole crowd held its breath.

I'll admit, moments like that always cracked me up: it's meant to thrill the kids, but everyone knows the shooter always hits the mark. Sure enough, the elf fired and landed it perfectly, and the crowd erupted in cheers.

Even Ciri clapped her hands wildly and said:

"Aidy! Could you do that too?!"

I shook my head, amused.

"Unfortunately, I haven't been trained with a crossbow yet, Ciri. Maybe someday."

She pouted.

"Once you learn, we should tie my governess to the wheel and you can practice on her at least then she'd finally quit with her lessons!"

I laughed, nearly tearing up.

"Ciri, let's not plan a murder. Besides, if Her Majesty finds out about your plan, I promise you'll get banned from sword training."

She froze and muttered something under her breath. I shook my head, amused, and spotted a bit further off a kids' water fight the younger ones perched on the shoulders of older brothers or parents, trying to knock each other into the water. I asked Ciri:

"Want to try?"

Her eyes lit up instantly and she dragged me toward the pool. I had to take off my pants, shoes, and shirt to keep them from getting soaked and honestly, I have to admit, I was in pretty good shape: the commander's daily training and healthier meals had finally paid off.

I stepped into the water and let Ciri climb onto my shoulders, teasing her as I did:

"You're heavy, Ciri."

She smacked the top of my head, feigning offense:

"That's no way to talk to a lady!"

I laughed.

"Aren't you the one who keeps saying you don't want to be a lady? Suddenly it works in your favor?"

She pouted:

"Shut up! It's starting!"

Let's just say the match was pretty one-sided: most of the adults carrying kids struggled to keep up after all, it was mostly meant as a kids' game. And Ciri… Ciri had absolutely zero mercy the moment she spotted an opponent. She used every trick in the book sweeping the other kid's support leg out with her foot to throw them off balance, then shoving hard to send them straight into the water.

I'd completely forgotten how little tact she had.

After hours of wandering and having fun, we made it to the main square, where music was already playing and plenty of people were dancing. Without hesitation, Ciri pulled me into a group dance; I laughed lightly and let myself get carried along by the rhythm beside her.

Strangely enough, several women came up to ask me to dance, much to Ciri's annoyance she'd pout every single time I came back from one of those dances, to the great

amusement of the men standing around.

While we sat drinking fruit juice to catch our breath, Ciri said, frustrated:

"You just keep drawing attention…"

I smiled, amused.

"Ciri, don't forget I'm a knight well, a knight-in-training and I'm obligated to accept when ladies ask."

She poked my chest, pouting.

"Even if that's true, you're *my* apprentice, not theirs."

I laughed warmly.

"Fine, princess. I'm your knight."

To me, it was just a harmless little joke, and I kept watching everyone dance, amused it had been a long time since I'd had this much fun.

POV Ciri

Sometimes I think I must be dreaming… Ever since that night we were locked up together, I've always had this feeling that Aidy and I were meant to stay together especially after that evening in the fields, when he comforted me.

I…

I'm sure he still thinks of me as just a kid, but I'm way more mature than that, or at least I think so.

Grandma's been teaching me politics during my lessons too nobody knows that except Mousesack. Ever since Aidy arrived, Grandma's seemed rushed, almost scared of something. She wants to teach me how to survive, how to tell truth from lies, how to lead and how to fight not to become strong, but to survive.

All this training has cost me a lot of my innocence. I've known that since that night in the warehouse. I saw Grandma crying in front of Mom's portrait, apologizing it broke my heart, and we just stayed there, holding each other while she cried.

Alone with Aidy, I can be completely open, share my dreams. I don't want to be a princess. I don't want to rule, or any of that.

I just want to stay with the people I love and…

I want to stay with h...

I shook my head and smiled at Aiden, keeping my thoughts to myself, and said cheerfully:

"Aidy, it's a promise: there's no way you're leaving without me."

If he knew what I was really thinking, he'd probably assume it was just some childhood crush that would fade with time. But no. So I'll wait.

POV Aiden

Ciri had fallen asleep on my back while I carried her. It was late, and as we walked back toward the castle, I gazed up at the beautiful moon. Sometimes I think about my parents, my loved ones I hope they've been able to grieve.

I'll never forget them, truly never. I'll always love them, somewhere in my heart that real friendship with Leo, that little crush on Emma, that family love I once knew.

I'll never forget you, and to prove it: I'll live this new life fully, because deep down I know that's exactly what you'd want. After all, what's the real difference between staying stuck in grief and just letting yourself die? None both keep you from moving forward.

Arriving at the castle gate, I smiled slightly: the queen was waiting, arms crossed, while Mousesack, leaning against a tree, waved at me with a smile. Standing before the queen, she asked:

"Did she have fun?"

I nodded, smiling.

"Let's just say Ciri showed the whole town that she's a real Lioness of Cintra too."

She nodded, smiled softly, and took Ciri from my arms, brushing a few strands of hair from her face. Then she looked me straight in the eye, suddenly serious:

"Aiden. Make me a promise."

Caught off guard by her tone, I glanced instinctively at Mousesack, who nodded just as gravely. I turned my attention back to the queen and said, seriously:

"What would you like me to promise, Your Majesty?"

She held my gaze in silence for a long moment, then said:

"Promise me you'll obey one single order, without ever questioning it: if I ever command you to leave Cintra without looking back, taking Ciri with you, you will carry it out without asking a single question. That is the only thing I ask of you as your queen, and as her grandmother."

POV Calanthe

I carried Ciri to her room and laid her gently on the bed, stroking her hair with tenderness. Then I heard Mousesack's voice behind me:

"Your Majesty, did you really have to do this? Your death isn't inevitable you could still rally the northern kingdoms, you carry immense prestige."

I didn't answer right away. Not long ago, I still believed everything would be fine, that reinforcements would come. But Mousesack had rushed in, his face grim, to tell me that the Skellige ships sent as reinforcements had been struck by a storm that appeared out of nowhere.

Worst of all, the druids said the storm bore the mark of a sorcerer. So that bastard already knew I'd ask Skellige for help, and he trapped me between him and these power-hungry northern kings. All that's left now is myself, and Cintra.

I gently stroked my granddaughter's face as I sat on the edge of the bed and said calmly:

"You know I can't do that. I've lived here, ruled here, found all my happiness here. As for begging those kings? I'd rather die with a blade in my hand."

Mousesack tried to push back:

"But leaving Aiden and Ciri alone? That's not a sound decision."

I shook my head.

"I know that. That's why you'll stay with them, and…"

I sighed.

"I've sent a dove to Kaer Morhen."

Mousesack froze.

"You called on him?"

I nodded, gazing at my sleeping granddaughter's face.

"Yes. Geralt of Rivia even though I hate that man for this damned destiny tying him to her is right about one thing: he's one of the few people capable of protecting Ciri and Aiden."

I looked out the window and said calmly:

"Cintra will burn, that much is certain. But at least…" I smiled slightly, turning toward Mousesack, "if Cintra must burn along with her last queen, then let her burn as a symbol of courage. And we'll take a good chunk of that bastard's army down with us, so he never forgets that a cornered lioness is still extremely dangerous."

POV Kaer Morhen

Vesemir was finishing up chopping wood when he saw a bird land nearby, carrying a message. He unrolled it, quickly understood what it meant, and turned to Eskel, who was mid-training:

"Eskel, go warn Geralt it's urgent!"

POV ???

I watched my battalions fall into position as the witch I'd hired approached and said calmly:

"Your Majesty, the Skellige reinforcements will never arrive."

I nodded and turned to my general:

"Sound the horns. We march on Cintra."

My dear daughter, I'm coming to claim you. My heir, I thought, watching the sun glint off the black banners flying above my battalions.

6: Chapter 6 : The Prelude to War

POV Aiden

I sighed, looking over the shopping list Ciri had handed me she absolutely needed her favorite sweets from a shop she thought she was hiding from her grandmother, even though I was pretty sure the queen already knew.

It had been a few months since the harvest festival. We were already in 1263, and it was becoming more and more obvious that something was wrong.

Walking through the streets, I'd see soldiers knocking on doors, unrolling a scroll, and announcing out loud that, by order of Queen Calanthe, everyone between the ages of 16 and 50 had to join the army to defend the territory refusal would be treated as treason against one's own country.

You could see families in tears, especially over their sons and husbands, since the vast majority of Cintra's population fell right into that age range.

Why the rush? Mousesack had eventually filled me in on the whole situation.

Flashback

POV Aiden

Arms crossed, leaning against a pillar, I listened closely as Mousesack explained. Once he'd finished, I summed it up:

"So, if I've got this right: Nilfgaard's about to attack Cintra, and these damn northern kings are refusing to help Her Majesty out of pure pride even though Cintra is literally the gateway to the North, the border between North and South. Strategically, it makes more sense to defend Cintra than to open up a whole new front up north, right?"

Mousesack sighed.

"Unfortunately, yes. In exchange for their support, they're demanding, at the very least, that Ciri be betrothed to one of their sons. They don't care whether Cintra gets destroyed or not what they really want is to secure a shot at ruling over it someday. Queen Calanthe carries enormous prestige, both on the isles and up north, and for a lot of them, that's exactly the problem. After all, she once repelled a Nilfgaardian attack, at the cost of her late husband's life which only boosted her reputation further."

He finished coating my sword with oil and added:

"There. I've finished treating your blade this oil's effective against humans, nothing miraculous, but it improves the edge and durability."

I thanked him as I sheathed the sword, then asked, a bit irritated:

"Am I still being too naive, Mousesack? I figured at least the people of the North would matter to the North."

He sighed again.

"Unfortunately, some couldn't care less take Kaedwen, for instance, where oppression against non-humans is already strong, with a cult called the Eternal Fire slowly spreading, calling non-humans abominations of nature. It's still small, but it's starting to make noise. And unfortunately, Queen Calanthe is one of the few rulers who fully accepts every race without distinction which doesn't sit well with everyone."

He pointed to a map of the northern kingdoms and continued:

"Even without direct reinforcements, the Queen of Rivia is lending us some resources, and Temeria's sending men but they're just farmers who've never seen a war. As for Redania… don't even get me started: their king wants Ciri married off to his son, Radovid, a boy who's, frankly, said to be more than a little unstable. Anyway, let's just say Queen Calanthe reminded everyone exactly why they call her the Lioness of Cintra but yeah, we're in quite the ghoul's mess."

I looked at Mousesack, amused.

"Since when does the great Mousesack use such colorful language?"

He smiled, exhausted.

"Since politics started wearing me down. Anyway, Ciri's waiting for you, you should go find her."

End of flashback

POV Aiden

The scenery around me had changed dramatically since the festival. Where food stalls once stood, makeshift war tents now filled the space; the smell of forge smoke hung in the air, and every so often a thick black plume rose into the sky. The walls were slowly bristling with ballistas and heavy crossbows.

Arriving at the shop, I saw the shopkeeper, surprised to see me, offer a faint smile tinged with worry over the state of things and say:

"I take it the little princess wants her candy."

I nodded and handed her the list.

"Yes, same as always."

She laughed softly and put a bit more than needed into the bag. Before I could say anything, she added:

"Don't worry about it honestly, I'm closing up shop."

Surprised, I asked:

"Can I ask why?"

She sighed softly, gazing toward the window.

"My son and my husband have both been drafted, and my daughter's far from here, studying in Redania. I've decided to enlist too, alongside my son and my husband. I love my country, and if I have to die, I'd rather it be next to the people I love."

I asked, uncertain:

"And your daughter?"

She smiled softly.

"I know she'll be sad. But she takes after me she's strong, stubborn. She'll pick herself back up, even stronger than before."

A few minutes later, walking through the castle halls, I kept turning it all over in my head, and I was starting to understand why the queen had asked that promise of me. Was I really going to lose, once again, everything I'd come to know these past few years?

My thoughts were cut off by Ciri's furious shout:

"NO! Don't send him! If you send him, I have to go with him!"

As I got closer, I found Ciri furious, facing off against the queen, the commander, and Mousesack, all gathered around a table covered with a map of the plains. Calanthe answered in a cold tone though anyone who knew her well might have caught a trace of pain underneath it:

"Young lady, don't forget you weren't invited to this war council. Go back to your studies."

Once Ciri got going, there was little that could stop her especially when she was angry. Just as she was about to keep arguing, I held the bag of candy up in front of her face. She spun around sharply, and I smiled softly.

"Ciri, Her Majesty's right. Go back to your studies, it's important. I'll be right there after, I promise."

She hesitated, grabbed the candy, and said:

"You promised, you can't take it back now." Then she stormed out of the room, not without shooting one last dark look at her grandmother.

Calanthe sighed, and a soft laugh slipped out of Mousesack, quickly stifled the moment she glanced at him. She turned to me, calmly.

"Thank you for that, Aiden. Since you're here, I'd like to let you know something. Commander Albert, go ahead."

The commander nodded and looked at me with that trademark grin of his.

"Right. At the queen's request, you'll be joining my unit for observation and training. You'll be taking part in the war alongside the commanders."

I froze for a second, caught somewhere between a flicker of fear and excitement but remembering the horrors of war we'd been taught about, that excitement faded fast. I answered, hesitant:

"Very well, Commander."

He laughed and patted my shoulder.

"Don't worry, nothing's going to happen to you with me around, I promise. Now go find her highness before she thinks we're keeping you all to ourselves."

I nodded and went to find Ciri.

General POV in the war room, after Aiden's departure

The commander sighed and turned to his queen.

"Your Majesty, are you certain about this?"

Calanthe nodded, a faint sadness in her voice.

"Yes. I've entrusted my granddaughter's life to Aiden, and to that witcher but I trust Aiden far more than I trust him. And even if it means putting him through the trauma of war to remind him of the horrors of this world, I'm resigned to it as her queen, and as Ciri's grandmother."

Mousesack, who had stayed quiet until then, spoke up.

"Your Majesty, I'll keep saying it: you don't have to die."

Calanthe was silent for a moment, then answered:

"I know. I know it perfectly well. But… I can't do otherwise. My husband died defending this kingdom. My daughter was born here. My granddaughter was born here. I'm not just fighting for my kingdom I'm fighting so that I can die for it, because it's all that's left of the memories of everything I've loved."

She stroked her wedding ring again, without quite meaning to.

"All the more reason I trust Aiden. I can see it in my granddaughter's eyes the only people who've ever truly been able to calm her down have always been her mother, and now Aiden. He matters enormously to her. And if I have one last act left to give as a grandmother, it will be to save them both."

She turned to the commander.

"The moment defeat looks certain, bring Aiden back here. That's your queen's final order."

The commander nodded solemnly.

"As you command, Your Majesty. I will defend your granddaughter's future, and my disciple's, with my life if it comes to that."

She allowed herself a small smile.

"At least that means Cintra won't be entirely lost. I trust Aiden with Ciri by his side, I'm certain they'll be able to rebuild Cintra and rally our cause."

Mousesack smiled slightly.

"I can tell you think very highly of Aiden."

Calanthe asked:

"Mousesack, do you know the game of royal chess?"

He nodded.

"Yes, it's quite popular in Temeria and Redania. Why do you ask?"

She crossed her arms.

"It's a game created by the first king of the northern realm. It's meant to reveal who has the makings of a king, or a leader. You, for instance how would you win a game of chess?"

Mousesack frowned.

"By building a strategy, and carefully guarding the king to avoid losing him. After all, isn't the whole point of the game to act as the true ruler would?"

Calanthe smiled.

"True, anyone would say that. But do you know what Aiden and Ciri did?"

She let out a small laugh.

"Aiden pushed his king forward alongside his own troops, so that he himself would become the target, while the rest of his pieces handled neutralizing the attacks. Ciri, on the other hand, left her king behind and advanced her pieces together with her queen. Both of them share the same mindset: a leader should fight alongside their troops."

She fell silent for a moment, then concluded:

"Those are two personalities that complement each other perfectly. I don't know what the future holds for Aiden and Ciri, but I know one thing for certain: I will fight to the death for Cintra and my people. And Cintra, my people, will become the sword and shield of Ciri and Aiden, so that they may live, and let their talents shine before the whole world."

POV Aiden

I knocked on Ciri's bedroom door, and a faint voice answered:

"Come in."

Walking in, I couldn't help but smile: a princess's room was supposed to look like a world of dolls and delicate perfume. Here, there was literally a training dummy, a wooden sword, and several stable clothes scattered across the floor it looked more like a soldier's quarters. I walked over to Ciri, sitting by the window, and leaned against the wall beside her, arms crossed, looking out at the view in silence, waiting for her to speak first.

She finally said softly:

"Do you really have to go?"

I kept my eyes on the view, just like her, and answered softly:

"Yes."

She looked at me, sad.

"Why? You know very well that if you said no, Grandma would let it go."

I sighed softly, looking straight into her eyes.

"That's true, Ciri. But how much longer am I supposed to run from reality?"

I glanced at the training dummy and went on:

"Ciri, I know why the queen wants me to go. She wants to confront me with reality show me that, no matter how much I've improved with a sword, no matter everything I've learned in this world, none of it means anything against war. She wants to mark me, maybe even traumatize me. And honestly… I want that too."

Ciri jumped up from the windowsill and planted herself right in front of me.

"Why? Why would you want to be traumatized?!"

I smiled softly and rested my hand on her hair.

"Because I need to learn, Ciri. I need to see those horrors so I can protect you you, and your future."

She shook her head, without pulling away from my hand, and said sadly:

"But I want to be by your side, not be protected."

I smiled softly.

"I know. But for now, let me go first. You'll catch up soon, I know it."

The commander appeared in the doorway.

"Aiden, it's time. Go get ready."

I nodded and stepped out. Just as I was about to tell her I'd be back soon, she shouted:

"Aidy! I'll catch up with you! This is the last time you leave me behind next time, I'll be right there with you, you hear me?!"

I turned back for a moment, meeting her gaze burning with determination despite her tears, then walked away, my back to her, saying:

"Then I can't wait to fight by your side, my princess."

I walked off, leaving her crying behind me as the only sound echoing through the silent hallway.

7: Chapter 7 : The War

POV Aiden

A few hours earlier, the army had marched out toward the plain, at the border of Nazair territory under Nilfgaardian occupation. Another part of our forces had been sent to the Mettina border, in case Nilfgaard decided to open a second front to catch the main army from behind.

Setting up camp had been simple enough: the regular soldiers' tents sat lower down, and the higher you climbed, the closer you got to the high command's tents.

Queen Calanthe, for her part, had stayed back at the castle from what Mousesack had hinted, she was preparing some kind of dramatic gesture, in case things went south.

I was in the command tent area, sitting on a makeshift cot, letting my hand hover over the fire, enjoying the crackle of logs splitting in the flames.

It gave me time to think. Honestly, I didn't even know myself whether I'd survive. From what I knew of the first war between Cintra and Nilfgaard, even the king who fought alongside Cintra's finest soldiers had ended up dead, caught by a surprise cavalry charge. That cavalry had later been wiped out, securing Cintra's victory: despite the enemy's superior gear and horsemen, Cintra's army was simply better on foot. The king's death, against the annihilation of the enemy cavalry.

Was that really a victory? Or a bitter one? After all, it had bought Cintra years of peace but at the cost of the king's life.

I sighed. Honestly, I couldn't say I would have acted any differently I think I too would have chosen to fight alongside my men.

I shook my head, amused at my own thoughts. Seriously, me, leading a battalion someday? Get it together, Aiden.

That's when my tent flap opened. The commander walked in, dressed casually, a bottle and cups in hand. He grinned widely, sat down on a stool, and asked:

"So, how you doing, champ?"

I sighed.

"Honestly, I can't even tell if I'm terrified or excited."

He laughed, set the cups on the small table, downed one in one go before pouring himself another, and said:

"I get it, you know. I'll always remember my first battle it was alongside King Eist Tuirseach."

I turned my cup in my hand, curious.

"I know the king was a great warrior, but I don't know much about him."

He gave a small laugh, gaze fixed on his cup, a wistful look on his face.

"Eist… Eist was an excellent husband, and an excellent warrior, but a poor ruler, let's just say. For him, making a real friend usually meant a good punch to the face that's exactly how he and I became brothers-in-arms."

He let himself get lost in the memory.

"I remember it like it was yesterday. I was still young, full of warrior dreams. Eist was recruiting men from Skellige to help Queen Calanthe plenty mocked him for it, but the moment someone tried, he'd settle it with his fists. Bit by bit, from settling his arguments that way me included we ended up respecting him. Not for some leader's charisma. For that warrior's confidence he carried."

Flashback

POV Commander Albert, aboard the ships heading to Cintra, years earlier, in the middle of a storm

I stormed forward, still furious, my jaw aching from the punch that damned Eist had just landed on me, not caring about the ship's lurching or the foreman's shouts ordering the men to row. I found Eist at the bow, arms crossed, that confident smile still plastered on his face.

His black hair, his brown eyes burning with drive and self-assurance that particular confidence of a man who knows exactly what he's fighting for had always made me a little envious, while also making me proud to follow him. I clapped him on the shoulder.

"Eist! What's got you staring at the horizon like that, there's nothing to see!"

He laughed, a man overflowing with life, and clapped me back on the shoulder.

"Albert, my brother, it's fine that you don't get it. But I'm staring at that exact spot because I know Calanthe's looking in the same direction, right now."

Those words pulled out a question that had been nagging at me for a long time why would a man who could easily have been adored back in Skellige, surrounded by prestige and women, want to throw his life away for the mainlanders and their damned politics?

"Eist, why do you do this? Why sacrifice so much for one woman?"

I must have hit a nerve: his smile vanished, and he turned to look at me, suddenly dead serious.

"Calanthe isn't just some woman. You want to know why?"

He turned his eyes back to the horizon.

"A man's a simple thing, you know. You think people say a man's worst weakness is a woman just for the fun of it? It's because it's true. When a man loves a woman, and she loves him back the same way, that man becomes his woman's weapon. He'd burn the whole world down, if she asked him to."

He burst out laughing.

"Maybe I'm crazy! But I don't give a damn! I'm madly in love with that woman, and I always will be! You don't get it yet, brother, but I promise you, one day, when you find a woman to love, you'll understand just how crazy a man can go for her. Hahaha!"

I laughed with him.

"I highly doubt it."

End of flashback

POV Aiden

He laughed softly.

"And yet, he was right. When we arrived to defend Cintra, I saw, for the first time, a man fight with one single desire: to protect what his woman loved. That's exactly when he'd draw the most people to him being a leader isn't just about charisma and brains."

He looked at me seriously.

"A leader is someone you can trust your life to without a moment's hesitation. A leader is someone who, if he tells you to go kill some guy, you can do it with your eyes closed, because you know he'll protect you in return because you've entrusted him with your life. Trust and loyalty, that's what matters most, Aiden."

I stayed quiet after that story. He patted my shoulder.

"I'll say it again, the way he told me: Eist was right. When I met my wife, when we had an incredible daughter together, I became a man who could kill anything for them. You can't understand it yet. But someday, when you fall in love with a woman or maybe several, who knows you'll understand just how fearsome love can make a man."

Then he got up, ruffling my hair on his way out.

"Aiden, I promise to defend you. You will not die here, not while I'm around. Now drink up, it's dwarven spirits. Sleep well, tomorrow's going to be a rough day."

He left the tent, leaving behind the distant laughter of soldiers trying to ease the mood, mixed with the notes of an instrument and voices singing to soothe the fear hanging in the air.

I sighed he'd given me a lot to think about. But was he right? Would I really become that way, for whoever I might love someday? One thing was certain, in any case: I would protect Ciri.

I downed the spirits in one go, wincing at how bitter it was, set the cup down, and lay down to sleep.

POV Aiden inside the dream

Where am I?

I looked around: it looked like a throne room, but finished with extraordinary craftsmanship, deeply elvish in style. I couldn't move. Turning my eyes toward the throne, I saw a tall, very pale man, clad in armor, handing a goblet to an elf of striking beauty, wearing a crown.

The crowned elf drank from the goblet, then suddenly dropped it, hands flying to his throat. The other elf leaned in close to his ear, and I heard his voice, cold and dripping with malice:

"The king is dead. Long live the king."

The elf king collapsed, dead. Just as a smile began forming on the assassin's lips, he turned his head toward me, as if surprised to see me there, and smiled without stepping any closer.

"So, he didn't give up after all. I thought that bloodline was dead."

He gave a small laugh, picked up the fallen king's crown, snapped it between his fingers, and went on:

"It will be mine. Zireael will be mine. And you, Ceanndraig, there's nothing you can do about it."

Then, as if pulled away, I was suddenly ripped from that place.

POV Aiden

I woke with a start, hand on my chest, breathing hard, drenched in sweat. I tried to make sense of what had just happened that wasn't just a dream. Who was that elf? Who was this "Ceanndraig"? Was he looking at me? And what did that word even mean? And who was "Zireael"? None of it made any sense.

I didn't have time to think it over any further: Commander Albert stepped into the tent and said:

"Come on, Aiden, meeting time get dressed and come." Then he stepped right back out.

I shook my head. If I could have seen my own reflection right then, I'd have noticed my eyes glowing again one white as snow, the other blue as ice before fading back to normal. I got up, gave myself a solid slap across the face, and told myself: "Focus on

the war for now, Aiden. You'll ask Mousesack your questions later." Then I left the tent, without noticing that a few more strands of my hair had turned white, or that a patch of ground around me had frosted over.

Outside, I saw the soldiers forming up into squads, each with their own battalion leader some checking their weapons, others praying. If it gave them any comfort, good for them.

Arriving at the command tent, I found most of the officers already there, including Commander Albert, who nodded.

"Right, now that everyone's here, let's go over the attack plan."

A few hours later, we were on horseback atop a hill, alongside Commander Albert and his trusted men. Nilfgaard's army stretched out across the far end of the plain. He gave a scornful little laugh.

"Look at them, Aiden. Seems like they only know one color."

One of the soldiers snickered.

"Maybe their wives only wear black too. Maybe they piss black too, the way they're always dressed the same!"

The others burst out laughing, and even I couldn't help but smile. But the commander raised his sword surely amplified by some magic artifact, because his voice suddenly boomed far louder than usual:

"Listen up, brave soldiers! Today, we're going to show these men in black just how brave and fearsome the soldiers of Cintra are, same as their queen! You're not just fighting for your country you're fighting for your families, for your children, for the very future of Cintra! So tell me, soldiers: are you going to surrender?!"

A collective roar burst out from thousands of throats: "NO!" "DEATH TO THE NILFGAARDIANS!" Horns sounded from both sides almost at once, and the two armies charged straight at each other. Within just a few minutes, Cintra's edge was already showing, thanks to our turtle formation. Then I spotted a squad of riders swing wide around our lines, heading straight for the commanders. Commander Albert let out one last laugh.

"Come on, let's show these Nilfgaardians the strength of Cintra!"

He charged in without hesitation, his men right behind him, straight toward the enemy cavalry.

My heart pounded hard, caught between stress, fear, and adrenaline. I galloped alongside the rest of the men on the mare the queen had given me. I saw Commander Albert rise up in his saddle, then leap off his horse to slam two men to the ground, killing them instantly.

No time to think: I barely managed to parry a rider's strike that could have killed me. As I kept fighting him, my mare landed a solid kick to the enemy horse's head, throwing it off balance I took the opening to aim for the rider's neck and cut it clean. He dropped, dead on impact. I still couldn't get used to it.

No time to dwell on it either: another fight broke out right away, and for hours all we heard was the clash of blades and the screams of the dying. But we were clearly gaining the upper hand. I fought most of the time near Commander Albert, who fought like a raging bear you'd have called him a berserker.

He came up beside me, drenched in his enemies' blood, a few light wounds visible.

"So, Aiden, having fun?!"

I shook my head, a smile on my lips, cutting down another Nilfgaardian soldier, my own armor just as soaked in blood, sweat running down my neck.

"Commander, I'd honestly rather have a good b..."

I didn't get to finish that sentence about a nice hot bath: something froze everyone in place all at once. Massive fireballs shot up into the sky, and in a dead silence that fell over everyone, those magical projectiles rained down on Cintra's army. Almost immediately, heavy cavalry surged forward and began slaughtering our routed infantry thousands fell within seconds. What snapped me out of my daze was Commander Albert's furious scream:

"Damned mages! Neutrality my ass, yeah right!"

He turned to me, smiled softly, ruffled my hair one last time.

"Forgive me, Aiden. Looks like the queen was right, after all."

I didn't have time to answer: I felt arms hauling me roughly onto my mare, and the commander slapped her rear to send her galloping away, far from the battlefield. He

shouted at two of his men:

"Louis! Eric! Protecting Aiden that's your final order!"

Both men nodded and galloped alongside me. I clenched my jaw to hold back tears as we fled.

POV Commander Albert

I smiled slightly, watching Aiden ride off, even as I frowned seeing two heavy cavalrymen take off after him. Just as I was about to react, I saw the enemy's heavy cavalry bearing down on my own squad. I sighed softly I had to trust the kid. He'd make it.

I smiled, proud. I'd lived a full life. Anna, I'm coming to join you we'll drink with our ancestors. And you too, Eist, we'll see each other again.

Still smiling, I murmured:

"Aiden, you'll make it. You and Ciri I know it you're going to change the course of this world's history."

Then, laughing, I tore off my armor, standing bare-chested, drew both my axes, and shouted to what remained of my men:

"Brothers! Let's meet up for a drink with our ancestors!"

They roared alongside me, and we threw ourselves at the cavalry for one last dance.

POV Aiden

We were in a bad spot. Louis had just been cut down by an arrow dead. The two riders kept chasing us relentlessly. Eric fought as best he could, but an arrow struck him square in the head, killing him instantly.

I kept galloping, dodging the cavalry's arrows as best I could, but I could feel I wasn't going to make it.

Ciri…

I shook my head and yanked hard on the reins, sending my mare skidding sideways through the dirt, catching one of the riders off guard. Thanks to the momentum, I took his head clean off. The last rider, startled, stopped short and nocked an arrow to his bow. In that same instant, I hurled my sword straight at him it pierced clean through his skull. But it was already too late: his arrow had been loosed, and I watched it fly toward me in slow motion.

Dodge.

DODGE.

DODGE, DODGE, DODGE…

Then, all at once, I felt like I'd been teleported, and I crashed violently, mare and all, into the stables of Cintra's royal castle my eyes glowing again, one white as snow, the other blue as ice. Had I… teleported?

But before I could say anything…

8: Chapter 8 : The Flight and the Destruction of Cintra

POV Aiden

I got up, aching all over a landing that rough is never pleasant. Straightening up, I stared at my hands, unsure.

"Did I… teleport?"

My mare's whinny snapped me out of my daze. I walked over to her, stroking her gently.

"It's okay, it's okay, that was just a little surprise, girl."

She nuzzled against me, and I smiled faintly as she got back on her feet. But before I could even catch my breath, I saw a massive fireball sail over the castle and slam into a wall. I understood immediately: Nilfgaard was attacking the capital. But how?

No time to think it over. I shouted urgently:

"Stay here, girl, I'll be back!"

Then I took off running through the castle, searching for the queen and Ciri.

POV Calanthe

I watched through the window as Nilfgaard's army laid siege to my city. My servants, Ciri, and Mousesack stood beside me. Mousesack said, uncertain:

"We still have no word from the army at the Nazair border. Unfortunately, the worst we feared has happened: Nilfgaard threw its main force at the Mettina border, where we'd only left a small garrison. They were wiped out."

I sighed softly it looked like my plan would finally have to be carried out. I looked at Ciri, fists clenched, staring at the burning capital with rage and hatred in her eyes. Even though it pained me to say it, I answered calmly:

"Ciri, keep watching. That, unfortunately, is the face of the defeated, and there's nothing we can do about it."

Ciri cried out, furious:

"But why attack the people?!"

I rested my hand gently on her hair, smiling.

"I know you find it unfair. But the defeated don't get a say."

Then I turned to Mousesack.

"Any news of Aiden?"

He shook his head, sadly.

"None. As I told you, not a single word from the Nazair border. All I can do is pray he's sti..."

"Don't finish that word, Uncle Mousesack!" Ciri shouted. "He's alive, I know it!" She murmured: "I can feel it."

Just as I was about to tell Mousesack to leave, the door burst open: Aiden, still in his armor, covered in blood and sweat.

POV Aiden

I was breathing hard. Seeing Mousesack's relieved smile, Queen Calanthe, and Ciri, I let out a sigh of relief myself. Before I could say a word, Ciri rushed toward me and threw her arms around me.

"I knew it!"

I smiled softly, stroking her hair. Calanthe stepped closer and asked, calm:

"What's the situation at the Nazair border?"

I stayed silent for a moment, fists clenched, then answered:

"We were winning when the main army got hit by spells. The mages have dropped their neutrality."

Mousesack, furious, said:

"I knew those damned sorcerers would be nothing but trouble. I'll need to have a word with the Chapter about this!"

Calanthe raised a hand to calm Mousesack, then looked at me, unnervingly calm.

"Just as I thought. Commander Albert kept his word. Now it's your turn to act, Aiden. Keep your promise."

Those words left me uneasy. Mousesack sighed and started getting ready to leave.

"I'll go grab my things from my tower."

He walked out.

Ciri, still in my arms, asked, not quite understanding yet:

"A promise? What's going on?"

Calanthe looked me straight in the eye.

"Aiden." She sighed softly. "I know this is hard, terribly hard, but… you cannot stop the inevitable."

She walked to the window, gazing at the capital in flames.

"We've lost. Nilfgaard outsmarted us, and our so-called allies did nothing to help. From this day forward, I will be the last queen of the Cintra of 1263."

She turned to me.

"Aiden, I have named you servant to Princess Ciri." I clenched my fists, head bowed. Ciri, beginning to understand, tried to pull free from my arms but I held her. She asked, more and more scared and upset: "What… what's happening? Aiden? Grandma?"

Calanthe acted as if she hadn't heard Ciri's voice, and went on:

"Aiden, from this day forward, I name you Aiden of Cintra, honorary knight of Ciri. And here is your one and only order the only thing I will ever ask of you: protect Ciri. Protect Cintra's future."

Ciri kept struggling to break free from my arms, her tears coming harder as she understood. Calanthe came closer, knelt to our level, and pressed her forehead against mine, then against Ciri's a gesture that froze us both in place. She said softly:

"Forgive me. I wish I could have given you both the future where you'd have grown up together, safe. But I have failed, as a grandmother."

She looked at me with gentleness, while I kept my head bowed, fists clenched:

"You are exceptional, Aiden. You are full of talent, and I know you will become one of the major players in this world. From what little I've learned of your past, you are not a mere commoner, as you believe. There is far too much darkness buried in your history. Find out where you come from I'm certain it will help you enormously. But despite all this, I'm counting on you to keep living, and to protect what matters to you most and my granddaughter."

Then she turned, with tenderness, to Ciri, in tears:

"Ciri, my little lioness. You will always be my most fearless granddaughter, the strongest in spirit. But I love you. Your mother loves you. And we will always be by your side. Know this, my dear granddaughter: you are brilliant, incredible, and above all, gifted always keep being yourself."

Ciri broke down sobbing, repeating, "Grandma, no!" over and over.

Calanthe straightened up and said, in a calm voice:

"Aiden, in the name of your queen, I order you to take the princess and flee this castle. Run, in the name of your promise and of this order."

I gritted my teeth and held Calanthe's gaze.

"I swear it, Your Majesty. I will protect Ciri, and I will find a way to rebuild Cintra alongside her."

Then I pulled Ciri, thrashing hysterically, into my arms. I couldn't hear anything anymore except her sobs and screams, as if my ears had filtered out everything else the whole world had shrunk down to that one sound. Everything else was silence.

POV Calanthe

Watching the two of them ride away, I let a single tear slip, which I wiped away quickly with the back of my hand, murmuring:

"Stay safe, children, and be strong. A goodbye doesn't always have to mean an end."

Then I spotted that servant the one I'd long known to be a Nilfgaardian spy quietly trying to follow the two children. Without a moment's hesitation, I drew my sword and slit his throat. The spy, startled, clutched his neck and collapsed to the floor, dead, as my handmaidens cried out in shock before I calmed them with a single look. I stared coldly at the corpse.

"Thank you for your service, dear spy. Thanks to you, Nilfgaard's army is about to have quite the explosive send-off."

POV Mousesack

As I hurriedly gathered my things to go join the two children, a whistle in the air made me react on pure instinct: I spun around and drove my staff into the ground, summoning a wall of thick thorns that just barely absorbed a bolt of fire meant to burn me to ash. The scorched wood crackled from the heat. I looked up toward the shattered window and saw Vilgefortz, hovering in midair, his own staff still smoking.

"Vilgefortz. So you're the one working with Emhyr?"

He descended slowly, unhurried, a smile on his lips.

"Oh, Mousesack, you really think I'm the only one? No, don't worry. But yes, I am one of those chasing the same goal: the famous Princess Cirilla."

Without waiting for a reply, he swept his staff through the air an invisible blade of wind tore through the room, ripping away part of the wall behind me. I dropped and rolled to dodge it, then struck back with a sharp gesture: the roots of the great oak planted beneath my tower years ago burst through the stone floor and closed around his legs like claws.

Vilgefortz grimaced, caught off guard despite himself, and had to slice through the roots with a blade-sharp spell before they crushed him entirely. A deep gash already ran along his forearm, blood dripping onto the flagstones. I seized that second of distraction to hurl a burst of raw energy straight at his chest it hit him full force, throwing him against the far wall, a pained groan escaping him.

I stared at him coldly.

"So he's still obsessed with his daughter, huh."

Vilgefortz slowly straightened, one hand pressed to his ribs, still smiling despite the pain.

"Honestly, I don't care about that. What interests me is what she carries within her her true bloodline."

I frowned, about to ask what he meant, but he raised his staff one last time, and this time an entire fireball engulfed half the room, forcing me to raise one final wall of interlocking branches to keep from being burned to ash on the spot. The wood ignited instantly, but held just long enough to shield me.

Through the flames, I saw him retreat toward the shattered window, breathing hard, part of his mage's robe scorched black.

"Well, I don't have time for this. I've got a princess to catch. Farewell, Mousesack don't worry, I'll tell the Conclave you died with dignity, killed by some soldier or a doppler, whatever, I'll come up with something."

One last fireball burst from his staff, hurtling straight at me the biggest of the entire fight.

POV Aiden

As I was hoisting Ciri onto my mare, Mousesack's tower exploded in a deafening blast, sending chunks of stone crashing to the ground. Ciri screamed:

"Uncle Mousesack!"

I clenched my teeth, watching flashes of a magical duel in the distance. I wanted to rush over and help, but I felt a magical presence faintly slip into my mind Mousesack's voice echoed in my head:

"Aiden, run! I'll buy you time! You need to get away from the capital, now. Don't worry about me, I'll survive. Let's meet at Kaer Morhen. Go!"

Then the contact cut off. I saw the flashes of magic intensify in the distance, and murmured weakly:

"Don't die, Mousesack."

I climbed onto my mare and shouted "Hyah!", racing out of the capital with Ciri, ignoring the screams, the soldiers, the slaughter all around us. Ciri cried against my back, but I couldn't slow down or look back.

By the time we finally reached the plain, far enough from the burning capital, I slowed down. Ciri stared at the blazing city too, fists clenched, murmuring weakly:

"Grandma… Uncle Mousesack…"

For once, I didn't know how to comfort her I didn't even know how to comfort myself.

But it seemed like even the queen, on her end, had already seen this coming.

POV Calanthe

I sighed, understanding that Mousesack likely wouldn't be able to reach them in time. Through the window, I watched Aiden's horse ride away from the capital with Ciri which made me smile. I murmured:

"Live well, children."

Then I turned to my handmaidens, who had stayed with me until the end, and said calmly:

"Drink the potion."

They nodded sadly and each drank their cup, collapsing to the floor, dead within moments. I walked to the window, threw it open, grabbed a torch, and surveyed Nilfgaard's army, along with its command, gathered before my castle gates. The enemy commander shouted:

"Queen of Cintra! By order of Emperor Emhyr var Emreis, surrender, and Cintra will be spared!"

I smiled faintly and shouted back:

"Is your dear emperor watching this very moment, Commander?"

He frowned.

"His Majesty is indeed watching, from the heights. Don't keep him waiting any longer, Queen Calanthe."

My smile widened further. I turned my gaze toward the distant hills where the emperor stood that bastard and signaled to one of my soldiers to open a hatch leading to the sewers. I held my torch up before everyone, my soldiers kneeling in silence. The enemy commander began to sense something was wrong.

I smiled.

"Then, in honor of our dear emperor, I'll give him an explosive send-off one worthy of a Lioness!"

I let the torch fall into the sewers. A trail of flame spread instantly, like a fuse racing through the whole underground network. The vast army massed in the capital had no idea what was happening but the commander understood. He tried to order a retreat, but it was already too late.

My last thought was: *My dear daughter, I'm coming to join you. My foolish husband, I'm coming to drink with you.*

POV Aiden

A colossal explosion tore through the entire capital an enormous blaze, thick smoke, a shockwave so powerful it reached us and beyond, accompanied by a deafening roar. Calming my mare, I stared at the explosion, heart pounding: the queen had done something insane. The whole capital had been leveled, an enormous crater at its center but Nilfgaard's main army had been wiped out in the blast.

Ciri cried her heart out, but said with fierce resolve:

"Grandma! I'll make you proud! Watch me with Aiden by my side we'll avenge you."

I smiled softly, resting my hand on her hair.

"That's right. We'll avenge them. But for now, Kaer Morhen."

She looked at me, worried.

"Do you think Uncle Mousesack is…"

I shook my head.

"I'm sure he isn't. He's probably alive."

I was worried about him too, but for now, our safety came first. Just as I was about to spur my mare back into a gallop, a man appeared on his own horse two swords strapped to his back, a scar across his face, cat-like eyes freezing us both in place.

The man gazed at the distant explosion, sighed sadly, and murmured:

"So, you decided to go out like that? May you rest in peace, Calanthe."

Then he turned to me, glanced at Ciri with a faint smile, and said:

"It's been a while, Ciri."

Ciri, still in shock, exclaimed:

"Geralt!"

POV Vilgefortz

I pressed a hand to my chest, still aching that damned druid had actually managed to skewer me with his branches, despite his own wounds. That's exactly why he's one of the candidates to lead the Druidic Order.

I sighed, gazing at the smoke in the distance, an amused smile on my lips.

"So, the Lioness decided to go up in smoke? Clever."

I glanced toward the emperor's camp, easily picturing his face twisted with hatred toward Calanthe she'd just completely upended his plans. But for now, that mattered little to me. I needed to find the princess, and settle my score with that blasted druid who'd survived.

I smiled, amused.

"We'll meet again, Mousesack. And you won't stop me from getting my hands on the princess for my plans."

9: Chapter 9 : The White Wolf's Apprentice

POV Aiden

The logs crackled in the makeshift campfire. After we found Geralt, he hadn't told us much of anything, other than to follow him. At first, I was wary after all, I didn't know him at all but Ciri had assured me we could trust him, since he'd already helped her once before, when she'd been in danger in the Brokilon forest.

I'd sighed, and we'd followed Geralt through the woods on horseback him on his mare, which he'd apparently named Roach, of all things. Ciri had stayed with me, on my horse, quieter than I'd ever seen her before. I hadn't said anything everyone grieves in their own way.

I was sad myself. I wanted to punch something out of pure rage. From time to time, following Geralt through the forest, I'd still see Mousesack's smile, hear Commander Albert's laugh whenever he beat me at training, the queen's voice Calanthe, that woman who seemed so hard on the outside, yet so loving toward Ciri and everyone close to her.

All of it, because of Nilfgaard… Even though I know what Calanthe did must have hit them hard, it won't stop them for long. Maybe it'll set them back a year or two, but they'll come back, more determined than ever, and eventually lay siege to the northern kingdoms exactly what Calanthe and Mousesack had feared all along.

But what bothers me most, I think, is how the northern kings reacted. They did nothing or next to nothing. I hope, not without some bitterness, that they'll eventually understand the suffering Queen Calanthe had to endure to make those decisions, for her people.

I felt a slight wetness on my knees: faint tears trickling down Ciri's face as she slept against me during our stop. She murmured her grandmother's name, likely lost in a dream of her. I gently stroked her hair and dried her tears with the edge of my glove.

That's when Geralt said:

"Honestly, it's rare to see her trust someone that much."

I looked up at him. He was sitting on a log, our horses grazing behind him on what he'd prepared apparently some decent feed for the animals.

I turned my eyes back to Ciri and answered softly:

"Yeah. Honestly, we ended up together in an extremely dire situation, and I think that's when we started trusting each other completely."

Silence settled for a moment, as if Geralt were searching for something to talk about. I beat him to it:

"You're a witcher, right?"

He nodded, calm.

"Yes. A witcher of the Wolf School. That's actually where we're headed Kaer Morhen."

Curious, I asked:

"I know a little about Kaer Morhen, from the book *The Monstrum, or a Description of Witchers* but that book never gave the exact location."

He nodded, tossed another log onto the fire, and said:

"Kaer Morhen is extremely hard to reach. First off, geographically, it's a real headache getting there."

He traced a path in the dirt with a stick and went on, calm:

"After that, you have to take the Witchers' Trail some call it 'the Killer,' too. It's an incredibly dangerous path: without knowing exactly where to step, a traveler who tries it has every chance of dying, or getting lost. Not to mention the monsters lurking around it."

He continued:

"If you want a simpler answer, Kaer Morhen sits northwest of Kaedwen, up in the Blue Mountains."

I frowned.

"Kaedwen? Don't you have trouble with the king out there? From what I know, he's not exactly fond of non-humans."

Geralt shrugged.

"We avoid the capital and the main roads. And honestly, our neutrality creed might work in our favor with the king or maybe he just doesn't even know we're there. Either way, we've never had any direct trouble with him."

I nodded. Monsters intrigued me too: during my potion training, I'd handled ingredients taken from creatures, read books about ghouls and alghouls, but I'd never actually seen one myself. I asked, curious:

"What are monsters really like? I mean, do they act like wild animals? Or more… human?"

He looked at me, a little surprised, then smiled, amused.

"You know, something's been nagging at me since earlier. Usually, people who see a witcher for the first time fear us even when they're paying us for a job well done, you can feel it in their eyes, like they'd almost rather kill us. But you've never shown a trace of hatred, or disgust."

I stayed quiet for a moment, eyes on Ciri, sleeping, still gently stroking her ash-colored hair, then finally answered:

"I think it's because I don't come from a place eaten up by prejudice, and I had a good upbringing. I've always believed in meeting kindness with kindness, and cruelty with cruelty that's probably why I don't feel that kind of aversion. And besides, according to Ciri, you saved her life that makes you someone I trust too, in my eyes. Does that make me naive?"

Geralt gave a small laugh.

"No, I wouldn't call it naive. Just be careful not to assume everyone's kind, though. That said, hold onto that mindset I promise you it'll take you far. And you're right about one thing: a lot of people think witchers have lost their emotions, but the mutations don't do that."

He stared into the flames, calm.

"We still love, cry, get angry. The mutations just make it harder to show any of it the good and the bad alike. Anyway, to answer your question: monsters come in all kinds. Some act like plain animals drowners, ghouls. Others are made through magic golems, gargoyles. And then there are some far smarter ones higher vampires, dopplers."

Another question was nagging at me:

"Why are you out here, this time of year? I thought witchers went back to their keep for the winter, and winter's coming soon. Why are you still out here?"

He looked me straight in the eye.

"Calanthe sent a messenger all the way to Kaer Morhen. I think she already knew this war was lost before it even started, and she wanted to save you both. Of course, I'm putting it in my own words in her message, she made sure to remind me she still hated me, over that whole destiny business."

I didn't understand and asked, unsure:

"Destiny?"

He looked surprised.

"She never told you?" I shook my head. He sighed.

"A few years back, Calanthe hired me, through Mousesack, to stop an impostor demanding her daughter's hand. Word was it was some kind of monster. At first, I nearly turned it down I don't much like working for kings or queens, it's always a nest of schemes of every kind."

He glanced at sleeping Ciri and went on, calm:

"On the day of the princess's celebration, the monster showed up and demanded her hand. Calanthe wanted me to kill it, but my medallion, and my own experience, told me right away it was a cursed being. I refused to kill it, and had to fight the queen's own knights to protect it."

I smiled slightly that sounded exactly like the queen and asked:

"Is that why she hated you?"

He shook his head.

"No. While we were fighting those knights, the princess had had enough turns out she was in love with the man herself, and she made it very clear to her mother that she intended to marry him, with or without her blessing."

I laughed, looking at Ciri.

"Guess stubbornness runs in the family."

He nodded.

"Exactly. After that, the curse broke, and the monster turned back into a man. Calanthe wanted to reward me I refused at first, since I'd technically broken my original contract. But she insisted, so I finally said: 'I want that which you already have, but do not yet know.' And that's the exact moment the princess threw up, right in front of the whole court. I just froze, same as everyone else I'd just claimed, without even knowing it, a Child of Surprise."

I was stunned.

"A Child of Surprise? Like in the legends, the ones that bind two people to some important destiny?"

He nodded.

"Yes. And unfortunately, Calanthe wasn't thrilled about that. She protects her children above all else, like a true lioness. She had me thrown in prison, meant for execution but Mousesack got me out, and once she'd calmed down, passed along a very clear message: never set foot in Cintra again, or face execution on sight."

He tossed another log onto the fire, stood up, crossed his arms, and looked at me.

"Honestly, I don't know why she ended up asking for my help anyway. But Ciri is my Child of Surprise, and I can see how attached you two are to each other her especially. She can be stubborn as a mule, but when she wants something, she always gets it one way or another. So I'll protect you too, Aiden, don't worry. But tell me what do you plan to do now?"

I lowered my head.

"I don't know… I want revenge, that's true. But mostly, I want to learn more about my past what the queen told me and above all, I want to protect Ciri. That's the promise I

made to everyone who gave their life to save us, and I intend to keep it. But I know my limits, I…"

I clenched my fists slightly inside my gloves and looked Geralt straight on:

"Geralt, train me. I want to get stronger. When I saw those mages, I felt like an ant about to be crushed by some massive power. Watching that duel of spells from a distance, I felt useless. I thought I was strong I was still painfully weak."

I glanced at Ciri.

"I know countless trials are waiting for us, and I feel it, deep down, that I need to get stronger like something terrible is coming. Don't ask me why, but…"

I turned my eyes back to Geralt.

"Train me. I don't care if I throw up my guts, get beaten every single session, get called an idiot or useless. I'm just asking for a chance to be trained."

Geralt sighed, then stayed silent for several seconds before answering:

"Fine. I'll train you. But get ready for hell there won't be any room for kindness. I'll train you like a witcher apprentice, nothing less. Is that clear?"

I nodded, serious.

"Yes. Very clear."

He nodded back, moved off a short distance, settled into a meditative position, closed his eyes, and said:

"Now sleep. Training starts tomorrow."

I nodded, gently pulled Ciri's head against me, lay down beside her on the ground, pulled the blanket over the two of us, and fell asleep holding her close.

POV Geralt

I cracked one eye open to watch the two children sleeping, then sighed, looking up at the sky.

"Is this really destiny, handing me these two?"

What Aiden didn't know was that I'd seen his eyes change one turning icy blue, the other snow white while he was talking about wanting to grow stronger. I had no idea what it was: not a curse, not a possession, but something magical, and terrifyingly powerful.

My medallion had vibrated violently, and every combat instinct in me had screamed to run, just from meeting his gaze. I still didn't understand what that phenomenon was the moment he fell asleep, that pressure had vanished completely, as if it had never existed at all. But I'd felt it, all right. No doubt about that.

I smiled slightly.

"Destiny sure has a funny way of telling me I'm not getting any peace anytime soon."

I hesitated, turning over in my fingers a communication crystal one a certain red-haired sorceress had given me, right before I left her bed.

I sighed.

"Once we get to Kaer Morhen, I'll need to call her. Hoping Yennefer isn't with her I don't feel like arguing again, especially since she still holds it against me, for having the djinn's wish undone, the one that bound us together. But it was for the best, for both of us. I still believe that."

I shivered again, remembering Yennefer crying in my arms, after I'd saved her from the djinn the wish that had bound the two of us together. We'd been deeply in love, back then. Then, during a contract, I'd gone along with Triss and we'd stumbled onto another djinn. I'd wanted to know, once and for all, whether my love for Yen was truly genuine or just a product of magic. So I'd made the wish to undo that first bond: only another djinn could break it. And just as I'd feared, my love for Yen turned into nothing more than friendship while what I felt for Triss stayed real…

I sighed.

"My life, huh…"

10: Chapter 10 : The Witcher's Lesson

POV Aiden

Just as promised, the very next morning after we woke up, Geralt started training me though for now, it was mostly about knowledge. He had several books on him, picked up over the course of his travels, which he'd hand me to read while we rode.

Ciri had named my mare Nocturne, because of her black coat, and since it seemed to make her happy, I'd accepted the name without arguing.

The fact that I spent a good chunk of my time studying had ended up bothering Ciri a little. Instead of pestering me directly, she'd started grilling Geralt with all kinds of questions and true to form, he quickly grew tired of it. But Ciri being Ciri, and convinced I was now "too focused on studying because of him," she got her revenge her own way: she gave the witcher no peace at all, except at night, when she'd fall asleep sprawled against me, as if she hadn't slept in weeks.

Sometimes Geralt would come back with monster carcasses and teach us, right then and there, how to tell an alghoul apart from a plain ghoul despite the infernal stench, since they both belong to the necrophage family. I had to personally dig through a gargoyle's corpse myself: according to Geralt, "practice makes perfect." I won't lie: after several sessions of rummaging through those carcasses for ingredients, I ended up throwing up, completely overwhelmed by the smell.

As for sword training, we'd sometimes stop early so he could teach me the Wolf School's footwork pretty tough to master, almost like a musical score where every step has to land exactly on beat. From what he explained, each witcher school has its own specialty: the Griffin focuses on Signs, the Cat on cunning and agility, the Viper on gear and close-combat techniques, the Bear on brute strength, the Manticore on dexterity, and the Wolf his own on counterattacks, dodging, and parrying.

I even got the chance, once, to face down a real monster though I'll admit the experience was pretty strange.

Flashback

POV Aiden

I was hiding in a bush with Geralt. He pointed at a drowner sitting on the beach, licking its leg, and asked calmly:

"What can you tell me about this monster?"

I studied it for a moment and answered:

"A drowner I'd say a fairly young one, given the lighter markings. Separated from the main group, judging by the lack of tracks in the sand around it."

He nodded.

"You're right, but you missed something: look closely at its eyes slightly red. That means it's been in a recent fight, and it's licking its wounds now, even though most of them have already healed. With drowners, that kind of behavior is pretty animal-like usually just a way to clean their injuries."

He handed me his silver sword.

"I'll let you handle this one."

Surprised, I nodded seriously anyway and took the weapon. Ciri, quiet until then, crouched beside us, murmured:

"Be careful."

I smiled at her, then stepped slowly toward the drowner, sword gripped in both hands. The creature caught my scent, spotted me, let out a bestial screech, and charged.

Rule number one: never parry a monster's attack head-on.

I dodged its leap and sliced its leg on the way past. It howled in pain then did something that caught me off guard: it let out a shrill cry toward the sky, as if calling for backup. Turning around, I saw two more drowners burst out and charge straight at me. I dodged the first, which leapt at me in turn, but had to jump back to avoid the second one's claws. I was already thinking through a strategy as both of them prepared to attack again.

I tried something: I charged at them. One leapt, the other swung its claws but remembering the footwork Geralt had just taught me, I planted my left foot firmly, pivoted, dodging both attacks in a single motion, then struck the clawing drowner square across the belly, killing it instantly. Before the other could get back up, I drove the sword straight through its skull.

Breathing out in relief, I saw Geralt and Ciri applauding. Geralt said:

"Nice work. I'll let your mistake with that first drowner's cry slide" he finished off the wounded one with a stab of his steel sword straight through the heart "but remember this well: a young drowner acts like an animal, kind of like a baby calling for its mother when it's in trouble. Most young necrophages do the same except alghouls and a few other species but with drowners and ghouls, the young almost always call their parents in as backup."

I nodded and handed the silver sword back. Ciri asked:

"Can I hold it?"

Geralt simply answered:

"No."

She pouted.

"Come on!"

I tried to keep a straight face watching their little back-and-forth, but I already knew how it would end: after a long sigh, Geralt finally handed her the sword. Thrilled, she wandered off a bit to try imitating my footwork.

Geralt went on:

"Good work on the footwork. It's not perfect yet your center of gravity still leans a bit too far left but it's something we can build on."

I was listening closely to his advice when he handed me his knife, pointing at the drowner corpses with an amused smile:

"I'm sure you've missed the smell of wet carrion. Go on, harvest their brains."

I sighed, took the knife, muttering "Sadist," then leaned in, holding my breath or at least trying to convince my brain to forget the smell and got to work. Behind me, Geralt

added, calm:

"Don't worry, your nose'll get used to it eventually. Drowner brain is one of the ingredients in Swallow potion. You told me Mousesack trained you in potions and herbalism? Then you'll be the one brewing this one we're officially adding witcher potions to your training."

Ciri, curious, wandered over.

"Looks like a moldy old candy, that brain."

I sighed, looking at her.

"Why'd you have to say that? I'm never gonna be able to eat candy again now, that's all I'm gonna see."

She shrugged, a teasing smile on her face.

"Oh well, more candy for me then."

Then she went back to training with Geralt, like she'd asked him to do several times already.

End of flashback

POV Aiden

Arriving in a fairly quiet village, I saw the locals pointing at Geralt, muttering "mutant," some with open disgust. Ciri was seething, but I shook my head and murmured to her:

"Even if you're mad, Ciri, it won't do any good."

She looked at me.

"But…"

Geralt, still on his horse, said calmly:

"Aiden's right. Their prejudice runs too deep. There's no point fighting it."

Arriving at the inn, we left Roach and Nocturne at the stables, then walked in Geralt in front, Ciri by my side. We clearly heard some of the patrons grumbling in disgust: "I ain't eating next to a mutant," "They say they steal kids, don't they? You think those are his prisoners?", "A witcher's worse than a leper, don't get close."

It made me angry, obviously, but I kept myself more composed than Ciri, who looked ready to explode. I put a hand over her mouth and shook my head.

"Ciri, no. It gets to me too, this whole thing. But look at Geralt he's not reacting. All we can do is stand by him and respect his call."

She nodded, though not without shooting a few dark looks at the patrons. As we approached Geralt, already deep in conversation with the innkeeper, we heard the man apologizing: "Forgive them, witcher Cintra's fall has everyone on edge."

Geralt shook his head.

"Don't worry about it, I'm used to it. We'd like somewhere to sleep, if that's possible."

The innkeeper apologized.

"All I can offer is some benches."

Geralt nodded, pulled out a bottle of rum, set down four crowns, then three more.

"That'll do. Bring us something to eat too."

We followed him to a quiet corner of the room. The moment she sat down, Ciri couldn't hold it in anymore and demanded, furious:

"Geralt, why aren't you doing anything?"

He sighed softly, pouring himself a drink.

"Unfortunately, what do you want me to do? Yell? That'd just rile up the crowd more. Get even? That'd just prove to everyone that witchers are killers and our reputation's already tarnished enough thanks to the Cat School. So unfortunately, Ciri, it's better to just take it in silence."

I pulled our bottle of milk out of my bag, poured a glass for Ciri and one for myself, right as the innkeeper brought over chicken legs, salad, and beans. While we ate, Ciri muttered into her plate:

"It's not fair."

Geralt smiled softly at her.

"Unfortunately, life isn't fair."

I gently stroked her hair.

"Geralt's right. You can convince one person, face to face but convincing a whole crowd, that's like asking your grandmother to cancel your etiquette lessons: goes in one ear, out the other."

She burst out laughing.

"Idiot I never had to ask Grandma. I just skip class."

We kept eating, laughing, trading stories about Calanthe. I even caught Geralt cracking a faint smile a couple of times. Once we'd finished eating, he pulled out a deck of cards.

"You two know gwent?"

We both shook our heads; he explained the rules. Ciri picked the Scoia'tael faction, I took the Northern Realms, and I faced off against Geralt who, how should I put it…

Was terrible....

Genuinely terrible....

Whether he played me or Ciri, he got wiped off the board every time. Playing against Ciri, though, was a real challenge even though I won most of the time, because the second she got a weather card in hand, her sly little smile gave it away instantly.

The hours slipped by. Geralt stayed half-awake, meditating on his bench, while Ciri and I eventually drifted off, huddled together in a corner, warm and safe from the rain.

(What deck were you using? Personally, Northern Realms.)

POV Geralt

Listening to the rain drumming outside, I glanced out the window at the drops splattering on the ground, then turned my gaze back to the children, sleeping peacefully. Day by day,

spending time with them, I found myself growing more attached to Ciri's stubborn spirit, and to Aiden's constant drive to improve.

Honestly, I felt a particular closeness to Aiden. Sometimes I saw a bit of myself in him a boy who never really chose his path, but had it forced on him by fate instead. I'm sure that if he'd been given the choice, he'd have stayed in Cintra, by Ciri's side. But fate decided otherwise. Unlike me, though, I intend to give him what I never had: real protection, real guidance.

Even though Vesemir is something of a father figure to me, I still think of him more as a mentor than a real father.

I sighed, drinking from my cup, eyes on the rain, not noticing a bald merchant watching the children from a distance, at the edge of the forest before turning his gaze toward me, then vanishing into the trees, whistling.

General POV, in the forest

Still whistling, he smiled and murmured:

"So the swallow's child found the White Wolf, huh. Funny old thing, fate, showing me this boy too. I thought the P..."

A sudden gust of wind rose up, as if to swallow the bald merchant's voice.

The wind died down. The man laughed softly.

"I really am curious whether this world will survive. For now, I've got a debt to collect von Everec. But either way, we'll meet again, my dear boy."

Then the figure faded into the darkness of the forest, still whistling the same tune.

11: Chapter 11 : The Snowstorm and Nivellen's Manor

POV Aiden

We were walking on foot through a particularly brutal snowstorm. Geralt and I had to lead our own horses, since they themselves were struggling against the thick blanket of snow.

Ciri had stayed perched on Nocturne, while I led her by the reins on foot. Geralt, for his part, guided Roach. I'd wrapped my cape around Ciri to shield her from the cold, keeping one arm raised in front of my eyes to try to make out anything through the icy haze.

Geralt shouted no way to talk normally with this wind:

"Aiden! Take my cape! You've been without any protection for several minutes now, you're risking hypothermia!"

I shook my head and shouted back:

"No need! I don't know why, but I'm not cold!"

Geralt looked at me, surprised. Even Ciri lifted her head slightly to look at me, just as puzzled we'd ended up selling my Cintra armor to a blacksmith, too recognizable, and I'd equipped myself with a simple leather set instead. I'd kept Mousesack's sword at my belt, but that wasn't what surprised them: leather does hold warmth, sure, but not enough for a storm like this and I didn't even have gloves.

And yet my hands weren't red from the cold quite the opposite, they looked perfectly normal. And unlike Ciri, who was shivering despite the cape, I wasn't trembling at all. I actually felt completely fine.

I watched Ciri shaking and shouted:

"Geralt! We need to find shelter, Ciri won't hold up much longer!"

Ciri, trying to play it down, answered through chattering teeth:

"No, no need to worry about..."

I looked at her, dead serious:

"No, Ciri. You're shivering, we're not risking hypothermia."

A little surprised, she nodded shyly not quite used to me being this assertive with her. If I could have read her thoughts right then, it probably would've sounded like "so cool!"

Geralt gave a small laugh and shouted:

"I know a place, follow me!"

After a few more minutes of walking, we spotted the outline of a village in the distance. Along the way, I kept wondering about this total lack of discomfort from the cold if anything, it was the opposite: whenever snow landed on my skin, it felt almost like a warm hug, like being wrapped in a blanket. Even Geralt, seasoned witcher that he was, occasionally slipped on the ice but I never stumbled once, the whole way there.

Arriving at the edge of the village, we stopped short: something about the place felt off. The wind howled through the abandoned houses, banging doors and shutters in an eerie echo. But the worst part was the complete absence of any villagers. I looked at Geralt and shouted:

"Is this normal?"

He frowned, walked over to Roach to grab his silver sword, and shouted:

"Arm yourself, this isn't normal!"

I nodded, drew my sword, and called out:

"Ciri, get down!"

She dismounted from Nocturne, moved behind me, drew her knife, and looked around. Only the howling wind broke the oppressive silence. We moved carefully through the village, leading our horses, on high alert, without a single other sound reaching us. Geralt came closer and murmured:

"Let's head to the castle. There's light over there, but stay on your guard."

Ciri and I nodded and followed him the urge to investigate was there, but we were short on time, and the risk of hypothermia for Ciri was still real. After several more minutes of walking, we reached the castle courtyard. The windows kept banging violently, the doors too until, all at once, everything slammed shut, and complete silence fell.

Geralt readied himself for combat. Suddenly, a massive creature smashed through the front door and lunged at him, pinning him to the ground. But Geralt's sword found its mark, slashing across the creature's face. Just as I was about to step in, Ciri was already leaping toward the monster when a voice rang out:

"Geralt, my old friend!"

Geralt blinked, recognizing the voice:

"Nivellen?"

The creature burst out laughing, got up, and hoisted Geralt off the ground like a rag doll:

"Ahaha, of course, my old friend!"

Geralt frowned:

"You've changed."

Nivellen sighed:

"That I have. But for now…" he looked at us and stepped closer. I instinctively placed myself in front of Ciri. He laughed softly "Don't worry, big guy, I come in peace. Geralt's an old friend. You must be freezing come on, there's food, and…" He shot a wink at Ciri, behind me, clearly amused by the whole thing. "…a hot bath for this charming young lady. I'm sure she'll appreciate it."

Ciri nodded, stepped past me, and said:

"Hell yeah! Come on, gentlemen, let's go!"

She walked off toward the manor alongside Nivellen. I sighed. Geralt patted my shoulder and murmured in my ear:

"Take care of the horses, and keep an eye out."

I nodded, watched Geralt sheathe his sword and follow Ciri, and resigned myself to leading Roach and Nocturne:

"Come on, girls, let's get you out of this snow."

POV Geralt

Walking in with Ciri and Nivellen, I stayed on guard, taking in every detail around me. Too good to be true: an entire village abandoned, and only Nivellen still here? And on top of that, he's turned into a monster. Cursed, maybe.

Once in the dining hall, Nivellen smiled at Ciri, snapped his fingers, and conjured up a full feast out of nowhere:

"Ta-da!"

Ciri laughed and clapped. I let a faint smile slip out myself it had been a while since she'd smiled that much since we'd been on the road. Nivellen came back with a bottle of wine:

"A Toussaint vintage, straight from my cellar. I'm sure you'll enjoy it for old times' sake."

I nodded, face unreadable, and sat down across from Ciri, never letting my guard down. I was certain there was more going on here than he was letting on.

That's when Aiden walked into the room.

POV Aiden

I shook the snow off my clothes, catching the delicious smell drifting through the room. Ciri waved me over to the chair beside her:

"Come on, come eat, Aidy!"

I smiled, seeing her so happy, and sat down next to her. Nivellen smiled:

"Enjoy the meal, kids. Your hot baths will be ready right after."

I nodded:

"Thanks for having us."

He laughed, pleased:

"It's nothing. It's been a long time since I've had company."

While we ate, Geralt set down his glass:

"Good thing you mentioned it earlier, Nivellen. Why is the village, down below the castle, abandoned?"

Silence settled for a moment, then he answered:

"Unfortunately, Geralt, my monstrous appearance scared the villagers off. You understand why."

Ciri, a piece of chicken still in her mouth, set it down, wiped her mouth, and asked:

"Why, though? I mean, you're nice, right? You took us in."

Nivellen laughed softly:

"Thank you, little one."

I sighed and stroked Ciri's hair; she looked at me. I said:

"Unfortunately, Ciri, that's actually something Geralt taught me during our very first lesson. Let me ask you the same question: what's the difference between a witcher and a regular armed man?"

She frowned, thinking it over:

"The length of his sword?"

Nivellen nearly choked on his wine, holding back a laugh I think he'd taken that a different way entirely. Geralt sighed, an amused smile on his lips. I laughed lightly:

"No."

I held her gaze:

"A witcher is the border between monster and man. Geralt taught me there are good monsters and bad ones it's up to witchers to judge, since they're mutants themselves, but also hunters, for those who prey on humans. If a monster just wants to live peacefully alongside people, then a witcher won't touch it a witcher isn't an executioner, just the line between the two worlds."

Ciri nodded and finished her plate then mine, on the way before saying:

"I'm gonna go take my bath."

Nivellen nodded:

"Come on, little one, I'll show you the bathroom and your room."

He left with her, exiting the dining hall. As I finished my own plate, Geralt said calmly:

"Aiden, once we're done eating, go check out the manor, just in case. I'll ask Nivellen a few questions it's not normal for an entire village to be abandoned like this. He's not telling us everything."

I nodded and went off to explore the manor on my own.

POV Geralt

I stood up, staying on my feet, arms crossed near the fireplace. Nivellen walked in:

"Aiden's gone?"

I nodded without saying anything more. He came and sat on the couch, drink in hand:

"It's been a while, my friend, huh. Didn't picture you as a babysitter."

I let a faint smile slip, before returning to my unreadable expression:

"Suits me just fine, that role. But let's talk about you instead. Tell me the truth about yourself, and what's going on in this village."

Nivellen stayed silent for a moment, staring into the fireplace flames, then said:

"When we parted ways, my father had just died, and I inherited his gang. I know I promised you I'd stop, but the victories, the admiration from my men… it went to my

head, and I kept up the raiding."

My face darkened, but I let him keep going without interrupting:

"One day, after we sacked the Temple of the Lion-Headed Spider Goddess, my men dared me to go assault a priestess 'make a man out of me,' as they put it."

He went on, likely guessing my thoughts:

"I'm not proud of it. I could make excuses the hallucinogenic mushrooms, being drunk but I'd rather own my sin as it is. Before she died, the priestess spat in my face and cursed me: 'Since you were a monster in a man's body, then that man shall become a monster.' I transformed shortly after. Since then, I've taken refuge here, atoning for my sin without hurting anyone else."

Honestly, I had no right to judge him I'm no judge. But I couldn't help feeling genuine disgust at the story. Still, I had a more urgent question:

"And the village?"

He locked eyes with me:

"Geralt… what would you do, for love?"

POV Aiden

Exploring the manor, I mostly found rooms overrun with spiderwebs and thick dust nothing but the creaking of old wood, typical of a place like this. Just as I was about to open a hatch leading to the attic, I heard Ciri scream:

"Who are you?!"

I rushed toward her voice, kicked open the door, and found Ciri, dressed in clean clothes, facing a woman who froze at the sight of me. I drew my sword and was about to run to protect Ciri but the woman, strikingly beautiful, suddenly shifted into a monster and let out a shriek that split my eardrums. I barely had time to parry her attack: she'd lunged at me, going for my throat.

Parrying with my sword, she dragged me along with her straight through the window, which shattered behind me. I heard Ciri's voice screaming, in the distance, running

toward us: "Aiden!" then I crashed into the snow, while she, still airborne, was already preparing to dive down and finish me off.

POV Geralt

I drew my sword, Nivellen having just confessed that the woman he loved was a bruxa and the one responsible for the villagers' disappearance. I was about to rush to Aiden and Ciri's aid when a scream rang out: I immediately understood it was the bruxa. Behind me, Nivellen shouted, as if hoping she'd hear him anyway:

"Vereena, no!"

I saw Aiden crash into the snow, clearly having fallen from the upper floor. Without hesitation, I ran for the window, shattered it on my way through, and reached him just in time to parry the bruxa's attack. I struck back with an Aard, throwing her violently against the stone wall. Keeping an eye on the dust cloud she'd kicked up on landing, I pulled Aiden to his feet:

"Aiden, go protect Ciri."

POV Aiden

Geralt helped me up, his gaze still locked on the spot where he'd just thrown the bruxa. My heart was pounding, but I nodded. I saw Ciri come rushing outside with Nivellen; she leapt into my arms, and I hurried to the stable where our horses were, setting her down inside:

"Ciri, don't you move from here!"

She clenched her jaw but nodded. I stayed posted at the door, sword in hand, just in case my arms were still shaking from the bruxa's strength, and my ribs screamed in pain. But protecting Ciri came first.

POV Geralt

I drank my potions, pulled from my satchel my veins darkened instantly. Thunderbolt, and Black Blood. I cracked my neck to brace against the toxicity of the mix, and readied

myself for the fight. At least I knew the kids were safe. The bruxa emerged from the rubble, bloodied, letting out a shriek that carried a shockwave but thanks to Quen, I shrugged it off easily. She lunged at me.

I dodged, cut into her skin as I moved, and she started swinging her claws in a hysterical frenzy. I dodged some, cut her down with my silver sword at other times, took a few hits in between but in a fight like this, there's no room to look away, not even for a second.

Nivellen rushed in and grabbed her from behind as she struggled:

"Vereena, calm down! Please, love!"

I shouted:

"Nivellen, what are you doing?!"

He was about to answer, but the bruxa bit into his neck. I swore, bracing for what was coming because when a vampire feeds, its abilities spike tenfold for a few seconds. That's exactly why every witcher needs Black Blood running through their veins: without it, the fight's already lost.

The bruxa managed to tear free from Nivellen's grip and kicked him square in the chest, sending him flying toward a stone statue holding a spear, near the children. She then charged straight at me; I barely dodged in time, but she grabbed me by the throat and slammed me against a wall. The impact tore a spray of blood from my mouth and my back screamed in pain but thanks to the Quen I'd cast mid-fall, the damage stayed limited.

Getting back up, I saw the bruxa charging straight toward the children. Aiden was already bracing to defend Ciri. I ran toward them, knowing he wouldn't hold but I was too slow.

POV Aiden

Seeing Geralt slammed against the wall, I heard Ciri scream:

"Geralt!"

She tried to bolt out of the stable, but I stopped her. She protested:

"We have to help him!"

Frustrated, worried, I answered:

"We'd just be a burden, Ciri! I'm sure he's fine!"

My words shut her up cold, and she bit her lip in frustration. Watching him get back up made me let out a sigh of relief but seeing the bruxa charge straight at us, I braced for the impact. That's when Nivellen got back up, tore the spear from the stone statue's hands, and drove it into the bruxa's body, crying.

I froze for a moment, the tension draining out all at once, replaced by Nivellen's sobs. Geralt and I walked toward him, Ciri right behind us, and we heard him murmur:

"I'm sorry, Vereena. So sorry."

Coughing up blood, the woman took back her human form and said softly:

"No. It's for the best. Nivellen, I spent the best years of my life with you even knowing I was a monster."

He shook his head, kissed her, and said sadly:

"To me, you were never a monster. You were the only one who accepted all of me even the monster I became."

Vereena smiled softly:

"I know." She turned her eyes toward us. "I'm sorry, children. If I'd been able to control myself, I never would have done this."

We nodded slightly, not quite sure how to react. I felt like the villain of the story, watching this couple say goodbye. Ciri took my hand in silence. Geralt stepped closer to Nivellen:

"Nivellen. I have to do this."

Nivellen looked at him and gave a weak nod:

"Do it. I know it's necessary, by the witcher's code." He turned to Vereena, kissed her one last time, and murmured: "I love you."

She smiled softly, bit into his neck, mingling their blood and Geralt brought his sword down on the bruxa's head, decapitating her cleanly.

I kept my eyes fixed on the scene. Even Ciri, lips pressed tight, eventually walked off toward the stable.

Before our eyes, Nivellen slowly returned to human form, Vereena's lifeless head still in his hands. Geralt said:

"Your curse broke, by saving an innocent. The man-monster's curse has lifted."

Nivellen looked up at him:

"And so what? I lost the only being who ever fully accepted me." He stood and walked back into the manor, calling out before he vanished: "Take whatever you want. I'm going to join Vereena." Then he disappeared inside.

Was it right? She'd attacked me, sure, but was it really necessary to…

Geralt, probably guessing my thoughts, rested a hand on my hair his eyes still darkened from the potions and said:

"I know what you're thinking. But she's responsible for the death of every villager here. It's sad, I know that too. But as witchers, we also have to bring justice to the innocent."

He shot a weary glance toward the manor door:

"Even I didn't want to do it. But she hurt innocent people, and giving them justice that's the witcher's code."

He looked at me:

"Go check on Ciri. You're in the best position to comfort her. I'll handle the supplies."

He sheathed his sword and headed back toward the manor.

12: Chapter 12 : Kaer Morhen

POV Aiden

It had already been several weeks since we'd left Cintra, and we were finally getting close to the famed fortress of the Wolf School, Kaer Morhen.

Along the way, aside from the whole Nivellen episode, our days mostly boiled down to training with Geralt: the basics of the Wolf School's combat style. I'd picked up the fundamentals of the footwork, and I was just starting to learn a few striking techniques.

We were on horseback, Geralt riding a little ahead on Roach he was the one guiding us along the trail, a path far too dangerous for anyone who didn't know it. I looked at Ciri, sitting in front of me, and noticing she seemed a bit down, I found myself thinking back to our conversation, the day Geralt had gone back into Nivellen's manor.

Flashback

POV Aiden

Arriving at the stables, I saw Ciri gently stroking Nocturne and Roach, lost in thought, visibly a little upset.

I approached without saying anything right away after all these years together, I'd learned that when she was holding something in, the best thing to do was let her come to me. So I got to work saddling the horses in silence.

While I adjusted Nocturne's saddle, she asked from behind me:

"Aidy, was…" She hesitated. "Was what Geralt did necessary?"

She held my gaze, pacing back and forth as if trying to convince herself:

"I mean, I know she attacked us, that she deserved to die, she wanted to kill us, but…"

I smiled slightly.

"Leaves a bitter taste, doesn't it?"

She nodded.

"Yeah, exactly that! I don't get it, I mean, why?"

I finished Nocturne's saddle, moved on to Roach's, and answered calmly:

"Ciri, close your eyes and think back on the scene. What exactly feels bitter to you? The bruxa's death? How it all ended? Or…"

She cut me off, her voice small:

"No, you're right. I think what leaves that bitter taste is the way Geralt handled it."

I smiled, finished adjusting the saddle, turned to face her, arms crossed:

"Why?"

She thought about it:

"I think it's his behavior. I mean, yeah, she killed innocent people, no denying that, but…"

I smiled and finished her sentence:

"But was killing her really necessary, when it was pretty clear she wasn't a threat anymore?"

She nodded. I crouched down to her level so we'd be eye to eye:

"Honestly, I don't have the answer."

She looked at me, surprised I usually had an answer for everything and said, almost on instinct:

"But then…"

I tapped her nose.

"But does that actually change anything?" She rubbed her nose, annoyed. I went on: "Ciri, we both learned this: life isn't black and white, it's gray. Your real question isn't what you think of Geralt it's whether you think you'd end up like him. That's it, right?"

She stayed quiet for a moment, then nodded.

"I know we're going to train with Geralt, at Kaer Morhen. And I know the whole world's going to come looking for me, because of my position as princess."

I looked at her, mildly surprised. She laughed, and this time it was her turn to tap my nose.

"Don't look so shocked, Aidy remember, Grandma trained me in politics too."

She watched the falling snow, wistful.

"I know whoever manages to capture me gets a privileged claim in Cintra, a legitimate one. That's why Geralt's hiding me somewhere no one will ever find us. But it's also why I asked him to train me I don't want to just be the princess everyone has to protect anymore. Remember our promise, Aidy? That from now on, we'd fight together?"

She gave a small laugh.

"Actually, I think that's really what leaves the bitter taste what I might become. Will I end up like Geralt, putting the code above what he feels?"

I shook my head.

"Ciri, you're overthinking this way too much. Want my answer?"

She nodded, listening closely. I smiled.

"I don't like what Geralt did."

She looked surprised. I went on:

"Don't be so surprised. Even though I admire Geralt, even though I love talking with him, even though I see him as a real mentor that doesn't mean I fully accept his code. Does that mean I should hate him for it? No. Everyone's got their own way of doing things. If it had been up to me, I'd have let the bruxa live, by Nivellen's side, given her a chance and come back to kill her if she ever hurt another innocent. But I'd have given her that chance, that's true."

I ruffled her hair.

"That's what you need to remember: training under someone doesn't mean blindly copying their rules. What separates a real student from a mere copy is the ability to think for yourself. Train hard, sure, learn from Geralt's experience but think about who YOU want to become. That's what'll define you, Ciri. Not anyone else."

She stayed quiet for a moment, then nodded softly.

"Yeah, okay."

End of flashback

POV Aiden

I patted her back.

"Still thinking it over? Careful, at this rate you're gonna turn into a real scholar."

She gave me a gentle elbow to the ribs.

"Shut up."

Then she went on, more serious:

"Yeah, I thought about it, and you're right. I'll take Geralt's teachings, his experience but I'll always be the one making my own choices. And like you, I'd have let her live."

I laughed lightly. Geralt, who'd clearly heard every word, said without turning around:

"Honestly, that's exactly what I'd tell you to do."

We both looked at him, surprised and maybe he'd expected that, because he continued:

"A witcher never dies in his bed that's a lesson Vesemir's drilled into me my whole life. Even so, I'll admit, sometimes I still want to prove him wrong, convince myself I'll manage it anyway. Rare thought, but it's there. What I'm trying to say is, training matters, but it's not a cage always stay true to your own principles. And if someone gives you grief for that, it probably means their own principles were shaky to begin with."

Ciri smiled, lighter now. Seeing her smile like that made me smile too. Maybe to lighten the mood a bit, I called out:

"Geralt? You, wanting to contradict your own mentor?"

Geralt didn't turn around, but I'm sure he was smiling.

"Yeah. But at least I do it well. And you, Aiden what goes into oil against higher vampires?"

I went dead silent damn it, these potion formulas are genuinely hard to memorize. Seeing my silence, he added, teasing:

"Still too young for that one. I've got plenty more arrows left for your teasing."

Ciri burst out laughing and, to get a little payback on my behalf, started messing up my hair while laughing, trying to push me off. Even Nocturne didn't so much as flinch probably used to our nonsense by now.

A few minutes later, a breathtaking landscape opened up before us, blanketed entirely in snow, dominated by a massive fortress carved into the mountainside. Stopping Roach, Geralt turned to us.

"Welcome to Kaer Morhen."

POV Geralt

We'd finally made it to Kaer Morhen. I wondered whether the old wolf was still busy forcing Lambert to get off his ass. Walking into the castle courtyard, the kids behind me, I spotted Vesemir chopping wood. A smile slipped out despite myself. I dismounted from Roach, handing the reins to Aiden so he could lead our horses to the stable, and walked over to Vesemir, who, seeing me, drove his axe into a log and came to meet me.

He pulled me into a hug and said, in that gravelly voice of his:

"White Wolf. Snow doesn't agree with you you're paler than I am."

I smiled slightly.

"Vesemir, good to be back. But I think I've still got some room before I catch up to you, age-wise."

He laughed.

"Me? Teasing me about my age, when you're the oldest witcher after me?"

Then he turned to the two children approaching, crouched down to their level, and said:

"Hmph. You trained them well."

I just nodded, smiling, arms crossed, taking in the moment.

POV Aiden

Seeing another witcher, much older than Geralt, I figured this had to be Vesemir, his mentor, the one he'd already told us about. I stepped forward with Ciri. He held out his hand; I shook it, and he said:

"Vesemir, mentor of the Wolf School."

I nodded.

"Aiden of Cintra. And this is…"

Ciri puffed out her chest proudly.

"Cirilla Fiona Elen Riannon. But just call me Ciri."

He gave a small laugh.

"Well, seems like youthful fire's alive and well. Come on in, warm yourselves up."

Following Geralt and Vesemir, I couldn't help but look around, impressed: most of the walls were still standing solid, and I even spotted a ballista rusted, probably, but still impressive that they'd managed to keep a castle like this maintained over the years.

Arriving at the main door, Vesemir opened it and called out:

"Eskel! Lambert! Come meet our guests!"

Following him into the dining hall, what struck me most was the towering vaulted ceiling. The air smelled of leather, dried herbs, and good cooking a warm atmosphere,

despite appearances. Turning my head, I spotted a witcher, like Geralt, dark-haired, a wide scar cutting across his face, but a warm smile on his lips. He shook our hands.

"Pleasure to meet you. I'm Eskel. And that other grump over there, that's Lambert don't worry, he talks more than he bites."

Lambert, sitting a bit further off, snorted.

"Eskel, don't speak for me." He shot us a glance, staying seated at the table, offering just a simple nod as a greeting, muttering: "Great. Guess I gotta add 'babysitter' to my resume."

Vesemir, bringing over the soup as we sat down, answered calmly, without even looking up from his bowl:

"Not so bad you've already got 'fisherman' on there."

Geralt sat down, holding back a laugh threatening to slip out:

"Lambert? A fisherman?"

Lambert slowly set down his spoon, held Geralt's gaze with an almost theatrical seriousness, and let a silence stretch out before answering:

"Yeah. With bombs."

Ciri, who happened to have a spoonful of soup halfway to her mouth, froze, eyes lighting up with interest:

"A witcher technique?"

Lambert took his sweet time answering, a smug grin slowly spreading across his face, clearly savoring the effect his line was about to land:

"Nah, kid. Lazy man's technique."

A brief silence followed, giving everyone a second to catch the joke. Eskel shook his head, amused despite himself, and gave his brother a light shove.

"Cut it out, Lambert, you're gonna give them ideas."

Lambert shrugged, taking his time serving dinner, plate by plate, before tossing out, almost offhand:

"So what? It's not like they know how to make bombs."

I stayed quiet, keeping my eyes fixed on my plate to avoid giving anything away preferring to keep to myself the fact that I already knew the recipe for a Grapeshot bomb by heart.

During the meal, Geralt started laying out the situation. After several minutes of explanation, Lambert asked:

"So what, we're just keeping them here as servants?"

Vesemir shook his head, setting down his own spoon:

"No. We're training them to become witchers."

Silence fell over the table. Lambert, fork frozen halfway to his mouth, went still then, visibly angry, set it down hard, already thinking of the Trial of the Grasses. He slammed a hand flat on the table, rattling the silverware:

"Witchers? Are you kidding me, old man? You're gonna put them through that?"

Eskel and Geralt said at the same time, almost in unison:

"That's enough, Lambert."

But Lambert, stubborn as ever, pushed his chair back slightly and looked at his two brothers-in-arms, incredulous:

"Are you two even hearing this? He wants to turn them into witchers!"

Vesemir let out a long sigh, pressing his palms flat on the table, as if to steady himself before answering:

"If you'd let me finish: we're training them to become witchers combat, monster knowledge, bombs. But under no circumstances will they go through the Trial of the Grasses."

Lambert slowly sat back down, still wary, but visibly calmer. Ciri, who'd followed the whole exchange with wide, curious eyes without daring to interrupt, finally couldn't hold back her curiosity any longer and asked:

"What's the Trial of the Grasses?"

A brief silence followed her question, as if no one quite knew where to start. Geralt set down his fork and answered, more measured:

"It's the trial that turns a witcher apprentice into a full witcher."

Lambert, a bitter smile on his lips, couldn't help but add:

"Don't forget the part where you've got a ninety-nine percent chance of dying from it."

Eskel shot him a pointed look and sighed:

"Lambert, let Geralt talk."

Geralt continued, his tone a bit heavier than before:

"Like Lambert said, it's an extremely dangerous trial. Survivors often come out of it weakened, sometimes with lasting damage and unfortunately, for those who don't make it, it's never a gentle death. Either way, the formulas for the potions used were lost a long time ago."

Lambert nodded.

"Good riddance."

That's exactly the detail that caught my attention: normally, Vesemir shouldn't have leaned on that whole "lost formulas" story so easily after all, isn't he the mentor here? Maybe I was just overthinking it. But he stayed quiet on the matter, and quickly steered the conversation elsewhere:

"Anyway, Ciri, you'll be trained by Geralt and Aiden, since you're the more advanced of the two. With me, it'll be monster lore. Once Geralt's done with you, Ciri, it'll move to combat training. With Eskel, you'll both learn the different combat styles across the schools there are several. And with Lambert, it'll mostly be hunting, potions, and bombs."

Lambert gave a small laugh.

"I'll teach you bomb-fishing, kid."

Vesemir sighed, then smiled softly at Ciri and me.

"I got your rooms ready figured you'd want to sleep next to each other, so that's what I did. Go get some sleep, kids. Tomorrow, training starts for real."

We nodded, and Ciri and I left the table to go explore the castle a bit. She pulled me by the arm, smiling, snapping me out of my thoughts:

"Come on, Aidy! Don't lag behind!"

13: Chapter 13 : Training

Training had already been underway for a few days now. Vesemir had taken charge of starting mine, as promised, while Geralt mostly focused on Ciri she needed to learn the basics first. As for me, being the more advanced of the two, I went straight into more serious training.

The snow was still coming down hard; we were already at the midpoint of winter.

Vesemir snapped his fingers, jolting me out of my thoughts, and said calmly:

"Knowledge isn't learned by staring at the scenery, young man."

I snapped out of my daydream.

"Right, sorry, Vesemir."

He nodded, grabbed a particularly thick book, and continued calmly:

"All right, let's start the quiz. What's the difference between a katakan and an ekimma?"

I thought for a moment.

"If I remember right, the main difference is intelligence? The katakan's more bestial than the ekimma, isn't it?"

Vesemir nodded, opening the bestiary in front of him, and went on with his explanation:

"Correct. But never forget any monster, whatever it is, can be deadly to any witcher, weak or not. A katakan, for instance, is classified as a lesser vampire an ekimma, on the other hand, as a higher vampire."

Curious, I asked:

"Why that kind of classification, exactly? Is it based on how dangerous they are?"

Vesemir nodded.

"Good question. Knowledge is the best weapon against any enemy."

He settled comfortably into his chair we were in Kaer Morhen's library and continued, calm:

"Lesser vampires are closer to animals, in intelligence, in awareness, and in raw strength. Careful, though, I'm not saying they're weak far from it. A seasoned katakan can easily wipe out a whole battalion of trained soldiers."

He went on:

"As for higher vampires, it's mostly a matter of intelligence. There's even a hierarchy among them: ekimmas, for instance, are sort of the 'common folk' class of higher vampires, if you want to think of it that way. Beyond that, there are higher vampires fully capable of blending in among humans, starting a family, having children those children are called dhampirs. Honestly, we know very little about higher vampires overall, other than that they arrived during the Conjunction of the Spheres. But one thing's certain, a hundred percent: there are vampires even more powerful than higher vampires. Only a handful of witchers can stand against them and when I say a handful, I mean extremely few."

He looked at me.

"Take this with a grain of salt, though I got it from a witcher I crossed paths with in my youth, from the Manticore School. He told me about the ancient vampires: the most powerful the world has ever known. Thankfully, they mostly just keep the higher vampires in line. But from what he told me, ancient vampires are scattered across the world not many of them, sure, but no witcher, and I mean none, could ever kill one."

I looked at him, surprised after all, in my eyes, what I'd seen of Geralt already outclassed every fighter I'd ever come across.

"That powerful? Seriously?"

He nodded, serious.

"Honestly, even I have my doubts I've never seen one myself, no book really talks about them. But it's the truth: no witcher could withstand one. Actually, I'm not even sure anyone in this world could."

I stayed quiet for a moment. I understood this world better and better and the more I learned, the more I realized just how far some monsters outclassed anything I could have imagined, whether in strength or intelligence. Quietly, under the table, I clenched my fist. I'm weak, damn it.

The hours passed like that, Vesemir continuing his lessons on monsters.

The weeks eventually stretched into two months. The snow fell less heavily now, though it was still very much present. That day, it was physical training with Geralt and Eskel. I found Ciri sitting on some logs, covered in bruises, hair damp with sweat, and smiled as I approached.

"Rough?"

She laughed.

"Geralt didn't go easy on me at all. But I like it I actually feel useful for once!"

I smiled.

"You know you're already useful, Ciri. Don't think like that."

She shrugged.

"Maybe, in your eyes, but…" She held my gaze. "I promised I'd be by your side, and right now you're way ahead of me. I'm gonna catch up to you, Aidy and actually stand beside you for real."

I smiled slightly, ruffled her hair affectionately, and went off to join Geralt for my own training.

Arriving there, he pointed at a cart wheel.

"Warm-up for now: you're carrying this wheel around the field until I say stop."

I nodded and got to work.

POV Ciri

Sipping my water, I'd been watching Aidy carry that cart wheel for several long minutes, Geralt standing beside him, arms crossed, silent as ever. A hand came to ruffle

my hair: Lambert, Eskel, and even Uncle Vesemir were approaching. Even though we'd only been training here for a few months, I'd quickly grown fond of these old men Lambert and Eskel felt a bit like older brothers, always eager to teach us something new.

I still laughed thinking back to the day Lambert took Aidy "bomb fishing," after Vesemir had asked him to teach him the basics of explosives Lambert had made a point of explaining that practice beat theory any day. The result: Aidy came back with an impressive haul of fish for that night's dinner, while Geralt and Eskel snickered and Lambert conveniently ignored Vesemir's scolding about it being absolutely not the right method. But judging by the smile on Aidy's face, and how much closer he'd gotten to Lambert since then, I think it was actually a pretty good idea it's rare to see him smile that much.

With Eskel, it was a similar kind of closeness, but centered around the Wolf School's combat techniques. The two of them hit it off fast it was actually pretty funny watching them both slip in the mud together, that one day.

Flashback

POV Ciri

After my own training, I'd sat with Geralt on a stone parapet, watching Aidy train with Eskel. Looking up at Geralt, whose beard was just starting to grow back in, I asked, curious:

"Geralt, what exactly are the Wolf School's fencing techniques? I know it's dodging and countering, but not much beyond that."

Geralt nodded, leaned against the parapet, arms crossed, eyes still fixed on the training.

"There are three main techniques. Like you said, dodging's the first but it's not as simple as it looks. Watch."

I watched the training: several times, I saw Aidy try to dodge, only to end up taking hits from the wooden sword. I winced at every impact that was gonna leave some serious bruises but bit by bit, he started dodging most of the attacks better. Geralt, beside me, asked:

"So, you see it?"

I shook my head, looking at him.

"Is it experience?"

He shook his head too, pointing a finger toward my eyes.

"It's the gaze. Humans or pretty much any living creature, with a few exceptions tend to look with their eyes wherever they intend to strike. Of course, if the creature has no eyes, or is blind, that's different, but in most cases, it's the eyes you need to read. That said, you're not wrong about experience either: even if Aiden's probably picked up on this instinctively, without even realizing it, there's still a gap in experience and raw physical power. Even knowing how to dodge, if the body doesn't follow, or doesn't react fast enough, that's still a problem."

I kept watching, this time seeing Aiden hit the ground more often under the wooden sword's blows. I saw him bleeding slightly, which made me bite my lip, but I said nothing, and asked instead:

"And that, over there, what's that?"

Geralt smiled.

"Try to guess. Countering, or something else?"

I thought about it, watching the fight more closely. Aiden kept falling into the snow; every time, Eskel would help him back up but each time, he switched combat styles. I didn't get it… it didn't look adapted to anything…

I fell silent for a moment, then looked at Geralt.

"Adaptation."

He smiled, visibly proud.

"Exactly. That's the third teaching of the Wolf School. We're known for dodging and parrying, sure, but the third pillar, far less known, almost secret that's learning to adapt mid-combat."

He continued:

"In life, you'll often run into situations theory alone can never solve. That's why, from the youngest age, we train to adapt, to force our minds to keep evolving as a fight drags

on the longer a fight lasts, against a person or a monster, the more you adjust to their patterns, their abilities. Simply put: the longer the fight, the more you adapt."

I was genuinely surprised. I watched Eskel start training Aidy on countering, then turned back to Geralt.

"Do the other schools have this too?"

He shook his head.

"No. I could be wrong, but their combat styles wouldn't really lend themselves to it. Ours works specifically because it's built around countering and dodging that naturally makes us better at reading and adapting mid-fight. The other schools just don't have the right structure for that."

At the end of the two-hour training session, I hopped down from the stone parapet to join Aidy, whom Eskel was helping to his feet, Geralt following along behind me.

End of flashback

POV Ciri

Smiling a little, curious it was rare to see them all gathered together like this I asked:

"So why are you all here, anyway?"

Vesemir sighed. Eskel came to stand beside me, gently holding my arm, as if to keep me from moving. I looked at them, confused, worry creeping in.

"Eskel? Lambert?"

Lambert, arms crossed, stared silently at Geralt only at Geralt with a heavy, complicated look on his face.

I stammered:

"Lambert?" Then turned to Vesemir, my voice small: "Uncle Vesemir?"

He shook his head.

"Ciri, we're all here because Geralt needs to do something check on something and it concerns Aiden's life. We're here just in case, to support him, and also to keep you from putting yourself in danger."

POV Geralt

Arms crossed, I watched Aiden push through his warm-up. This was hard… I kept replaying the conversation we'd had the night before, with Vesemir, and I understood now, far better, just how precious Ciri and Aiden were but more than that, just how close Aiden was to dying. I needed to check it for myself. Even though I wanted to trust Vesemir's word, I…

I needed to be sure of what he'd told me.

Flashback

POV Geralt

Walking down the stairs toward Vesemir's potion lab, where he'd summoned me, I couldn't help but smile, replaying the scene where Ciri had thrown food at Lambert to throw him off during his arm-wrestling match against Aiden a match he'd ended up losing, before chasing Ciri clear across the dining hall.

Shaking my head, I finally reached the lab. I found Vesemir examining some strange flowers and walked over.

"You called for me?" Then, looking closer at the flowers: "I don't recognize any of these. New species?"

One of the planters held some rather unusual flowers: petals of an incredible whiteness, a stem of a green that seemed frozen in time. My medallion vibrated just from looking at them. But it was the other wooden planter that caught my attention most: its petals looked made of snow and ice, as if frost had frozen right onto them, the stem shifting between the two colors. I couldn't sense any magic coming off them but my medallion buzzed violently the moment I touched one. An intense cold shot through me, like my hands were about to freeze solid in seconds.

Vesemir said, from behind me:

"Yeah. It's urgent. And it's serious."

I set the flower down, crossed my arms, and looked at him. He continued, grave:

"The white flower's a species we thought extinct. It's called the flower of time it normally only blooms under extremely specific conditions, conditions that are basically impossible to meet. And it bloomed right where Ciri trains, right where she bleeds."

I looked at him, confused:

"Flower of time?"

He gave a bitter smile:

"You probably know it better as a cynoglossum the flower that only grows where…" I cut him off:

"Where the Elder Blood flows…"

He looked surprised:

"How do you know that?"

I looked at him, the words coming hard:

"I thought I was wrong. But ever since Ciri was born, I've started having visions and in one of them, I heard that name."

Vesemir sighed:

"I won't ask why you never mentioned it everyone's got their secrets. But you understand what this means, right?" I nodded, not wanting to dwell on it any further, and pointed at the other planter. "And this one?"

Vesemir's face went hard.

"This one's worse. It bloomed exactly where Aiden trains with you and Eskel where he bleeds, too. It's a species I've never seen anywhere. But I can state quite a bit, even if some of it's still guesswork."

He lifted a petal between his fingers.

"I've run several tests. I'm certain both Ciri and Aiden carry Elder Blood in them but not the same way, not through the same bloodline. I know it's hard to explain, and I'm no mage, but let's just say my tests show the intensity and the flow aren't the same at all between the two of them."

I shook my head.

"Break it down for me simply. I'm starting to feel like I'm listening to a certain black-haired sorceress telling me I don't get it."

He sighed.

"If you want a picture: imagine two glasses of water. Ciri's the glass filling up calmly, slowly and the glass itself is perfectly suited to hold that water. All we have to do is let time do its work."

Then, more gravely:

"Aiden, on the other hand, is the exact opposite. Like I told you, I used several magical instruments to study this and every time the flower got near one of them, it was like an invasive kind of magic: it latched onto the device, swallowed up all its magic, reducing it to nothing but a dead trinket. That's why this is serious."

He set the petal back down on the table, which frosted over almost instantly in a small patch around it.

"The human body isn't built to hold that much magical power, not at that age. Aiden's literally the opposite of Ciri: the glass overflows, and on top of that, the glass itself isn't remotely suited to hold it in the first place. And…"

He looked at me, his voice suddenly harder to get out:

"Even a witcher couldn't absorb it I tried it myself, impossible, whether as a potion or swallowed straight. Our bodies, even ours, aren't capable of containing this flower."

He didn't notice that I'd frozen in place the only thing I still heard, right before sinking into something close to despair, were his final words:

"Aiden's going to die if we don't do something. There are only two options: either we call on mages far more skilled than me on this, or we try a temporary fix draining that magic out of him. To do that, he'll need to be pushed through intense emotions. Otherwise… I don't think he'll survive the winter."

14: Chapter 14 : The Breaking Point

POV Aiden

I heard Geralt's voice behind me as I kept doing laps around the field, cart wheel in tow.

"Aiden, that's enough, grab a sword and come here."

Wiping the sweat from my forehead, I walked over to the rack of blunted swords. Approaching Geralt, sword in hand, I noticed, confused, Ciri being held back by Eskel and Lambert, while Vesemir watched me, his face grim. I didn't have time to wonder why: Geralt attacked me right away.

On pure reflex, I blocked overhead but he used the opening to sweep my legs out from under me with a trip, sending me to the ground. I heard him as I got back up:

"That's it?"

I shook my head and straightened up. He'd just caught me off guard. I went back on the offensive, trying a few feints going for his flank to set up a kick to his ribs but every time, he countered, parried, or dodged, effortlessly. What hurt worse, though, was watching his eyes fill, bit by bit as the fight dragged on, with disappointment. Contempt, even?

I shook my head. Contempt? Geralt couldn't possibly...

But I didn't get to finish that thought: he grabbed my arm just as I was about to parry, headbutted me hard enough to draw blood from my nose, twisted my arm until I dropped my sword, and shoved me down with a kick that sent me back to the ground.

Getting up, I saw drops of blood staining the snow. Watching him, disbelieving, I saw him approach, his face full of contempt.

"What's the point of all our training, then? Seriously, you can't even land a proper counter. Get up."

I gritted my teeth in frustration and went back into the fight.

POV Ciri

Every time I saw Aidy hit the ground, bleeding, I couldn't understand what was happening. I kept trying to get to Geralt, to tell him to stop this wasn't him, something was wrong but Eskel kept holding me back, gripping my arm tight. I pulled against it, trying to break free.

"Eskel, let go of me!"

He shook his head without even looking at me. It was Vesemir who answered, calm:

"Ciri, calm down."

I glared at him, a dark anger rising in me.

"Calm down? Look what's happening! Let me go!"

Maybe drawn by the noise, Aidy turned his head toward me, despite his bloodied face, and started to say something but Geralt ripped the sword out of his hands, holding it in his free hand while sheathing his own, and struck Aidy full in the face, sending him crashing to the ground. As if mocking him, the snow started falling harder, slowly blanketing his motionless body.

The sight froze me with horror. I struggled with everything I had in Eskel's arms, tears of frustration spilling out.

"Let go of me! Aidy!"

I threw a few elbows into Eskel's stomach, uselessly. Lambert, jaw clenched, finally snapped:

"Old man, if you've got a plan, now's the time to spit it out! Either you tell her, or I will even I'm sick of this whole act! Look at Geralt, even he wants to stop!"

Vesemir stayed silent for a moment, then answered:

"No, Lambert. I can't tell her, or the illusion won't hold, and…" He lowered his head. "After this, I'll apologize to them both, directly, and take full responsibility. So Lambert stay put."

Lambert stomped his foot in the snow.

"God damn it!"

I still didn't understand what was going on, but I could tell something was off. For now, all I could think about was Aidy.

POV Aiden

I struggled back to my feet. Damn it, he hadn't held back at all. And worse, I hated seeing him look at me like that, I…

Geralt grabbed me by the collar, hauling me up, contempt or so I thought, I could barely hear anything past a dull ringing, my whole focus locked on his eyes, brimming with disappointment. I gritted my teeth and swung at his face with my free hand he caught it with his own. That stopped me cold for just long enough that, with my other hand, I managed to strike the weak point of his arm enough to make his fingers loosen and drop my sword. I caught it mid-air and hurled it toward his throat, believing, for one brief second, that I'd finally beaten him.

But he let go of me, dodged effortlessly, and drove a kick into my ribs. Teeth clenched against the pain, I grabbed his foot before slamming the metal pommel of my sword against his calf, making him wince. He wrenched free with another kick and charged at me the last thing I saw before hitting the ground was his hand slamming into my face.

POV Geralt

Breathing steadily, I wiped the sweat from my forehead. I knew Aiden was talented, a real prodigy but damn it, this had been anything but easy. I've fought in countless battles, I've got the experience, and even holding back from seriously hurting him, I had to draw on everything I had just to keep pace. His strikes carried a strength and weight far beyond normal. I don't know where he gets that kind of power, but if I hadn't been a witcher, even I would've had to dodge instead of parry there's no way I'd have held up otherwise.

I clenched my teeth. I don't want to do this…

But I have to, to save you, Aiden. I hope you can forgive me for what I'm about to say.

I walked toward him, snow falling harder now, and seeing his bloodied face, I instinctively clenched my fists in anger at myself. I said, coldly:

"That's all you've got? You're right, you're pathetically weak. You say you want to protect Ciri, but I don't see any improvement in you. You're weak, and you'll stay weak forever."

I picked up his fallen sword.

"Tomorrow, you're leaving this keep. You're useless here, and I don't need dead weight like you around."

I turned my back on him, hoping with everything I had that this would work because if it didn't, I genuinely had no idea what else could push him this far.

POV Aiden

I watched the snow fall onto my face, those soft little flakes such a strange contrast to the pain radiating through my whole body but I think Geralt's words hurt worse than any of it.

Me? Weak? Yeah. I already knew that.

Almost against my will, I turned my eyes toward Ciri, still struggling in Eskel's arms, while Geralt walked toward them, his back to me.

I blinked and in that instant, I saw Cintra burning, Nilfgaardian soldiers standing where the witchers had been, holding Ciri back. I watched her being taken away, fighting fiercely, and heard Calanthe's furious voice ringing in my head:

"You had one duty! Protect Ciri! I should have known you'd stay hidden at the bottom of that pit."

Then Mousesack's, dripping with contempt:

"I thought you were a good student. I was wrong. You're worth nothing. You're not my student anymore."

And finally, Geralt's words:

"You're useless. You're pathetically weak. Leave this keep."

Leave this keep?

Ciri, alone?

Me, weak?

I screamed:

"SHUT UP!"

And I felt an immense wave of cold burst out of me. I don't remember anything after that except a voice, distant, murmuring: "Ceanndraig, not yet. But we'll meet again."

General POV

As Geralt walked back toward the others, his gaze dark, a wave of freezing cold erupted behind him. He didn't even have time to turn around: instinct took over and he dodged but not fast enough. A massive volley of compact ice spikes tore through his left side. He gritted his teeth against the pain.

Aiden surged forward with astonishing speed, gliding across sheets of ice like skates, cutting through the air. Reaching Geralt, he lashed out with a kick that shifted mid-strike into a razor-sharp ice spike. Geralt barely had time to cross both arms in front of him to absorb the blow, which sent him flying into the rocks, arms torn open and bleeding.

The rest of the group froze in horror for a moment. Lambert charged at Aiden, Vesemir right behind him, trying to divert his attention but Aiden now fought like a machine, without a shred of hesitation. The fight was brutal: spiked ice traps kept erupting from the ground without warning, and the air itself seemed to be freezing solid, harder and harder to breathe. Eskel let go of Ciri and rushed to Geralt to hand him a Swallow potion. Ciri stood frozen in place, eyes locked on Aiden and strangely, no attack, no injury ever seemed to reach her. Everything around her stayed untouched, as if the ice itself had chosen to protect her.

POV Geralt

I grimaced, swallowing down the Swallow potion. Eskel asked, worried:

"So, White Wolf, taking a nap already?"

I grimaced again.

"No. But I'll admit, I wasn't expecting this."

Ahead of me, I could see Lambert and Vesemir doing everything they could to hold their ground against Aiden, even though the outcome already looked grim both of them bleeding from multiple wounds. I even heard Lambert shout:

"Old man, if you've got an idea, now's the time! I don't wanna end up a damn popsicle!"

Vesemir rolled across the ground to dodge a massive ice spike and cast Quen:

"Shut it, Lambert! Watch your footing better!" A spike still punched through his magical shield, sending him tumbling a short distance away.

The air kept growing harder to breathe. Getting back up, teeth gritted, I turned to Eskel.

"Come on, we need to help them."

He nodded, and we ran together to join the other two.

POV Ciri

My eyes stayed locked on Aidy. No that wasn't Aidy, not really. That was cold. He'd lost that warmth that always defined him.

His skin kept cracking, gradually covered over in ice. Despite their combined efforts, Geralt, Vesemir, Eskel, and Lambert weren't getting anywhere: every time one of them tried to close the distance, a massive ice spike would erupt to force them back.

The air had become unbearable for them I could see them struggling to breathe. That's exactly why Lambert didn't manage to dodge a spike that pierced his shoulder; he barely had time to cast Quen before an ice club sent him slamming into the stone.

They weren't going to hold. I could feel it, deep down and somehow, without knowing why, I was certain I could help him. Me. I started walking toward him. I heard Geralt shout:

"Ciri, get back!"

But he had to dodge another wave of attacks himself. I kept walking anyway, certain of what I was doing and nothing touched me. No attack, nothing at all.

Reaching Aidy, he stopped dead, staring straight into my eyes, no emotion visible at all. His left eye glowed icy blue, the other pure white, like snow. His hair had turned completely, snowy white.

But I wasn't scared. I wrapped my arms around him, despite the intense cold radiating off him, and murmured softly:

"Aidy, I know this isn't you. Come back to us. There's no danger, not to me, not to you so come back, okay? Dinner needs to be served."

Maybe it was my voice I'll probably never really know why but the air went back to normal all at once. The witchers could finally breathe freely again, and the ice shattered around him. His eyes returned to their normal color. I heard, right against my ear:

"Forgive me, Ciri. I must have scared you."

I shook my head.

"No. I could never be scared of you, Aidy. We promised each other, didn't we? We'll always stand side by side!"

He smiled softly but even as his eyes settled back to normal, they'd changed color for good, and his hair stayed snow white. Before I could say anything else, I heard him murmur:

"Sorry… I wish I could've kept our promise, Ciri."

I looked at him, confused, when I heard a sharp crack: his skin was turning into ice, spreading over his flesh. I stammered:

"Aidy?"

He gave one last soft smile, closed his eyes, and collapsed against my shoulder, unconscious. I could barely hold him up, screaming in panic:

"Lambert! Eskel! Vesemir! Geralt!"

Lambert rushed over despite his wound, scooped Aidy up into his arms, and took off running toward the castle with Eskel, heading for the infirmary. Before joining them, I

turned to Geralt and Vesemir, both injured, and fixed my eyes on Geralt in particular, biting my lip to hold back tears of frustration.

"Do something, Geralt. I… I will never forgive you if something happens to him."

Then I ran to catch up with Eskel and Lambert.

POV Geralt

Watching Ciri run off, her last words still echoing in me, it felt like my heart was tearing apart. All I could do was stay silent. I knew all of this had been to save his life… but I never imagined it would get this bad. I never wanted to say those words, or put either of them in danger least of all them.

Vesemir pulled me out of my thoughts.

"We got it wrong. If Aiden hadn't had to hold that power inside him all these years if someone had helped him channel it, day by day this might never have happened. But instead, it's like we just uncorked a well about to overflow. This is on me, Geralt, I…"

I shook my head.

"No. Don't apologize."

I wiped my hair, soaked with sweat and blood. I ached everywhere, my shirt in tatters, soaked through with blood. My arms still bore the marks from Aiden's ice spikes but honestly, none of that mattered to me. My eyes stayed fixed on the direction they'd carried him. Vesemir asked:

"Any ideas?"

I nodded, looking at him.

"Yeah. Just one. The other option: I need to call a sorceress. I'm calling Triss."

15: Chapter 15 : The Sorceresses

(Hey everyone, sorry about Monday I was busy all day and couldn't even get this chapter posted in time. Anyway, thanks to everyone leaving comments, reviews, and power stones on to the next part of your story!)

POV Yennefer

I grimaced slightly, walking through the streets of Novigrad. I will never understand why seers insist on setting up shop in such squalid places.

My heels were ruined, caked in mud, not to mention all these men who wouldn't stop whistling as I passed…

I opened the seer's door without waiting for an invitation. She was in the middle of a conversation with a beggar, who was no doubt asking her when he'd finally strike it rich. I didn't really have time for that, so I said calmly:

"Excuse me, dear sister, but I'm in a hurry."

The beggar, furious at being interrupted mid-session especially since the seer had clearly been about to tell him he'd just crossed paths with a stunning woman turned around: "Listen, ma'am, I'm already…" But he froze the instant he saw me.

The seer smiled faintly.

"Looks like you got your revelation. If you'd please leave us."

The beggar grumbled, but eventually left, head down. I stepped aside to let him pass, then approached the seer.

"You sent me a message saying my destiny had changed. I was curious after all, your so-called destiny told me, in no uncertain terms, that I'd end up with the White Wolf. And unfortunately for you, we're not together anymore. So?"

The seer gave a small laugh.

"True, you're not together anymore. But that doesn't mean you'll never see him again, does it?"

I was about to snap back, but she cut me off:

"Let me save you some time I'll get straight to the point. What I saw was far more important than that."

I sighed, crossing my arms, and said, sarcastic:

"Of course. I'm listening to the impenetrable voice of destiny, go ahead."

She closed her eyes; her pupils vanished, leaving only white. In a flat, monotone voice, as if someone else were speaking through her, she said:

"Yennefer of Vengerberg. An extremely important choice, in your life, will decide the fate of this world. Will you choose the path of the black sun's banners, or the path of the Pen..." But she never finished the sentence. She caught herself against the table, breaking into a sweat, before continuing, her voice exhausted: "That's all I have. But at least now you know."

I laughed, sarcastic:

"Great. So I've got a choice between Nilfgaard and a name you can't even finish saying. What a waste of time."

Without waiting for her answer, I left. But I still heard her voice as I teleported away:

"Yennefer of Vengerberg. Fate isn't necessarily bad. But like you said yourself, it's your choice and I hope you never come to regret it."

That crazy old woman, honestly. Me, Yennefer of Vengerberg, worry about a fate she can't even manage to fully put into words? She's dead wrong.

I teleported away.

POV Triss

I sighed at home, in Novigrad, turning the communication crystal over between my fingers the twin of the one I'd given Geralt. And yet, that idiot had never once called me with it.

I heard a voice behind me that made me smile despite myself:

"So, Triss? Still waiting on your white-haired knight in shining armor?"

I laughed lightly, got up to hug her, and said softly:

"Good to see you, Yen. I figured you'd still be busy scheming at the Aedirn court?"

She shook her head, settled into a chair, and poured herself a glass of wine.

"No, you know how much all that plotting disgusts me and the king who won't stop eyeing me like I'm a piece of meat. Anyway. And you, Triss, enjoying waiting on your knight in shining armor?"

I sighed, sitting down across from her.

"Stop it. You know exactly how Geralt is."

She laughed, more easily than before back when I used to talk about Geralt, her laugh always carried a note of sadness and bitterness, but it seemed like the breaking of that magical bond between them had finally freed her from it. She went on:

"Let me guess: hopeless with feelings, incapable of understanding that when a woman gives you a communication crystal, it's so you'll actually talk to her even from far away. I'll bet you the first time he calls, it'll be to ask for help."

I laughed softly.

"Fine, bet's on. Ten crowns."

Yen shook her head, teasing:

"That's pretty cheap, Triss, for one of the most talented potion-makers on the continent. Let's say a hundred crowns."

I sighed.

"Fine, bet's on."

The moment I finished that sentence, the communication crystal started ringing. I jumped to my feet, heart racing, hearing Yen laugh behind me. Flustered, I snapped:

"Shut up, Yen."

I accepted the connection. Geralt's low voice came through, slightly out of breath, as if he were catching his breath, or gathering his strength:

"Hey, Triss. Sorry for calling out of nowhere."

Yen came to stand next to me, a teasing smile on her lips, rubbing her fingers together in the universal gesture for money. I sighed and answered softly:

"It's fine, Geralt. Are you calling about something specific?"

He hesitated before answering:

"Yeah. I need help."

Yen burst out laughing beside me:

"Ha, I knew it!" which made me blush with embarrassment.

Geralt, hearing that, asked, surprised:

"Yen?"

She snatched the crystal out of my hands.

"Thank you, gallant knight of my friend Triss thanks to you, I just won a hundred crowns."

I grabbed the crystal back, telling her to be quiet, still a little flustered:

"What do you need?"

His voice, uncertain, came through:

"What I'm about to tell you could make the whole world your enemy. I need to be sure before I say it I trust you both, but this could put your lives in danger."

I frowned, and so did Yen. She answered, serious:

"Are you being serious right now, Geralt? You think we don't already risk our lives every single day? So hurry up and spit out your information, we're not princesses that need protecting."

He sighed, then explained the whole situation with Aiden what had happened, the information they'd managed to gather, and the fact that we were the only two who could help. But it was the end of his sentence that made us both go still:

"And the princess of Cintra is here, at Kaer Morhen."

Yen burst out laughing:

"Damn, Geralt. You really outdid yourself this time."

I sighed softly:

"Of course we're coming to help. We're on our way."

Geralt sighed softly through the crystal:

"Thank you, both of you. Really."

The crystal went dark. I looked at Yen, serious:

"Any idea what's going on? Because from what Geralt just told us, all I can figure is that Aiden must be a mage whose powers woke up late and it just ended up exploding all at once, from never being channeled in time."

Yen shook her head and opened a portal toward Kaer Morhen.

"Doesn't matter. Let's go see for ourselves."

I nodded and followed her through the portal.

POV Geralt

I waited for the two sorceresses in the courtyard. Watching them appear, two very different memories hit me at once: with Yennefer, that moment she cried in my arms, cursing me for breaking the djinn's bond, feeling like her feelings had been a lie this whole time and with Triss, memories more along the lines of bed, and that little beauty mark on her right cheek…

Geralt. Focus.

I barely had time to string together a coherent thought before Triss was already there, her hand brushing my face, taking in my battered body, worried:

"Geralt… you're hurt everywhere. Was this Aiden?"

I nodded, my face darkening.

"Yeah. Didn't take the time to heal, I'm way more worried about him right now, don't worry about me."

She stroked my cheek gently, sighed.

"Okay."

Yen, behind her, was studying the courtyard with a serious look.

"Geralt, this could be far more dangerous than you think."

I looked at her, confused Triss too. As she examined the area herself, she looked just as surprised, just as worried, and turned to Yen:

"Yen, you don't actually think that's possible, do you? No sorceress alive except maybe Francesca, and even she's just a pale imitation. That's supposed to be impossible."

Yen shook her head, serious:

"Let's hurry."

I nodded. Walking into Kaer Morhen's great hall, a wave of intense cold hit us head-on. Vesemir approached, his face grim.

"It's uncontrollable. Lambert and Eskel are barely holding on, using Igni just to push back the ice and Ciri's the only one who seems completely untouched."

I nodded. Yen and Triss made a few hand gestures, wrapping us in a protective barrier. Walking forward, Triss said:

"Good to see you again, Vesemir, circumstances aside."

He nodded.

"Likewise, Triss. And good to see you too, Yen."

She gave a small laugh, nodding, her expression darkening further the deeper we went. Arriving at Aiden's room, the door wide open, we found the hallways already coated in ice from the cold wave. The two sorceresses' faces grew even grimmer. Unable to hold back my curiosity any longer, I asked, serious:

"What's going on, that's got you both looking so grim?"

Yen sighed.

"Magic existed before the Conjunction of the Spheres. But nobody today can use it in its original form anymore the Conjunction, according to most theories, degraded it significantly."

Triss continued, serious, conjuring a small fireball in her hand to push back the cold wave:

"The magic we use today is really just a branch derived from the old magic. What everyone uses now is, let's say… a corrupted version of the original magic. It's still usable, of course, but far weaker, far less efficient. Since nobody can use the old magic in its pure form anymore, it never really mattered in day-to-day life."

I asked, a little worried:

"So?"

Yen examined the ice, exchanged a look with Triss, then said, grave:

"So we're dealing with something that shouldn't even be possible and terrifyingly stronger than any mage or sorceress alive today. This ice is one hundred percent magically pure. In plain terms: it was produced by the old magic, the kind everyone assumed had vanished centuries ago."

She looked at me.

"Geralt, I don't know what mess you've dragged us into, but now, on top of everyone already after the princess, you're adding this boy into the mix. If mages ever learn he exists, every single one of them, without exception, will want to get their hands on him whether to study him, dissect him, or claim that magic for themselves."

Walking into the room, I saw Ciri, still, holding Aiden's hand his face asleep, but everything around him coated in ice. Lambert and Eskel kept alternating Quen and Igni without rest; Triss instantly relieved their exhaustion by warming the room with a wave of magic. As she approached the bed, Ciri sprang up like a cat ready to defend its territory:

"Who are you?"

Triss smiled softly.

"We're here to help. We're sorceresses I'm Triss Merigold, and this is Yennefer of Vengerberg."

Yen said nothing, simply studying the princess closely, as if making sure it really was her, before shooting me a look that said "you really do love attracting trouble, don't you." She took her place on Aiden's left side, while Triss settled on the right, next to Ciri. I clenched my fists, still crusted with dried blood, hoping with everything I had that they'd succeed.

Ciri grabbed Triss's arm, her voice anxious:

"Please, save him."

Triss smiled softly.

"We'll do our best."

Yen nodded.

"Now, little one, go join the bearded one."

Ciri hesitated, then got up and came to stand beside me. I rested a hand on her hair and said softly:

"They'll pull him through. They're the best sorceresses I know." She nodded, still worried my words were as much to reassure her as they were to reassure myself.

Yen examined Aiden's body first and said to Triss:

"His body's practically wrecked, Triss. I don't even know how he's still holding on but it feels like his magic's starting to mix directly into his blood. We need to stop that, his heart isn't built to handle it at all."

Triss nodded, and the two sorceresses began their incantation. All at once, as if they were bracing against a storm with bare hands, an immense wave of cold surged to overwhelm them. Aiden started thrashing, clearly in pain. Ciri tried to rush toward him, but I held her back, wrapping her in my Quen even the four of us witchers could barely stay standing inside our own protective bubble, the magic radiating off him was that intense.

Yen laid her hands on Aiden's body, lifting his shirt: his entire chest was covered in ice, as if his very skin had transformed. She unleashed her magic, and two titanic forces clashed for countless minutes, then hours. Eventually, Triss and Yen switched positions: Triss took over the magical fight while Yen rested briefly, still maintaining a shield around Aiden's heart.

The hours dragged on like that. The cold wave slowly weakened. I'd stepped out to heal myself after Ciri fell asleep in my arms I'd laid her down in my own bed, with Lambert, Vesemir, and Eskel watching over her while they worked on clearing the ice from the hallways. Once healed, I still stayed close to the two sorceresses, arms crossed, still bandaged in places, my eyes fixed on Aiden.

I…

I blamed myself terribly. I'd sworn to protect them, and here I was, the very first time I actually tried, having nearly killed him with my own hands. My face darkened.

But after hours of relentless effort, Aiden's skin finally returned to normal the ice vanished, along with the cold wave. Both sorceresses let out exhausted sighs. Yen looked at me, serious:

"You're going to have to talk, witcher. I want to know everything about him, because this isn't normal even granting that he carries the old magic, Triss and I are two sorceresses with considerable power and reserves, and it still took us hours of trading off just to contain his magic and his apparently bottomless reserve."

I nodded.

"I'll tell you everything. Actually, I need to tell you about Ciri too…"

Triss frowned, worried:

"Ciri too?"

I nodded.

"Yes. I think they both need sorceresses like you two to protect them really protect them. Even though I want to keep watching over them myself, I understand now that I'll never be strong enough on my own. So I'm going to tell you everything."

Yen wiped the sweat from her forehead and said, flatly:

"Fine. For now, be a gentleman and go get us something to eat and something to drink, while you're at it."

I nodded and left. Even with Yen's usual condescending tone, I knew she was just as worried as the rest of us. And Triss I knew she'd help us, without a moment's hesitation.

Sighing, I made my way to the dining hall to put together some plates.

16: Chapter 16 : The Conversation

POV Geralt

The days blurred together without my really noticing. Of course, for most people, that much time passing tends to build stress rather than ease it that was especially true for Ciri, who, after every training session with Vesemir, would rush off barely showered to go check on the two sorceresses.

As for Triss and Yennefer… let's just say Yennefer eventually gave up trying to claim space in the tower where I slept, knowing Triss had already settled in with me. So she'd commandeered an entire room for herself instead, reshaping it with magic to make it livable for however long this would take. Triss, meanwhile, had naturally moved into my room she often came to comfort me, even when I didn't show I needed it. In her eyes, apparently, it was obvious I still blamed myself for what had happened with Aiden.

Speaking of Aiden: his condition hadn't changed much. He still had at least one of the two sorceresses at his side at all times, continuously feeding him protective magic and training his heart to withstand it.

From what I'd eventually pieced together and I rarely understand much about magic, no matter how many times Yen smirks at my questions Aiden was like a glass of water exploding from the inside, and Triss and Yen were acting like craftswomen, working to contain the overflow while reinforcing the glass itself, so there'd eventually be no more danger.

Shaking my head slightly, I went back to Ciri's training. That day, Triss was resting while Yen watched over Aiden. Despite the biting cold, I'd suggested she stay inside; she'd shot back, sharp:

"I'm not a princess who needs protecting."

And yet, once outside, she'd taken my cape without even asking. Ever the gentleman, I'd wanted to say something but her glare had lodged the words firmly in my throat. Anyway.

Noticing she wasn't quite herself, I said calmly:

"Ciri. Your legs. You're being too passive."

She sighed and went back to the drill for several minutes, but I could tell something was off. I walked over, grabbed two logs, set them down in front of her which stopped her cold, confused and sat on one, gesturing to the other.

"Sit down, Ciri."

She grumbled:

"I don't need..."

I cut her off calmly:

"Ciri. Sit down."

She huffed and sat, arms crossed, carefully avoiding my eyes. Great. Teenage moodiness? Or is she still worried about Aiden I'm worried too, but this is the first time it's hit me this hard. Think, Geralt.

Rubbing my hands together, searching for the right words, I heard Ciri, still facing away from me:

"Is Aiden going to make it?"

I nodded.

"Of course he's going to make it. He's in the hands of the best sorceresses I know and trust me, I've known plenty of sorceresses."

I caught my own slip a beat too late, of course: from a distance, I heard Triss call out, half-amused, half-pointed: "Oh really? Plenty of sorceresses, huh?"

I… decided not to deal with that for now, staying focused on Ciri, and continued calmly:

"Look, I know this is hard, but…"

She cut me off, slightly offended:

"Stop treating me like a kid. You think I'm blind? I know exactly how hard this is."

I sighed, watching her close herself off again. Protection, information, combat those I can handle. Feelings?

I felt two hands slide onto my back, gently massaging the back of my neck, and Triss's familiar perfume drifted around me. She said, softly:

"Ciri, forgive Geralt. This is hard for him too, you know especially watching you turn into a real young woman."

Ciri looked at her, nodded as if I'd suddenly ceased to exist, and answered, as if she'd finally found someone who understood her:

"Yes! Exactly that!"

Triss laughed softly, settled herself onto my lap without ceremony, and continued:

"Ciri, Geralt's just not good with words he's never really had to deal with a young woman growing up before. A boy like Aiden, that's much easier for him."

She gently took Ciri's hands, looking her straight in the eye:

"Listen, Ciri. What Geralt was trying to tell you is that you're not alone in this. Vesemir blames himself. Lambert blames himself. Eskel blames himself. And Geralt blames himself, enormously."

Ciri glanced at me briefly, gripping Triss's hands a little tighter. Triss went on:

"Honestly, he understands exactly what you're feeling. He feels responsible for Aiden, and he thinks it's partly his fault Aiden ended up like this. Actually, you two are incredibly alike both stubborn as mules the second anyone tries to convince you it's not your fault."

She rose from my lap, pulled Ciri into a hug, stroking her hair as the girl went still for a moment, then continued softly:

"Ciri, Aiden's going to pull through. He'll come back to make you laugh, to stand by your side again and I bet you know him better than I do: he'll ask to see you first, much to Geralt's dismay, and right after that, he'll ask for food."

Ciri let out a small laugh, wiping her tears with her sleeve, amused despite herself:

"Yeah, that's exactly him. Even when I'd get hurt during our training back in Cintra, he was always the one comforting me first even when he was the one more injured. You'll

see, Triss, how impressive he is."

I smiled softly, watching the two of them open up to each other bit by bit. Getting up from my log to give them some space, I hesitated a moment, then gently brushed a hand down Triss's back, a silent thank-you. I felt her shiver slightly without even turning around, but I could easily tell she'd understood the gesture. I headed back inside, leaving the two of them to talk.

Arriving in the dining hall, I found Eskel and Lambert deep in a game of gwent, though I could easily tell, from their faces, that they were still worried. I patted Lambert's shoulder.

He jumped, startled:

"Geralt? What about training?"

I shook my head.

"Ciri was struggling with her feelings about Aiden's situation. Triss picked up on it right away, and she's handling it like a champ way better than I could."

Eskel teased:

"So the White Wolf admits he lost to a redhead?"

I shrugged.

"Not exactly a huge loss, in my book especially when it's her, the redhead in question."

Lambert burst out laughing, pointing at Eskel:

"I'll bet you anything, I know Geralt he probably did that on purpose just so we'd talk about his conquests."

Eskel took a drink, answering:

"Bet's on."

The two of them turned to look at me. I sighed.

A few hours later, after a few rounds of drinks with Lambert and Eskel which Lambert ended up winning, as usual I found myself, arms crossed, in Aiden's room, where Yen was working. Catching me staring at Aiden without a word, she finally said, gently:

"You really do care about him, don't you."

I blinked, looked at her I'd almost wanted to say no, but the words stuck in my throat. I just said:

"Yeah."

She looked mildly surprised, but I saw her nod and continue, softly:

"You know, we've never really talked about this, but after our bond broke, I wanted to curse you, even kill you. Deep down, I genuinely believed you'd just used me."

I started to answer, but she stopped me firmly:

"Let me finish."

I nodded, silent. She went on, calm:

"But seeing you like this, with him, I finally understood it was really you. You never abandoned me, even without the magical bond. Maybe your feelings changed, but I finally get why you never said anything back then, when I cursed you out loud after the bond broke you took every word, even the worst ones, without flinching."

Yen looked me straight in the eyes, serious:

"Remember this well, because it'll be the only time you ever hear it: I'm sorry, Geralt, for what I said back then. You didn't deserve that."

I was genuinely stunned Yennefer of Vengerberg, apologizing? Someone should mark the date on a calendar. I was about to tease her:

"Sorry, I didn't quite ca...."

But she cut me off sharply:

"Don't play with fire, witcher."

I stayed quiet, turning my eyes toward Aiden:

"Friends, then?"

A silence followed, then she answered softly:

"Yeah. Friends. But if you ever make Triss cry, I really will turn you into a white wolf, put a leash on you, and hand you over to her you'll become her actual white wolf."

I nodded seriously she'd absolutely follow through even though I'd never had any intention of making anyone cry. Speaking of her, right then I felt two arms wrap around me from behind; she rested her head on my shoulder, pressing a kiss to my neck, and asked softly:

"Did you two talk?"

Yen answered first:

"Yeah, him and me, we're friends now. I warned him that if he ever made you sad, I'd turn him into a white wolf for you."

Triss laughed, shooting me a look mixing desire and teasing:

"Like a pet… mmh, wouldn't mind that, actually."

I rubbed my forehead:

"Triss, don't start."

She laughed again, resting her head against my shoulder. I asked, curious:

"And Ciri?"

Triss murmured in my ear:

"Sorry, girls' secret. But I can tell you she's doing a lot better."

I nodded, my eyes still fixed on Aiden:

"Thanks, Triss."

She pressed a kiss to my cheek without another word there wasn't much left to say to prove we loved each other.

That's when Vesemir walked in, slightly out of breath, as if he'd just discovered something important, and asked hurriedly:

"Am I interrupting?"

We all shook our heads. He continued, arms crossed, calmer now:

"Yennefer, tell me honestly: how much longer before his body wakes up?"

Yen, the most knowledgeable of us all on the subject, frowned.

"Honestly? At least a few months, best case scenario. His body's completely wrecked, to put it kindly."

I clenched my fists, instinctively, the guilt rushing back all at once. Triss took my hand in hers and turned to Vesemir:

"If you're asking that question, you've already got something in mind."

Vesemir nodded and pulled out the flower I recognized immediately Aiden's, the one we'd already discussed. He addressed Triss:

"Listen, Triss. You're the best alchemist Geralt knows, and even I, with all my years of experience, can't hold a candle to you on this front. Could you…"

He hesitated, glanced at Yennefer, then continued:

"If his body were no longer human, but a witcher's instead could he hold on?"

A dead silence and a bone-deep chill fell over the room. Instinctively, I stood, ready to say something harsh to Vesemir he was proposing putting Aiden through *that* trial? Even without saying a word out loud, I categorically refused the idea of him going through it. But Triss laid a hand on my chest, calming me instantly. It was Yen who answered, cold, almost cutting:

"Are you hearing yourself right now? You want to put him through more suffering, Vesemir? I didn't realize your secret passion was torturing children."

Vesemir wasn't fazed by the remark and pressed on:

"Answer my question, Yennefer."

She sniffed coldly, thought it over for a long moment, then answered:

"In theory, yes. But from what I know, in his current state, he has zero chance of surviving the Trial of the Grasses. That would be nothing short of sentencing him to death."

He nodded, then turned to Triss:

"I know that. That's exactly why I'm asking you, Triss: if you had the full formula for the Trial's potions, could you modify it using this flower? Call it an old fool's crazy idea if you want, but I feel it, deep down this flower might be exactly what could save Aiden."

I stared at him, stunned, nearly furious:

"You kept the formula?!"

He didn't even answer me, keeping his eyes locked on Triss, who was deep in thought. After a long silence, she finally answered, grave:

"I can try. But I, and only I, will decide whether it's possible and I'll be the one administering the potion myself, personally. Those are my conditions, non-negotiable. Even though I like you, Vesemir, I have the final say on all of this. Is that acceptable to you?"

He nodded.

"Yes. Completely acceptable. I'm counting on you, Triss."

I turned to her, anxious:

"Triss… you know how horrific that trial is. I've told you already."

She stroked my cheek, gentle:

"I know. But I also know my own skills in alchemy, and this flower carries a purity of magical energy I've never encountered before. If anyone can pull off modifying the witcher's potion, it's me. Geralt, trust me, okay?"

I clenched my jaw, feeling utterly useless in the face of all this but seeing the sincere, determined look in Triss's eyes, I finally let the tension go, and said simply, softly:

"I'm entrusting Aiden to you, Triss."

She smiled tenderly, kissed me, and murmured:

"I'll save Aiden."

Then she went to join Yen to gather all the information they'd need about his condition, before getting to work.

I stayed a while longer, watching Aiden's sleeping face.

Aiden…

You'll wake up, kid. I swear it.

17: Chapter 17 : The Birthday

POV Ciri

Running easily through the woods, dodging branches, I chased a rabbit that darted fast but the natural obstacles kept forcing it to slow down, letting me close the gap.

Thanks to my training, I could move through bushes and rough terrain far more easily now, even if a branch occasionally whipped across me, leaving a thin cut behind. But my eyes stayed locked on the rabbit.

Dodging one last branch mid-run, I spotted an opening. I slid across the wet ground around a tight turn and grabbed the rabbit, struggling between my fingers I finished it off cleanly with my knife.

Wiping the sweat from my forehead, I looked at the castle, a little further off. Aiden still hadn't woken up, even though he no longer needed as much magical support as before just one session a day now, which Yennefer handled personally.

The months had flown by surprisingly fast, and spring had just arrived. And today was my birthday. Ironic, right? I was turning twelve today and I'd be celebrating without him.

Walking back toward the castle, wiping the dirt off my hands, I found myself thinking about the two sorceresses. I'd grown incredibly close to Triss I talked to her about everything, but mostly about my feelings. With Geralt, I know he'd have just nodded uncertainly if I'd tried explaining what I was feeling. He's a great protector, but pretty useless when it comes to emotions. Not that it matters just having him around is enough to reassure me most of the time.

As for Yennefer… let's just say it's more complicated. I think our personalities complement each other, but even I have to admit we both need the last word and sometimes, I'm the one who's wrong. I muttered under my breath, frustrated: "But I'll never tell her she's right."

Arriving at Kaer Morhen's gates Geralt had sent me out to hunt my own meal, apparently some witcher tradition for birthdays I saw Geralt, still wrapped in bandages, and couldn't help smiling as I showed off my catch.

"I got the rabbit!"

He nodded, teasing.

"I see that. But you know there's seven of us here, right? Planning on splitting it seven ways?"

I shook my head, patting his arm, amused, already walking toward the castle gate.

"Nope, not for you guys. It's for Aiden."

He nodded; I could still see that stubborn guilt lingering in his eyes. But I didn't blame him anymore honestly, I don't think I ever really did. Sighing, because sometimes he and Aiden were way too alike, I stopped, forcing him to stop too, and pulled him into a hug.

"Geralt, listen. I don't blame you. I never blamed you. It was just the heat of the moment and I know Aiden. He'll never hold this choice against you."

He smiled faintly, wrapping his arms around me.

"I hope so too, Ciri that Aiden wakes up someday. But even if neither of you blames me, I'll probably keep feeling guilty about it anyway. That's normal, don't worry comes with the responsibility. But thank you, your words really do mean a lot to me."

I nodded, smiling, and walked toward the door. Stepping inside, I saw Yen and Triss holding a dress that froze me in my tracks, the other three witchers grinning like idiots. The whole hall had been completely transformed into a party space, and Lambert's sarcastic voice rang out, amused:

"So, your little imaginary witcher hunt actually worked out?"

Eskel sighed.

"Lambert…"

It was Yennefer who shut him up with a single icy look. I stood frozen in front of the dress a gorgeous blend of white and green. I heard Geralt's amused voice, his hand landing on my shoulder.

"Had to get you out of the castle somehow to set up the surprise. Sorry for lying to you."

I shook my head, wiping my tears, and stepped toward the dress not without first shoving the rabbit into Lambert's hands, sticking my tongue out at him. I ran toward Triss, about to touch the fabric, but Yennefer caught my sleeve.

"Nope. You're filthy. Come on, little one."

Then she held my arm firmly, walking toward her room, Triss following with the dress, and said softly:

"Yennefer's right. You need to look stunning tonight, Ciri."

POV Geralt

I watched the three of them walk off, relieved to see Ciri really didn't blame me. Eskel approached, Lambert trailing behind him, teasing.

"So, what's it like watching her turn into a real young lady?"

I looked at Eskel, amused.

"Strange, I've gotta admit. Time flies way too fast."

Lambert laughed, starting to deal with the rabbit.

"Sounds like something Vesemir would say."

Vesemir, who'd just pulled out his old party hat and was already busy with dinner prep, answered flatly at the remark:

"At least Geralt's got the wisdom of an elder, like me. You, Lambert, I'll apparently need to keep teaching that wisdom to."

Lambert snorted, amused, and went to sit at the already-set table with Eskel. It warmed my heart, honestly, even if you wouldn't guess it from looking at me. I knew Lambert was still somewhat cold toward Vesemir when he'd learned about the whole plan, and that Vesemir had kept the formula hidden all along, he'd flown into a rage. He'd ended up disappearing into the woods for several days to cool off; I know him well enough to know he'd gone to sit by the unmarked graves of former witcher apprentices.

Eskel was less expressive about it, but I knew he'd taken Vesemir's lie hard too. Even I'd felt a sting of betrayal when I found out. But saving Aiden was my top priority and even though it turned my stomach, I'd come to accept it. At least it was all in Triss's hands now.

I sat down with Lambert, who wore a clearly provocative grin.

"Heard the famous White Wolf can't even beat a couple of kids at gwent."

I pulled out my own deck of cards, dead serious.

"That's an insult, Lambert. You're gonna regret that."

A few minutes later, I'd already lost twenty crowns to him. Seriously, his monster deck isn't even that complicated, and yet somehow he gets me every single time, without fail…

Lambert burst out laughing, openly mocking me. Eskel laughed too until he stopped dead, Lambert right along with him, both of them staring at something behind me, whistling low, visibly impressed. I turned around and found Ciri in her dress, Triss gently holding her by the shoulders, beaming. Ciri was blushing slightly, her hair pulled back into a ponytail. She'd grown up so much, without me even really noticing.

She looked at me, almost as if waiting for my verdict. I smiled softly.

"You look beautiful, Ciri. Like a real lady."

She laughed softly. Triss came to sit beside me, Ciri taking the other side, Yennefer settling at the head of the table. Lambert couldn't help but say, genuinely this time:

"Honestly, you look a lot less like a tomboy now."

Eskel and I sighed in unison:

"Lambert…"

Yennefer let out a disdainful laugh, pointing at Lambert while sipping her wine.

"And then you wonder why you've never got a sorceress at your feet. No point having a pretty face if you've got zero tact."

I heard Triss sigh beside me: "Yen…" Ciri, meanwhile, was clearly enjoying the show. Lambert burst out laughing, looking at Yen.

"Oh yeah? I'm only taking away one thing from that: you said I've got a pretty face. Even the great and terrifying Yennefer of Vengerberg just paid me a compliment."

She sighed, keeping that same disdainful smile.

"If it makes you happy, Lambert."

The two of them kept bickering, though it was clearly more for the fun of it, all in good spirits Ciri herself kept throwing in a jab here and there, just for the pleasure of winding Yen up. She really loves that, apparently.

I felt a hand slide into mine. Turning, I saw Triss smiling.

"It's good to see you more relaxed."

I sighed, squeezing her hand.

"Was it that obvious?"

She nodded, amused.

"Let's just say sometimes you looked like you were constipated."

I sighed with an amused smile. She stroked my hand with her thumb, then said softly:

"Don't worry my research on the potion's showing good results. I'm getting more and more confident it'll be safe."

She continued, taking a bite of bread.

"Aiden's flowers have purifying properties that strip out a huge amount of the toxicity from the original Trial recipe. Actually, if my theory holds up, we won't even need to worry about more witchers like him popping up the potion will be exclusive to his body, literally impossible to replicate on anyone else. But that's still theoretical for now, I can't guarantee it'll work yet."

I nodded and kissed her.

"Thank you, Triss."

Vesemir arrived with the main course, putting an end to the bickering.

"All right, kids, that's enough, let's eat."

Serving everyone, he sat down himself and said:

"Well. Tonight's a bit of a special occasion." He turned to Ciri, smiling softly. "Ciri. Happy birthday."

Everyone raised their glass, shouting "happy birthday" together. Ciri smiled, genuinely happy, thanking everyone. As we ate, I had this feeling, just for a moment, that we were a real family. My eyes drifted, almost against my will, to the spot between Vesemir and Triss: Vesemir had set an empty place, loaded with food, as if to say Aiden was part of this evening too, somewhere.

I closed my eyes for a moment to steady myself. I swear it, Aiden: the moment you wake up, I'll apologize to you, and I'll protect you and Ciri both even if this whole world wants your powers, I'll protect you, no matter what it takes.

The minutes passed. We finished off the cake Triss and Yen had brought back through their teleportation. Lambert, finishing his drink, said:

"Ah, nice to have something sweet. So, Ciri, what's your wish? It's your birthday, after all."

Ciri smiled, a little sadly.

"I've only got one wish. That Aiden wakes up."

I sighed Lambert, without meaning to, had completely shifted the mood with that question. I watched Ciri stand up, take Aiden's plate in her hands, and smile softly.

"Thanks for the birthday. I'll never forget it. I'm gonna go celebrate with him now."

She left, an extra piece of cake in her other hand, heading down the hallway toward the bedrooms. I started to get up to follow her, but Triss held me back, shaking her head.

"No. Let her go."

I hesitated, but eventually nodded, my eyes still fixed on the hallway. I heard Yen land one last jab on Lambert:

"Nice work, pretty face."

Lambert, finally catching the reference, just grumbled:

"Shut up, Yen."

POV Ciri

I'd just closed the bedroom door behind me, smiling softly at seeing him still asleep. He still wasn't waking up. Taking off the heels Triss had given me, I walked over to the stool beside him. Every night, I came to see him, to feed him he could eat, drink, but he never woke up.

Sitting down, I started feeding him gently, and said, into the silence of the room:

"I managed to kill a rabbit, you know. Caught it mid-chase!"

I laughed alone in the silence.

"You should've seen Lambert and Yennefer tonight. I definitely won that argument."

I kept talking, alone.

"You know, they gave me a dress. First time I ever really felt like a woman."

I went on, but felt tears rising, my voice starting to shake.

"The cake, it was your favorite flavor. The one I don't even really like."

Finishing feeding him, I bit my trembling lips, holding back my tears with everything I had.

"You know… I loved our family, tonight, so…"

I couldn't hold it back anymore. I laid my head on his chest, crying, overwhelmed with sadness.

"I miss you, Aidy. It's not the same, my birthday, without you. Please wake up. I miss you so much. I don't want to lose you."

I kept crying, stammering through my sobs.

"Aiden… I can't imagine my life without you… come back to me, please. I miss you so much. You promised you'd be by my side."

But only silence, and my tears, echoed in that room.

POV Geralt

I had my hand pressed over my face. I hadn't been able to stop myself from following her in silence, and hearing her cry, hearing those words, I clenched my fists until they bled, squeezing my eyes shut as hard as I could. Then I felt my head pulled gently against Triss's chest, her hand stroking my hair, murmuring:

"Don't hold it back. Not with me, Geralt."

I held her tightly, biting my lip, holding back my own tears with everything I had because yeah, I missed Aiden terribly too. And even for me, it just wasn't a real birthday, without him.

18: Chapter 18 : The unique potion

POV Geralt

It had been two weeks since Ciri's birthday. Since then, she'd gone all-business during training out of breath, drenched in sweat, sometimes hurt, we'd practically have to force her to stop and rest.

Triss and Vesemir spent most of their time down in the potion lab, in the cellar. I often had to bring them food myself, or the two of them would probably forget to eat entirely. As for Eskel and Lambert, they'd decided to get back on the Path winter was over, contracts would start rolling in again.

Flashback POV Geralt

Arms crossed, I watched Lambert and Eskel finish saddling their horses. I noticed Eskel had switched mounts and asked, curious:

"New horse?"

Eskel nodded, tightening the saddle strap.

"Yeah, won him in a card game. Named him Scorpion."

Lambert, finishing up with his own saddle, gave a small laugh.

"Scorpion? Seriously?"

Eskel looked at him, amused.

"Mock all you want, but I'm not the one who named my mare 'Elena' after that woman you kept visiting after every contract."

Lambert shrugged.

"Not my fault. Poor thing was lonely all the time, her husband was off on every battlefield imaginable, and in her eyes, I was basically her knight in shining armor."

I rolled my eyes.

"Sure, Lambert. And next you'll tell me Eskel pulls women in with that scar of his."

Eskel looked at me.

"Ouch. Low blow."

Lambert burst out laughing.

"Honestly, Geralt, you're about the only one who gets to play the moralist with us. Fine, you've never touched a married woman, sure but don't tell me you're some symbol of purity, you, the great Geralt, defender of the fair sex, sword of sorceresses."

I smiled, amused.

"All right, Lambert. I get it. You're jealous."

He laughed.

"Of course I'm jealous."

He stepped forward, we clasped forearms, and he said:

"Take care of yourself. And the kids, Geralt."

I nodded, did the same with Eskel, then asked:

"You want to wait for Ciri to come down and say goodbye?"

Lambert shook his head. Eskel, already mounted on Scorpion, answered:

"Nah. We'll see each other come winter anyway. Hoping to find Aiden back on his feet by then."

Lambert nodded, eyes drifting toward the castle.

"Yeah. Hope the kid pulls through, and Merigold's potion works out."

I nodded, serious.

"Yeah. Me too."

Because if it came down to it if it meant striking a deal with a demon, I'd do it. Even knowing that kind of choice never ends well. I just can't picture myself digging a grave for Aiden.

Lambert nodded, swung up into the saddle, and rode off, raising a hand.

"All right, later, White Wolf."

Eskel did the same. I answered simply:

"Good luck on the Path."

End of flashback

POV Geralt

I stirred the rabbit stew, glancing absently around the room. The dining hall was quiet, as usual Ciri had gone back to Aiden's room, Triss and Vesemir still locked away in their lab. I sighed.

That's when a portal opened. Yen stepped out, face closed off, clearly furious. She grabbed a random bottle of wine, poured herself a glass, took a sip, and grimaced.

"Damn it, this is piss…"

She kept drinking anyway.

I walked over, wiping my hands on a towel.

"Rare to see you this worked up. Even rarer to see you drink bad wine without a single complaint."

She gave a dry laugh.

"Yeah. I was with my dear friends the mages, sitting through one of their little meetings where they decide people's lives like they're moving pieces on a board, without a shred of remorse."

I sat down across from her, arms crossed.

"Isn't that kind of what you used to do, with me, during your little schemes?"

She smiled, stung, but kept her sarcastic tone.

"Oh, sure. Except with you, I always made it perfectly clear you were my pawn. And I don't recall you ever complaining, given what I paid you in return."

She drank more.

"Anyway, forget that. What's bothering me is that two factions are forming among the mages: those backing the northern kingdoms, and those leaning toward Nilfgaard."

I asked:

"I take it that's not going smoothly."

She shook her head.

"No. There's more support for the North right now what Calanthe did, at her death, turned a lot of opinion in her favor. But on Nilfgaard's side, the two heads of the movement are Vilgefortz and Fringilla, and their names alone carry a lot of weight. Worst part is, there's no one left to represent Skellige anymore, which could've tipped the balance clearly one way. Mousesack's been declared dead, his body was never found in Cintra's ruins, and no druid will speak to the mages since. So, in short: it's a mess. A dark one, at that."

I nodded.

"Hearing the famous Yen say 'mess' twice in one sentence really confirms how bad it is."

She smiled, sarcastic.

"You know, Geralt, the ones who repeat other people's words back at them, over-analyzing every syllable that's usually fools or simpletons. Which one are you?"

I shrugged. We probably would've kept going like that, but Triss came rushing in, hair a mess, dark circles under her eyes, a huge smile on her face.

"Geralt! The potion's ready!"

I stood up immediately, following without waiting, Yen right behind me. I asked, urgent:

"Triss, what's the success rate?"

She answered, still out of breath.

"Honestly? Ninety-nine percent. I always keep that one percent of uncertainty, because anything can happen but with Vesemir, I'm genuinely confident."

Arriving in the lab, I found Vesemir sitting down, rubbing his eyes, looking just as worn out. Seeing me, he grabbed a vial and held it out.

"We did it, Geralt."

I looked at the potion. Unlike the classic Trial of the Grasses potion, which was green, this one was a clear blue, almost like spring water but just holding it, I could feel the cold seeping into my hand. I asked:

"Explain it to me."

Yen, arms crossed behind me, cut in:

"Yeah, he's right I can feel this potion's packed with pure magic. Confirms the old magic hypothesis. Go ahead, Triss."

Triss nodded, clearly relieved to finally share her work.

"Actually, it's pretty simple once you get it. The classic Trial of the Grasses is basically like throwing a witcher apprentice into an arena to fight a leshen, armed with nothing but a steel sword. The goal isn't to kill him the goal is for him to survive. Except a leshen is extremely dangerous, even for a well-trained witcher. Result: only the best make it through."

She lifted the vial in her hands.

"Here, it's the opposite. The opponent's a simple drowner and the apprentice is armed with a silver sword, in master-crafted armor. Might as well call it a sure thing."

She continued, more softly:

"The only real issue is that this potion is extremely cold. And when I say cold, I mean if a normal human swallowed even a single drop, their whole mouth, their entire stomach, would freeze instantly. One drop would be enough."

I didn't get it. So Aiden would die? He was still human, after all.

Triss saw the question forming on both our faces and smiled.

"Figured you'd both think that. To answer: that's exactly why I keep saying this potion is exclusive to Aiden. His whole body's already used to that cold. For him, it'll be like drinking lukewarm water."

I nodded, but a doubt lingered.

"There's something I don't get. If his body's already used to that concentration of cold, of magic why isn't he waking up?"

Triss looked at Yen. Yen answered, thinking out loud.

"Because his body got strengthened naturally, sure but too violently. All at once. Imagine someone lands a massive punch straight to your gut, hard enough to knock you out cold. It might make you stronger, long-term. But how long do you stay unconscious after that? Depends entirely on when the body decides to reboot. That's exactly what's happening with Aiden."

I nodded, my stomach tightening a little.

"And these properties, then? These abilities he'll have?"

Vesemir, behind Triss, spoke up.

"First off, know that the base recipe hasn't really changed just a few ingredients, plus Aiden's flower. So he'll have roughly the same qualities as any witcher, with a few notable exceptions."

Triss picked up from there:

"You already know this, Geralt: you witchers are limited to the Signs, because the transformation blocks off almost all the rest of your magical potential. For Aiden, it'll be the opposite. He'll have the Signs, like any witcher Igni, for instance, among others but on top of that, he'll be able to keep casting real magic, mostly anything tied to water. From our research, mine and Yen's, his affinity for ice and water is… we've genuinely never seen anything that high."

I glanced at Yen for confirmation. She nodded.

"She's right. I've never seen that kind of natural talent for water magic."

Triss then pulled out a frozen, dead mouse, cradled in her palm.

"During our trials on a rat, we noticed something specific. The old magic always tries to improve, to adapt. Even seconds after death, the rat kept trying to live, to adapt, thanks to that magic."

She looked at Yen, a little excited by her own theory.

"So we've got a hypothesis. Our current magic, the kind everyone uses…"

Yen finished her sentence, a crooked smile on her lips:

"…is an adapted version of the old magic. It adapted to its environment, and in adapting, it degraded because it couldn't manage both at once, improving AND adapting. It sacrificed improvement to survive."

Triss nodded.

"Yeah, for now, it's still a hypothesis." She looked me straight in the eye. "But basically, it means that in Aiden's body, once he drinks this potion, both properties will stay permanently active continuous improvement, and adaptation. The improvement will be slow. Very slow. Vesemir and I ran some numbers, still hypothetical, but roughly: each year, he'd gain about 0.5% more strength compared to a witcher who just finished his mutations. You know how it works a witcher can still improve a bit through red, blue, or green mutagens from monsters, but that's it, that's the ceiling. Him, though…"

I finished her sentence, a little stunned:

"He'll keep improving. In a hundred years. And after that too."

For a second, the thought hit me out of nowhere: a century from now, I'd be long dead, and he'd still be there, still growing stronger. I pushed the thought away.

She nodded, serious.

"Yes. Aiden will become extremely powerful, over time. But that's not the most important part."

She looked at Vesemir, who picked up, grave.

"When we examined the rat since the formula's still largely based on the classic Trial of the Grasses normally, it should have lost all ability to reproduce, like any witcher. Except…"

Triss finished the sentence, eyes fixed on me.

"Like we explained, the old magic always tries to adapt, to fix whatever it can. We found it was actually correcting that fertility issue. Plainly put: within a few years, Aiden will become the first fertile witcher in history."

I stayed quiet for a moment. It had been years since I'd made peace with that, for myself without even really thinking about it most of the time. Maybe that was part of why I liked being around these kids so much. It made me feel…

Anyway. Don't think about that.

19: Announcement

Hi everyone, I'm going on vacation this week, so unfortunately there won't be any chapter this week. The next chapter, "Will Aiden make it out?", will be released next week on Monday.

Also, I really want to thank everyone who supports me, whether it's through comments or power stones. It means the world to people like me and beginner writers, as it keeps us motivated to write again the next day.

Anyway, have a great week and see you next week!

20: Chapter 19 : The Awakening

(Hi everyone, I'm back! Thank you all for your messages, power stones, and comments despite my absence !)

POV Aiden

I looked around. Just darkness.

No light anywhere.

How long had it been? I couldn't tell anymore. I'd lost all sense of time. My senses? I couldn't feel them at all.

Was I even still alive?

After some unmeasurable stretch of total silence, I heard a fragment of a voice.

"Aidy, my wish is to see you wake up, please."

Ciri? What wish are you talking about? I'm still here, aren't I?

Then, after another silence, I heard again:

"Geralt, are you sure you want to do this now?"

Geralt? What are you about to do?

I heard his voice answer:

"Yeah, we have to. I trust you, Triss and you and Yen are here to stabilize his body just in case. I just hope he wakes up."

Triss? Yen? Who are they?

But I didn't have time to wonder any further: I felt something like a needle prick in my arm. For the first time in what felt like forever, real pain. Raising my arm in that dark

space, I saw it clearly then I collapsed.

General POV

Watching Aiden shake, foam at his lips, Geralt held him steady while Triss and Yen channeled their magic to try to stabilize him.

Ciri, held back by Vesemir, screamed behind them:

"Aidy!"

Geralt turned to Triss and Yen, his voice urgent:

"Is this normal?!"

Triss, drenched in sweat from the surge of magic pouring off Aiden after the modified potion injection, couldn't answer too focused. It was Yennefer, more skilled in this area despite the sweat on her own brow, who answered without breaking her movements:

"His body's changing. The potion's weaker than Aiden's current state. We need to keep feeding it to him until it wins out."

Continuing her incantations, she went on:

"It's like a reinforced door. Aiden's body's trying to reject this intrusion because his old magic doesn't recognize the potion as the right key. We need to keep giving it to him until his body finally understands it's the same thing otherwise, it'll just violently reject it."

Geralt held Aiden by the shoulders to keep him from thrashing, despite the intense cold already creeping over his own fingers:

"I don't care! It has to work!"

POV Aiden

PAIN....

PAIN....

PAIN....

PAIN....

I clutched at my own body, an immense pain, like my organs were freezing solid one by one from the inside, massive spikes tearing through my heart, over and over.

Why do I keep fighting this?

If I just closed my eyes, maybe the pain would stop?

Just as I was about to give in, I heard, very faintly, Ciri calling my name.

I clenched my teeth. Images flashed through my mind, as vivid as real memories: Geralt training me relentlessly, Lambert cracking up the day I fell in the lake after throwing a bomb, Eskel teaching me Wolf School techniques while sharing his own stories, Vesemir talking with me about monsters, Queen Calanthe's last words, Mousesack's lessons, and above all…

I saw Ciri again, galloping beside me across the plains. Our evenings laughing together after training. The harvest festival. Her huge smile at the idea of traveling together someday.

I HAVE TO RESIST.

I gritted my teeth and, forcing myself up, screamed, more to myself than to anyone else:

"Goddamn it, get up, Aiden! You promised Ciri. You promised the queen. And since when the hell are you this weak?!"

Struggling up with extreme difficulty, I hurled every insult I could think of at myself bastard, idiot, moron but ironically, it worked: it kept me on my feet. Looking up despite the pain, I finally took in the landscape around me.

A ferocious blizzard raged in every direction. A snow-covered forest stretching endlessly, and at its center, a massive portal. Somehow, without knowing why, I knew that's where I had to go. I started walking, painfully, through the thick snow.

I fell several times from the pain, but every time, I got back up. The suffering didn't matter. I HAD TO GET THERE.

Just as I was finally nearing the portal, my hand reaching out toward it, a figure made entirely of ice appeared in front of me and shoved me back, sending me to the ground.

Looking at it, a chill ran through me: it was my own face staring back at me, my own features, carved out of perfectly clear ice. Its voice rang out, calm my own voice:

"Why do you want to go there?"

I gritted my teeth, staring at it:

"I have to! They're waiting for me!"

It looked me straight in the eyes eyes made of pure ice and answered, just as calm:

"Sure. But why?"

It stepped closer, crouching down in front of me, and continued:

"Out there, so many people want Ciri. Your power, though, is immense. You'll be hunted for your blood, for your magic whether to study you or just to kill you. Why not just let me take over your body instead?"

I stared at it.

"Who the hell are you to ask me something like that?"

Ignoring my language, it went on:

"I am you. Or rather, the magic living inside you. You're a unique being, Aiden something preserved across countless years to decide the fate of countless worlds. To most people, you're nobody. But to those who hold real power, you're a hero to some, a target to others, a pawn to the rest."

I shoved it off as I got up, but it grabbed my hand, gripping it with terrifying strength, and continued:

"Why keep going, Aiden? You were just a student, before all this. And now, they're training you to kill, like a witcher. If you cross that portal, you'll become a mutant, one step closer to your destiny, and..."

I headbutted it square in the face, knocking it back. For the first time, I saw real shock cross that icy face. I smiled.

"So what? Screw destiny. Screw all those people. They want to control me? They want me dead? Let them come, I don't give a damn. This is MY body. These are MY decisions. And it sure as hell isn't my magic that gets to decide my life for me!"

I pressed my hand against its chest, absorbing I don't know what but I could feel it all coming back into me, little by little. The being of ice let me do it, but said again:

"Are you sure? You'll know suffering. Sorrow. Betrayal. You could still let me protect you from all that. I might be a prison of ice, in your eyes but a prison that shields you from pain."

I kept staring at it, still absorbing, and answered calmly:

"Yeah, that's true. But that's exactly what makes us alive. Yeah, I regret dying in my old life. Yeah, I still regret, I still ache from having to say goodbye to Cintra, to people I cared about deeply. But…"

I went on, weaker now:

"But I accept it. That's what defines me. And if you're really me, you should understand that better than anyone. Geralt. Vesemir. Eskel. Lambert. Mousesack. Calanthe. The commander. Some of them are dead, and I still grieve them. Others are still here, and I want to keep living, for them, to help them."

I looked into the eyes of the being of ice, and said, with an oddly amused smile:

"And Ciri. We promised each other, didn't we? We're supposed to travel together, get our revenge on Nilfgaard. So understand me: yeah, I'll suffer. Yeah, maybe I'll die someday. But that's life. And… I'm not a coward. I accept all of it. Completely."

The being of ice stayed silent for a long moment, then answered, a note of amusement in its voice:

"You're right. So, Aiden me, your magic I'll keep protecting you. After all, without you, I'm nothing. Live your life fully. And even once I'm dormant inside you, know that I, as the spirit of the old magic, will always watch over you."

I smiled, simply:

"Then let's work together, starting now."

The being of ice dissolved into a shower of fine snowflakes. I felt, inside me, like some conflict had finally resolved. Pressing a hand to my chest, I felt whole for the first time in what felt like ages. Looking at the portal, I walked toward it, the pain completely gone now. With every step, my hair grew a little whiter, until it turned fully snow-white.

My left eye froze into an icy blue, my right eye into pure snow-white. Crossing through the portal, I said simply:

"Ciri, I'm back. Your wish came true."

Then I woke up, finding Geralt frozen above me, the rest of the room coming into focus around him. I said, my voice still weak:

"Sorry I'm late. I heard Ciri make her wish, and I… took my time."

POV ???

Watching my… work it out on his own, I smiled faintly. Turning my head, I saw him appear beside me, and sighed.

"You wanted to see my… face that alone. Happy now?"

He didn't answer right away, keeping his eyes fixed on the spot where my… had just stepped through the portal, back to his own. Then he said, calm:

"Yes. I needed to be sure. You know as well as I do that he'll need to be ready to face it, alongside Zireael. His strength is already starting to grow, and even I'm finding it harder and harder to contain especially since he's still wearing my daughter's body, and the Aen Elle are starting to take an interest in that power too."

I frowned.

"That's true. But don't forget: Aiden will decide his own path. That was our deal."

He nodded.

"I know. Don't worry. I promised your wife, and you, back when I needed someone to help settle this. But he'll need to learn, sooner or later, what's really waiting for him."

I sighed.

"Fine. Are you going to call on Lycaon?"

He nodded.

"Yes. He's already waiting to put him through his first trial so he finally learns the truth about this world, and what awaits him if he accepts that responsibility. At least Lycaon will get to reunite with his beloved, once it's done."

He turned his eyes toward a dark corner and continued:

"I need to leave you again. He's stirring again. Don't forget: I can't hold him back forever. One day, he'll resurface, and every world will have to decide its own fate."

He vanished in a cloud of snowflakes. The place sank back into darkness. I sighed.

"Hrívë… you're still suffering too, aren't you, despite everything…"

I looked for a moment at the spot where he'd vanished, then, before fading away myself to rejoin my rest deep within that soul, I murmured:

"Tedd Deireádh is coming soon. And even you, Hrívë, won't be able to hold it back forever."

Then I returned to my rest, deep within that soul.

21: Chapter 20 : The discussions

POV Aiden

After I woke up, we headed down to the dining hall I was starving. I devoured absolutely everything within reach, rabbit stew, bread, all of it. What was pretty funny was watching Ciri make constant trips back and forth with a plate, full or empty.

It took long minutes before I finally managed to fill my stomach. Ciri sat down next to me, smiling, and hugged me without a word. I stroked her hair, and looking around, I noticed two new faces two women, both genuinely stunning.

If I wasn't mistaken, the redhead was named Triss, and the black-haired one, Yennefer? Anyway. Stunning, no doubt about it.

Geralt pulled me out of my thoughts.

"Good to see you this alive."

I smiled slightly.

"Same here, Geralt. Honestly, I wasn't expecting to wake up months later. Sorry for making you all stress so much."

Geralt shook his head, waving off the idea. Ciri lifted her head from my arms.

"No. You don't have to apologize. What matters is you're awake!"

I smiled again, but Yennefer cut our reunion short.

"That's real touching, all this. But Geralt, when exactly do you plan on telling them? Triss and I waited until Aiden woke up to bring this up, but now that he's up, you two witchers need to tell them the truth. Now."

Triss shot Geralt a worried look, saying nothing but it was clear she agreed with Yennefer. Vesemir looked at Geralt, who nodded. Vesemir spoke up, calm, looking at

both of us.

"Kids. Like Yennefer just said, we need to be honest with you about what's ahead especially concerning you two."

Ciri shot Vesemir and Geralt a worried glance. I just nodded ever since becoming a witcher, my senses had sharpened considerably. I hadn't had the chance to test it in real combat yet, but I could already tell I was much stronger than before.

What struck me most, though, was my emotions. A lot of people think mutations wipe out a witcher's feelings but now that I was living it myself, I knew that wasn't quite true. You still feel anger, sadness, all of it it's just kept in check much better. Kind of like when people say "keep a cool head" when you're angry: with the mutations, you're basically stuck with that cool head permanently. But you still feel it, underneath.

I answered calmly:

"Of course. We're listening, Vesemir."

He nodded and began:

"Let's start with Ciri. Ciri, at the spot where you train with Geralt, flowers of time appeared."

Ciri dug through her memories of botany, unsure.

"Flowers of time? I don't remember seeing those in your books, Uncle Vesemir."

Geralt shook his head.

"That's normal, Ciri. Those books burned a long time ago, during something that happened here, at Kaer Morhen a long story I'll tell you another time."

Vesemir continued:

"Like Geralt said, that information's been lost from most libraries but during my own witcher training, I had access to it. These flowers of time are extremely rare, a species thought extinct: the only way for them to appear is in the presence of Elder Blood."

Triss chimed in, her voice gentle, as if to reassure Ciri:

"They're also called, in Elder Speech, Feainnewedd. They're nearly essential for creating witcher mutagens."

Ciri frowned.

"Elder Blood? So my blood could be used to create new witchers?"

Vesemir nodded.

"Yes. Your blood could indeed be used to create new witchers that's actually one of the reasons you're so valuable, for the future."

Geralt frowned, and so did both sorceresses. I stroked Ciri's hair, feeling her tense up after all, no matter how you phrase it, if her blood could be harvested to create new witchers, she'd become a target for half the world. I said, to reassure her:

"Don't worry. With me and Geralt around, I'm sure it'll be fine. And besides, isn't that exactly why you're training? So you can protect yourself."

She nodded, a bit reassured, and turned to Triss.

"Can you tell me about the Elder Blood?"

Triss nodded with a gentle smile.

"Elder Blood is a bloodline normally considered extinct Lara Dorren's bloodline. A traitor, to some elves. A hero, to others."

Yennefer cut Triss off, sarcastic:

"Tell her it's really just a bunch of stubborn elves who think failing her rebellion makes her a traitor. I'll bet you anything that if she'd succeeded, those same elves would call her a hero today."

Triss sighed, then continued simply:

"Before Yen cuts me off again: Elder Blood carries an extraordinary quality of magic, including a power tied to time and space. They call Lara Dorren 'the Lady of Time and Space.'"

Maybe to reassure Ciri further, Triss added, softer:

"Don't worry even carrying Elder Blood doesn't necessarily mean you can manipulate time and space. For a very long time, certain mages have tried to manipulate Lara Dorren's heirs to recover that specific power. It's never worked. So don't worry, okay?"

Ciri nodded and kept questioning Triss about Lara Dorren's history. Meanwhile, I found myself thinking on my own after all, the day I'd nearly taken an arrow to the head, I really had teleported, hadn't I? I cut into their conversation:

"How does teleportation actually work?"

Triss, surprised, thought for a moment.

"Honestly? I don't really know. What we do know is that it's instantaneous for that bloodline a natural gift for them. Why the question?"

I shook my head.

"No, just curious."

I hesitated to say more. Maybe just a coincidence, but I filed it away in the back of my mind. Maybe...

Geralt spoke up, addressing Ciri:

"Like Triss said, you'll need to train to master this power, even without inheriting the time-and-space gift itself. Lara Dorren's bloodline stays extremely powerful in magic and extremely sought after because of it."

Ciri nodded and turned to Triss, as if to say "she's the one training me," when a small laugh escaped Yennefer.

"Sorry, sweetheart, but I'm the one training you Geralt asked me to. Don't worry, I don't bite. Well, not always. Mostly just the ones who don't get it."

Ciri frowned, frustrated.

"Great. I get the raven lady as my trainer."

Yennefer shrugged, teasing, staring her dead in the eye.

"And I never asked to babysit some kid. But Geralt begged, and I've got a big heart, believe it or not."

While the two of them kept trading barbs, I smiled I could tell that, deep down, Ciri actually enjoyed these exchanges with Yen. Vesemir turned to me.

"As for you, Aiden you're a special case. Practically an anomaly, in this world. Both you and Ciri will be targets, whether to be studied, or worse."

I shook my head, calm.

"I know. I already told you about the ice humanoid that interrupted me, back there. Don't worry, Vesemir I know it, or rather, I feel it. Even as a witcher now, I'll keep protecting Ciri, and I'll keep protecting myself. Isn't that the whole point of all this training?"

Vesemir nodded, smiling. Geralt smiled too.

"You can count on me too, and on the rest of the witchers. We might not be as extraordinary as you two, but you're part of the family. We'll defend you."

I nodded, smiling, and looked at Ciri, who was still listening to Yennefer's jabs with delight. She said, cheerful:

"That's so true, Uncle Vesemir! At least, the day you can't walk anymore, I, Cirilla, will help old Vesemir get around!"

Vesemir let out a small laugh.

"You little devil. I'm not that old."

Triss looked at me, smiling.

"Like with Ciri, I'll be the one training you in magic. I mostly specialize in fire magic, so I can teach you to control your own element."

I nodded.

"So I guess my main element's ice?"

Yennefer shook her head, conjuring a bubble of water in her hand.

"No, actually. You mostly control liquid your affinity for water is extremely high. But yeah, you do also have a strong affinity for a sub-category of water magic: ice."

I frowned, curious.

"Sub-category?"

Triss nodded, smiling.

"Every kind of magic breaks down into four main elements: fire, water, earth, and air. Across those four elements, there are tons of sub-categories and combinations earth and fire make magma, or shadow; air and fire make light. Those are just a few examples out of countless possibilities."

I nodded, understanding better now, a little eager to start.

"When do we start?"

Geralt put a hand on my shoulder.

"Not today. Today's rest, for you. We'll ease back into it slowly, get you readjusted to your own body don't forget, everything about you has changed."

I nodded. Just as I was about to add something, Ciri pulled me up by the hand.

"Come on, Aidy! I've got at least one new move to show you!"

I sighed, smiling, letting her drag me outside.

POV Geralt

I smiled slightly watching Aiden let himself get dragged along without a fight. Vesemir got up too.

"I'll go keep an eye on them, just in case."

He left. Yennefer spoke up, serious:

"Why haven't you told them about Nilfgaard?"

I sighed. Triss added, worried:

"Yen's right, Geralt. You need to tell them the emperor's put a bounty on Ciri's head alive. Every northern king, every mercenary, and Nilfgaard itself want her, because of her title: whoever marries her gets a legitimate claim to Cintra."

I glanced toward the entrance.

"I'll tell them when the time's right. For now, we keep training them."

Yennefer frowned.

"You can't train them forever, Geralt. Wrapping them in cotton wool isn't the answer. They need to see the world as it actually is. I've told you already: we could send Ciri to Aretuza to deepen her training…"

I cut her off, frowning.

"I'm not sending Ciri to that place where you mages plot the fate of this world like it's a chessboard."

Yennefer, just as sharp:

"Do I need to remind you we're mages too, Geralt? Or do you see me and Triss as nothing but manipulators?"

I was about to answer, but Triss cut in, her voice cold:

"Enough, both of you!"

She continued, softer:

"For now, we do what Geralt said we focus on training them. But Yen's not wrong, Geralt: Ciri's magic is extremely unstable, and for all our talent, we don't necessarily have the knowledge to help her properly."

I looked at Triss.

"Fine. But for now, we focus on training we'll deal with the rest later, and only if Ciri decides that for herself."

Yen nodded, still a little stung I'd probably hurt her more than I meant to. Triss took my hand.

"We'll do it this way for now. So make up, you two, all right?"

POV Vilgefortz

I studied the emperor's library with curiosity, waiting for him to finish his talks with the envoys from the northern kingdoms.

Mousesack had survived. I'd gone back to the site and found traces of teleportation magic heading toward Skellige. I could have hunted him down for information, but something else held my attention right now something far more important. My research was finally nearing completion: the emperor's daughter, alias Cirilla, carries Elder Blood, and is one of the rare cases where the bloodline has stayed this pure. With a bit more finesse in my methods, my instruments would let me…

The emperor's voice cut into my thoughts.

"Vilgefortz. How's the research on my daughter progressing?"

I smiled easily smiling like an actor had become second nature around him. I've been using you from the start, ever since I helped you seize the throne. But you're far too proud to notice.

"From what we know, she escaped with her knight, some Aiden of Cintra."

The emperor nodded.

"Keep sending your spies after her. I want her alive. She needs to come back to consolidate my power."

I bowed, smiling inwardly. Does he really think I care about that? About his petty little power? No I need Ciri for something far greater. I need to understand this world at its depths. The Conjunction of the Spheres didn't happen by accident I finally have a few faint clues, and everything points to the fact that…

The emperor interrupted my thoughts again.

"And the mages?"

I shrugged.

"Unfortunately, most remain loyal to the northern kingdoms. Our faction stays a small minority."

The emperor thought in silence for a long moment.

"Let's see. Will they stay neutral, during the attack?"

I smiled, amused I know exactly how mages behave.

"You mean Sodden Hill? I figured you'd take your time. After all, Queen Calanthe hurt you pretty badly, blowing herself up along with her capital, didn't she?"

The emperor's face went cold.

"No need to remind me, Vilgefortz. The secondary army, led by Marshal Menno Coehoorn, is already marching toward it. It needs to cross the Yaruga to conquer the North. Those northern king fools still think they're safe, convinced Cintra was the only way in."

He looked at me.

"Keep sending your spies after my daughter, and keep working to bring the mages to our side. If they break their neutrality mid-battle, we'll deal with it. You're dismissed."

I bowed and left his study. Walking down the halls, I smiled. I'm curious myself whether the mages will actually resist it'd be a shame if they didn't, I could use a few test subjects for my next experiments. Maybe I should quietly stroke a few egos, push some of the more reluctant ones toward breaking their neutrality.

This battle needs to happen. It serves my plans.

22: Chapter 21 : The Leshen

Hey everyone, this is your author just a quick note to check in with you readers, and with future readers too.

First, some of you may have noticed already, others maybe not, but I'd rather be upfront and honest: this is going to be a long story, one where I focus mainly on relationships, backstory, and world consistency. So if you're expecting an extremely powerful, politically dominant hero right out of the gate, sorry, that'll come later I'm taking my time with this.

Second, if you want to talk Witcher lore, discuss my fanfic's story, or even just throw out ideas, drop your Discord here and I'll add you as a friend so we can chat for instance, one of my readers, Andre_D_5820, who I added a while back, gives me really good ideas, like weapon enchantments, which could be fun to develop.

And third, sincere thanks to everyone supporting this story, whether through simple power stones or comments like "thanks for the chapter" it genuinely boosts morale for a small, unknown author like me. At least, that's how I experience it.

All right, enough feelings another huge thank you, and enjoy the read!)

POV Aiden

I ran through the forest bordering Kaer Morhen, weaving effortlessly between branches and roots, never slowing down. Behind me, I could hear ravens, and wolves closing in fast through the trees.

Honestly, that was exactly the plan. I easily dodged a wolf's lunge by sliding through the mud, summoning an ice spike that pierced it and killed it instantly, before continuing my run toward the river.

Reaching the top of the slope, I jumped to slide down, dodging a root attack from the monster. I landed cleanly at the bottom, and as I approached the lake, I saw the wolves

closing in, growling, slowly surrounding me.

The ravens suddenly swirled together into a vortex, and a massive leshen emerged, letting out a howl some mix of cracking wood and something else entirely, hard to put into words.

I smiled slightly, drawing the silver sword Geralt had lent me. I dodged a raven swarm, then drove my blade into the water: the river froze instantly into a massive block of ice, trapping the wolves' legs they howled in pain along with the leshen, which struggled uselessly to break free.

Skating effortlessly across the frozen river, I decapitated the wolves one after another, then closed in on the leshen. I dodged another root attack, and with a simple gesture of my hands, summoned massive ice spikes that tore through its back it howled in pain. Sliding beneath it, I built a bridge of ice to gain speed, and with the momentum combined with my strength, I took its head clean off.

Landing on the ice, the leshen's head slid over to me. I picked it up, smiling honestly, I'd come a long way since I first started training.

Flashback

POV Aiden

I winced, rubbing my shoulder. It had been three months since I'd resumed training Geralt really wasn't holding back anymore. But that was normal: I'd basically absorbed the entire Wolf School swordplay technique by now, so the only thing left for him to teach me was experience. Even that had its limits.

Arriving at the spot where Triss had asked to meet me, I found her sitting on a tree stump, watching the sunset. Seeing me, she smiled softly.

"Looks like Geralt's really not holding back anymore, huh."

I shrugged, smiling.

"Doesn't really bother me anymore. I know he's doing it for my own good, and honestly, I'm starting to enjoy these fights."

Triss laughed, standing up, brushing off her clothes.

"Sure, but if you ever need me to, just say so. I'll tell him to go easy he actually listens to me."

I laughed.

"That's so true. You're literally the only one he listens to without arguing."

She smiled.

"I don't think so, no. He's just as weak to your requests, and Ciri's, you know."

I smiled, a little amused. She went on:

"All right, let's start training. What do you know about magic, in general?"

I thought about it.

"Mousesack taught me a bit. From what I know, it plays a lot with our emotions a fire mage, for instance, is more prone to instability, to madness, from using it."

(Small author's note: the fire magic Triss uses in the games is a CD Projekt scripting choice in the books, Triss is actually traumatized by the wounds she suffered at the Battle of Sodden. She's still one of the most brilliant sorceresses, but more oriented toward healing, herbalism, and protective spells. Your author well, I think I'm your favorite author, I chose to merge both versions of Triss, the games' and the books'.)

Triss nodded, smiling, conjuring a small fireball in her palm.

"Mousesack taught you well, then. Our feelings shape our magic a lot fire, like you said, can drive its user mad, unstable."

I looked at her, a little puzzled, pointing at her fireball.

"So how do you do it, then? I asked Geralt, and apparently you're one of the most fearsome fire mages around."

She gave a small laugh, amused.

"Guess I'll have to reward Geralt for that compliment even though he's probably forgotten I'm way more than just that. But for my part, I use my fire magic with intense feelings too, except I've trained myself to channel love, passion, desire instead."

I looked at her, surprised.

"So if I'm getting this right, we're not limited to just our most basic emotions?"

She nodded, conjured a small shield with her other hand, then threw the fireball at it I saw the shield crack slightly. She explained:

"See, that fireball's already pretty destructive, and I didn't put any real feeling into it. Now, if I add the desire to protect someone instead…"

She cast the spell again. I noticed the small shield in her hand looked denser this time the fireball slammed into it without breaking through. She continued:

"And if I put my most intense feelings into it, like the love I feel for Geralt, then…"

The new fireball was noticeably hotter; it slammed into the shield, which cracked badly this time, eventually giving way but it had held up regardless. She smiled.

"You get it, Aiden? Magic is extraordinary, both in terms of imagination and power it all comes down to whoever's wielding it. Of course, despite what you just saw, I keep perfect control over my emotions. But if, say, I were genuinely furious, my fire magic would get a lot stronger in exchange, my protective spells would suffer, because anger feeds raw power, not support."

I nodded, curious.

"And Yennefer? What's she specialize in?"

Triss smiled, like she'd just been handed some good gossip.

"Yennefer, huh? I'll skip over the fact that you watch her a lot during training… Anyway. Yennefer's extremely versatile. I even know and this stays between us that she practices some things that are normally forbidden. And even as her best friend, I honestly don't know the full extent of her power."

The minutes slipped by without me noticing. I kept training with ice magic, but all I managed to produce were tiny snowflakes barely enough to chill a beer. Triss laughed softly behind me, took my hands in hers, and said:

"Let's try something else. Close your eyes, Aiden, and focus only on my voice, okay?"

I nodded, closed my eyes, and focused on her voice, which began:

"Picture a lake, flowing gently."

I pictured the lake as a calm stream, deer coming down to drink from it.

Triss continued:

"Now, picture winter."

I did as she said small snowflakes started falling onto the grass and the water, which slowly turned to ice. She went on:

"Now, picture yourself skating on that ice, with Ciri."

Without even realizing it, I smiled I saw myself skating beside her, trying to teach her the basics, laughing at my own falls. I heard Triss say softly:

"Aiden. Open your eyes."

I opened my eyes and found the whole area around us covered in snow and ice. Triss's hands were shaking slightly, but her smile hadn't wavered. I rushed to warm them between mine.

"Sorry!"

She shook her head, clearly touched by the gesture, and used her own flame magic to warm her hands instead.

"Do you remember the feeling you had, just now?"

Closing my eyes, I nodded.

"It was calm. Gentle. Warm like affection."

She smiled.

"Then hold onto that feeling, and use it for your ice magic."

I nodded, focused on that emotion, pictured an ice spike, and threw it at a tree trunk. It pierced through, then two more trunks behind it, before stopping on the fourth. I was thrilled I'd actually done real magic and I said to Triss, grinning like a kid:

"I did it!"

She laughed.

"Nice work."

End of flashback

POV Aiden

I walked toward Kaer Morhen's gates, leshen head in hand, smiling without even noticing, lost in that memory one of my most treasured ones, since it was the very first time I'd ever produced real magic.

Since then, I'd been taught the witcher Signs. I'd turned out to be particularly good at them: Quen, thanks to the foundation Triss had laid, remained my strongest, followed by Igni, Aard, Yrden, and Axii.

As for my training with Triss, it kept getting better and better ice held no real secrets for me anymore. I'd already started secretly training with other liquids too: in my room, I tried to make my own blood move. After all, blood's still a liquid, and I figured it could come in handy someday forcing an adrenaline spike mid-fight, for instance. But for now, it was still really difficult.

And Ciri? Her training with Yennefer was going well and at the same time, not really. She was getting better at controlling herself, but the instability was still a problem. Sometimes I'd catch Yennefer and Geralt in the middle of an argument about her, but every time I asked, they both told me it was nothing.

Arriving in the courtyard, I found Geralt, arms crossed, smiling, with Yennefer and Vesemir beside him. He said:

"Looks like the leshen didn't put up much of a fight."

I shrugged, smiling.

"Had some good teachers. Mostly just used the environment to my advantage."

Vesemir patted my shoulder as I reached them; I could see the pride on his face.

"Nice work. I'll tell you, it's not every day a witcher takes down a leshen those things are dangerous."

Even Yennefer smiled softly, teasing.

"They're right. Impressive, for your age, Aidy."

I rolled my eyes, laughing.

"Since when do you call me that, like Ciri does?"

Yennefer shrugged.

"She lost a bet. Now I've got the right to call you that too. She's a little sore about losing exclusive rights to the nickname Triss is still off playing mom, comforting her. You should go see her too, by the way."

I shook my head, amused, but Geralt cut back in:

"You ready for your final trial?"

I looked at him, nodding.

"Yeah, of course."

Vesemir pulled a Wolf School medallion out of his pocket.

"Your final trial is to solve a witcher contract on your own. It'll prove you've completed every stage, and you'll be able to proudly carry the title of Wolf School witcher."

He handed the medallion to Geralt, who stepped closer and slipped it around my neck.

"Even though I know you don't really need it, given your knack for detecting magic, it's tradition to hand this over."

During my training with Triss, we'd actually noticed that my old magic gave me full visibility on anything magical spells, curses, enchanted objects. I answered:

"Thanks, Geralt. Don't worry, I don't mind wearing it anyway."

He nodded, smiling.

"Go see Ciri, and get ready."

I nodded and walked off, rubbing the medallion between my fingers with a smile. I'd almost finished my training I was finally going to see the world, even if it was just for a simple contract.

POV Geralt

Watching Aiden walk off smiling, an automatic smile crossed my own face but Yen's words wiped it off instantly. She said, fairly hostile:

"You should've told him about your decision. About Ciri."

I frowned. Vesemir, behind us, simply said:

"I'll leave you two to talk." He headed off in the same direction as Aiden. I turned to Yen, sighing.

"I would've liked to, but you know how he'd have reacted. He'd have wanted to come with us."

Yen, arms crossed, kept her eyes on me.

"That's true, you're right. But he had a right to know. Now, it's too late."

I looked at her.

"Don't worry. We won't stay long at Aretuza, and there'll be three of us protecting her. Nothing's going to happen we'll be back before Aiden even gets home."

She shook her head.

"Maybe. But he'll hold it against you for not telling him especially about Ciri, especially since we're taking her to Aretuza while he's gone."

She started walking in Aiden's direction, calling back as she left:

"But I can't really blame you, it's true this isn't easy to bring up. Don't worry if he's mad at us for making this call without him, Triss and I will still be right there with you."

I watched her walk away. She was right I did feel guilty for leaving Aiden in the dark. But sending Ciri to Aretuza was still necessary: the instability of her power had only gotten worse over the months, and there, she'd be protected by me, by Triss, and by Yennefer. And if Aiden had come with us, with his old magic in tow… I didn't even want to imagine the chaos it'd cause if someone detected it.

It was the best thing to do: leave while he was on his way to his own final trial, and be back before he returned.

23: Chapter 22 : The Departure

POV Aiden

We'd just finished eating. Ciri had left the table a little earlier. I was still buried in a book about different monsters a fairly interesting read, if you overlook the author's insistence on explaining the difference between a drowner's mating habits and a ghoul's... Otherwise, the book was actually informative.

What pulled me out of it was Geralt, knocking on my door, arms crossed, a grin on his face.

"So, still deep in your studying?"

I smiled slightly, set the book down on the nightstand, and sat up properly on my bed.

"Yeah. Even though I think I'm ready like Vesemir would say, preparation breeds safety."

He laughed softly, pulled up a chair, and sat facing me.

"Vesemir's right. But let me give you my own method for staying focused."

I looked at him, surprised.

"Go ahead, I'm listening."

He put on a grave expression, like he was about to confess a state secret, then said:

"I picture a naked woman."

A silence followed. Then Geralt burst out laughing.

"Sorry, had to do it. Though she might be a bit too old for you."

I shook my head, amused it was a terrible joke, sure, but it had at least worked to relax me.

"No, I'm fine, but yeah, there's clearly a lot of room for improvement there."

Geralt shrugged.

"Consider it a legacy, then." Then, more serious: "Honestly, there's no real magic trick against stress, or the fear of failing. But know this, Aiden: no matter what happens, Kaer Morhen will always be your home. And most of all…"

He tapped my shirt, right over my heart, looking me straight in the eye.

"I know this sounds cheesy, the kind of thing you'd read in some knight's tale but I promise you, it's real. Believe in yourself. You've got the skills, you've got the talent, you're not stupid. Everyone here knows you're going to make it. So believe in yourself, all right? There's no such thing as a witcher who's born that way there are only witchers who trained, and who know their own worth."

That hit me harder than I expected. I nodded, my voice soft.

"Thanks, Geralt. Really."

He smiled, crossing his arms again.

"Don't worry about it, it genuinely means something to me too. Besides, it's a matter of honor for my title as trainer you're my first student, before Ciri. Gotta live up to the White Wolf name."

I laughed, punching his arm lightly.

"Yeah, sure."

He laughed too, then his eyes drifted to my bedroom door.

"You should go say goodbye to her. You know that, to her, you're the person who matters most in the world."

I sighed, pulling on my shoes.

"Yeah, I know. But I'll admit I'm scared she'll get too dependent on me, I mean…"

Geralt finished my sentence:

"That you think she'll struggle without you?" I nodded. He went on: "It's true it'll be hard. You two have been together for years, you're the only survivors not counting Cintra's civilians and you're tied together by a lot, even things we still don't fully understand today. But Aiden, don't underestimate Ciri. Yeah, it'll be hard. Yeah, there'll be moments where she goes through things alone, things that'll make her cry, make her feel hopeless. But it'll teach her her own worth. And more than that, it'll let her actually live."

I hesitated before heading out, not looking at Geralt.

"Geralt… am I… am I too protective of her?"

A silence followed, then he answered softly:

"You know, the first time I became a witcher, I was still an idiot. I thought I could change the world, play the knight in shining armor, especially toward women I still had this fairy-tale kind of morality, wanting to protect everything. See, on top of the White Wolf nickname, they also call me the Butcher of Blaviken."

I looked at him, surprised I'd never pictured Geralt that way. He went on, eyes distant:

"I wanted to defend some villagers who were about to get slaughtered by bandits. I thought I was doing good, protecting them. But in the end, my actions backfired on me, and the townsfolk started seeing me as a murderer, a butcher. That's where the name comes from for anyone who wants to remind me of that sad story."

He looked at me with a faint smile.

"That's what I want to teach you. If you genuinely feel like you want to protect her, then keep doing it. But above all, learn what YOU actually want not what everyone around you expects of you. Even after earning that title, even after seeing people's true face, I still hold onto my own values, my own choices. It's me who decides now not what I'm desperately trying to earn in other people's eyes. So stop asking yourself that question. Ask instead: do you actually want to keep protecting her the way you're doing now?"

A few minutes later, I was at the highest tower of Kaer Morhen, where Ciri sat on the parapet, gazing at the moon. I walked over with a basket of candy Triss had brought back once, set it down between us as I settled onto the ledge beside her, popped a piece into my mouth, and asked:

"Why the gloomy face, Ciri?"

She looked at me with a soft smile, took a piece of candy herself.

"No, I just wanted to relax a bit, think things through."

I let her continue. She went on, eyes still on the moon:

"You know, sometimes I wonder what a normal life would look like, for us. But the more years pass, the more I feel like we'll never really have one. Weird, right? Dreaming about that?"

I shook my head. She looked at me.

"No, you know, before coming up here, Geralt stopped by to reassure me I was a little stressed about the trip."

She looked at me, half-teasing.

"Aidy, stressed? Never would've believed it."

I smiled softly.

"I'm not perfect, you know. Anyway, he reassured me but mostly, I asked him something: whether I should keep protecting you the way I've been doing."

Ciri started to answer:

"Aidy, I already told you that…"

I cut her off, slipping a piece of candy into her mouth.

"I know. That you wanted to fight by my side, travel, get revenge on Nilfgaard with me. Don't worry, I remembered that's exactly why I was thinking it over on my way up here."

I looked up at the full moon, breathtaking.

"We've watched people close to us die. We're both carrying promises on our shoulders. But despite all that, it's our own choices that'll decide whether we honor those promises, and what we actually do with them."

I looked at Ciri, serious.

"Ciri, I promise to keep protecting you but not the way I used to. We'll fight together. We'll live our adventures together. I'm done seeing you as some damsel in distress,

because there's two of us now. And yeah, you're right: we'll face a ton of fights ahead me, because of my old magic, I'm basically a juicy piece of meat for any mage out there; and you, with Lara Dorren's bloodline in you, even dormant, that's still a prime target. Not even counting your title as Queen of Cintra, as its last direct heir."

I smiled softly.

"But should any of that actually hold us back? Since the start, we've lived our own adventures the way we wanted to. At the harvest festival, even though you were stronger than every other kid there, you still used every trick you had to win. So let's do the same now. Let's stop overthinking everything, and make our choices with our whole hearts without telling ourselves 'but if I do this, I'll be in danger.' Let's stop thinking about that. Let's live by our own choices, not anyone else's."

Ciri stayed quiet for a moment, before a few tears started falling she wiped them quickly with her sleeve, then smiled and leapt onto me for a hug, hard enough that I nearly toppled backward before catching us both. The candy basket wasn't so lucky: it fell quite a ways down and smashed on the ground. Ciri murmured against me:

"You're right. Let's stop being scared. Let's live by our choices, and regret nothing."

She pulled back from my chest, wiped away her last tears, and said with a huge smile:

"Wait for me, Aidy. We'll live our adventure together, we'll get revenge on Nilfgaard, and we'll rebuild Cintra. Together."

I laughed softly.

"Yeah. Together."

The next day, I was getting my mount properly ready when I saw everyone arriving. Ciri jumped on me first, before going to pet Nocturne's muzzle. I sighed, amused, looking at the four faces in front of me.

"Hope you all don't change too much while I'm gone."

Yennefer gave a small laugh.

"Maybe Vesemir and Geralt will pick up a few more gray hairs, but I promise my beauty will stay just as stunning for your eyes, Aidy."

I coughed, embarrassed. Triss helped by shushing Yen, who was clearly gearing up to pile on more. Vesemir stepped up first, handing me a satchel full of ingredients, then a second one holding bombs and oils.

"Like Yennefer said, I'll probably have a few more gray hairs by the time you're back, but I promise that's all it'll be. I packed you enough to get through the trip. I know Geralt already reassured you, but trust me, every witcher's been through this at the start. I'm really proud of you. And when you get back, Eskel and Lambert will celebrate with us."

I thanked him with a nod. Triss went next I was caught off guard when she pulled me into a hug, but I returned it without hesitating; over the course of training together, I'd genuinely grown attached to her, her gentleness, the way she listened. After the hug, she handed me a small crystal.

"This is a crystal storing a fireball of my magic took me all night to charge it. Only use it if you're truly in danger, okay?"

I sighed, amused, nodding.

"Promise, Triss."

She gave me a soft, almost motherly smile, ruffling my hair. Then Yennefer stepped forward, a smile equal parts teasing and sincere.

"I don't have a gift for you, but know that if you ever need a sorceress, I'll help whatever you ask."

I thanked her with a nod, but she used the moment to plant a kiss on my cheek, leaving a smudge of lipstick behind, before walking off laughing.

"There. The gift of happiness and good luck, Aidy."

I heard a soft growl behind me Ciri, muttering something about "witches." I rubbed my cheek to wipe off the mark, my face a little warm despite myself. Then Geralt stepped up, unbuckled the sheath of his silver sword from his belt, and handed it to me. I was stunned for a witcher, a silver sword is far from a casual gift. Before I could even ask, he said:

"Don't worry, take it. Vesemir's not hitting the Path this year, so I'll borrow his in the meantime, until yours gets forged. For now, take this one it'll put my mind at ease a little, like I'm still protecting you, even from a distance."

I smiled, looking at the sheath, drawing the blade slightly to study the runes already carved into it.

"Thanks. I'll take good care of it."

He smiled, and pulled me into a hug of his own.

"Come back proud of yourself, all right?" I returned the hug, nodding. Once we'd let go, I went to join Ciri, still petting Nocturne's muzzle. Seeing me without Yennefer's lipstick mark, she let out a small sigh of relief one I caught with a smile, which she returned just as quickly. She pulled a white scarf out of the satchel she always carried, and wrapped it around my neck.

"To remind you I'm always by your side."

I smiled.

"Thanks, Ciri."

She tugged me closer by the scarf and pressed a kiss to my forehead, cheeks slightly flushed.

"Take care of yourself."

She walked back, a little shy, to join Yennefer and the others, who teased her fondly she shot back with her own jabs, amused. I looked at them all one last time, mounted Nocturne, and started off slowly toward the gate, waving goodbye. I fully intended to come back and see every single one of them again.

POV Ciri

Watching Aidy leave, I clenched my fist slightly. I felt a hand stroke my hair, and looked up at Geralt and the others, who were watching me with a smile. Geralt asked softly:

"You okay?"

I nodded, casting one last glance toward the spot where Aidy had disappeared, then turned to Geralt, serious.

"Yeah. I know he'll make it. And Geralt you asked me once if I wanted to train at Aretuza, and I never really gave you an answer. Well, here it is: I want to go. I want to

get stronger, so I can stand by Aidy's side."

24: Chapter 23 : Roggeven

POV Aiden

I sighed, exhausted, taking in the vast fields of golden stubble stretching out to the horizon. It had been nearly three months since I'd left Kaer Morhen with Nocturne. I'd made it through the roads fairly peacefully aside from a bandit gang or two, nothing too complicated.

I'd also made a point of not lingering in Kaedwen, given its well-known reputation for despising non-humans honestly, I didn't feel like spending my time justifying myself to villagers, especially if I also needed to pick up a contract there.

Speaking of contracts…

I'd figured finding one would be simple. It wasn't. Just like Geralt had taught me, I stopped in every village, checked the posted notices but aside from announcements about a lord raising taxes or needing help in the fields, there was nothing concrete. Hence the sigh.

I'd gone back and forth between heading to Aedirn or Redania, and ended up choosing the latter. Honestly, riding through the Redanian roads, I'd been genuinely impressed by the overall stability of the kingdom.

Even though, deep down, I still carried some anger toward the northern rulers who hadn't lifted a finger for Cintra, that didn't change the fact: Redania remained impressive.

Whenever I asked the locals, they'd often praise their king, kind and wise they even called him the Just. But honestly, thanks to bits and pieces Triss had shared during our training, I already knew that king didn't act entirely alone. Philippa Eilhart, for instance, held the position of court sorceress under King Vizimir.

The little Triss had told me about her was that she was a formidable sorceress, someone she genuinely admired but I could tell, behind her hesitation, that there was more to it. Even without her saying it outright, I could easily guess as much.

Flashback

POV Aiden

We'd just wrapped up a magic training session. Behind me, a massive ice statue, something like a golem, collapsed onto the ground with a dull thud that shook the earth. Triss laughed.

"Honestly, I've rarely seen talent this impressive with magic."

I shrugged, smiling.

"Maybe it's thanks to the old magic. Hey, since we're on the subject of magical talent, I'm curious about the other sorceresses besides you, Mousesack, and Yennefer, I don't really know anyone."

She looked surprised, then nodded slowly and sat down on a log.

"Let's start with me, then. I'm the court sorceress for King Foltest, in Temeria. I'm not big on politics, but you get used to it after a while and Temeria's a pretty unique place. I'll have to take you there someday."

I smiled.

"I'd like that, Triss."

She went on, still smiling.

"Yennefer serves as sorceress at King Demavend III's court, in Aedirn though she barely shows up. As you'd expect, she's proud, independent, and hates court politics, so she skips most gatherings, no matter how much the Council of Mages insists. Let's just say she's never really cared what they think."

She continued:

"In Kaedwen, it's Sabrina Glevissig, at King Henselt's court though I'll admit her behavior is pretty… let's say 'intense,' to put it kindly. You probably won't like how she acts. Not that I think you'd like most sorceresses, honestly a lot of them tend to feel a bit superior."

Then her smile turned wistful.

"And for Redania, that's Philippa Eilhart. Let's just say she's ambitious, and pretty cold. Sorry, Aiden, I'm going to stop there, on that one."

I nodded I could tell there was more behind that silence, but I didn't push it. She clapped her hands together, as if to restart the lesson.

"All right, let's get back to it. This time, I want two golems."

End of flashback

POV Aiden

Naturally, seeing Triss so wistful that day, I'd gone to ask Geralt about it, who'd shaken his head, explaining he couldn't tell me anything without Triss's permission. I'd then tried my luck with Yennefer, who hadn't hidden her hostility toward Philippa at all she'd simply said she was "a manipulative bitch" who'd deeply hurt Triss, both intimately and otherwise.

She hadn't told me much more than that, but I could easily piece it together: something must have happened between Triss and Philippa, probably before Geralt and maybe Philippa had manipulated Triss somehow? Either way, it was all just guesswork on my part.

Arriving at the gates of Roggeven, I already caught the smell of the sea a scent I'd almost forgotten and the distant cry of gulls. The city, fortified, rose up ahead of me. I joined the line of travelers being checked by the guards at the gate, taking the chance to look around: we were in the thick of autumn, the orange leaves putting on quite a show, and the Redanian banners hanging on the ramparts paired nicely with the scenery.

What snapped me out of my thoughts was a guard walking up.

"A witcher? Rare, around here."

I answered:

"Yeah. I'm here for contracts got any around?"

He jotted something down in his notebook, shrugging.

"You'd have to check with the steward, he's the one who handles that."

Curious about something else, I noticed the unusually large number of guards posted at the entrance, well beyond normal, and asked:

"Something going on?"

He looked at me, a little confused, before following my gaze toward the extra security, then answered, weary:

"Yeah. Apparently the court sorceress is here, and ever since she showed up, the town lord's been bending over backward for her, like some kind of dog."

Another guard elbowed him to shut him up, but he just shrugged.

"Everyone knows the lord's head over heels for the sorceress." Then, turning to me: "Witcher, everything's in order, you can go in."

I nodded and stepped into the city. What struck me first was the crowd massive. Luckily, I was still up on Nocturne, so I wasn't jostled much, but it was still impressive. It reminded me a lot of Cintra.

Along the way, I could hear merchants shouting out their goods, or announcing discounts the place was alive, in short.

Arriving at an inn called *The White Shark's Teeth*, I settled Nocturne calmly into the stables, dismounted while stroking her muzzle, gathered my gear, my swords at my waist, and my saddlebags. I gave the stable hand five crowns to take good care of her, then walked into the inn. The contrast between the cold outside and the warmth inside hit immediately.

But mostly, it was the atmosphere that struck me that tavern feel that always brings a faint smile, between the music, the strong smell of alcohol and food fighting it out with the less pleasant scent of sweat and unwashed bodies. I settled onto a stool facing the innkeeper.

"I'd like a room, and some food, if that's still possible."

He looked at me, surprised, then leaned in.

"A witcher, in my inn? Now that's rare. I can offer you the last of the stew, if that works. How long are you planning to stay?"

I pulled out my purse.

"At least two weeks. What do I owe you?"

He thought it over.

"Five crowns a day, so for fourteen days, that comes to seventy crowns, witcher."

I nodded, handed him the sum, which he pocketed right away, then added two more crowns for a drink and the last of the stew. As he walked off, I felt a tap on my shoulder a stranger, smiling.

"Witcher! Fancy a game of gwent? I'll bet ten crowns."

I agreed. I wiped the floor with him, to the laughter of his own friends sitting behind him, and the disgruntled grumble of the man himself, who handed over his ten crowns. When my meal finally arrived, I asked the innkeeper, busy wiping down glasses:

"When I got into town, I heard the court sorceress was here?"

He nodded, sighing.

"Roggeven's usually a peaceful town, no trouble at all. But lately, strange things have been happening: dead sailors climbing back out of the sea. The first night was a straight-up massacre lost a lot of sailors that night. The lord tried posting guards, but a good number of them died too: those corpses don't fear steel. Even beheaded, they keep fighting."

He shivered.

"Now there's a curfew at nine, and you can often hear those dead things wandering outside at night. Even corpses from the graveyard have started joining in. The lord called on King Vizimir, who sent the court sorceress along with some guards. But rumor has it it's actually another mage's doing all anyone knows, from witnesses, is that it's a man."

I frowned.

"Is the sorceress managing to fix it?"

He shook his head.

"She's been here for weeks now. Her magic does stop the dead, but they keep multiplying night after night every time she takes down three, six more show up the next night. Never-ending."

I nodded, running through the possibilities. From what I remembered of the bestiary, no classic monster really fit this kind of behavior even among specters, aside from maybe the rare penitent, but that one usually only shows up near a lighthouse, and only raises the specters of its own victims. I asked:

"What do these dead look like, exactly?"

He thought about it.

"Kind of like waterlogged corpses, skin falling off in chunks. And the smell unbearable. Like a body that's been underwater for years."

I nodded, about to sink back into my thoughts, when the music suddenly cut off. A man stepped up onto the small stage a silk bard's outfit, a plum-colored felt hat, chestnut hair, a faint smile somewhere between arrogant and warm. He spoke, his voice clear:

"Ladies and gentlemen, I do hope your spirits find some comfort tonight, for I, the great Dandelion, have come specially to console the people of this terrible ordeal!"

I choked slightly, spitting out a bit of foam, and stared at the man. Had he really just said Dandelion? The one Geralt always talked about in his stories the one he described as his insufferable best friend! Dandelion went on:

"I shall now perform my brand-new song: *The White Wolf and the Fire of Love*."

He began playing his lute.

(Author's note: inspired by the song "Lilac and Gooseberries," which always gives me chills. I reinterpreted the story so it's about Geralt and Triss instead hope it does it justice, I'm no musician, sniff.)

From snowy peaks down to the golden plain,

The weary White Wolf dragged his wounds along.

But by the hearth, a flame awaits him still,

Chasing old bite marks with her gentle song.

She held no shadow of the darker arts,

Just the soft warmth of a fireside night.

You blaze like fire beneath the moon,

Scented with roses and a tender heat.

When the wolf goes astray and thunder roars,

It's in your embers he forgets defeat.

Auburn passion, and wild rose,

A haven of peace amid the storm.

Her fire-red hair lights up your night,

Where the wolf's own eyes see only gray.

He's made of steel, of potions, and of blood,

She's the tenderness of a setting sun's ray.

The court and the king demand her voice,

But her heart beats only for the wolf.

You blaze like fire beneath the moon.

Scented with roses and a tender heat.

When the wolf goes astray and thunder roars,

It's in your embers he forgets defeat.

Auburn passion, and wild rose,

A haven of peace amid the storm.

(Hope you enjoyed my reinterpretation of that wonderful song, "Lilac and Gooseberries.")

25: Chapter 24 : Dandelion

POV Aiden

Watching the crowd applaud after Dandelion's performance, I saw him sit down at a table. I got up, drink in hand, and sat down across from him. Seeing me, he flashed a smile then, noticing my telltale cat eyes, grew even warmer.

"Charmed, my friend. It's pretty rare to run into a witcher."

I sat down, smiling, and offered my hand, which he shook.

"Thanks. But we've got some mutual acquaintances, I think Geralt's my mentor, at the Wolf School."

He looked surprised, shaking my hand even more enthusiastically.

"Ah, Geralt! Delighted to meet someone from his circle. I take it he's told you about our adventures?"

I laughed.

"He has. Told me about the time you lost your voice."

He smiled.

"Ah, what a fine memory. And you, what's your name? I forgot to ask."

I took a sip of my drink.

"Aiden of Cintra."

He looked mildly surprised.

"Cintra? So you were there when it fell?"

I nodded. He sighed.

"What a tragedy, all those deaths, honestly. I'm actually writing a song in memory of the soldiers who died in battle, and for the Queen of Cintra too even though our last meeting didn't go too well, it remains one of the most beautiful places I've ever known. And I'm not just talking about the women."

He laughed at his own joke. I smiled, amused, then continued more seriously.

"So you know a thing or two about what's going on around here? I got some bits from the innkeeper, but maybe you know more."

He took a sip.

"What do you know so far?"

I laid out what I had. He answered:

"I don't have much more than that, except word's starting to spread in the city's higher circles the sorceress sent here might be up to something, according to some, given how long she's taking to fix the problem. Still faint rumors, but they're growing."

I looked at him, a bit puzzled, a touch ironic.

"Seriously, how do you know what's being said in the higher circles? Geralt never mentioned you were the type to get invited to that level."

He smiled, proud.

"What can I say, my secret's talent and a pretty face."

I sighed.

"Anyway. You know where I could look into this further? I'll see if I can help."

He looked at me, worried.

"You know, this is way more complicated than a simple ghoul. Even experienced fighters are struggling against these dead things."

I nodded, serious.

"I know. But that doesn't mean I can't handle it. And besides, I can't exactly spend my time wondering which contract is the least dangerous."

He sighed, took a drink.

"Geralt's gonna kill me, but fine, all right. You need to head to the barracks, talk to the steward apparently that's where you sign up for the night watch against the undead."

I nodded, standing up.

"Thanks, Dandelion."

He simply raised his glass without a word. I then went up to my room for the night but instead of sleeping, I sat in the middle of the room, in a meditation stance, like Geralt had taught me, and cleared my mind.

POV Dandelion

I sighed, watching the boy walk off, finishing my last sip, thinking back on our travels with Geralt. Was I really going to let him face this danger all alone? Geralt would kill me if I didn't do something especially since he'd once confided to me that one of our trips together was among his most precious memories. Had to test whether that was actually true.

Finishing my drink, I watched the innkeeper start closing up shop, the last patrons leaving, boards going up over the windows. He wasn't wrong to be cautious people were clearly starting to lose hope, and it wouldn't surprise me if a few tempers started boiling over for real soon.

Shaking my head, I muttered to myself.

"Dandelion, are you really going to do this?"

Closing my eyes, finishing my drink, I walked up to the innkeeper, set down a few crowns.

"A room, my good man, if you'd be so kind."

He looked surprised, but nodded and handed me the key. Taking it, I climbed the stairs. Even though I couldn't fight, I'd go with Aiden I wasn't about to let someone this precious to Geralt I'd recognized his silver sword at the boy's waist right away face this alone. I'd never forgive myself if something happened to him.

POV Aiden

Getting up the next morning and heading downstairs, I found Dandelion busy restringing his lute. Seeing me, he stood up, smiling.

"I, the great Dandelion, have decided to accompany you!"

I frowned.

"Thanks, but where I'm headed might be dangerous."

He laughed.

"Don't worry, I'm used to it with Geralt. And honestly, I can liven up our travels a bit who knows, might even inspire me. You should know my music casts quite a spell on witchers, it's my best song so far." He winked at that. I sighed, already tired.

"Can't stop you from following me anyway."

He laughed, patting my shoulder.

"Exactly, my good friend. Onward, to adventure!"

Leaving the inn, he followed along like he'd said. Looking around, early that morning, I saw soldiers being tended to, others gathering corpses onto a cart a pretty disgusting sight, but you get used to it eventually. Geralt was right about that.

Arriving at the barracks, we were stopped by a guard.

"Halt. State your business."

I showed my medallion, calm.

"I'm a witcher. I'd like to see the steward, offer my help for a fee."

He looked surprised.

"Sorry, witcher. Steward Gildart will surely be glad to see you, but…" He looked at Dandelion, hesitant. "…who's your companion? Looks like he stepped straight out of a women's boutique."

Dandelion, offended:

"My good sir, this is an authentic bard's outfit, and I must say I am deeply..."

I cut him off, sighing.

"Consider him a friend."

The guard nodded and let us into the barracks, where several soldiers were resting, getting treated, or cleaning their weapons. I could hear Dandelion muttering behind me, still offended at being mistaken for a woman I didn't even try to answer him.

Arriving at an office, I found a scarred man with red hair, in knight's armor. Seeing me, he looked surprised; seeing Dandelion, he sighed with exhaustion, stood up, and shook my hand.

"Nice to meet you witcher. I'm surprised you're this young. But as for your friend…"

He looked at Dandelion, who smiled innocently.

"Dandelion, huh. You know the mayor's actively looking for you? He wasn't too thrilled about what you did with his daughter."

Dandelion coughed, embarrassed.

"Forgive me, but I merely fulfilled a young woman's dream of discovering the joys of this poet's vocal cords."

The man sighed.

"Forget it, I don't have time for tales of maidens." Then, turning to me, serious: "Witcher, are you aware of the situation?"

I nodded, calm.

"What the townsfolk say about it, yes." I kept to myself the rumors from the higher circles that Dandelion had shared with me.

Gildart crossed his arms.

"I see. Honestly, on the surface, things still look stable but I'll be straight with you, witcher."

He looked around, then continued, serious.

"I'm losing more and more men. Every night, I lose at least five exhaustion, psychological strain, wounds. But the worst part is, some of my soldiers' bodies get taken by these dead things, and come back themselves, as more of the walking dead. It absolutely crushes my men's morale. And the worst part is…"

He fell silent for a moment, jaw clenched, then slammed his fist on the table, furious.

"It's that damned sorceress. We ask her for help, and aside from twiddling her thumbs or coming to 'help' while sneering at us for not being able to handle it ourselves she does nothing. It's infuriating. My men are dying, and at this rate, there'll be no one left to defend the city if this keeps up. And our damned lord does nothing, completely smitten with her beauty."

He calmed down.

"Forgive me. I lost my temper."

I shook my head. Dandelion, behind me, added:

"It's fine, sometimes it feels good to let off some steam."

Gildart nodded, gestured to the chairs in front of his desk. Once we sat down, he began his explanation.

"The first sightings go back a few months around midsummer. At first, it was one or two dead. We figured some grieving widow or widower must have messed with powers they shouldn't have…"

He paused, wistful, then continued.

"But once the dead started coming out of the water, we went from two to four, then eight, then sixteen not even counting, of course, our own soldiers' dead, taken by those same corpses, or the civilians. It's only getting worse. The only thing that pushes them back is fire and even then, just pushes them back, doesn't destroy them. All we can do is cut off their legs, their arms, then their heads. But even that doesn't kill them."

I nodded, asking:

"Have you tried seeing what happens if one of them's still around when the sun comes up?"

He nodded.

"Turns to dust. But the time and effort it takes to get them to that state is considerable. It's true things got slightly better once that blasted sorceress showed up but barely, since she doesn't do much of anything useful. And whenever we ask for an explanation, she answers with that haughty, sarcastic tone, like it's all too complicated for our little ordinary human brains."

He kept talking about Philippa with the same hostility, before looking me straight in the eye.

"Help us, witcher. Your price is my price, and my men's. If my lord and that sorceress keep doing nothing, I'll hire a real professional myself."

I was about to nod and accept the contract when a sudden noise behind the door made me react, my hand already on my sword. Dandelion, seeing my move, jumped to his feet. The door burst open to reveal a woman with a cold face, chestnut hair falling past her shoulders, flanked by soldiers I'd never seen before. She looked at me, surprised, then with a smile that immediately put me on edge.

Gildart stood up, furious.

"How dare you, sorceress? This isn't your..."

She cut him off coldly.

"My apologies, Steward, but you have nothing to say to me. I outrank you, per your lord's own word so hold your tongue, the important people are talking."

I could see Gildart seething, but he held back at the sight of the soldiers accompanying Philippa. She stepped toward me, that same unsettling smile on her lips.

"A witcher. My spies warned me a Wolf School witcher had arrived in town. I'd have bet on the famous White Wolf himself, given his reputation but it seems I'll have to settle for you, young stranger."

Crossing her arms, a condescending, self-assured smile on her lips, she held my gaze.

"I'm Philippa Eilhart, sorceress at King Vizimir's court also known as the Just King, according to his beloved subjects. Anyway, what's your name, witcher?"

26: Chapter 25 : The Undead

(Hey everyone, this is a little message from your favorite author well, I think I'm your favorite.

Anyway, to give you an update: I'm planning to structure this story into Acts. We're still in Act 0 for now, and it's not close to wrapping up, since I've still got a lot to write before moving into Act 1, where Aiden will be an adult. Just wanted to clarify that for you.

Second, I also wanted to ask you something: am I doing a good job capturing the characters' personalities? I try my best, from my own perspective, based on the research I do, to keep the original characters and my OC as true to themselves as possible. Don't hesitate to let me know if I'm missing the mark.

All right, thanks again for the comments, the power stones, and for sticking around for every chapter it genuinely means a lot to me. Enjoy the read!)

General POV

Aiden kept his arms crossed, ignoring Philippa's outstretched hand, and simply said:

"My name's Aiden. As you've probably guessed, I do come from the Wolf School sorry to disappoint, I'm not the White Wolf himself."

Behind her, the guards immediately reached for the pommels of their swords after all, Aiden had just refused a handshake from someone of high rank. But Philippa kept her smile, withdrawing her hand without missing a beat.

"Aiden, then? You're amusing, I'll give you that. If you don't mind, I'd like to speak with you privately, without…"

She shot a disdainful look at Dandelion and Gildart the latter, apparently pushed past his limit, slammed his fist on the desk, knocking over his glass of wine, and shouted,

furious:

"How dare you! You storm into my office like it's your own, and now you're kicking me out, me, how..."

She cut him off, ice-cold:

"How dare I? The real question is how dare YOU. Need I remind you you're nothing but a common steward? So put away your little pride. If you want the dead problem solved, be a good boy, and leave."

He gritted his teeth, furious, but left the room, shoving past one of Philippa's guards on his way out. She turned to Dandelion.

"That goes for you too. This situation doesn't need sweet, honeyed words."

Dandelion looked at me, silently asking my opinion even stressed as he clearly was, if I'd told him to stay, he would have. But I shook my head, smiling.

"Don't worry, Dandelion. Go ahead and step out. Me and this charming lady are going to have a little chat."

He sighed, muttering that Geralt would kill him, but left with Philippa's guards, leaving us alone in the office. She gave a small smile.

"Charming lady, huh?"

She deliberately ran a finger across the steward's desk, looking disgusted at the dust she found, then stepped over the spilled puddle of wine. I answered, calm but distant.

"Indeed. I'm sure you've heard plenty about how the White Wolf is quite the charmer with the ladies unless you don't consider yourself a lady."

A small jab, but Philippa kept her amused smile.

"Trying jabs on me? Adorable. But I admit, this is interesting you remind me of someone I know. Maybe you know Yennefer of Vengerberg?"

I shook my head.

"No. Why would I know her?"

She stayed silent a moment, studying me, then found her smile again, idly flipping through the steward's books.

"No, but you two would get along, I think. All right, jokes aside now, let's talk business."

I stayed standing, arms crossed the distance didn't seem to bother Philippa; if anything, she seemed to enjoy it. She sat on the steward's desk, first placing a cushion down, and continued:

"I take it the commoners, and this steward, already explained the situation to you?"

I nodded.

"They did. But why aren't you doing anything about it? I doubt you're some run-of-the-mill sorceress, if you're at the royal court."

She laughed.

"You did your homework, good. To answer your question, witcher: yes, this whole situation strikes me as child's play. I already know it's a mage experimenting with necromancy."

I frowned, sarcastic.

"So why aren't you fixing it, then? Scared of breaking a nail?"

She smiled, amused.

"No. Because this situation is bringing me certain things. But you don't need to know everything. One question: do you want to help me solve it?"

I didn't answer right away, asking instead:

"I won't do anything until you at least explain why you need my help. You've clearly seen I'm just a young witcher."

She got up from the desk, stepped closer to me.

"Indeed. And that's exactly what's interesting it's been ages since there's been a witcher around here."

She then trailed her fingers along my crossed arms; I stayed still, waiting for her to finish. She continued:

"I'll tell you why I need you. You, witcher how do you see the future of this world?"

I frowned.

"Is that a philosophical question, or…"

She sighed, irritated.

"Witcher, just answer the question. Keeping a lady waiting isn't very gallant."

I answered, sarcastic:

"I'm still wondering if you're really a lady you still haven't confirmed that." Then, with a sigh: "I guess witchers will keep getting rejected more and more by society, as monsters keep disappearing."

She laughed, not offended by the sarcasm.

"Indeed. And you find that normal?"

Her smile turned colder.

"It's these little humans who dare beg us for help whenever it suits them, only to turn around and treat us like traitors, like something less than human."

I shot back:

"The unknown's always scared humanity, so…"

She cut me off, cold:

"No need to lecture me, I already know that. But it's still no excuse. Don't you find it unfair people born into the right family holding all the power? Don't they say the strong should protect the weak? So why should we, mages and witchers, keep obeying these so-called superiors?"

I frowned.

"That sounds almost like treason, coming from a court sorceress. And I'm pretty sure you tacked on 'witcher' to that sentence just because I'm standing here."

She laughed, looking me straight in the eye, licking her lips.

"Smart, too? True, I added 'witcher' because you're here. But does that change anything? Everything I said is true. And even if it is, there's only the two of us here, witcher and even if you complain, who'd believe you?"

I answered:

"True. But don't forget: even if I can't reach the higher circles like you, we regular folk have our own networks. I'm sure I can whisper into the ear of a few people who talk to crowds pretty often. And even if it doesn't seem like much, it'll eventually reach the king's ears. And even if he doesn't believe it, he won't be the only one to hear it plenty of nobles will too, and the doubt will settle in a little more than before."

Philippa fell silent, staring into my eyes, then said calmly:

"Aiden, is it? You'd throw yourself headfirst into that mess, just to prove me wrong?"

I answered, arms crossed, not looking away.

"Why, Philippa? You wanna try me?"

She stayed silent, then burst out laughing.

"Aiden, Aiden, Aiden. You're adorable. But you're right you've earned the right to know what I actually want. From you, at least."

She turned her back to me, staring out the window.

"I want you to come with me. I have some trust in my own men, but I'd much rather have a real witcher, someone who actually knows how to fight, protecting me."

I asked:

"Protect you from what? From what I've heard, the rumors say you shouldn't have any trouble on your own."

She glanced at me sideways.

"True, Aiden, I could probably wipe out that whole army of the dead. But even I need to stay vulnerable for a moment, while I track down the mage's lair. And in those moments, I'd rather have a real professional by my side."

She continued:

"And to finally answer your question fully: why you, specifically? I want the local population, and beyond, to see clearly that those they call 'non-humans' and 'mages,' the ones they exclude from humanity, are exactly the ones who saved them. Roggeven's one of the busiest ports around word travels fast here, and it'll make it harder for those wanting to exterminate non-humans to spread their lies."

I shot back:

"But that's not everything, is it? I doubt it's purely about reputation."

Philippa turned back, smiling.

"Indeed, there's more. But it doesn't concern you, and you don't really need to know, do you think?"

I held her gaze without a word, then simply answered:

"Fair enough. What's your plan?"

She smiled.

"Don't worry, I'm generous. You'll have me as an ally going forward, and you'll walk away with a nice purse of crowns at the end. All you have to do is be my bodyguard, from start to finish and by 'finish,' I mean until we've dealt with the mage responsible for all this."

I nodded.

"How many crowns?"

She thought it over, smiling.

"Four hundred crowns…"

I cut her off:

"Six hundred crowns, plus in-depth training in mage magic."

She looked surprised.

"What makes you think I'd agree to that?"

I answered calmly, spinning the pommel of my silver sword between my fingers.

"Because even if you're feeling confident, even you can't stay here forever without starting to annoy powerful people. And like you said yourself, you don't trust your men much. And even though I can tell you doubt my skills, you also know that if I'm wearing this medallion, with these cat eyes, it's because I survived some very real trials. Even lacking a bit of experience, I'm still well above ordinary soldiers. So yeah, I'm putting my worth on the table. Take it, or leave it."

She went quiet, then flashed a predatory smile that sent a shiver through me despite myself, before answering calmly:

"You're getting more interesting by the minute, Aiden. Few people can negotiate like that with a sorceress. Very well, I accept your terms lesson included. You really are interesting. I'll remember your name: if I ever need a witcher again, you'll be my first choice."

She gestured toward the door.

"Wait for me in the main square tonight, we'll handle it together. Don't be late, that wouldn't be very gallant."

As I walked out, I heard Philippa add, amused:

"And to finally answer your question, Aiden: yes, I am indeed a lady. Don't make me prove it to you."

POV Aiden

I was eating a sandwich with Dandelion, sitting on some crates in the main square, packed with people passing through. I'd just finished recapping our conversation. He looked at me, amused.

"I don't know if you're not secretly Geralt's son, honestly you're already catching a sorceress's attention."

I sighed.

"I don't really see what I did to cause that."

Dandelion laughed, busy restringing his instrument.

"Honestly, I got the impression she was flirting dangerously with you. Maybe Philippa's got a thing for young men."

I sighed, finishing my sandwich.

"I don't see where you got flirting out of that. I got more the impression she was trying to manipulate me. Anyway."

Dandelion shrugged, amused, pointing a finger at me.

"Love's sometimes just manipulation, you know. After all, you manipulate your own words and gestures pretty well when you're flirting with a woman trust me, I know a thing or two about it."

I laughed lightly.

"Sure, the great Dandelion knows a thing or two. Remind me how often women actually respond to you?"

He shrugged, smiling.

"Know that out of ten women, at least two fall for my charm."

After that little vain speech, he set his instrument down beside him, curious.

"By the way, why the magic training?"

I didn't answer right away it was a risky bet, honestly but eventually said:

"Honestly? Even though I've already had some magic training, Triss once told me that Philippa, manipulative or not, remains an extremely powerful and experienced sorceress. She's had time to gather a lot of knowledge over the years. And even with the risk of manipulation, I'll take it anyway."

Dandelion sighed.

"I'd have said you just wanted to see her again. But be careful, all right? Geralt's had his share of stories with sorceresses, and I know a few myself it's sometimes dangerous playing games with them. They're gorgeous, sure, but their behavior would make even the greatest bard around me shiver."

I laughed.

"Yeah, yeah. Anyway, you heading back to the inn tonight?"

He shook his head, serious.

"No. I told you, I'm coming with you."

I frowned.

"Dandelion, that's not..."

He cut me off with a wave of his hand.

"No need to tell me, I know it's dangerous. But you're close to my friend Geralt, and that makes you someone I need to help too. Even if you refuse, I'll follow you anyway it's a matter of principle, for me."

I sighed, smiling despite myself.

"You should really change your outfit, though. You look way too much like a woman in that."

He acted offended, smiling, and walked off.

The hours passed, and evening came. The streets had emptied out. I heard footsteps, including the click of heels, and looked up: Philippa was approaching, that smile on her lips, her eyes locked on me, still sending a shiver through me despite myself. I got up from the crates, Dandelion beside me, now changed into leather gear, his instrument still slung over his shoulder.

As she got closer, she smiled.

"I thought pets weren't allowed after dark."

I frowned, knowing she meant Dandelion. Before I could answer, he smiled, not offended in the slightest.

"Indeed. But unfortunately for you, madam, if you want to keep your little contract with Aiden going, you'll have to accept me too because, to be honest, I have absolutely zero trust in you."

One of Philippa's men stepped forward, ready to strike Dandelion, but I stepped between them and struck the man's throat he dropped to his knees, choking, under the

watchful eyes of the other soldiers, who drew their swords. Looking at Philippa, who watched the whole thing like a show, I said calmly:

"Keep your soldiers on a leash, Philippa. I'll handle Dandelion, you don't need to worry about him."

She shrugged, amused.

"As you wish, as long as the contract gets fulfilled, you can keep him." She walked past me, letting her fingers trail across my armor, staring at me. "But careful, Aiden. Don't push your privileges too far."

Then she headed off toward the port with her men. I said nothing, just watching her go, then turned to Dandelion.

"Let's go."

He nodded, and we set off through the streets, alongside Philippa and her soldiers including the one I'd struck in the throat, still a bit short of breath, shooting me hostile looks. Honestly? No regrets on my end. As we walked, I asked:

"What exactly does your spell involve?"

She smiled, glancing at me sideways without slowing down.

"Looking for information? If I interest you, just say so."

I didn't take the bait.

"Just answer me."

She sighed, calm.

"I'm going to take the corpse of one of the dead, which my soldiers will hold in place, and cast a spell no point explaining the details. But if you'd rather know: I'll be vulnerable while casting it, my soldiers around me, and you'll need to hold the line. The spell will take about ten minutes."

I nodded. We eventually reached the port, where bloated corpses were already climbing out of the water the smell was unbearable, a mix of rot and mildew. Drawing my sword, I walked forward calmly. I heard Philippa behind me:

"I need one, don't forget."

I didn't answer. When one of the dead attacked, I simply dodged, slicing off its legs and arms in a fraction of a second. Dragging it along, ignoring the others closing in, I brought it over to Philippa, who watched me with a smile, and I shattered the corpse's jaw with a kick.

"Will this do?"

She laughed.

"Efficient, and distant. Just how I like it." She crouched beside the corpse. "Indeed, this'll do." She signaled to her guards two took position in front of her, the other two holding the corpse still and began conjuring magical circles from her hands, reciting an incantation.

Watching the dead approach, I drew my silver sword this time if these were magic-born monsters, silver had always been the most effective and moved toward them, blade firmly in hand.

POV Philippa

Even while reciting my spell, I could keep an eye on this witcher no, on Aiden, rather. He was interesting. Nothing like the usual men who look at us sorceresses like nothing more than pieces of meat.

The only one I'd ever found even remotely interesting before him was Dijkstra. But well, he's still human and even though he'd never say it, he still secretly believes himself above me. What an idiot. This young witcher, on the other hand, was far more to my taste: young, intelligent, and that cold distance he maintained so effortlessly.

Even though he never said it outright, I noticed he wasn't surprised by my name so someone had already mentioned me to him. Triss, probably. After all, if he's truly a Wolf School witcher, he must have crossed paths with the famous White Wolf the one who became Triss's little fling.

What an idiot, that woman. I had so many plans for her, once. But no matter, I've found a much better pawn in this witcher. Even young, he's given me more surprises than I've had in a long while he managed to catch the little hints I deliberately left for him, just to test his attention. He didn't disappoint.

As for his strength? Watching him spin through the dead, cutting them down without a hint of expression a clean sword strike beheading one after another even fully surrounded, he practically danced with that silver blade, weaving between witcher Signs to push back the horde or shield himself, right in the middle of the swarming corpses, as if strolling through a quiet market. The most insulting part is that he walked never rushing, as if the whole thing bored him slightly, even though I could easily tell he stayed perfectly focused.

I couldn't help but smile, licking my lips, finishing up my nearly complete spell. Glancing over at the crown's so-called elite, struggling against barely two of the dead simply from lack of experience with monsters, I couldn't hold back a disdainful look. The worst part was that damned musician, smacking monster skulls with his lute, doing more to help my soldiers finish them off. Even a blasted bard proved more useful than they did.

No matter. This whole event will accomplish exactly what I set out to do in the first place: raise the standing and worth of mages in the public eye. The witcher? Just a bonus. As long as the other party's satisfied, everything's fine.

Finishing my spell, I finally caught sight of the lair I'd been searching for, delighted to find one of my suspicions confirmed. This was going to be interesting. Getting up, dusting off my robe, I called out:

"Aiden, it's done, you can come back!"

I conjured a wall of flame to keep the remaining dead from bothering us any further.

27: Chapter 26 : The truth

POV Aiden

Walking up to Philippa, who kept her smile, the wall of flames still behind me, I sheathed my silver sword and asked:

"So, where's this lair?"

Philippa smiled.

"Already impatient? Not really a great quality, Aiden. But fine."

She pointed toward the sea.

"The mage's hideout is in the water, probably in one of the sea caves nearby. Guess we're getting wet."

I sighed, already picturing myself diving in. She laughed.

"I'm teasing you. Don't worry, you won't need to dive I've got a spell to get us both down there without holding our breath, or even getting wet."

The guard I had struck in the throat a little earlier spoke up:

"Ma'am, you're not seriously going down there with that mutant, he..."

Philippa didn't even look at him, ice-cold.

"Since when does a guard speak without his superior's permission?"

The guard, a bit embarrassed, lowered his head but maybe out of frustration, he pressed on anyway:

"We're responsible for your safety, so.."

He didn't get to finish: Philippa turned to him and froze him with a spell. Holding him paralyzed, she stepped closer, cold:

"And on top of that, you keep talking? Protect me? You people can't even handle two walking corpses you're just corpses waiting to happen yourselves."

To keep things from escalating, I stepped between them.

"Can we quit the bickering? We've got dead people to deal with, and the problem's still not solved, I'll remind you."

She sniffed, releasing the spell. The guard, trembling, watched her with undisguised fear. Philippa smiled.

"Lucky for you I like you, Aiden. But you're right let's ignore these idiots, focus on what matters."

I turned to Dandelion.

"Head back to the inn, I'll meet you there."

He whispered in my ear, one eye on Philippa already giving orders to her soldiers.

"You sure about this? You see how she is."

I murmured back:

"Don't worry, I can handle myself. Trust me."

He looked at me in silence, then sighed he knew that, this time, Philippa held all the cards. Even if I could swim and dive, who knew how deep it went, or whether there were drowners along the way? Too much danger for him, in short. He finally said:

"Fine. But if anything steamy happens, you tell me, all right?"

I smiled despite myself, appreciating his way of lightening the mood.

"Of course. You'll get every detail for your songs."

Dandelion nodded, stepping back, ready to leave the moment the wall of flames dropped. Philippa approached.

"Ready?"

I nodded. She spoke a few words in Elder Speech, probably and dissolved her wall of flames. Dandelion walked off, casting me one last look, while Philippa's guards headed off in their own direction, dragging the remaining undead along with them. Philippa conjured a sort of bubble around the two of us, and we started walking toward the sea.

General POV

As Aiden and Philippa descended underwater, the depths revealed an entire army of the dead, seemingly frozen in stasis, waiting for orders. Moving toward the spot where Philippa had detected the lair, Aiden asked, hand on the pommel of his silver sword:

"Necromancy's really that powerful?"

Philippa, keeping an eye on their surroundings, answered calmly:

"Indeed. Though it's pretty rare to have this many dead at once takes a seriously powerful mage to keep them all in stasis like this. And contrary to what children's tales say, the dead don't actually come back to life: it's magic artificially rebuilding them. Without it holding them together, they'd fall apart, since nothing's holding their limbs in place anymore. Honestly, magically speaking, golems and the walking dead aren't all that different except corpses are a lot cheaper to make."

Aiden let out a sarcastic laugh.

"Great. So now human lives cost less than soulless golems."

Philippa laughed, amused.

"What did you expect, Aiden? We don't live in a world of unicorns. And trust me, you haven't seen anything yet."

Silence settled as they moved between the frozen dead, heading toward the cave in the distance, where a strange light seemed to hold back the water. Aiden broke the silence, murmuring:

"You got an example of horror, then?"

Philippa smiled, glancing at him sideways.

"Plenty massacres, or the horrific experiments of our predecessor mages, without a shred of scruple. But I'll save the juiciest ones for myself, so we've still got something

to talk about later."

Aiden sighed, saying nothing more, Philippa's soft laugh echoing behind them. Arriving at the cave entrance, he ran his hand over some kind of barrier holding back the water, curious.

"What's this?"

Philippa examined it quickly.

"Just an illusory wall, blocking anything inanimate water, for instance. Whereas we…"

She walked through the entrance to demonstrate. Aiden did the same, and arriving in the massive chamber, the place was nothing ordinary anymore: it reeked of corpses, potions, and mold. But what would have made anyone unused to this kind of sight throw up was the pile of bodies heaped in one corner, like discarded trash. Philippa said, calm, far from her usual teasing tone:

"The mage who lived here was clearly focused on research involving bodies and corpses."

Aiden pinched his nose, hiding his disgust, and walked toward a kind of desk. Pushing aside some uninteresting papers, he found others far more telling:

"Looks like he was into DNA, or rather bloodlines testing compatibility between different people, like whether an elf could survive with a human bloodline added to their own. That's disgusting."

Philippa, showing no disgust whatsoever, used her magic on the corpses without a word. Aiden turned to her.

"Philippa?"

She turned toward him.

"Nothing. Let's keep moving, the mage might still be around here somewhere."

Aiden studied her for a moment, saying nothing, before following her, keeping his thoughts to himself. Along the way, the smell of decay started to fade Philippa simply explained it was a decontamination spell. Arriving finally in what looked like a throne room, a man stood there but what truly froze Aiden was the young girl with white hair standing beside him.

POV Aiden

I stood frozen, staring at the girl with ash-colored hair standing there, motionless, lifeless. Instinctively, I blurted out:

"Ciri?"

But noticing she looked older than she should, and that her eyes weren't the same green as Ciri's, I realized it wasn't her. My instinctive words had still drawn both people's attention. The man smiled.

"So my hypothesis was correct. Pleased to meet you, Aiden of Cintra."

Philippa, beside me, smiled without a word. I didn't even look at her I already knew I'd made a mistake, too late to fix it now. Fine. I drew my silver sword.

"You sick bastard. What did you do to your victims?"

The man laughed, running a hand through the young girl's hair beside him.

"Oh, Aiden, don't worry, you'll understand soon enough. But I take it my dear Philippa didn't say anything?"

I stared at Philippa, who kept her smile without answering, before turning back to the man.

"You know Vilgefortz. But self-interest always comes first, and I hate telling people things they don't need to know."

The man Vilgefortz, then laughed.

"Indeed. You haven't changed, Philippa. Still just as condescending, still just as manipulative."

He looked me straight in the eye, rising from his throne, his mage's staff shrinking into a simple cane in his hand, and said, calm but amused:

"Did she tell you she already knew where I was? Or that she's been using my own corpses for her magical experiments?"

I looked at Philippa, who shrugged, laughing, holding my gaze.

"What did you expect, Aiden? I already told you: this world's not made of unicorns and rainbows."

She shrugged and stepped toward me without a hint of fear, a smile on her lips she could clearly see me gritting my teeth at the contempt these two mages showed for the lives of the dead. She trailed a finger along my hand, still gripping my silver sword, her face close to mine, and said, staring at me:

"Consider this your lesson as a mage. Remember this well: when you negotiate with a mage or a sorceress, they'll always use you, one way or another, for their own ends."

She blocked, with a magical shield, the sword strike I aimed at her side, and said, detached:

"Shame, Aiden. But you see, I honor my contracts I gave you your lesson on sorceresses, and…"

She conjured a pouch from some spatial pocket and turned it over, spilling an impressive amount of crowns at my feet. Vilgefortz, behind me, seeing me seethe, laughed outright.

"You're harsh, Philippa. The poor boy's going to be traumatized."

Philippa tossed the empty pouch at my chest and, turning her back on me, walked toward Vilgefortz.

"Doesn't matter. For now, the grown-ups need to..."

But both of them instinctively sensed death closing in and summoned their strongest magical shields, barely blocking a massive, jagged ball of ice hurtling straight at them. Both magical shields shattered under the impact Philippa ended up wounded in the side while dodging, and Vilgefortz in the hand, trying to stop my ice sphere.

Philippa pressed a hand to her wound, looked at her blood-covered fingers, then raised her eyes to me. I felt a cold rage rising in me, mixed with a flat, terrible calm.

POV Philippa

I thought everything would go smoothly my whole plan was unfolding perfectly. Even humiliating Aiden a little would have only sharpened his sense of justice: once I

revealed it really was Vilgefortz conjuring these corpses, any normal man, playing the hero, would have stayed by my side to face him despite the contempt I'd shown him, without ever trying anything against me after all, on my own, I can handle a simple witcher just fine. But this…

I laughed, bitterly, but with real pleasure too my eyes must have been gleaming with hunger, quite literally, at what I saw: an aura of ice rapidly freezing over the entirety of Vilgefortz's lair. My breathing grew harder, the whole room turning colder, and the look he gave the two of us was a rage as cold as it was terrifyingly calm.

I laughed, using my own fire magic to cauterize my wound, gritting my teeth against the pain, then said, my voice dripping with hunger:

"Aiden, Aiden… You were hiding even more from me. This magic… how do you make it this pure?"

Further off, Vilgefortz sneered:

"Don't touch him, Philippa. His body belongs to me, and no one el..."

He didn't get to finish: Aiden, as if by magic, teleported right in front of him. Vilgefortz barely managed to raise a magical shield, but took the full force of the silver sword, now bristling with ice spikes, which sliced him clean in half.

I stood there stunned for a moment honestly, this magic, this teleportation, all of it only strengthened my desire to bring him further into my plans. Everything about it was so pure, so different from our own magic. But when he turned his glowing eyes toward me, I raised my hands in surrender.

"You can kill me, sure. But afterward, you'll have to explain why you came back alone, without the court sorceress. You really want the whole of Redania and the Council of Mages against you?"

Aiden froze in place. But before I could add anything else, a massive ice spike shot up beside him, and he smiled as if to get back at me for my earlier contempt. The spike shot toward me like an arrow. I summoned my magic, raising every magical shield I had but it tore through all of them, one after another. I was stunned: sure, I'm not the best at defensive magic, that field belongs to Triss, but I'm still one of the most powerful mages in this world. As I braced for what felt like my own death, the spike grazed my cheek, leaving a thin, bleeding cut.

I froze in place. When he stopped in front of me, his gloves still stained with blood, he brushed my wounded cheek and said, sarcastic, in the same tone I'd used on him earlier:

"I think you make a much better lady when you're bleeding, Philippa."

Honestly, I still don't know if I shivered from fear, or something else.

POV Aiden

Calming down, leaving Philippa frozen in place, I sighed, reining in my magic, when I heard a laugh Vilgefortz's. We both turned toward him: still sliced in half, he said, amused:

"Magnificent. Absolutely magnificent. Shame the main body will never get to see this."

Philippa, snapping out of it, frowned.

"The main body? Don't screw with me, Vilgefortz. I don't know how you survived that, but your magic's recognizable anywhere you can't just be some..."

But Vilgefortz laughed.

"Still so arrogant. You think you know everything, Philippa? The main body can't run all his experiments and be everywhere at once. But it's true I am Vilgefortz. And at the same time, not quite."

Philippa frowned, then went pale all at once.

"That madman! Don't tell me he actually used those powers for this!"

I looked at her, already running toward Vilgefortz, my instincts screaming danger.

"Philippa, what are you talking about?!"

She summoned an enormous fireball of her own, hurling it at Vilgefortz, shouting:

"No time to explain, we need to..."

But just as the fireball was about to hit him or my sword was about to take his head I heard laughter, and he spoke a few words in some demonic tongue, of which I only caught the end: "…Master Mirror, it's time to fulfill your contract."

The white-haired girl who so resembled Ciri teleported instantly in front of Vilgefortz, stopping the fireball dead in its tracks as if it had never existed, and caught my silver sword in one hand, snapping it clean in two. In one motion, she struck me hard in the gut, sending me crashing into the wall I coughed up blood, my back screaming in pain, and a volley of fireballs shot straight at me.

Ironically, it was Philippa who threw herself in the way, pitting her own flames against theirs in a deafening clash. She shouted:

"Aiden! Forget everything that's happened for now we need to work together to survive!"

I was about to ask why, but once the smoke cleared, I saw the girl fully transformed now, crouched atop Vilgefortz's severed clone say, in a demonic voice:

"Indeed. I'm here, as agreed. Don't forget: this is only for five minutes. After that, your soul is mine, and I won't do a thing more especially not in front of such a valuable client."

She or rather, he, speaking through this borrowed body added, almost disdainfully: "I must say, this body's a rather weak vessel to possess, but it'll do for the contract."

Vilgefortz's clone, still cut in half, sneered:

"Doesn't matter. That soul's nothing but an artificial copy, same as this body. Take it if you want, demon."

The girl then fully shifted into a demon genuinely demonic eyes, wings sprouting from her back and said:

"Then the terms of this contract are officially fulfilled."

She rose, staring at the both of us, conjuring a sword out of nowhere in one hand, a ball of black fire in the other:

"My dears, according to the terms of my contract, you must survive five minutes against me. Allow me to introduce myself: Master Mirror. I'd hate to kill potential clients, especially ones of such value. So, good luck."

Getting back up, I downed Swallow and Thunderbolt back to back, conjuring a blade of ice of extreme density. Black veins crept up my face, my eyes turning black from the toxicity. Cracking my neck, I said, without looking at Philippa:

"What are our odds?"

She laughed, using her magic to strengthen us both I could tell she was far from her usual self, serious, genuinely worried.

"Honestly? I'd give it ten percent, and that's assuming she's not even at full strength. If she were, we'd both die together, no question about it."

Bracing for Master Mirror's assault, I said, sarcastic:

"Well, at least we got our little date in. Try not to die I'm not really in the mood for the whole lovers-die-together cliché."

She laughed.

"We'll see, Aiden. I haven't forgotten your little wound but if we make it out of this, I promise, you'll get a kiss out of me."

With those words, the black fireballs surged toward us, Master Mirror charging straight at us, sword in hand. I lunged to intercept her, while Philippa handled the magic.

In a word, our goal: survive.

28: Chapter 27 : The Fight to Survive

(Before anything else, this little note is mostly for you, my readers I want to ask you a small favor. As you might guess, this chapter is packed with action.

This is one of the very first heavily action-focused chapters I've written, so I'd genuinely love your feedback on future action scenes what could be improved, or even if you think it works well as is. That's the only little mission I'm giving you.

Just so you know, I much prefer writing a 4000-word chapter if that's what it takes, because I hate it when a fight drags out over five whole chapters only for it to turn out, shockingly, that the hero never really doubted he'd survive. So on my end, it'll usually be condensed into a single chapter, even if it runs long.

Anyway, enjoy the read and honestly, I love discussing your theories and the little details I sneak in on purpose, so you can ask questions and point them out. Like how there's a bit of a forced romance vibe with Philippa yeah, that's true, that's on purpose.

Anyway, I'll stop talking now, thanks for your time!)

General POV

Aiden faced Master Mirror head-on, his reinforced ice sword in hand. At the clash of blades, he gritted his teeth, stepped his left foot back slightly, pivoting to keep his footing, and immediately triggered Aard to deflect the force of the opposing blade so it would slide along his own rather than meeting it head-on.

Master Mirror answered with a simple wave of the hand, summoning hundreds of flame lances around them in a split second. Philippa, backing him up, retaliated at once with her own water lances, sending them straight into the flames creating a massive cloud of scalding steam that engulfed both fighters.

The seconds ticked by in that thick fog, where the silhouettes were barely visible. Still, it was clear Aiden was at a serious disadvantage: despite instinctively using Aard to deflect Master Mirror's blade and attempt a weak counter, the man simply brushed it off with an almost insulting ease.

Cracks were already spreading through the ice sword Aiden had to keep regenerating it constantly to keep it from shattering completely. If he hadn't had the reflex to dodge, to let the opposing blade slide rather than meet it head-on, his weapon would already be in pieces.

Only the grinding of blades echoed through the lair, punctuated by both fighters' ragged breathing. Philippa, despite the lingering smoke, didn't hold back: she hurled powerful stone spheres and vines that surged toward Master Mirror.

He spared them barely a glance before stomping the ground creating an immense pit of flames that instantly incinerated the vines. A fire golem rose from the pit, absorbing the stone spheres without a scratch, and charged screaming at Philippa, completely ignoring Aiden.

Aiden seized that split second where Master Mirror had to look away to counter: the moment the man pushed his blade slightly forward, Aiden deflected it, slipped over the top, and stabbed his side. Master Mirror only smiled despite the blood, and with a sharp jab of his elbow, snapped off the ice sword lodged in him, tossing the shards into the air to catch them with his other hand while the now-free hand was already gripping Aiden's arm.

Aiden couldn't resist the force holding him, but seeing the blade airborne, he cast Aard to knock it away, conjuring an ice dagger at the same time to stab Master Mirror's left eye. The man merely laughed, spun Aiden through the air, and hurled him away.

One minute gone. Four remain.

Philippa was struggling on her end this golem, forged from demonic magic, barely responded to her attempts to slow it, ordinary magic having little effect on its makeup. But one does not underestimate one of the most powerful sorceresses in the realm with impunity: gritting her teeth, she summoned a powerful gravity spell, crushing the golem into the ground in a crash of shattered stone.

Master Mirror wasn't about to let his familiar be destroyed like that. After hurling Aiden into the wall, he conjured a bow of demonic flame and, upon firing, simultaneously produced a hail of burning arrows streaking toward Philippa. She had to abandon her gravity spell to raise a wave of water, swallowing the projectiles whole

but that brief window let the golem get back up and slam into her ribs. She barely had time to summon a magical armor, still feeling the force of the blow, coughing up blood.

The impact of the wall against her back tore a pained growl from her. Her legs were bleeding, her torn skirt revealing a deep wound. Without hesitation, she set her hands ablaze and cauterized the injury, screaming in pain but as she raised her head, she saw Master Mirror closing in, that dagger still lodged in his eye, the golem charging alongside him.

Aiden, back on his feet despite the impact, arrived like a rocket: propelled by a burst of ice, he raised a wall that blocked Master Mirror, reinforced by a magical zone that rained down ice spikes as sharp as blades buying a few precious seconds.

Riding that momentum, Aiden shot like an arrow toward the golem's arm as it prepared to finish off Philippa. His kick deflected the strike just enough, narrowly missing the sorceress's head, though she still felt the flames' heat lick her face. Without wasting time, Aiden having crashed hard back to the ground slid using his ice magic, circled behind the golem, conjured an ice morning star, and struck with all his strength at the cracked stone. The golem shattered, exposing its energy core to Philippa, who slid a water serpent straight through the cracks killing it instantly. The golem collapsed in pieces between them.

Two minutes gone. Three remain.

Barely a moment to catch their breath: Aiden's wall shattered, and Master Mirror appeared right in front of him. On instinct, Aiden teleported to dodge the blade slicing toward him, landing behind his opponent but the man, without even turning, twisted his arm back to aim for Aiden's eye.

Aiden only had time to tilt his head, body tipping backward but the blade still caught his left eye, which snapped shut instinctively under the rush of blood. With only one working eye, he still managed to land a solid hit with his morning star on Master Mirror's back, inflicting a serious wound without so much as a grunt from the man. He then grabbed Philippa's head by the hair and hurled her body violently into Aiden, who, under the weight and force of the impact, ended up pinned against the wall with her, his skull bleeding.

Philippa, less hurt, struggled back up, leaving Aiden still dazed. She barely had time to raise a wall of water to block a fireball but Master Mirror passed straight through it without a care, grabbed her by the throat, tore the ice dagger from his own eye, shattering it on the ground, and regenerated the eye while healing his wounds with a smile.

Just as he was about to snap her neck, Aiden managed to slice off his arm with a fresh ice sword visibly less dense now, lacking sufficient energy. He'd already used his magic to stop the bleeding from his head, quickly wiping the blood from his left eye with his sleeve hurt, sure, but no real danger to his sight. His face stayed smeared with blood, simply from the hasty gesture.

Philippa, landing back on her feet after severing the arm, unleashed another burst of gravity, slamming Master Mirror violently into the wall.

Three minutes gone. Two remain.

While Philippa fought to stay upright, exhausted, her leg wound reopened, Aiden was no better off between the shock and the constant drain of magic, both of them were drenched in sweat, clothes clinging to their skin, mixed with blood from their wounds.

Their breathing grew heavy, labored. But Master Mirror had a contract to honor: with a simple snap of his fingers, despite the gravity spell still pinning him to the wall, he summoned burning skulls toward both of them. Aiden conjured a massive ice sword to cut them down, producing a cloud of white vapor where fire met frost and using that brief moment of disruption, which slightly threw off Philippa, Master Mirror broke free of the gravity spell by sacrificing his other arm, seemingly unbothered in the slightest.

In a flash, he regrew both arms without difficulty, along with his sword back in hand indifferent to losing his weapon, since he could summon it back at will.

Aiden tried to intercept him with his own ice blade, but Master Mirror, without a second thought, let himself be run through by Aiden's sword simultaneously driving his own into his opponent's ribs. Aiden coughed up blood from the impact, before being violently shoved to the ground.

Philippa tried to keep Master Mirror from closing in further walls of flame, walls of water, deadly traps, poison nothing seemed to slow him down. He kept walking, calmly, until he teleported right in front of her and struck her stomach so violently she felt her organs give way, coughing up blood. Not wanting her to pass out too soon, he grabbed her by the hair and landed a right hook straight to her face, dropping her, exhausted, badly wounded, unconscious.

He approached her head calmly, summoned his sword again, and swung it down to behead her.

Four minutes gone. One remains.

But the blade was caught by Aiden's own hand, which began bleeding under the pressure, shielding Philippa's throat just in time a shallow cut still marked her neck from the tip. Drawing on his last reserves, he pressed his hand to Master Mirror's throat and, without even understanding how, triggered a teleport that flung them both to the far side of the room, away from Philippa, collapsed on the ground.

Master Mirror answered at once with a brutal right hook to Aiden's face he took it without losing consciousness, despite the blood he coughed up, staring his opponent dead in the eye. His own eyes blazed with such intensity that even Master Mirror felt, for one instant, real danger.

Danger? Him?

No time to dwell on that thought: the sword fight resumed in full force. Aiden kept conjuring ice blades without a thought for his own energy reserves anymore; Master Mirror, well used to it by now, took every hit with something close to genuine enjoyment, grabbing Aiden's arm again the moment he tried to stab him.

Trying the same move again, he aimed this time for Aiden's throat with his blade but Aiden teleported behind him, stabbing him again in the same spot.

Forty seconds.

Master Mirror snarled in frustration and slammed the ground violently, making Aiden stumble. He used the opening to swing his sword, aiming to cut him clean in half but Aiden crouched just in time, gripping his blade in a thrusting stance, and struck the opposing hand with the pommel of his ice sword. Master Mirror simply summoned his blade back into his other hand, striking his opponent's back at once.

Twenty seconds.

Aiden dodged just in time, pivoting on his right foot, still feeling the blade's edge nick his chest not that he cared. Drawing on his last strength, he gritted his teeth and summoned thousands of ice blades around Master Mirror, which surged toward him from every direction. In something like a beautiful, terrible dance, Aiden teleported instinctively from point to point, striking every side of his opponent, dodging by reflex the blades sinking one after another into Master Mirror's body.

Then, finally, Aiden's strength gave out, and he dropped to his knees, breathing hard, staring at his opponent now transformed into a veritable hedgehog of ice blades.

Five seconds.

But Master Mirror shattered every blade in a single gesture, right before Aiden's exhausted eyes.

Four seconds.

Seeing Aiden on his knees, Master Mirror lunged, sword aimed at his throat.

Three seconds.

He was only inches away now.

Two seconds.

Just as the blade was about to pierce his flesh, Aiden, in one last desperate effort, caught it bare-handed, keeping it from reaching his throat.

One second.

But his strength was fading. Despite his bloodied hands, he couldn't hold on any longer, and Master Mirror's blade came down, sinking into his neck.

Zero seconds.

The tip nicked Aiden's throat, drawing a thin line of blood, before stopping cold. Staring into his eyes, Master Mirror spoke in his demonic voice:

"Time's up."

Vilgefortz's clone, silent throughout the entire fight, couldn't believe it these two had actually held their own against Master Mirror. Even sliced in half, he drew on his last reserves to attempt one final spell, hoping at least to kill this boy, far too dangerous for the main body to leave alive. But just as he began his incantation, Master Mirror appeared before him and sliced off his tongue, stunning him into silence. He simply smiled.

"Sorry, but your contract's closed I don't have time to wait around for you to finish your spell."

Under Aiden's gaze, Vilgefortz's clone could only watch, powerless, as his own failure played out, hoping the main body would succeed where he hadn't.

The clone's body disintegrated, leaving only a skull, which Master Mirror calmly picked up. Turning to Aiden, he smiled.

"We'll meet again, Aiden of Cintra. I'm quite curious to see just how far you'll go, especially since…"

Aiden couldn't follow the rest Master Mirror had switched to some demonic tongue but from the tone, he guessed it was probably a name. Master Mirror walked off toward the wall, whistling, tossing the clone's skull into the air; the borrowed body collapsed like a rag doll, while the skull dissolved into nothing. Only the whistling lingered a moment longer in the silence of the lair.

But the important thing was: they'd survived.

(Hope you enjoyed that, I did my best to capture this fight.

Small note: a few real-world fencing techniques inspired this chapter, like:

— Das Fühlen (The Feeling): instantly sensing, through the mere contact of blades, whether the opponent is pushing with force (Hart) or lacking support (Weich). Against a much stronger opponent, detecting that excess force immediately triggers deflection techniques.

— Abwenden (The Deflection): a fluid redirection where you let the opponent's heavier blade slide along your own, slightly adjusting the angle of your guard, without ever meeting force with force.

— Ringen am Schwert (Wrestling at the Sword): the whole set of arm locks, throws, sweeps, and leg hooks performed using the guard or pommel of the sword as leverage to throw a heavier opponent to the ground.

Those were the three main techniques I used to build this fight.)

29: Chapter 28 : Roggeveen's departure

POV Aiden

I winced as I sat up, the echo of Master Mirror's whistling still seeming to ring in my ears. Instinctively, I touched a hand to my neck, feeling barely a drop of blood nothing more.

I sighed, caught between relief at having survived and worry at the sight of my right hand, badly injured from gripping that blade bare-handed. It was shaking. Even though I couldn't quite feel it yet myself, my body was trembling with fear I'd come within a hair's breadth of dying.

Clenching my fist a few times to shake off the daze, I got up slowly, wincing in pain, one hand pressed where Master Mirror had stabbed me the wound had reopened. I cast a low-intensity Igni, gritting my teeth to hold back a cry, until the injury closed, at least partially.

Once it had sealed, I wiped my bloodied hand absently on my tunic, then turned around: Philippa was getting up too, just as painfully, and said with a smile:

"We survived. Coming to collect your reward?"

I sighed, walking toward her in small steps.

"Cut the act."

She frowned, healing herself with her magic.

"I don't see what you're..."

I cut her off flat, stomping the ground an immense ice lance shot up instantly, level with her throat. Exhausted, I said:

"I'm not repeating myself. I'm wiped out, I hurt everywhere, and I'm done playing your little game."

She stared at me in silence for several long seconds, then tied her hair back into a ponytail and answered, in a flat calm, very unlike her usual tone:

"Fine. This is starting to wear me out too."

She tapped a finger against the lance.

"Get that out of my sight. Either way, there's nothing you can do if you walk out of here alone — everyone will think you killed me. So hurry up."

I said nothing, but made the lance disappear. She immediately went back to eyeing me with her usual arrogance until I conjured several more lances around her, coldly.

"True, I can't kill you. But I can make you suffer. And besides, if you make it out of this, you're not exactly going to go around telling everyone that the great Philippa got seriously roughed up by a simple witcher."

She didn't answer, but I could tell that if we hadn't both been wounded, she'd already have sought revenge. She finally said, cold:

"Fine. You win, Aiden."

She turned away, conjuring a teleportation portal, but shot one last glance before leaving.

"One more thing: don't think you'll get any peace now. I want to know more about your magic, and for your information with or without your consent, that makes no difference to me."

She smiled.

"By the way, just as you yourself suggested, I'm going to make sure everyone knows it was me, the fabulous sorceress, who solved this whole mess you having been nothing more than basic support. You don't mind me taking all the credit, do you?"

Then she tossed a pouch full of crowns at my feet, pulled from her storage space, and said, cold:

"That's to honor the terms of the contract. The coins I gave you earlier were just an illusion I'm only doing this so you don't think I'm worth less than some back-alley con artist. I have a reputation to maintain, after all."

She walked toward her portal, waving a hand.

"Anyway, my dear future pawn, don't stray too far. Even if you run, I'll find you you're far too interesting for me to just let you go."

Just as she was about to teleport, I muttered, sarcastic:

"You're right. I prefer Yennefer."

She shot me a furious look her hatred of Yennefer was public knowledge and started: "You little..." But she didn't get to finish the insult: she vanished into the portal.

I sighed, looking around. All right. Now, how was I supposed to get out of here? I started walking toward another room, limping slightly, and arriving in a sort of office, I began going through the documents scattered there.

Most of them concerned deals for buying corpses with other powers, or letters exchanged between Vilgefortz's main body and his secondary body the most recent one, written years earlier, hinted, through some particularly harsh words, that this secondary body was demanding its independence. But turning around, I froze on the spot.

In front of me stood a complete genealogical tree of Cintra's royal family, tracing back over a century impressive enough on its own. But what chilled me were the small notes scrawled beside Calanthe, Ciri's mother, and Ciri herself: notes referencing the Elder Blood, and a power someone was actively trying to awaken with or without her consent.

I didn't need to see anything more. I had to warn Geralt, Ciri, and the rest of the group at Kaer Morhen, as fast as possible. I headed for the exit but arriving at the water barrier, I realized we'd gone way too deep. With my wounds, there was no way I'd be able to swim back up to the surface.

I thought it over. There was one option left: that strange teleportation magic I'd already used back in Cintra, and again during this fight. Closing my eyes, I did as Triss had taught me and, strangely, I could still hear her voice.

"Clear your mind, Aiden."

I cleared it. I found myself in a completely black world, without a trace of light.

Triss's voice continued, inside my head:

"Magic is instinctive. Fire answers to intense emotions, water to calming ones. So when you're looking for something, think it over, deep down: how would you define

your own magic?"

Free. Without the slightest restraint, without the slightest obstacle. Like a swallow.

Triss's voice came again, soft:

"Good. Now try to..."

But suddenly, I frowned her voice cut out all at once. The swallow exploded in front of me, an immense shower of feathers filling my entire field of vision. I forced myself to come back to the real world, but all at once, as if I were losing my very sight, everything went black.

Even when my inner world was dark, I could usually still make something out, like in the night. But this time, nothing at all. I could feel my own breathing, the cold air against my teeth, as if all my senses had suddenly sharpened to an extreme degree.

Then, all at once, as if someone had switched on an enormous light, my sight returned but I couldn't move. A massive reptilian eye stared at me with indescribable intensity, and I could feel the breath from its nostrils sweeping across my face.

How is this possible? This is my mind, not the real world, I...

What silenced me was a swallow that came to perch calmly on the dragon's snout and, as if scolding it, gave its nose a few little taps with its wing the dragon's only response was a snort, before it spoke, for the first time, in a deep voice:

"You are not yet ready, Ceanndraig, to use this power without understanding what's truly at stake. It's for your own good. But this once, you will use it anyway know only that the hour of your choice has come."

Without waiting for my answer, it devoured me.

I woke up in the real world, feeling an immense power rising within me. What I couldn't see myself was that my eyes were glowing no longer with a cat's slit pupils, but with true dragon pupils. Had I been paying closer attention, I'd also have noticed scales appearing along my arm, and the wounds on my chest sealing themselves shut.

Then I felt that it needed to be released my entire body grew intensely luminous, and I absolutely had to let it go, and then…

The only thing I remembered upon opening my eyes again was that I was in midair, diving straight down toward the water but near the harbor, this time. I caught sight of Dandelion just in time, completely frozen in shock at seeing me plummet, powerless, toward the water.

He didn't hesitate a second: kicking off his shoes in one motion, he sprinted toward the harbor. The last thing I remember is my head hitting the water first. Then nothing.

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Waking up with a start, hand on my heart, I felt a jolt as I accidentally headbutted Dandelion while sitting up. Holding his skull, he said:

"Your head's as hard as a maiden's thighs."

Looking around, I recognized my room at the inn he must have dragged me all the way here. Meeting his worried gaze, I asked, on instinct:

"What happened?"

He sighed, picking his needle and thread back up, tilting my head to the side.

"Stop moving, I'm trying to stitch up that cut on your eye you'll have a nice scar, just like Geralt."

I sighed, letting him work. He continued as he sewed:

"Honestly, I waited for you until the next day. You slept for fifteen hours."

I froze.

"Fifteen hours?!"

He nodded.

"Yep. Don't worry, aside from becoming every kid's dream after they watched you fly through the air by magic, and a few widows particularly enjoying the view of your chest."

I sighed at his usual humor which, strangely, I'd missed, so much lighter than Philippa's and smiled.

"Thanks, but no thanks. Anyway, what do you actually remember?"

Finishing the stitches, he answered:

"Just that when you appeared in the air, it looked like you were literally tearing through space with claws, before bursting out like a thunderclap. Don't worry, I managed to save you from drowning, and to dodge the guards' questions, but…"

He stood up, set a pouch on the table, and smiled.

"Gildart found out Philippa officially took credit for solving the whole thing, with you as nothing more than vague backup. All the public recognition goes to her. But the steward could tell your role was way bigger than that and when he heard about some mage who looked like a wounded warrior showing up out of nowhere, he immediately knew it was you. He tracked you down, and gave you the reward meant for him and his men. He even said outright that nothing would stop him from doing it, even if some would call it a kind of betrayal."

I was surprised at the weight of the pouch eyeballing it, there had to be around three hundred crowns in there. I looked at Dandelion, who kept smiling.

"How is that even possible? I mean, I didn't even officially agree to his contract."

He shrugged.

"Like you know, I asked him why. He simply told me that, to him, you'd been a savior for him, and for his men. And even if no one else knows the truth, in the steward's own heart, you solved their problem. That's enough for him."

I sighed, looking at the pouch, then held it out to Dandelion, who froze. Just as he was about to hand it back, I stopped him.

"Keep it."

He shook his head.

"I can't, Aiden, that's..."

I cut him off.

"No, keep it. You saved my life in the water. You came with me even though you didn't have to. And even though it's a bit hard to admit, I was glad to have you by my side it made dealing with Philippa a lot more bearable."

Seeing him still hesitate, I smiled.

"If you hesitate again next time, you're buying the food and drinks."

He sighed, nodding, then froze.

"Wait, what do you mean? You're already leaving?!"

I nodded, sitting on the edge of the bed, feet on the floor, still wincing from the pain and exhaustion, then explained everything I'd discovered in the lair. It froze him in place.

"Aiden, you don't have to go right this second."

I sighed, eyes turned to the ceiling. I knew I didn't have to stress this much Ciri was at Kaer Morhen, protected by two of the best sorceresses and witchers around. But I had to check for myself. I looked at Dandelion, serious.

"I know. But I have to go anyway."

He sighed, stood up, smiling.

"Shame. And here I wanted to take you to the cabarets or the brothels to forge you into a real man."

I laughed.

"Ciri would've killed you. And I'm not even counting Triss, who'd have burned you alive on the spot."

Over the next few minutes, he asked me about Ciri, about our childhood together and I genuinely enjoyed talking with him. He's a great storyteller, and I finally understood why Geralt liked him so much, despite his rather peculiar behavior: someone who, in this world, was clearly no fighter, yet wouldn't hesitate for a second to follow someone into mortal danger simply because they were close to his best friend. That kind of thing wasn't exactly common.

The hours passed, letting me regain a bit of strength though not quite enough. Stroking Nocturne's coat, who nuzzled affectionately against my arm, I saw Dandelion arrive with several bags, smiling.

"If you can't enjoy the meal here, here's some provisions instead."

I sighed.

"You didn't have to, again."

He shook his head, amused.

"It's a gift from the innkeeper, and the townsfolk."

Once again, I was caught off guard. He laughed at my reaction.

"The steward spread word of the truth. Sure, the high society types will never believe a mere steward, but the common folk believe him without hesitation Gildart's well-loved by the people, especially since he was born a commoner himself."

I sighed, looking at all the provisions, strapping them to Nocturne's saddle with a smile, then pulled Dandelion into a hug.

"Thanks, my friend."

He laughed, returning the embrace, then said:

"Go find Ciri. And next time we cross paths, I'll buy you a drink and a new song about your adventures, I promise."

I smiled, mounted Nocturne, got her moving, then stopped for a moment, turning back to Dandelion.

"Can you do me one last favor?"

He looked at me, curious.

"Sure?"

I smiled.

"Spread the rumor without putting yourself in danger, of course that Philippa could've solved this whole thing much sooner, if she'd really wanted to. Even if it stays low-key, if it annoys her even a little, that'll already be a small victory for me."

He burst out laughing.

"Promise, I'll handle it."

I nodded, calmly riding Nocturne out of Roggeven. The townsfolk I passed greeted me with a smile, murmuring simply: "Thank you, witcher! Thank you for saving our city!"

Even though only they could really believe the truth, and my official reputation wouldn't reflect it nearly as much as it deserved, I smiled naturally, my heart swelling at these sincere thanks. Approaching the gate, I stopped short: Gildart was waiting there with his men, a smile on his face. Drawing his sword, he shouted:

"Soldiers! Show the witcher how Roggeven says thank you!"

Every soldier drew their sword, holding it against their chest, forming two neat rows with a clear path between them. As I rode Nocturne down that path, the soldiers raised their swords, shouting:

"Thank you, witcher!"

Arriving at the exit, Gildart, waiting there, smiled.

"Witcher, Roggeven will always be glad to welcome you back. May the road treat you well."

I nodded, smiling, then, clicking my tongue, sent Nocturne galloping off, far from Roggeven, my heart far lighter than when I'd arrived.

It had already been a few hours since I'd set up camp. Night had fallen, Nocturne sleeping peacefully in her corner. As night settled in and Roggeven grew further and further behind me, I felt a strange oppression creeping over me, like a dull pressure on my chest like I was being watched.

No. It had to just be my imagination. Aiden, don't get paranoid.

I was just about to settle in for the night myself when three figures burst out of the bushes, startling Nocturne awake, who whinnied nervously. I froze: three werewolves stood before me but nothing like the ordinary variety of that creature.

Before I could even react or analyze anything, the smallest of the three, armed with a club, charged at me with impressive speed slower than Master Mirror, sure, but I still hadn't fully recovered my strength.

Dodging his dagger just in time, I conjured an ice sword, aiming for his head but he parried it with ease, an arrogant smile on his lips. That smile vanished the instant my other hand drove a second blade into his side: activating my magic, the ice spread instantly through his entire body, freezing his organs solid. In one last desperate move, he tried to slash my throat with his claws but Nocturne charged in from behind and landed a violent kick straight to his head, knocking him out cold, the ice finishing off his frozen organs.

Turning to deal with the other two, it was already too late. The largest of the wolves stood right in front of me, a condescending smile on his lips, his fist far faster and more dangerous than expected flying straight at my face. I felt like I could still dodge, but just as I went to crouch, two vines shot up, wrapping around my legs: the third werewolf, hidden beneath a cloak, was using magic too, then.

No time to think further: the fist slammed into my face, sending me to the ground, dazed. As I tried to get up, the werewolf planted a foot on my back, pinning me down. I heard Nocturne's desperate whinnying, caught in the sorcerer's vines, tightening around her more and more, like a living cage.

The last words I heard came from the massive werewolf looming over me:

"Lord Lycaon sends his regards."

Then one last kick landed on my face. Nothing after that, except Nocturne's distant, desperate whinnying, just before I sank into unconsciousness.

POV Vilgefortz

I was comfortably settled in my mage's tower, at my desk, enjoying an excellent vintage of Toussaint wine, when a carrier pigeon brought me a message from the emperor: the army was already approaching Sodden Hill, and the Council of Mages would convene the very next day the fate of the North, or rather what they call their North, would be decided there. I was rather looking forward to it.

Glancing at the calendar, I said, amused:

"We've just crossed into 1264. And the plans are proceeding without a single hitch. Perfect."

What wiped that smile off my face was the appearance of that blasted demon, his eternal amused smile plastered on his lips. I said, cold:

"Already time, Master Mirror?"

He nodded, scanning my library with his eyes, and answered calmly:

"Indeed. Per the terms of our contract, every five years, you may ask me one question about anything happening anywhere in the world."

I laughed, arrogant.

"You really think I still care about that? I already control this world, while everyone else still imagines they're playing at the little game of kings. I'm about to separate this witcher from Cintra's princess the one who thought she could hide just by dyeing her hair, once she arrived at Aretuza. Honestly, I'm disappointed in Triss. She should know full well that only a rare few mages have the affinity to perceive the glow unique to each person's magic and Ciri's… delicious."

Master Mirror kept his smile, unbothered.

"Your little perverse games don't interest me in the slightest. A contract's a contract so honor it, and ask your question."

I sighed, irritated did this demon really think he could lecture me? I finally asked, almost at random:

"Fine. Tell me whether my clone succeeded in his experiments."

Master Mirror smiled.

"Are you sure about that question? After this, you won't be able to ask me another for five full years."

I sneered.

"No need to repeat yourself. Just answer."

He shrugged, still smiling.

"Your clone was successful in his research."

I nodded without even looking at him the grimoire on bloodlines sitting in front of me interested me far more and said, bored:

"Fine. Question answered, you may go."

Master Mirror bowed, not the slightest bit offended, and vanished through the window. Watching him disappear out of the corner of my eye, I frowned, suddenly realizing he'd used the past tense. Could my clone be… dead?

I shook my head, laughing at my own paranoia that demon was surely just trying to drive me mad, when it's me who holds him on a leash. I smiled, running my fingers over the grimoire's pages, my gaze drifting into the hearth's flames.

And if this world doesn't want a mage as ambitious as me, well then, let's destroy it, and claim the power of the Elder Blood for myself alone. All that's left is to get rid of Ciri's watchdogs and she'll finally be mine.

30: Chapter 29 : The Preludes to the Battle of Sodden

(Hey everyone! This message is just a heads-up: this time, for a certain number of chapters, we'll be following Yennefer, Geralt, Triss, and Ciri's points of view.

Some of you will ask: why? I came here to read a story about an OC. I'll answer that it's necessary. I fully agree that, most of the time, people read a fanfic to see the changes made to a character, and revisit a world they love that's one of the reasons these POVs will dominate for the next several chapters.

But why dedicate whole chapters to the Battle of Sodden? You can just look it up on Google and know how it ends, so why bother with canon material? I'll answer that the Battle of Sodden is simply one of the most defining battles in the entire Witcher universe. Especially since anyone familiar with the franchise already knows how much has been changed here Geralt at Aretuza before the Battle of Sodden? When the great Geralt famously despises sorceresses, that's already a huge shift, especially since he's about to actively take part in it.

The last reason is for readers expecting the usual type of story, where you just follow the OC through the world without ever digging into the relationships between characters. I'd rather be upfront right now: to those who don't enjoy chapters where my character isn't the center of the universe I'm truly sorry, and I hope you find a story that suits you better.

Sorry for the long message, but I had to get it off my chest I got some comments from readers who don't like that Aiden isn't in every chapter. Sure, he'll always remain the main character, but in my view, you can't write a story focusing solely on one character and their thoughts.

Anyway, enjoy the read and sorry again about yesterday, I fell asleep the moment I got home and didn't wake up until the next day, sniff.)

POV Ciri

I was sitting quietly on my windowsill, absorbed in a book about magical focus and meditation.

It had already been several months since we'd arrived here, at Aretuza, and honestly, I still wondered if it had been a good idea. On top of everything, I had to ignore the contemptuous looks from the other mages and sorceresses, convinced I only had access to the academy's massive library because I was sponsored by the great sorceresses Yennefer of Vengerberg and Triss Merigold.

I clicked my tongue, frustrated, tugging at a lock of my hair dyed black and sighed, looking out at the sea.

"I could've done without Aretuza, honestly, if I'd had a choice, bunch of idiots."

Geralt's amused voice made me look up. Leaning against the doorframe, he said:

"Still grumbling?"

I turned, smiling slightly.

"What do you expect? The great and terrible 'Pavetta' the name you all told me to pick to avoid trouble, in case people found out my real name's Ciri is so spoiled by the great sorceresses that everyone looks at me with pure hostility."

Geralt sighed, closed the door behind him, and sat down in the chair at my desk.

"I'm truly sorry you have to live through that."

I sighed.

"Don't worry, Geralt. It's not your fault. We all knew I needed this training even if it frustrates me not to be progressing at the level I want."

Maybe trying to get him to smile in return, I added:

"By the way, I see you're starting to feel right at home here nice shirt, sword at your waist. Looks like you're being well fed and housed, in Triss's quarters."

He laughed.

"Maybe so. Triss insists we both live properly here at the academy, you and me even if my opinion of mages hasn't changed one bit."

I smiled.

"Honestly, Triss is right. You're way more handsome when you smile, Geralt."

He looked surprised, laughed lightly as he stood up, and ruffled my hair.

"Thanks, Ciri. I know you're changing the subject so I don't feel guilty but think about yourself too, all right?"

I smiled, pushing his hand away.

"Then quit treating me like a kid!"

He laughed.

"We'll see. For now, in my eyes, you still are one."

I sighed, grabbed a coat, hopped into my shoes to keep my balance, and said, sarcastic:

"Well, I gotta go wouldn't want to miss the famous lecture from the celebrated sorceress Eleanor."

Geralt sighed.

"You shouldn't mock your teachers."

I shrugged and, right before heading out, stuck out my tongue.

"Then she shouldn't tell stories in front of us that are clearly false." Then I ran off, sensing I'd be late again but hey, I was used to being the black sheep by now.

POV Geralt

I kept smiling as I watched her walk off with that energy, even though I knew the lack of progress weighed on her far more than she let on.

Glancing toward her desk, I opened a drawer and found countless papers research on her own power and just seeing the wastebasket overflowing with crumpled drafts told

me exactly how much it was eating at her. I wished Triss, or even Yennefer, could be around for her more, but unfortunately, both were getting busier by the day: Nilfgaard's army was closing in dangerously on some hill, at Sodden, and negotiations with the northern kings were starting to mobilize their armies.

(Small author's note: what happens in the TV show is pretty far from canon I'm basing this on the books and games for the Battle of Sodden.)

A soft knock at the door, which opened right after, made me look up: Triss walked in, smiling, and asked softly:

"Ciri already left?"

I nodded, handing her the papers I'd found.

"Yeah. I'd really like it if you all could help her out a bit more, but I'm guessing I'm about to get turned down again?"

She said nothing, looking over the papers with sadness, then answered:

"Yeah. The Northern kings have gathered their armies for Sodden Hill. As for us, the council is meeting tonight to decide if mages will join them."

She looked at me, hesitant.

"Geralt, I'd like you to come with me, if the council decides to go to war."

I looked at her, surprised, hesitating myself.

"Triss, you know I'm supposed to stay neutral it's the whole foundation of being a witcher, I..."

She smiled, sadly.

"Yeah, I get it. No need to explain yourself, I promise. Stay with Ciri, it's better this way."

Watching her walk off, back turned, I stared at the papers on Ciri's desk and sighed. I was going to trust her, like she kept telling me to she was growing up, and didn't necessarily need me glued to her side anymore, like some guard dog.

I caught Triss's hand; she turned, surprised. I said, serious:

"Fine. I'll go with you. But could you find me some kind of mask? Even if I end up getting recognized anyway, I'd rather take every chance I can to stay discreet."

She nodded, beaming, and pulled me into a hug, rising onto her toes, hands looping behind my neck, kissing me tenderly my own hands naturally finding the small of her back.

The kiss lasted a good while. Then she said softly:

"Don't worry about Ciri. I'll ask Margarita to look after her, if the council votes for war."

I looked at her, worried.

"Margarita? You sure?"

She nodded.

"Trust me. I know you're wary of mages, but believe me: Margarita would rather take on the whole world than leave her students unprotected. She's viscerally apolitical."

I sighed.

"Fine, I believe you."

She smiled, a spark of want in her eyes, and pulled me by the hand.

"I think I'll reward you, in my quarters. Does that tempt you, my White Wolf?"

I smiled, and let myself be led away.

POV Yennefer

I stared coldly at the woman in front of me without actually hating her, far from it. If I had to sum up the person standing before me, I'd say she'd been far more of a mother to me than my own ever was. Tissaia de Vries or "Tiss," as I liked to call her, purely to annoy her and crack that mask of coldness she wore permanently, exposing, in the process, her borderline obsession with perfection.

I crossed my arms.

"Tiss, you can't be serious. You haven't lost your mind, you know as well as I do there's something off about Vilgefortz demanding a council session right after the northern armies gather for Sodden."

Tissaia flinched slightly as she meticulously arranged her pencils on her desk, but answered, calm:

"No, I haven't lost my mind, Yennefer. I know perfectly well Vilgefortz is hiding something. But he's not wrong about one thing: if Nilfgaard takes the North, our freedom, all of ours, will be at risk."

I sighed.

"Sure, he's right about that specific point. But you know him, Tiss he's a hypocrite wrapped in a manipulator. And even if I'm willing to believe he's acting for the council, for mages in general, you know very well that if we join this battle, it'll amount to officially telling the emperor that mages have picked a side."

Tissaia looked me straight in the eye, hands folded in front of her.

"You're right. Vilgefortz has always been thirsty for power. But I also have a question, about you. I've known you for so long usually, you'd already have jumped at the chance to negotiate with those council schemers for funding for your fertility research. And yet, here you are, asking me if there isn't some conspiracy behind all this. The strangest person in this room, Yennefer, is you."

I stayed quiet for a moment. It was true: I myself had long been a manipulator. I wanted to do anything to regain my fertility, I dreamed of becoming a mother someday. But now? Even though I was no longer with Geralt since the djinn's bond broke, I held onto the memories of all my relationships with Triss, those idiot witchers, Geralt, Ciri, and Aiden.

I closed my eyes, then answered calmly:

"Because I finally figured out that what I was looking for, I already had, for a long time now. Now, the only thing I really want is to pull myself out of all these mage conspiracies. But unfortunately, despite how much I hate all this, I know that to protect the people who matter to me, I'll still need to get my hands a little dirty, in these councils."

Tissaia stayed silent, watching me, and though it was barely perceptible, a faint smile crossed her lips it gave me a small flutter in my chest. She finally said:

"I'm happy for you, Yennefer. If you've found your happiness, that's wonderful. But never forget: you still need to stay strong to protect the people you love passivity is a luxury only the powerful can afford."

A few hours later, on the eve of 1264.

General POV

Whispers filled the council chamber, where two camps were already visibly taking shape: those in favor of passivity, and everyone else.

Exchanges of promises, threats, and offers murmured through the room until the door opened, Tissaia entering with Yennefer close behind, putting an end to the whispering. As Tissaia took her seat at the council, the most powerful and senior mages settled into theirs as well.

Yennefer joined Triss, sitting beside her despite their relative youth, both women had earned their place here, given their respective abilities. But what drew the most attention was Philippa: bandages peeked out from beneath her sleeves, and despite the makeup, a black eye remained clearly visible.

Yennefer, of course, couldn't resist.

"So, Philippa? An angry lover took a swing at you?"

Philippa shot back, cold:

"Unfortunately for you, Yennefer, I don't have time to play the heartbroken lover. We're here to discuss things like adults something you seem to have forgotten."

Yennefer laughed, twirling a finger around the rim of her glass.

"Oh, I remember perfectly well. But tell me, what manipulative little plan are you cooking up for us this time?"

To the great delight of the other mages, witnessing the mutual hatred between the two women despite Triss discreetly trying to calm Yennefer under the table it was Tissaia's cold voice that put an end to the exchange:

"Enough. Today, it's time to decide on the mages' participation in the Battle of Sodden, which will soon take place between Nilfgaard and the northern kingdoms. According to

our information and ongoing negotiations, the northern kings' army has gathered at least a hundred thousand men for this battle proof enough, if any were needed, of just how strategically important that hill is. It's up to us now to decide whether we remain neutral, or pick a side."

Taking a sip of wine, the mage Stregobor said, sarcastic:

"I don't see why this council's even necessary. Need I remind you of our previous meeting about Cintra? We already warned you her fall was due to her queen's arrogance, refusing any mage at her court, preferring to keep a druid by her side instead."

Artorius, more composed, added calmly:

"Let's also not forget this war concerns kings, not mages. Nilfgaard's after the North, not magic none of this concerns us. Frankly, a good cleanup might do the North some good."

Francesca snapped back, cold:

"Oh really? I didn't realize mages had become such cowards."

Philippa added:

"Indeed, dear. Seems like, on top of losing their fertility, mages have turned into eunuchs too."

Stregobor retorted, hostile:

"Francesca, stick to your elves in your little caves, wouldn't that suit you better?"

Francesca was about to respond even more sharply when Vilgefortz burst out laughing and rose from his chair.

"Isn't this magnificent?"

He smiled, drawing every eye to him.

"Here you all are, bickering like children, while reality's staring us right in the face. You really think Nilfgaard will show us mercy? Once the North falls, do you honestly believe they'll leave a power like ours alone?"

Tissaia added:

"Let's also not forget how the emperor already treats the mages in his service. I remind you that one of our most brilliant sorceresses, Fringilla Vigo, is currently chained like an animal, forced to obey on pain of death. You really think our freedom won't be at risk?"

Artorius calmly shrugged.

"That's an entirely different discussion, Tissaia. We're talking about the Battle of Sodden here, not what happens after a potential Nilfgaardian victory that's a conversation for another day."

Yennefer shot back, icy:

"Does stupidity run in your bloodline, or what? You really think this is just some minor skirmish? You should brush up on your politics."

Artorius smiled.

"Oh, a young mage trying to lecture me when she herself doesn't even attend Vengerberg's political court anymore?"

Philippa cut in, amused:

"There, I can actually speak up, much as it pains me to admit it: Yennefer's right. You should revisit your politics lessons, Artorius, unless age is making you senile. I know a lovely place for retirement, you should consider it."

Stregobor, ready to defend his ally, started:

"You little..."

But Vilgefortz spoke first:

"Listen to me, all of you. I know you're afraid of dying, and that's perfectly understandable. But our participation isn't up for debate. Do you really want to see us all chained like animals one day? Where's our pride as mages gone?"

Tissaia cut him off:

"Enough. It's time to vote. Those voting for passivity, conjure a red light. Those voting to join the northern kings, a blue light."

Vilgefortz sat back down, all smiles, not the least bit bothered by the interruption despite Tissaia's pointed look. He raised his hand, summoning a blue light. Tissaia did the same, followed by Yennefer, Philippa, Francesca, Triss, and sixteen other mages. But what truly froze the entire blue camp was watching Artorius and Stregobor raise a red light, unsurprisingly followed, to everyone's genuine shock this time, by every other mage in the room.

Stregobor stood, laughing, beside Artorius.

"The vote's been cast. We remain neutral."

He left the chamber with the group that had voted red. Before walking out, Artorius called back to Philippa:

"Seems I know a bit more about politics than you do, Philippa."

Then he left, leaving the remaining twenty-two mages in a heavy silence.

Triss finally asked, hesitant:

"So what do we do now?"

Vilgefortz shrugged.

"We could honor the council's decision. Or we could go anyway, all of us, right here."

Seeing he'd captured everyone's attention, he continued, serious:

"Think it through. Even though the majority declined, our little group here still counts among the finest mages from every kingdom combined. We'll crush Nilfgaard, and we'll be seen as heroes while the passive ones grit their teeth, because in the eyes of the northern kings, we'll be the only ones worth trusting. So, what do you say? You with me? Because I'm going, regardless. I won't leave the northern kingdoms without the mages' support."

He extended his hand, calm.

"Join me for this war."

31: Chapter 30 : The Battle of Sodden Hill

POV Geralt

I sighed, sitting up in bed, under Triss's tent. It had already been a few days since the decision about Sodden Hill had been made unfortunately, the vast majority of mages had voted for neutrality. But still, apparently, from what Triss had told me, Vilgefortz and the other twenty-one mages had decided to take part anyway, despite the vote's outcome.

I hoped Triss was right about Margarita, and that Ciri would be safe that's what worried me most. Normally, everything should go fine.

I felt two arms wrap around my back, Triss's bare chest pressing against me. She whispered in my ear:

"What are you thinking about?"

I sighed, tilted my head to look at her, and kissed her tenderly she returned it. I said:

"Mostly Ciri. And this war, of course."

She smiled softly, tracing one of my scars with her finger, following its line.

"I don't remember this one."

I smiled.

"That's from a bruxa, on a contract. Don't worry, it wasn't too bad she hadn't fed on blood in a while."

She sighed softly, kissed the scar, then rested her head against my back.

"Don't worry about Ciri. Margarita's one of the few sorceresses I actually trust and you know me, ever since Philippa manipulated me, I've gotten pretty paranoid about

relationships."

I let her keep her head resting against me.

"I know. I was surprised myself that you opened up so easily to Aiden and Ciri."

She got up, admiring her own bare figure with a mix of desire and tenderness, leaned down to kiss me again, and said:

"Yeah. And it still hurts me that we never told Aiden anything. This'll be the last time next time, we at least need to warn him."

I nodded.

"Don't worry, we'll handle it."

She nodded back and, as she bent down, I smiled, shamelessly admiring her until she threw my own clothes right at my face. I kept smiling. She said:

"Come on, hurry up and get dressed, I need to make myself presentable."

I shook my head, amused.

"Honestly, out of every woman I've known, you're one of the rare ones who fixes herself up after..."

But without turning around, still doing her hair, still bare, she cut me off:

"Oh really? You've known a lot of women before me?"

I went quiet for a moment, then smiled.

"Doesn't matter. I never thought about anyone but you."

Getting dressed, grabbing my steel sword, she called out before I left:

"Don't forget we've got the mages' meeting at the main tent."

Nodding, putting on my mask, I stepped out.

Outside, I found hundreds, maybe thousands of tents stretching as far as the eye could see for the first time, the northern kingdoms had decided to unite. According to Yennefer, at least a hundred thousand men were gathered here, the various northern

kings' armies combined into one force. I walked through the tents, passing stewards handling supplies, or soldiers listening to others play an instrument maybe to calm their nerves, to forget that the comrade beside them might be living out his last night.

Others stood in line outside a tent to pray to their respective gods after all, when men feel lost, gods are the first thing they turn to for answers. But most often, all they get in return is silence.

Arriving at the mages' tent, I found Yennefer waiting for me, an amused smile on her lips:

"Finally, the mysterious witcher every sorceress is dying to know the one who conquered the heart of the famous Triss Merigold."

I sighed.

"Yen, do you really have to?"

She shrugged.

"Yes. Watching you squirm is my greatest pleasure. Don't worry, aside from Philippa, me, Triss, and Tissaia because she's sharp we're the only ones who know who you really are."

I frowned. I didn't know Tissaia well, but I knew Yennefer held a lot of respect for her, which was rare coming from her. Philippa, though, worried me more.

"Philippa? Is that a problem?"

She shook her head.

"No. Philippa's got plenty of flaws, but she knows better than anyone that knowing your identity serves her far more than revealing it to everyone."

Triss arrived just then, in travel gear, slipping her hand into mine.

"Did I miss something?"

Yennefer smiled.

"Just that some soldiers are probably crying tears of sorrow after hearing your little escapade last night. No, come on, the meeting's about to start, we're just waiting on Vilgefortz."

Nodding, we followed Yennefer into the tent, Triss never letting go of my hand.

POV Vilgefortz

I was quietly enjoying a good glass of wine in the marshal's tent when he walked in, in full armor. Seeing me, he frowned.

"You again? What do you want, mage?"

I smiled.

"Marshal Menno Coehoorn or just Menno, if you'll allow the familiarity from a mere subject of our emperor especially since I have some information that might interest you."

Menno sat down in his chair, pointing at me with open hostility.

"If it were up to me, you'd already be hanging, mage. But fine, what are you offering?"

Unbothered by his pathetic hostility, I answered:

"You see, I'd like to give you the exact position where the northern mages will be stationed so the mages you're holding prisoner can strike that spot precisely."

Menno considered this.

"That's interesting information. But how do you plan to manage that? From what I know, you mages are far too arrogant to follow orders."

Finishing my glass, I answered:

"Indeed, that's true. But you see, it's exactly that arrogance that will be their downfall. And for our emperor's plans, a massacre needs to happen so the mages finally understand the full extent of his power."

Menno stayed silent, studying the map, then said after several long minutes:

"Very well. Mark it on the map."

I nodded, drew a cross with a simple wave of my hand, then stood up, smiling:

"With that, I must rejoin my dear colleagues." Using teleportation, I heard, as I left, his last words: "Damned snake…" If only that were all I was.

Arriving outside, I brushed the dust from my hair, then walked into the mages' tent, smiling:

"My apologies, dear brothers and sisters. I have new information about Nilfgaard."

General POV

The armies had been waiting for hours now, ready for the assault. As promised, the mages stood at the top of the hill. Geralt, beside Yennefer and Triss, murmured, frowning:

"I don't know much about magic, but is it really wise to be this exposed?"

Yennefer, eyes still fixed on Nilfgaard's army, answered:

"No. But don't worry by the time they realize we're up on this hill, it'll already be too late. We'll have rained hellfire down on their mages and their troops."

Triss nodded.

"Yeah, don't worry, we're ready."

Geralt sighed, running a hand through his hair as the first drops began to fall.

"That's probably just my paranoia talking."

But he didn't get to continue: horns sounded from both armies, infantry advanced on both sides, and within minutes, shouts and clashing steel rang out.

Then came the cavalry from both sides, clashing, trying in vain to break through the opposing infantry lines.

Tissaia, beside Vilgefortz, frowned, watching him stay silent, eyes locked on the battle below.

"Is it normal the mages haven't retaliated yet?"

Vilgefortz kept his smile without answering, which only deepened Tissaia's suspicion. Philippa, arms crossed beside Francesca, said:

"At this rate, I'm starting to think we didn't even need to come. Nilfgaard's going to get crushed if this keeps up."

Francesca ran a hand through her hair as thunder rumbled and rain began pouring down.

"Maybe Nilfgaard just didn't expect mages, given how lopsided the numbers are."

Philippa stared at Vilgefortz's back. She hadn't forgotten what happened at Roggeven but why hadn't she said anything? Why would she, really, especially since Vilgefortz himself clearly wasn't fully aware of everything? Otherwise, she'd already have sold Aiden out for promises, while revealing the whole truth to Tissaia in the same breath.

But at that exact moment, something shifted across the faces of every northern mage present: normally, mage battles stayed limited in scope, their power too devastating to avoid causing panic and terror among ordinary humans. It had been years since mages had unleashed this kind of violence.

But Nilfgaard had other plans: massive fireballs and an entire sea of flame crashed down onto the first infantry battalions, reducing them to ash before they could mount any defense.

Then came more fireballs, triggering enormous explosions, hurling northern soldiers through the air some with their legs torn off, others unrecognizable, others still trying to drag a comrade who'd lost a limb, while explosions kept throwing dirt over their helmets.

As for the rare survivors, they either died minutes later from their wounds, or were finished off by Nilfgaard's advancing army. In mere seconds, at least ten thousand dead were already counted on the northern side.

Naturally, the northern mages reacted immediately, faces twisted with fury and hatred but just as they all prepared to strike back, their spells canceled out all at once, without exception. A crystal shattered quietly in Vilgefortz's pocket, unheard by anyone.

POV Geralt

Seeing Triss completely thrown, desperately trying to reactivate her magic, I shouted, hearing explosions and screams in the distance:

"Triss! What's happening?!"

Triss shook her head, hair soaked with rain.

"I don't know!"

Philippa and Francesca were also trying to get their magic working, along with Vilgefortz and Tissaia even Yennefer tried everything, even cutting herself deliberately to force it back on.

And the exact moment Tissaia and Vilgefortz got their power back, it was already too late: massive fireballs were already streaking straight toward us, up on the hill.

How? They knew where we were?

I didn't have time to think it through. On instinct, I wanted to protect both Triss and Yennefer, but Quen could only shield one person. In a split second, I saw Yennefer's powers come back online, while Triss still couldn't get hers working. Making an agonizing choice, I pulled Triss into my arms, activating Quen to wrap around us both, gritting my teeth, pushing everything I had then, all at once, nothing but the roar of explosions and heat all around us.

After long minutes of relentless bombardment from burning, necrotic projectiles, I released the Quen, wincing: my arm was burned. Triss rushed over.

"Geralt!"

I shook my head.

"Triss, go check on...!" I was about to say Yennefer when I heard several screams. Tissaia was on her knees before the bodies of several mages who hadn't had time to protect themselves some charred, others blown apart entirely. Tissaia was stroking the hair of a mage barely clinging to life, though everyone knew she was already lost, missing too many limbs. But it was Yennefer's scream that made me turn.

She had her hands pressed to her eyes, clearly in pain. Behind me, I could hear Philippa and Francesca's furious screams as they kept attacking with such violence I could already feel the shockwaves. Triss ran to Yennefer, pulling her hands away from her face.

Then she barely held back her own grief even I gritted my teeth despite myself: Yennefer's eyes were charred, as if someone had poured acid into them, likely from residue off the burning projectiles.

Triss tried to comfort Yennefer, who wanted to scream in pain and rage but no longer even could. I clenched my jaw, blaming myself terribly could I have saved them both, could I have...

Triss spoke softly, stroking Yennefer's face as thunder rolled and the rain came down harder.

"Yen, Yen, calm down. Don't worry, I can heal your eyes, okay?"

She gripped Triss's hands, as if afraid she'd never find them again, and said weakly:

"You're sure?"

Triss nodded, stroking her hands.

"Yeah, don't worry."

Yennefer nodded, gritting her teeth.

"Get me over there, so I can give you my magic. And make them explode, Triss. Make them suffer!"

Triss nodded, took Yennefer's hand, positioning herself beside her. Coming closer, I supported Yennefer so she could lean on me without getting in Triss's way. Yennefer placed her hands on Triss's back, channeling her magic into her and for the first time, I understood exactly why Triss ranked among the most powerful sorceresses in terms of raw power.

General POV

While Francesca and Philippa kept blasting apart Nilfgaard's ranks and shattering the spells of their opposing mages,

Triss began her incantation. Her eyes turned into pure flame, her red hair seeming to catch fire, and she recited in Elder Speech:

"Nâr nîn metheno am-gardh em

Nâr nîn dambatho mme-greg nîn

Nâr nîn teithatho am-chamm ke-menel

MUSPELLEIN"

An enormous volcano burst from the ground, seemingly born instantly right in the heart of the Nilfgaardian army. It spewed massive gouts of burning magma across the entire enemy force infantry, archers, mages, and even the rear war camp itself.

For the first time since the battle began, casualties piled up at a horrifying rate this time, on Nilfgaard's side.

Backed by Philippa, Francesca, Vilgefortz, Tissaia, and three other mages, who shielded Triss's volcano while fending off enemy spells,

After a few minutes, Nilfgaard's horn finally sounded the retreat.

The volcano died down shortly after the enemy's withdrawal, sinking back into the earth. But the battlefield remained forever marked: still-burning flames, rivers of magma, countless bodies, smoking craters. It wasn't really a battlefield anymore just the remnant of two magical forces that had literally reshaped the landscape.

POV Ciri

After my lessons with Margarita, I'll admit I finally get what Triss meant when she told me how amazing she was it's completely true. I love her classes, and for once, people actually look at me like a real student, not just someone who got in on a favor.

Okay, I'm still terrible at control, but that'll come!

I heard a knock at the door of my quarters at the academy. Approaching, a knife hidden behind my back, I cracked the door open and found a woman with an oddly pale face. I heard her voice then, directly inside my head:

"Pleased to meet you, princess of Cintra. My name is Lydia van Bredevoort, but you may call me Lydia. My master, Vilgefortz, would like to speak with you, once he returns he could help you with your power. In exchange, though, this must stay between us. Will you agree to learn more, and come with me to his laboratory, Cirilla Fiona Elen Riannon?"

(The Battle of Sodden had me so hyped! I love this kind of battle, where you really see that no matter how many strategies you throw at it, how are you supposed to protect yourself against that kind of power? By the way, good luck translating the Elder Speech!

I hope you enjoyed this chapter, and thanks again for all your comments, your power stones, and above all for sticking with me you're all seriously the best. Have a good day, everyone, and see you tomorrow for the aftermath of this terrible battle.)

32: Chapter 31 : Ciri's decision

(Just a small heads-up: this is the last chapter without the main character starting next chapter, we're back with Aiden. I'll admit I'm feeling a mix of stress and excitement, because the chapters coming up, starting tomorrow, are going to dig into lore I've built and imagined entirely myself. Small hint: I'm going to give a real backstory to the Conjunction of the Spheres, to monsters, and so on. So yeah, I'm a little stressed, honestly I really hope you'll enjoy my take on it, since it's going to be one of the foundations of this entire fanfic.

Anyway, enjoy the read!)

POV Ciri

I twirled my pen between my fingers in Margarita's classroom, caught somewhere between boredom and stress. Ever since Lydia's famous visit, this Vilgefortz character wouldn't stop sending me invitations.

Seriously, who would agree, all smiles, "Sure, I'll join you, and I won't tell a soul, not even the people I trust like family"? Did he really think I was that stupid?

No. But when Geralt came back, I'd had to swallow my words because seeing Yennefer return, her eyes ruined, carried by Triss, and Geralt clutching his burned arm, of course I'd run to them.

Flashback

POV Ciri

I ran through the hallways, weaving past grumbling mages I didn't care in the slightest. They were back. Rushing in, someone who'd been standing there left quickly at the sight

of Yennefer sitting on the bed, hands trembling, while Triss murmured healing spells. I rushed forward.

"Geralt! Yen! Triss, what happened?!"

Yen tried to smile, hiding her face, maybe trying to reassure me.

"Just a minor injury, don't..."

I cut her off, stepping closer, cupping her face in my hands, and seeing her ruined eyes, I bit my lip before simply pulling her into a hug.

She was caught off guard, clearly unsure how to react, but she eventually returned the embrace, trembling slightly, her head buried against me. Then I felt Triss gently pull me away from her.

"Yennefer needs rest."

I looked at Yennefer, who, despite not being able to see me anymore, said:

"Come on, don't worry, it'll be fine. Triss is going to take care of me, everything'll be okay."

I looked at her, knowing full well she was lying if nothing else, her trembling hands gripping the sheets gave it away but I also knew she had far too much pride to admit it out loud. I just nodded. Geralt applied a bandage soaked in herbs and potions, then walked me out, leaving Triss to look after her.

Even though I wanted to stay, what more could I have actually done? I had neither the knowledge to help Triss, nor the magic to ease Yennefer's pain.

I clenched my fists without even realizing it. I was still just a burden…

End of flashback

POV Ciri

Remembering that memory from a few weeks back, I felt another wave of frustration rise but I sighed, pulling myself together.

Of course, I'd warned Geralt about Vilgefortz. He'd become extremely vigilant and wary ever since, even though he hadn't told me much about the battle itself, other than calling it, in his own words, "a hell of a mess." I could tell something was off.

Even outnumbered, Triss and Yennefer were far more than street-corner sorceresses so I was certain something had stopped them from defending themselves properly.

I wrote in my notebook: *Traitor? Object?*

I circled "traitor," the most likely option. But who? From the little I knew, through Margarita's or Triss's lessons, despite all their hostility and rivalry, the Council of Mages had always at least tried to preserve its own power within the northern kingdom.

And above all, I circled Vilgefortz's name several times I found it deeply suspicious that, barely after the battle ended, he'd sent his assistant to find me, explicitly demanding I tell no one. Instinctively, I wrote: *Vilgefortz = traitor?* Then crossed it out it was just a theory, after all, maybe he had nothing to do with it, and had simply discovered my identity. But I kept it in mind, and…

My thoughts were interrupted by a ruler slamming down on the platform. Margarita said calmly, but firmly:

"I see Miss Pavetta isn't paying attention to my lesson. You'll be staying for detention with me."

I started to protest, but she added:

"Of course, you're welcome to argue but prove to me first that you've been following the lesson."

I looked at the board and shut up immediately: overlapping elemental circles paired with equations straight out of a nightmare. I answered simply:

"Sorry."

Margarita sighed, then smiled kindly.

"You should focus, Pavetta. Let's continue the lesson."

After that little incident, I helped Margarita wipe down the board as punishment. She said, tidying her papers:

"You know, when Triss asked me to look out for you, I figured at first it was just overprotectiveness. Didn't bother me, though I like teaching."

I looked at her, surprised I thought I was just attending her class like any other student. I stopped wiping the board and murmured:

"Sorry."

Margarita smiled softly.

"Listen, Pavetta, I wasn't born yesterday. I know perfectly well 'Pavetta' isn't your real name."

I was stunned how had she figured it out? But before I could say anything, she raised a hand to stop me and said softly:

"How did I know? Micro-expressions never lie. If you'd really been born with the name 'Pavetta,' you'd react far more naturally when someone calls you that. It shows even if you're a natural-born actress, you're still forcing it."

She smiled anyway.

"But it doesn't bother me. To me, you're just a difficult student, and that's enough for me. So if you ever need help, whatever it's about, tell me. And before you say there's nothing don't take me for a fool, I watched Vilgefortz's assistant try to convince me he wanted to 'tutor' you personally. Unless he thinks I've lost all my wits, you're the only one who checks every box for that kind of anomaly."

She counted on her fingers:

"You're oddly blunt for your age, you're tied to Triss and Yennefer, you're tied to that mysterious man always at Triss's side, and Tissaia — who normally checks every single student's file never asks me a thing about you. You check every box."

She ruffled my hair gently.

"But it doesn't bother me, Pavetta. Just tell me what you need to know, and I'll help that's what a teacher's for."

I stayed quiet, not sure what to say. Could I trust her? I didn't know. But I finally asked, holding her gaze:

"If a girl had a secret identity that could be used as leverage against the people close to her, to force her hand what could she do to turn the tables?"

Margarita stayed silent, holding my gaze, thinking it over, then smiled.

"Then she raises the stakes, and forces the other side to fold."

A few hours later, I walked back to my quarters, exhausted. After that conversation, I'd gotten two extra hours of lessons with Margarita on magical functions, which had thoroughly scrambled my brain with all those x's and y's. Night was already falling, and Geralt wouldn't be long ever since he'd learned Vilgefortz was after me, he'd gotten even more protective, much to my dismay.

Walking into my quarters, I froze on the spot: a man stood by the window, gazing outside. Hearing the door open, he turned to face me, smiling.

"Ah, Ciri. You're quite hard to catch, but I made the time so we could finally talk. My name's Vilgefortz though you've probably already heard of me."

Nodding, I discreetly drew the knife I always kept on me, hidden behind my back a gift from Triss, ironically. Staying close to the door, I frowned.

"You know it's pretty creepy, a grown man sneaking into a girl's room in the middle of the night?"

He laughed.

"Indeed. But unfortunately, who would believe you? In the eyes of many, I'm a hero. And you're just 'Pavetta' ironic, taking your mother's name, Ciri, but honestly, not that hard to figure out. And seriously, dyeing your hair? I'm disappointed in Yennefer and Triss."

He stepped closer, smiling and the moment he was within reach, I struck with my knife, straight for his throat, without hesitation. An invisible barrier stopped me cold. He laughed.

"Indeed, worthy of the Cintra bloodline. But enough games now."

Just as he reached for my wrist, and I went to dodge, Vilgefortz took an Aard straight to the chest, hurling him against the wall but he got back up easily, raising a shield that also blocked Geralt's Igni, who'd just arrived. Vilgefortz sneered from behind his shield:

"Witcher, looks like you got here early. Lydia missed her mark."

I moved to stand beside Geralt, knife still in hand. He'd already drawn his steel sword, a silver bomb ready in his other hand in case things escalated.

Geralt frowned, ice-cold.

"Vilgefortz, if you try this again, I don't care if I have to kill kings or even mages like you you won't lay a single finger on Ciri."

Vilgefortz stopped laughing, staring at Geralt with a calm that sent a chill through me.

"Oh really? Is that a threat?"

Geralt shot back, sarcastic.

"Why, you want to find out? Tell me, a dimeritium bomb shoved right in that mouth of yours running a bit too much you think you'd lose your head first, or your powers would cancel out first, thanks to the silver?"

Vilgefortz burst out laughing, one hand on his head.

"You really are entertaining, witcher. But now…" He stopped laughing, stepping right up beside Geralt, who never took his eyes off him, and murmured: "But tell me, witcher if the whole world found out Ciri, the last heir, was staying right here, I wonder how many would be willing to tear her right out of your hands. Even if you claim to protect her, can you really do that against the entire world?"

Geralt's fists clenched. Even I felt my face darken, frustrated to see him so cornered because everything Vilgefortz had just said was true. Seeing Geralt's silence, Vilgefortz turned to me.

"Of course, you could just come with me quietly, and all of this stays secret, and..."

Geralt pressed the tip of his sword to Vilgefortz's throat.

"Dare to finish that sentence."

Watching the situation spiral, I gritted my teeth. I had to do something stop just being the girl everyone protects, wake up, Ciri! You made a promise to Aiden. I said, to Vilgefortz:

"What are you proposing?"

Geralt looked at me, shocked.

"Ciri!" But I silenced him with a single look. Vilgefortz laughed.

"I've been studying bloodlines for years, and I'm the best person to help you master your power. In exchange, I just need a bit of your blood, at regular intervals."

I frowned. I was about to refuse when I heard a faint voice, one I instinctively knew came from my own blood, from my own bloodline. It murmured inside me:

"Blood cannot be copied. Take the deal."

Seeing my silence, Vilgefortz waited, still smiling. But inside, everything was churning. Should I actually try this? Was I insane to trust a voice I didn't even know? But it had a point: if Vilgefortz had been studying bloodlines for that many years, you'd have to be an idiot not to realize he was already after the Elder Blood in me. He probably already knew.

I closed my eyes, thinking of Aidy. What would you have done, in my place? Would you have said yes? But…

Damn it!

Stop overthinking, trust your instinct, Ciri. And that instinct, right now, kept screaming that this strange voice, surfacing in me like some kind of virus, was telling the truth. And if I could turn his research to my advantage, knowing whatever he got from me would ultimately be useless… I looked Vilgefortz in the eye, calm.

"I accept. On one condition: Geralt stays with me, permanently."

Vilgefortz laughed.

"You have absolutely no right to negotiate with me, so sto..."

I cut him off, stepping toward him without the slightest hesitation, holding his gaze, my voice flat and calm.

"Oh, you'd better negotiate. Go ahead, tell everyone I'm the princess of Cintra. I'll happily become nothing but a political pawn. But never forget: even as a simple pawn, whether for Nilfgaard or the northern kingdoms, I'll still be of royal blood and I will be an absolute nightmare for you."

I kept walking until I stopped right in front of him, despite our difference in height. His smile faded. I continued:

"I survived witcher training. I will become your worst nightmare. Even if it takes years, I will dismantle your political power, in the South and in the North alike. I will destroy your plans. I will destroy everything that gives you power. And I don't care if it takes years because unlike you, I know I will never be just a pawn. And you want to know why?"

I smiled, without even realizing it, a cold smile.

"Because I know all I have to do is ask one single person to make you suffer and he will, even if it takes years. Unlike you, I have people I trust completely. So, Vilgefortz. You want to play by my rules? Or would you rather we tear each other apart right now after all, don't forget, you'll still have to face down every other mage and every king to actually have me. So, Vilgefortz. Do we have a deal? I give you my blood, and in exchange, you give me Geralt, permanently at my side and if needed, Triss too. Or you refuse the contract."

He stayed silent, watching me with a look somewhere between amusement and cold calculation, for several long seconds, then said:

"We have a deal, princess of Cintra."

Aiden, wait for me. I'll be stronger, when we meet again.

POV Aiden

How many days?

How many months, maybe?

I didn't know anymore. I was locked in a cage, deep in a cave only the sound of dripping water breaking the silence. It stayed dark constantly; I didn't even know what time it was anymore.

The only source of light was the werewolf mage who brought my meals every day, torch in hand. And for the first time in that unbearable silence, the footsteps echoing through the corridor sounded different.

There were several of them, this time.

33: Chapter 32 : Hisié

(All right, from here on, for a few chapters, this is going to be pure invention on my part, blended with the Witcher universe. Just so you know, everything that follows is what I personally imagine Andrzej Sapkowski might have done to further enrich his world.

Let's be honest: The Witcher is one of my absolute favorite book series, so it's hard for me to stay objectively neutral about it.

Anyway, I won't ramble too much, but I genuinely hope you'll enjoy what I've added to this universe, because it's going to be one of the pillars of this whole fanfic.

Anyway, enjoy the read, and I'd love to hear your honest thoughts feel free to ask questions, I'll answer as long as it doesn't spoil anything, and go ahead and share your theories on what I'm about to reveal!)

POV Aiden

I finally saw the shapes approaching: the two werewolves who'd captured me, I don't even know how long ago anymore I'd completely lost track of time, stuck in this cave, in this cage.

The one who'd knocked me out approached, banging on the bars.

"Wake up in there. Lord Lycaon's ready."

The werewolf mage made a simple gesture with his hand, unlocking the cage door. The muscular werewolf stepped forward, and the moment he got close enough, I tried once more to jab a sharpened spoon into his throat, with what little magic I had left but he caught my move without effort, twisting my wrist, making me wince in pain without letting go.

Smiling, he said:

"You're stubborn, I'll give you that. Even with dimeritium cuffs, you're still pulling off a bit of magic. That's fascinating, don't you think so too, Valerius?"

The werewolf mage, Valerius, answered:

"Quit having fun, Garrick. Lord Lycaon needs him alive." But even he couldn't quite hide his own curiosity.

Garrick, the muscular werewolf, shrugged and hauled me up effortlessly, slamming me against the cage bars, tearing a grimace of pain from me, keeping me from getting up easily.

Indeed, ever since I'd arrived here, I'd been wearing dimeritium cuffs, like any mage blocking my magic, keeping me from freeing myself. But I could feel, deep down, that I was starting to adjust, or rather adapt: a bit of magic was slowly coming back, the dimeritium losing its grip little by little. That was my plan: patience. But apparently, this Lord Lycaon hadn't planned on waiting that long.

Garrick pulled me to my feet without difficulty and, staying behind me, gripping my cuffs, shoved me forward.

"Come on, get moving."

Walking barefoot through the cave, flanked by the two werewolves since when I'd woken up, all I had left were my shirt and pants I looked around. Honestly, it was a far cry from the dark space I'd been held in: several torches hung along the walls, a sign the place was maintained, and I was now far from the dripping water that had been my only company.

I couldn't say how many minutes we walked before arriving in an enormous chamber, where the cave opened into a circular space. Several werewolves, far less intimidating than the two escorting me, were already there at least forty of them, by my count.

But what caught my eye was a girl crying, locked in a cage hanging above us. I quickly understood this place served some kind of ritual, an invocation and that either she or I was meant to be the sacrifice.

Then, suddenly, Garrick struck the back of my knee, forcing me to the ground. I saw both werewolves kneel, saying respectfully, in unison:

"My lord."

Looking up, I froze: for the first time in my life, every fiber of my being screamed at me to run, not to even think about fighting. In front of me, between two braziers, stood a black-furred werewolf covered in scars but it was the sheer danger radiating off him that was most terrifying. He reeked of murder, power, ancient age. And he stood well over two meters tall.

All the other werewolves knelt as well. After a moment, Lycaon spoke, calm:

"You're the famous Aiden of Cintra. Hisié's told me quite a bit about you. Do you know him?"

I frowned, swallowing my trembling, biting my tongue hard enough to draw blood, then, meeting his gaze, which studied me with mild surprise, said:

"No, I don't know him. But if you don't mind, I'd rather be direct: why capture me? This was clearly premeditated."

He stayed silent a moment, resting his head on his hand, elbow propped on the armrest, then smiled.

"Indeed, this wasn't random. You see, Hisié asked me to capture you. And yes, you're right to be clear, this is your trial."

I frowned.

"A trial? I figured, given your power and everything surrounding you, you wouldn't be the type to follow anyone else's orders."

He laughed.

"You're right, Aiden. But he promised me something." His tone shifted, turning sad, though still calm. "That you'd be the only one able to help me find my beloved, Lily."

I frowned.

"Forgive me, but I don't know any spell that would allow..."

He raised a hand, cutting me off.

"Aiden. Do you know the Moon Village? Or perhaps the event known as the Blood Moon?"

I frowned again, and seeing my confusion, he gave a bitter laugh.

"Of course you don't. The vampires took great care to erase everything connected to it, with the help of every other species in this cursed world."

He seemed to sink into his memories.

"The Moon Village was the first place where werewolves and humans traded peacefully. After all, vampires weren't the only ones entitled to enjoy this life. But they didn't like others encroaching on their precious blood supply so they decided to corrupt the village's mayor into doing the worst thing imaginable."

He smiled, bitter, and continued:

"I was an ancient wolf one of the oldest and the leader of that werewolf community. And yet, I loved a human woman, and she loved me back. My beautiful Lily was gentle, and never drew a line between werewolves and humans all she saw was me. And that was enough for me, because despite everything in my past, she'd accepted me. We were expecting a beautiful child the first of its kind, half-human, half-wolf. I thought I'd finally have a real family, but…"

He slammed his fist against the armrest, a rage centuries old cutting through his voice.

"But because she was the mayor's daughter, he locked her in her own room, keeping me and my men from finding her, from getting her back. I even got down on my knees before him, before those humans. I was ready to give anything for the woman I loved. And yet…"

He exploded with fury.

"And yet that bastard let an ancient vampire drain her, day after day, down to the last drop while, during the daytime, that same vampire beat her belly, where my child was growing!"

He looked at me, regaining an icy calm.

"That's when I finally became who I truly was again. I slaughtered every last villager, one by one, without exception and I slaughtered that ancient vampire too, until war broke out between vampires and werewolves, under the name of the Blood Moon War."

I stayed silent at these revelations, then said, gritting my teeth:

"I know very little about ancient vampires, but I know they're supposed to be extremely powerful. Ancient wolves, though, I know nothing about."

Lycaon gave a small laugh.

"Of course you don't. But know this: the reason ancient vampires stay hidden in their lairs is because they're afraid of me."

He fixed his eyes on me, an enormous smile spreading across his face.

"One ancient wolf is worth five ancient vampires. We're their worst nightmare."

Then he looked, sadly, at the werewolves kneeling around us.

"And yet, we lost that war. I thought vampires would at least have the honor of sending fighters our own level but no, not a single lesser or greater vampire was sent. There were seven ancient vampires, back then. They slaughtered my tribe without mercy, while I was busy fighting five of them at once, the other two wiping out the rest of my pack."

He continued:

"But it was a hard blow for them too: four ancient vampires died under my claws, and a fifth, badly wounded, fled with his tail between his legs, all the way to Toussaint. I could have kept fighting that war, but I'd already lost too many of my men. The ones you see here are the last survivors."

He fixed his eyes on me.

"Aiden, I hate this world. I hate every other species living in it. I wanted to keep fighting that war until death that's what I truly wanted, deep down. But I'm a leader. I have to protect my people, and I already failed once. I don't intend to make that mistake again. But if I have even the slightest chance of seeing my love again, then I won't hesitate to sacrifice myself to this world, or wage war on it for her sake."

I was genuinely moved by his story but that didn't excuse what he'd done. Was it hypocritical of me to judge him anyway? Probably. We're all killers, in our own way. And could I become like him, if I learned one day that Ciri, Geralt, Yennefer, Triss, Eskel, Lambert, or Vesemir had been killed by someone?

I didn't know how I'd react. How could I?

I just asked:

"And now?"

He looked at me in silence, then nodded.

"You're a good person, Aiden. Anyway, for now, let's talk about you. Like I told you, Hisié's going to put you through a trial but first, he needs to see you."

He rose from his throne, walked over, crouched down to my level, then cut open a vein, letting his blood flow like an offering into the center of the ritual circle which flared bright red.

The two werewolves stepped back, and Lycaon placed me at the center of the circle. The moment I was set down, an avalanche of intense cold swept through my entire body. I screamed in pain my organs freezing, my skin freezing, my eyes freezing. The last thing I heard before losing consciousness was the girl's crying, and Lycaon's final words:

"Good luck. I'm curious to see if you're really his heir."

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I woke up with a start, one hand at my throat, looking around. I found myself in a world entirely blanketed in snow, cold, lifeless ice. Even the trees looked frozen down to their core, and the air itself felt saturated with that biting cold.

And yet, I wasn't cold. My breathing stayed perfectly normal.

Getting up, I walked through the forest, noticing the total absence of sound except for the wind's icy breath. The trees creaked occasionally, but no life remained, only silence. Reaching the edge of a cliff, I found the remains of a village only a few rooftops still poking through, proof that life had once existed here. But now, nothing.

What cut through my thoughts were footsteps behind me, along with a calm voice:

"Quiet, and dead, here, don't you think, Aiden?"

I spun around sharply, instinctively reaching for my sword but I had nothing on me. I found a white-haired man, dressed like a soldier, but what stood out most was his arm, made entirely of pure ice, his calm blue eyes, and his hair as white as snow. He said:

"Pleased to finally meet you, Aiden of Cintra. My name is Hisié. I am, if you prefer, the incarnation of winter in your own language."

I froze: he wasn't speaking the language of this world. He was speaking my native tongue, the one from my own world. I said simply:

"How is this…"

He stayed beside me, taking in the landscape.

"You've got a lot of questions. And you'll get your answers, along with a decision to make I promise you that. But for now, I'd like to ask you something."

I took a deep breath, trying to steady myself, then asked:

"Where am I? What is this place? And why bring me here?"

He stayed silent.

"Your answers will come on their own, I assure you."

I sighed, understanding I wouldn't get anything right away.

"Fine. What do you want to ask me?"

He looked at me.

"What do you know about Ithlinne's Prophecy, and the Conjunction of the Spheres?"

I frowned.

"Aside from an old song farmers sometimes sing, about the 'white cold'… As for the Conjunction of the Spheres, all I know is that it happened without anyone really knowing why."

He sighed.

"I see. Sounds like his pawns really did manage to carry out his plan."

I was about to say something, but he placed a hand on my shoulder, and all at once, the landscape shifted entirely, transforming into a massive battlefield, frozen out of time. Pulling his hand back, seeing my startled expression, he said:

"We're standing on the battlefield where the fate of several worlds was decided where the White Frost was created, and where the Conjunction of the Spheres was corrupted."

He fixed his eyes on me.

"Aiden. The hour of truth has come. You're about to understand the truth about this world."

(Tomorrow's going to give you all so much to chew on! Hope you enjoyed this chapter let me know if you have any questions, I'll answer as long as it doesn't spoil anything, of course, and feel free to share your theories on what I'm about to reveal!)

34: Chapter 33 : The Truth About This World

POV Aiden

I followed Hisié across that battlefield, which seemed frozen in time. I could feel my heart pounding faster and faster because if what he was about to reveal to me was true, then everything mages, scribes, in short every living being convinced their knowledge was solid, believed, was actually a lie.

Seeing him stop, Hisié turned to me and said calmly, snapping his fingers. We instantly found ourselves in a new setting, filled with lush greenery; birdsong echoed all around us. But what caught my eye most were four figures, each dressed in their own outfit they looked almost Roman, judging by their attire.

One had hair the color of the sun, a huge smile, and eyes shaped like suns, while she carried a long sword on her back. The other was a giant, wielding a massive hammer, his hair the color of autumn leaves. The two seemed to be laughing as they sparred.

Meanwhile, a beautiful woman with green hair, her arms wrapped in vines, gently stroked her rounded belly, sitting in the grass beside her Hisié, easily recognizable, though this time his arm wasn't made of ice: only his eyes and hair still set him apart.

Then, beside me, Hisié said calmly, a hint of sadness in his voice:

"You see, my three companions and I were born in this world. Of course, we were curious for a long time about how but the only thing we can conclude is that we were born of the old magic."

I looked at him, surprised, and asked:

"The old magic is powerful enough to create life?"

He nodded and said:

"When this world was created, there was nothing. Then the old magic arrived, like a gentle mother bringing forth life: nature was born, the beautiful trees, the beautiful flowers, water in short, everything that defines life. But it also needed guardians to look after all of it, and it gave life to the four of us: me; Tuilë, the woman with hair like tender nature, my wife; Augusta, the woman with hair as bright as the sun; and Yávië, the giant. We were the incarnations of this world's seasons but that wasn't all we were."

He made a gesture, and the landscape slowly shifted around us. He continued:

"As the incarnation of winter, I was the one who dealt with death, with solitude, and everything tied to the darkest feelings. Tuilë was the incarnation of spring, of renewal often recognized as the goddess of home, family, and peace. Augusta, incarnation of summer, was known as the goddess of war, of strategy, but also of celebration and joy. As for Yávië, incarnation of autumn, he was the god of wisdom, of elders, and of intelligence."

The scene shifted, and I saw Tuilë again, this time alone, playing with a little girl with blond hair and golden eyes. Hisié, beside me, said softly:

"Our daughter, named Morniel, was the incarnation of the stars and of passion." He paused, looked at me, and added: "Forgive me. I need you to see this scene."

He snapped his fingers, and like two ghosts outside of time, we watched this moment unfold as mere spectators.

General POV, during the scene

Tuilë laughed, playing with her daughter's hair, saying gently:

"Morniel, I didn't know you liked ponytails this much but I'm glad you asked me for one."

Morniel laughed innocently, playing with her mother's fingers, and said softly:

"Papa would've messed it up, I'm sure of it."

Tuilë burst out laughing as Hisié appeared, smiling:

"I hear the ladies making fun of me?"

Morniel, running barefoot through the grass, threw herself into Hisié's arms, who spun her around, holding her close. Landing back on the grass, laughing, she cried out:

"Papa!"

Hisié laughed, stroking his daughter's hair, then kissed Tuilë's lips as she came closer, keeping her near, resting his head against her hair to breathe in her scent while their daughter played with her father's fingers. Tuilë asked softly:

"Tired?"

Hisié nodded.

"Yeah. As you know, Yávië and I have to watch over the Conjunction of the Spheres constantly, and keep fighting off the evil trying to corrupt our creation."

She nodded in turn.

"I know, love. But take care of yourself too, sometimes. You know our dream's coming true beautifully we have our family, and the Conjunction of the Spheres, joining our four powers, is doing its work perfectly: bringing together the different peoples from different worlds who seek peace."

Hisié nodded.

"I know. Elves and humans are starting to get along apparently, the first human king is getting engaged to the elven princess."

Tuilë smiled lovingly and slid her hand into Hisié's, both their rings catching the light his made of flowering vines, hers made of ice. She said:

"I still remember our wedding."

Hisié smiled.

"Mmh. I remember our wedding night too."

Tuilë kissed his lips.

"Shh. Morniel's still here."

Morniel, pouting, jumped onto both her parents' laps.

"Well then, pay attention to me!"

Hisié burst out laughing, and Tuilë took Morniel into her arms before heading off to play tag in the lake, Hisié joining them shortly after.

POV Aiden

The scene stopped. Looking at Hisié's hand, I saw the ring again withered, this time. He said, eyes still fixed on that memory:

"That day, I thought nothing could ever happen to us. That Morniel would keep growing up, that no conflict would ever come. But I was wrong."

I had a small idea, and asked:

"Was it because of the Conjunction of the Spheres?"

He nodded.

"The Conjunction of the Spheres is a spell where we combined our four powers, to fulfill one of our shared dreams: to have living beings other than ourselves. And it worked beings from other worlds, seeking peace and stability, arrived, and every people helped one another. But unfortunately, that turned out to be our greatest mistake."

He made another gesture, and we reappeared on the battlefield but this time, beside six figures. I easily recognized the first four: Augusta, Tuilë, Hisié, and Yávië. But unlike their more relaxed attire from before, they were all soaked in rain and blood. Countless bodies lay scattered around them elves, dwarves, humans, but also vampires, werewolves, and other monsters. Hisié said then:

"We had been too lax, and we'd created one of the worst things imaginable."

He made a gesture, and an orb appeared, sending a chill through me for reasons I couldn't explain. He explained:

"We called this orb the Observer. Originally, it was simply meant to watch over the world around the clock, solve the simplest problems to lighten our load a bit like an automaton, if I had to draw a comparison to your world. But unfortunately, while we thought it would never develop a real personality, we were wrong."

With his hand, I watched the orb absorb black tendrils into itself. He continued, a note of anger cutting through his voice but anger turned inward, at himself:

"Peace doesn't exist without war, just as light doesn't exist without darkness. One day, an envoy of corruption one that constantly seeks to corrupt our creation, the Conjunction of the Spheres managed to slip past its filter and let through a demon named Master Mirror."

I looked at him, surprised.

"I know him! He fought me, the day I faced Vilgefortz he's the one who summoned him."

Hisié nodded.

"I see… Anyway, this Master Mirror found the Observer and whispered promises of peace to it. After all, the Observer was only continuing its work of protecting peace and stability, exactly as it had been taught. But like I told you, even in a peaceful world, the moment living beings feel things, conflict inevitably arises and it was all these factors that shaped the Observer, until it reached a conclusion."

He paused a moment, then continued:

"'If peace cannot be achieved as long as living beings feel things, then let's take away their ability to feel, and peace will come.' But that was short-lived: living beings need to feel otherwise, what would separate us from a mere object? And yet, corruption, without us noticing, had already taken hold of the Observer the guardian had become the executioner. But it didn't have the power needed to face us directly. It needed someone like us."

He clenched his fists.

"It chose the only being more powerful than the four of us combined, one who could still dream. Morniel was corrupted. The Observer made her promises, offered her a dream Morniel had always wanted to see beyond our world, to visit the stars, and without us noticing, our love for our child had blinded us to the truth. Her curiosity, over the years, turned into an obsession with freedom. The Observer managed to turn her against us, to corrupt her naming us her jailers."

He showed me an immense rift then, once white, now turning black, like darkness itself:

"By the time we realized it, it was already too late. Morniel had corrupted the Conjunction of the Spheres, and was using darkness and corruption itself as a power

source, amplifying her own fall even further. Monsters, war, blood all of it entered this world from that point on."

"All living beings united to fight back, but unfortunately, the elves were the first to fall and give up, when their crown prince killed their king and queen and became a vampire himself, under the corruption's influence. Then came the dwarves and gnomes, who gave up in turn. Only humans held out until the end, under their last king, Eldarion, and his wife the elven heir princess, who became elven queen under the name Caladwen."

He then brought the scene back before us, placing us once more as mere spectators.

General POV, during the scene

Hisié looked at Eldarion and said:

"Eldarion, you could have stayed with your people. You too, Caladwen. This isn't your fight it's our failure, we gods, for failing to protect you."

Eldarion, wiping the rain from his black hair, removed the crown from his head and stared at it for a moment, calm:

"You might be right. But since I arrived in this world, I found peace here, love, and a family."

He looked at Caladwen, who smiled softly, holding his arm, then turned his gaze back to the gods:

"I love my world. I love my wife. And we'll fight to give a future to our daughter, and to our people fleeing toward Tir ná Lia. I think you can understand that that a father would do anything for his daughter."

Caladwen nodded and looked at the goddess of home with a smile, seeing clearly how guilty she felt that everything they'd built was being destroyed by their own daughter. She said softly:

"None of our peoples blame you. These are our choices. We'll hold back Goddess Morniel's army, while you handle her."

Hisié and Tuilë exchanged a silent look. Hisié simply said, to Eldarion and Caladwen:

"Thank you."

They shook their heads, then the gods left to face their daughter and niece. Eldarion looked back behind them: the smoking battlefield, the smell of charred corpses, and above all the two monstrous lieutenants approaching with their army. Calmly drawing Aerondight, he walked toward them, his wife at his side.

Face to face now, paying no mind to the vampires and werewolves surrounding them almost laughable, this standoff between two living beings and an entire army of monsters the werewolf leader, named Lycaon, stepped forward and said:

"Eldarion, king of men. Abandon this fight. Our goddess will forgive you."

Eldarion shook his head.

"I'm sorry, but no. Your goddess is corrupted, and a king never kneels, except before his wife and his children."

Caladwen looked at the vampire leader or rather, her own brother and said:

"Thúrlas. Is this really how it ends?"

Thúrlas, the former elven crown prince, now transformed into a dark elf like the vampire leader, answered calmly:

"We don't have to, sister. Join us, leave this human, you…"

But Caladwen cut him off cold, her voice ringing across the entire battlefield:

"Enough, brother! You were the one I admired most in this world! You protected our mother and me from our father's blows but you dared kill our mother! Why?! For power?! You murdered our father! And you performed the ritual our mother forbade us from ever attempting, for that treacherous goddess!"

Thúrlas stayed silent a moment, then sighed:

"You won't understand, dear sister. But don't worry my goddess promised me a better world. With our mother, far from these schemes, far from our dark past. I'll bring us back together again, like when we were children."

A brief memory flickered through Caladwen's mind Thúrlas letting her slip a flower necklace she'd made as a child around his neck. Pushing the memory aside, she began unleashing her immense light magic.

Lycaon tried to intervene with his army of vampires and werewolves, but Eldarion beat him to it at a dizzying speed, beheading any creature that dared come too close to Caladwen. Planting the tip of his sword into the ground, he said calmly:

"No one crosses this line. No one touches a single hair on my wife's head."

Lycaon burst out laughing and charged at Eldarion a titanic clash erupted at once, moving too fast to follow, Eldarion facing down Lycaon and Thúrlas, who'd joined the fight, alone against two.

The two monsters' claws clashed again and again against Eldarion's sword, and despite the minutes passing, the ground heaving and cracking under the sheer violence of the fight, Caladwen's magic kept devastating the monstrous ranks, despite the rain pouring down harder, washing away the blood from Eldarion's wounds as he fell to the ground without showing the slightest emotion focused only on his duty as a husband, protecting his wife.

The army kept charging at Caladwen, and even as some broke through her spells, Eldarion, true to his promise, killed every one who dared cross his line of defense indifferent to the wounds Lycaon and Thúrlas inflicted the moment he turned away.

Seeing the fight dragging on, Thúrlas fell back and faced his sister directly, shadow magic against light magic, their clash exploding everything around them while the two melee fighters waged their own battle to the death beneath that storm of spells.

Hours passed with no clear victor, the monster army thinning steadily under Caladwen's relentless barrage. But unfortunately, while defending Caladwen once again from an attack by Thúrlas trying to break through her guard, Lycaon seized his chance in a split second and, worn down by hours of fighting creatures of such power, Eldarion had the arm holding Aerondight severed. Caladwen froze at the sight of her husband mutilated, and that same split second let Thúrlas fire a beam of shadow that pierced straight through Caladwen's stomach. She gritted her teeth and struck back with a beam of light that burned half of Thúrlas's body, unable to dodge in time but she herself had been hit, and now had to use her magic just to hold back the corruption spreading inside her.

Eldarion caught Aerondight's pommel with his teeth, parrying a claw strike from Lycaon aimed at his head, snatching the sword back into his left hand in a split second. He unleashed a flurry of strikes so fast that Lycaon, stunned that a mere human could still be this dangerous, took countless wounds, forced to retreat, left with permanent scars across his entire body.

Eldarion fell back toward Caladwen, holding her up despite the loss of his arm, and asked softly:

"How are you holding up?"

Caladwen, pale but smiling, answered:

"Like our first kiss. I've never loved being by your side more than right now."

Eldarion smiled softly.

"Is it time?"

Caladwen nodded, watching the monster army, Lycaon and Thúrlas charging to finish them off. Eldarion smiled, pulled off his shirt, bare-chested, gripped his sword, and said:

"Then, my dear wife. I'll defend you, as our wedding vows promised. Until death, we fight together for the future."

Then he charged the army and the two overpowered monsters, without a trace of fear, while Caladwen began her spell.

Aerondight clashed on without end against dozens, then hundreds, then thousands of enemies. One man alone keeping an entire army, and two overpowered monsters, from reaching his wife. His body was riddled with wounds and bite marks, and yet, even run through by Thúrlas straight through the stomach, his throat slashed by Lycaon, he still held, with nothing but the strength of his arms, the sword that eventually fell to the ground, sliding into the nearby lake, sinking into its depths. Despite the life draining out of him, Eldarion kept smiling, having protected his wife to the very end until the moment Caladwen unleashed her ultimate spell, engulfing miles around them in a light so intense it looked like broad daylight.

Silence returned. All that remained were the charred bodies of vampires and werewolves. Lycaon and Thúrlas lay on the ground, no longer breathing, burned to such a degree they were unrecognizable. Caladwen walked painfully toward her husband's body, the corruption from her wound slowly killing her, then knelt and lay down beside him, resting her head on his chest, life slipping slowly from her eyes. In her final moments, dreaming that her daughter might live happily, she murmured, as if leaving her one last message:

"Lara, I pray for your happiness. Your father and I will always be with you."

Then the first elven king and queen died, having killed hundreds of thousands of monsters higher vampires, werewolves, and many others within their ranks. Forgotten by history, but forever alive in their daughter's heart.

35: Chapter 34 : The White Frost

(Hope you're enjoying my take on the lore so far :) and a pretty long chapter for your enjoyment!)

POV Aiden

After the scene ended, I felt a deep sadness for those two. They'd never stopped loving each other, fighting together until the very end wasn't that the most beautiful symbol of a love lasting until death do them part?

I looked at Hisié and asked:

"I recognized Lycaon. How did he survive?"

Hisié answered calmly:

"Despite Caladwen's immense spell, Thúrlas and Lycaon both survived in the end though Thúrlas was killed years later by whoever wielded Aerondight. As for Lycaon, he changed the day he met his soulmate: he finally came to understand Eldarion's words and actions, even though, unfortunately, she died too."

I sighed, thinking it all over and the story wasn't even finished yet. Already, an overwhelming amount of information had just shattered everything I thought I knew about the real world. Turning around, I saw the spot where the four gods stood frozen, and Hisié, seeing my expression, said:

"We're getting close to the end. Are you ready?"

I nodded. With a snap of Hisié's fingers, the setting shifted, and I saw, seated on a throne, a woman with golden hair and golden eyes, dressed in a black gown, faint tendrils of dark energy coiling around her. Hisié said, with sadness:

"That's my daughter. Morniel."

I looked at Hisié, who'd gone quiet, staring at his daughter in silence, and said with compassion:

"She's beautiful."

He nodded.

"She inherited my temperament. But all her beauty comes from my magnificent wife." He sighed, then snapped his fingers, and the scene began.

General POV, during the scene

Morniel, still seated on her throne, snapped her fingers. A colossal knight in golden armor appeared, slamming down onto the ground with such force that a wave of terror rippled across the battlefield. The knight roared, its cry echoing like thunder.

Yávië and Augusta intercepted and pushed back its attacks with sheer brute force. The other two figures, Hisié and Tuilë, let them handle it and kept running toward their daughter because only the two of them could put an end to this madness.

A few minutes later, they stopped in front of Morniel, who rose from her throne with a contemptuous smile. Her voice, soft but dripping with sarcasm, scorn, and hatred, rang out:

"Father, Mother, what do you think of my gift? Do you like my magnificent present, a world where freedom reigns supreme, with no king, no ruler, to smother anyone's dreams?"

Tuilë spoke, her voice heavy with sadness and pleading:

"Morniel, I beg you… stop this madness. Come back to your mother's arms… please. Like before, when I used to do your hair." In that moment, the memory of Morniel as a child flooded back to her: eyes shining with wonder at the stars. "Mama, why can't we reach them? Can we live with that same freedom the stars have?" That same innocent question had become the rallying cry of her madness.

Beside her, Hisié stayed silent, his eyes filled with sorrow and resolve. Pain and resignation showed plainly on his face. He slid his hand into Tuilë's and murmured:

"We'll face this together. We have to save our daughter from the corruption by force, if we must. I won't let her do something she'll regret."

She nodded, squeezing his hand.

Morniel watched them, then suddenly burst into mad laughter. Her laugh, like a clap of thunder, sent shivers through everyone who heard it. Around her, the air seemed to vibrate, saturated with dark energy. She looked at her parents, eyes full of madness, and declared, biting:

"Mother, can't you see this is all your fault? You locked me in this cage of motherly love."

Tuilë, deeply wounded by those words, answered anyway:

"Morniel! I know this isn't you. Wake up, sweetheart! You're stronger than the corruption, you…"

Hisié blocked a spear blending light and shadow, conjured by Morniel, hurtling straight for Tuilë's head, meeting it with his own ice magic.

She walked toward them, summoning a hammer etched with strange, glowing golden symbols. Beside her appeared a gigantic beast, its limbs studded with stars, as if the universe itself had taken the shape of this creature. With every step, it left behind a trail of stardust rising and dissolving into the air.

Morniel rolled her eyes skyward and let out an icy laugh. Then, stopping abruptly, she fixed her parents with a cold stare:

"We're gods why aren't we free to explore the worlds? Why are we forced to stay here, protecting the will of some old magic that doesn't even speak?"

She paused, her face full of contempt, then turned her gaze to Tuilë and said, scornful:

"Mother, you disappoint me so much… but it's in your nature to see good in everything, even where there is none after all, they call you the dear goddess of peace."

Tuilë clenched her fists until they bled. Morniel then turned to Hisié, a calculating smile on her lips:

"And you… I thought you'd understand. You, who never truly accepted the Conjunction of the Spheres you only agreed to it for my dear mother, and her pretty eyes."

Hisié gritted his teeth, holding back a response filled with rage and grief. He conjured his ice sword and answered, his voice trembling with sorrow:

"Morniel, it's true I never wanted the Conjunction of the Spheres to exist, because I was selfish, because I wanted to keep this world for just the two of us. And I still am. But I would NEVER have caused this kind of destruction, knowing it would devastate your mother!"

Morniel shrugged, a casual smile on her lips:

"I know, Father. You've always been like that. Mother kept you on a leash you stopped becoming who you truly are." She paused, running her fingers over her lips, eyes brimming with madness. "After all, you remain the firstborn, the god of death, of endings I'm curious to see if that's true, dear father."

For a moment, she seemed to freeze, as if brushed by a vision from her past. She saw herself as a child, curled against her mother beneath a starlit sky, eyes sparkling with wonder. She remembered the nights spent gazing at the stars with Tuilë, always asking the same question: "Mama, why can't we reach them?" Her mother's love and patience filled those moments with a gentle warmth, and her father, beside them, listened to every question with tenderness, despite his natural reserve. But she chased away the vision with a cold laugh, no longer alive at all. A fleeting doubt crossed her gaze maybe hesitation but it vanished as quickly as it appeared, swallowed by the darkness.

She raised her arms, and a blinding light enveloped her. Her black gown transformed into a Valkyrie's armor, gleaming and menacing. She took a step forward, settling into a combat stance, golden hammer in hand.

Then, her face consumed by madness, she said:

"Let me break this leash, Father… and together, let's create chaos. The Observer waits eagerly for the conclusion of its experiment."

Morniel charged Tuilë, a cruel grin on her lips, hammer raised to strike. Hisié stepped in, placing himself right in front of Tuilë. His left arm became entirely coated in ice to intercept Morniel's hammer, and the clash of their powers released waves of energy: a blue, icy aura that froze the ground, against a golden aura that burned everything in its path.

Tuilë felt a deep ache watching her own daughter become her enemy, but she knew she had to fight. She stood beside Hisié, and in a brief exchange of glances, they shared a

mix of sorrow, resolve, and above all the despair any parent feels watching their child controlled by something else. He murmured:

"We face this trial together."

She then pressed her hands to the ground, and powerful vines shot up toward Morniel. The latter simply sneered with disdain. Her cosmic beast lunged forward, slicing through the vines with a swipe of its claws, leaving behind a trail of stardust and golden flame. The creature then threw itself at Tuilë with savage fury.

Tuilë leapt backward to dodge, then scattered seeds on the ground, murmuring in an ancient tongue. Instantly, a gigantic golem rose up, made of stone and interwoven vines. It placed itself between Tuilë and the beast and, with a deep roar, seized the cosmic creature. The two monsters traded blows: the golem's wounds sealed themselves shut with roots and flowers, while the beast left behind a shimmering trail of stardust with every strike.

Morniel watched them with a bitter smile, sinking deeper and deeper into the control taking hold of her, and said, in a voice no longer natural at all:

"You hoped to trap me in your perfect world, keeping me forever from reaching the stars. I just wanted to be myself, free of every chain."

Morniel's cosmic creature, though wounded, rose back up to resume the fight, as did Tuilë's golem, cracked and damaged, but ready to strike again. Tuilë cast one last glance toward Hisié before bracing to face the beast, which was already rising, ready to renew the battle with fury.

Tuilë faced Morniel's beast, an immense, almost divine creature, wielding a golden sword as massive as a tree trunk. The weapon radiated a menacing energy, casting bright reflections all around it. Thanks to her stone golem, Tuilë had the upper hand. The giant struck the beast with its rocky fists, pushing it back, while roots burst from the ground at Tuilë's command, coiling around the creature's legs to pin it down.

Seeing the fight going fairly well, but far more worried about her daughter and husband, Tuilë glanced over at the clash between Hisié and Morniel. But she only had a split second before hearing a sinister rumble. Morniel's beast was now wrapped in a dark, golden aura; a mad laugh spilled from the dark tendrils, and thousands of voices assaulted Tuilë's mind, filled with laughter and madness. The beast's eyes gleamed with a dark light, and its silhouette seemed to grow, its strength surging to extreme levels.

Tuilë's golem attempted another strike, but in one motion, the beast raised its golden sword and struck with all its might, cleaving the golem apart without the slightest resistance. Fragments of the golem scattered across the ground around Tuilë, who clutched her head, fighting with everything she had to push back the corruption in time.

She managed to shake it off but a few seconds too late: the beast lunged at her, its golden sword blazing with the dark aura. Tuilë tried to shield herself with roots, but the creature shattered her defense in an instant and ran her clean through, straight through the abdomen. She stood frozen for a moment, looking down at the sword impaling her. The beast yanked the blade free in one motion, and the corruption spread through Tuilë's body like a virus. She took one step toward her husband and daughter, then another then she saw Hisié watching her, frozen, and smiling sadly, murmured: "I'm sorry." She raised a hand toward Hisié and their daughter, looking at them with love and the sorrow of knowing she'd never be there again, then fell to her knees, collapsing to the ground blood spreading across the grass, which withered at its touch.

Before Tuilë's death, the fight between Hisié and Morniel had dragged on. Despite Morniel's relentless attacks, hurling flames of light increasingly blended with dark energy while wielding her hammer, Hisié dodged every strike with unsettling ease, as if he anticipated her every move. After all, Hisié had always been the strongest of the four.

Morniel redoubled her efforts, striking with a force and precision that would have felled any other opponent but Hisié blocked her hammer with his ice-covered arm. Finally, she made a mistake: carried by her own momentum, she lost her balance, and Hisié, seizing his chance, landed a powerful blow that tore the hammer from her hands. The force of the strike threw Morniel off balance, and he used the opening to drive a blade into her stomach but he hesitated for a split second, and chose instead to strike her with the pommel of his ice sword.

Morniel laughed despite her face, swollen from the blow. She didn't move, stroking the spot where the strike had landed with her hand, and said, amused:

"So this is your true power, Father. That kind of control impressive."

Hisié held his sword to his daughter's throat and said, pain cutting through his voice:

"Morniel, stop this! Come back to us, your mother and me, let us help you!"

Morniel's smile widened, her eyes sparkling with madness, her voice no longer her own, but someone else's entirely:

"No, Father. That was just a warm-up. Our fight isn't over I haven't seen everything the famous god of winter has to offer yet."

With a wave of her hand, a sound behind him caught his attention. Hisié froze in horror: Yávië and Augusta lay on the ground, trampled by Morniel's giant knight, its armor, once golden, now steeped in dark energy. But what tore at his heart the most was the sight of his companion, Tuilë, staggering toward him he ran to her without a second's hesitation.

The icy aura that had surrounded Hisié since the fight began dissipated all at once, the temperature dropping sharply as he let his ice sword fall to the ground, shattering it, and rushed toward Tuilë, who'd just collapsed. Snowflakes began swirling around him, forming a blizzard that intensified with every step. He murmured to himself, as if trying to convince himself none of this was real, horror coloring his voice, his feet carrying him in a desperate sprint until he dropped to his knees beside her.

He gathered Tuilë into his arms, his icy hand brushing frantically over her cheeks as he begged her, his voice breaking:

"Wake up, my love… please, wake up."

But there was no answer.

"Answer me… my spring."

Only silence reigned, and a fine snow began to fall, settling on Tuilë's still face. Her eyes stayed closed, and Hisié, devastated, felt his heart shatter into a thousand pieces. A biting cold swept over him, as if life itself were freezing solid around them, the ground beneath their feet coating over with frost and for the first time, a tear of ice fell from Hisié's eyes, shattering against Tuilë's cheek, a cry of pure despair tearing from his throat.

He lifted his head toward Morniel, his face twisted with rage and despair, his whole life reduced to shards of black and icy blue:

"Why, Morniel?! Why Tuilë?! Why did you do this?!" His voice shook with rage, as if trying to convince himself this was all just a nightmare, his icy aura intensifying, the falling snow turning into spinning needles of ice swirling around him.

Morniel approached him with a mad smile. She stopped just inches away and burst into cruel laughter:

"Finally! You've finally let go, Father! Ahahahah! This is exactly what I always wanted to see! The strongest of the gods, broken! Freed from the spring goddess's leash! Love's leash, finally snapped! Ahahahaha!"

Mad with rage and vengeance, Hisié could no longer tell the difference despite it being his own daughter and lunged at her, divine speed propelling him straight toward Morniel. In a fit of fury, he stabbed her violently, driving his sword until she was pinned to her throne. An oppressive silence fell over them, the very air freezing solid under the force of Hisié's icy power. He staggered backward, fists clenched, staring at Morniel's body as her laughter faded away until nothing remained in that crushing silence but the memory of that laugh and Tuilë's body, despite the footsteps of the giant beast and the knight approaching him, an emptiness consuming him entirely.

But Morniel slowly pulled the sword from her stomach, and the wound sealed shut instantly before his eyes. Before he could react, Hisié conjured countless blades of ice that ran her through once more. The throne transformed into a fortress of ice spikes, crystals bursting out in every direction. With one final snap of his fingers, Hisié's despair deepened further as he saw her reappear on her throne, her gaze filled with contempt but Morniel's eyes were no longer her own: they belonged to the Observer.

In a flat, emotionless voice, she or rather, it said:

"Hisié, I knew your daughter never stood a chance against you, nor even against my creations. But… thanks to you, I've finally understood, thanks to your family, how gods can die."

Hisié, consumed with fury, shouted:

"Observer!" He was about to start stabbing the body again, but the Observer dodged and, in the blink of an eye, appeared in front of him, driving a dark blade into his abdomen. Hisié collapsed, kneeling before him, paralyzed by the pain and the growing corruption he absolutely had to destroy in time.

"There you are, you, the once-feared god… kneeling before me."

He crouched to his level, bringing his face close to his, and murmured in a cruel voice:

"You've lost everything, Hisié. The battle. Your wife. Your family. Even your hopes."

With a wave of his hand, four orbs appeared, rising from the bodies of the fallen gods: one gleaming like the sun, another holding a flower within it, a golden orb ringed with shadow, and a final one adorned with an autumn leaf. Hisié stared at them in horror,

reaching toward the one holding the flower, as if to feel Tuilë's essence one last time. Then an orb of ice appeared, joining the other seasonal symbols.

The orbs began spinning faster and faster, merging into a single sphere, like a miniature Earth. The Observer rested his hand on it with a triumphant smile, eyes gleaming with satisfaction:

"Finally. All my sacrifices weren't in vain."

Filled with despair, Hisié felt his strength leaving him. He lowered his eyes and murmured, a faint smile on his lips:

"Maybe… this is for the best. Because I'll be with you again, my spring."

POV Aiden

I didn't know what to say to any of this the sheer intensity of the fight, and everything that had just happened, left me speechless, offering a silent prayer for those combatants. Looking at Hisié, who'd paused the scene, I said:

"If you're here, that means you didn't die."

He nodded.

"I was about to. But I remembered a scene that gave me hope again."

I looked at him and said, sincere:

"Show me."

He looked at me:

"You sure? It's got nothing to do with what I actually need to show you, I…"

I sighed:

"Listen, if you think I'm watching all this with emotional detachment, you're wrong. I can't even say what I would've done in your place." I paused, then added, hesitant: "I hope I never end up in your position having to be the one who kills his own daughter to save her, only for her body to end up belonging to this Observer anyway, all while

watching your loved ones and your wife die. How is that even possible? They didn't seem weak at all."

Hisié fell silent, then smiled softly:

"Thank you, Aiden." He waved a hand, conjuring a dark tendril, and said: "As you know, we were born of the old magic. But like light and shadow, this dark energy we call chaos is the old magic's nemesis. And the problem is, as beings made of old magic, that was our only weakness and I'm ashamed to admit it, but despite our countless battles, we relied far too heavily on the advantage of never truly being able to die. Our bodies, especially Augusta's, cared nothing for taking hits, and Tuilë was never really a fighter."

"Anyway. They managed to defeat us because the knight was literally a being made of chaos, and the immense beast the incarnation of the darkest dreams of living beings greed, avarice. Their chaos gave them the ability to kill us while matching us in strength. I'm not saying old magic is weak, quite the opposite like chaos, old magic is chaos's nemesis, and the only thing capable of destroying it."

I nodded, and Hisié fell silent, letting me think it over. Looking down at my own hand, I thought about my power. Was I the only one capable of this, then? Hisié, seeing my hesitant expression, said:

"You're not the only possibility. Those who carry the Elder Blood are also capable of killing chaos, thanks to the purity of their blood, which comes from the old magic."

I nodded and sighed there was so much to take in. I said simply:

"Show me that scene, please."

Hisié nodded, and the setting shifted temporarily.

General POV, during the scene

Hisié arrived in the garden, bathed in the soft light of the afternoon. The air was filled with the delicate scent of flowers, and a light breeze rustled the leaves, adding an almost magical serenity to the place. Tuilë, his companion, stood a little further off, absorbed in her painting, a smile on her lips as she hummed a familiar tune. She swayed gently to the rhythm of her melody, her dress dancing around her, her rounded belly a testament to the life growing within her.

Hisié sat down quietly on a nearby bench, a tender smile on his lips, watching her. She was beautiful, radiant, and he couldn't tear his eyes away from the way the light played in her hair, or the expression of peaceful happiness lighting up her face.

After a moment, Tuilë finally noticed him and, hand over her heart, called out:

"You know you scared me?"

Hisié smiled and walked over to her. He gently took a lock of her hair and kissed it softly before murmuring:

"Forgive me. You were so beautiful I couldn't help but watch you."

She laughed softly and wrapped her arms around him, pulling him close:

"You and your sweet words," she teased, before placing a kiss on his cheek.

Hisié smiled, holding her gaze:

"You know how I am… And tell me, how's our Morniel doing?" he asked, tenderness plain in his voice.

He knelt down then, pressing his ear to Tuilë's belly. After a brief moment, a radiant smile spread across his face:

"I felt her move," he announced, delighted, his eyes sparkling with joy.

Tuilë burst out laughing, amused by her husband's almost childlike enthusiasm:

"What did you expect? Morniel clearly inherited your fiery temperament!"

Hisié smiled, mischievous:

"And your joy, I'm sure of it. She'll carry your laughter and your light within her."

Tuilë's expression softened, and she placed a protective hand on her belly:

"Maybe, yes… No matter where she goes, she'll always find our love to guide her. We'll always watch over her, Hisié, no matter what happens."

Hisié held her a little tighter, and they stayed there, silent, sharing a moment of calm and closeness. Their eyes met, a tender smile on both their faces, as if they needed no words at all to express the depth of their love and their hopes for their family.

After a moment, Tuilë spoke again, her gaze dreamy:

"I keep thinking about everything we'll do with her. We'll take her into the woods to show her the flowers in spring, and she'll learn to listen to birdsong… We'll show her the stars, so she never forgets the beauty of this world."

Hisié, listening to his wife talk about their plans, couldn't help but smile, shaking his head slightly. This happiness, this peace… he couldn't imagine anything more precious.

POV Aiden

Watching the scene freeze, I said softly:

"You miss her?"

Hisié didn't answer right away, just lowering his head:

"Yes. She was my light and my warmth. But this memory is what let me get back up for her, and for our daughter. Let's go back and see the rest."

Nodding, I watched him gently caress his wife's face, eyes filled with sorrow, before shifting the scene back to where we'd left off, and the story continued.

General POV, during the scene

Hisié, his body battered and his spirit heavy with grief, rose slowly, straightening with determination. Every movement tore a sharp pain from him, and his gaze darkened with sorrow and despair. But in his eyes also burned the strength of his memories with Tuilë, and the promise to protect what she had dreamed for their daughter. Despite his suffering, he found within himself the strength to stand tall.

Drawn by this unexpected gesture, the Observer turned to face him, a surprised, analytical smile on his lips. He raised his arms in a gesture of victory, then questioned him in a detached tone:

"Hisié, why are you getting up? It's over. My goal is achieved: chaos will spread, feelings will vanish, and peace will come."

Hisié shook his head, his gaze filled with deep sorrow for his daughter's body, but resolute. "Forgive me, my daughter," he said, speaking more to himself, or perhaps to his daughter, some part of whom he still believed lay buried deep within, and continued: "But I don't believe you've truly forgotten what you loved. If I must wait a thousand years for Tuilë, for everything she dreamed of doing with you… then all I can do is save you."

Without hesitation, he plunged his hand into his own chest and tore out an icy orb, straight from his heart. Unlike his usual energy, this orb emitted an unsettling glow, a cold, merciless force that resonated like a cry of vengeance. The icy energy intensified, dark veins spreading across the orb, revealing a deadly power ready to destroy everything in its path.

The Observer, shocked, rushed toward him but his own body suddenly froze in place. In an uncontrolled motion, his left arm struck his own face, hurling him violently backward. He straightened, a flicker of panic in his eyes, and murmured:

"Impossible… How can you still have the White Frost's prison? You destroyed it when the Conjunction of the Spheres was created! And why won't this body respond anymore? She should already be dead!"

Hisié didn't answer right away. He straightened, his eyes fixed on the Observer with a new intensity, his features locked into a glacial smile.

The Observer's strange reaction that visible internal resistance that had forced him to strike himself finally confirmed his suspicions. Murmuring under his breath, almost to himself, he let slip:

"I knew it…"

The Observer, frozen by that statement, felt his blood run cold. He stepped back, realizing the scale of what Hisié was about to do, understanding that he'd seen through what he'd tried to hide.

Hisié, his gaze filled with certainty and resolve, raised the ice orb above him, a cold, relentless energy pouring out of it. His voice echoed across the entire world:

"Aen Ithlinnespeath."

An explosion of white frost spread outward, freezing everything in its path. The wave of ice unfolded in a perfect circle, frozen and unstoppable, from mountains to valleys,

turning the world into a desert of snow and ice. The icy breath swept across the earth, freezing every last trace of existence into eternal silence.

Time seemed to hang suspended, the world plunged into a glacial calm. Morniel's body froze solid within an immense prison of ice and the White Frost was born, exactly as it had always been meant to be: an eternal prison.

(Tell me what you think of everything I imagined here, and whether you understand what Aiden's going to have to face and find I'm curious to know if you picked up on the hints!)

36: Chapter 35 : Aiden's Choice

POV Aiden

After Hisié's attack, the scene paused or rather, cut off abruptly and we found ourselves back in that snow-covered area where we'd been before.

I saw Hisié gazing out at the snowy landscape. Walking over to him, I asked:

"Was your daughter still alive? I saw the hit the Observer took."

Hisié didn't answer right away, then said:

"Yes, she was alive trapped inside her own body, really. But even today, I still don't know whether Morniel's words, when she said she wanted to be free, were truly hers, or the Observer's."

He sighed.

"Sometimes I envy people without a care in the world."

Arms crossed, I stayed quiet, giving him time to sort through his thoughts, which let me think things over myself. In summary: the Conjunction of the Spheres had originally been a spell created by the four gods to bring together the different peoples from different worlds, in the name of peace and prosperity.

Then the Observer had been created to handle minor conflicts but Master Mirror, one of chaos's servants, according to my theory, had manipulated it and managed to turn it against its own creators, corrupting Morniel and setting off the chain of events leading to the famous White Frost.

But some questions still had no answer, despite everything he'd just told me. I asked:

"But even with all that, I still don't get how it's possible you speak my language. I mean, nothing in those scenes explains the answer to that."

He turned to me and said, plainly:

"Because, Aiden: you were born in this world."

I looked at him, confused.

"Wait, wait, what? You mean my world, where I died, right?"

He shook his head.

"No, Aiden. The place where you died isn't your true world. Your real world has been here, all along."

I stayed silent a moment, then said, angry, fists clenched:

"Don't screw with me, Hisié! Are you telling me everything I lived through my parents, my sister, Emma and Léo was all just pure imagination?!"

He shook his head.

"No, they're real, all of them even if they never knew you came from another world. I can't tell you who your parents are a contract keeps me from that but if you want the truth about your birth, Toussaint's where you need to go. That's where you were born."

I didn't want to believe it. After all, that would mean my parents' smiles, my friendship with Léo, with Emma, my sister and her stupid jokes, were all just pure coincidence.

I was breathing hard, unable to understand why I felt so heavy, cold sweat covering my whole body it felt like a genuine existential crisis. Maybe noticing that, Hisié said:

"But you don't need to worry. Even if you're from this world, that doesn't mean you have to believe everything you lived through there was fake."

I looked at him, still confused, still in the middle of an existential panic attack, and said simply:

"What?"

He stepped closer and said softly:

"Your parents, over there, loved you like their own child. Your sister loved you like an older brother. Léo considers you his best friend, and so does Emma. None of that is fake, Aiden. Even if I can't watch what's happening over there anymore, since you're no

longer there, I think you know, deep down, that all of it was always real. Even if this is a shock, you're still the same Aiden."

My breathing slowed after those words. Looking down at my own hands, I said:

"Yeah, that's true." What an idiot I'd been, stressing that much. He was right: the world keeps turning, and everything I'd felt over there was real. After closing my eyes to calm down, I felt lighter, strangely less compressed, and said, opening them again:

"Thanks, Hisié. Now I'd like to know more about myself why I'm the only one with this old magic, this strange teleportation, and these dreams I keep having."

He nodded.

"Honestly, it's pretty simple to understand. As for the dreams, that's not mine to tell you. But the teleportation and the old magic that's entirely because of me."

He stepped closer to me and placed a hand on my chest. I felt something trying to leave my body, and on instinct, I grabbed his wrist freezing cold and said:

"What are you doing?"

He looked surprised that the thing inside me refused to come out, and smiled softly.

"I see. You really are a worthy heir."

Pulling his hand off my chest, he placed it against his own instead, drawing out the orb he'd used to seal the Observer but this one was transparent, this time. He said:

"It's pretty simple, Aiden. Even though I can't tell you everything, know this much: what you carry inside you is nothing less than my own orb."

I froze, and asked instinctively:

"Am I going to become a god?"

He laughed lightly.

"If you want, yes but also no." I frowned at the contradiction, and he continued: "The old magic was born to evolve and adapt. Even though you see us as gods, that was only because the old magic, at its peak, created us using evolution and adaptation to suit its needs. After that, we became masters of our own powers. I did exactly the same thing that happened at our own birth: I gave you my orb, so it's up to you to decide what you

want to become. You can be a god, or anything else entirely. Of course, it won't happen instantly the old magic has to evolve alongside its bearer."

Resting my hand on my chest, feeling a warmth there, I looked at Hisié and asked:

"Why?"

He sighed, then said seriously:

"Aiden, the worlds are going to disappear, and I won't be able to hold this prison much longer."

He pointed toward that kind of white sun sitting there, radiating cold and dark realities, and said:

"I sealed the Observer with me. We're both, together, inside my soul."

I blinked, unable to process it, and said:

"Wait, what?"

He nodded.

"You were the only one with access, because we were bound together through the orb I gave you. Anyway, after the battle, I had to drag my own body to the very first place the four of us were born, then put myself into stasis, using my body as a prison and my soul as the jailer, to keep the Observer from escaping. And centuries passed like that."

Then he sighed, sadly:

"Unfortunately, that battle left me with irreversible damage. I'm dying."

I stayed quiet a moment, then asked:

"How long?"

He smiled, with difficulty:

"I'll die in 1273. So there's six years left before the end, before the White Frost truly starts hunting for the only two keys capable of shutting it down you, Aiden, and Ciri. And it'll come after both of you, even as I try to hold it back. The Observer's still extremely powerful, able to open tiny portals into different worlds, letting the White

Frost spread there bit by bit, while it keeps corrupting itself further, searching for the keys."

But I was worried about Ciri, and asked:

"Why Ciri? Is it because of her blood?"

He nodded.

"Yes. She's a descendant of Eldarion and Caladwen their daughter, Lara Dorren, is her direct ancestor. The Elder Blood is a bloodline created by the old magic itself, that's why it's so exceptional. Right now, in this world, only you and Ciri carry the old magic within you, each in a different way and you two are the only ones capable of destroying the White Frost's prison."

He looked at the white sun, wistful:

"I'm trying to hold it back with everything I have left, but it's getting harder and harder. The closer we get to the final date, the fiercer and more frequent the White Frost, the monsters, and everything else will become. Winter will come, along with hunger and disease it'll be the end of times. The old magic will be devoured by chaos, and nothing will be left."

Even though I still had questions, one worried me more than the others. I clenched my fists and said:

"Are you telling me all this just so I become some hero? The one who saves the world? So I'm just some random chance, a simple..." Just as I was about to spiral into a conspiracy theory, he said simply:

"No."

I frowned, raising my voice:

"No? Because from where I'm standing, I see it pretty clearly..." He cut me off again:

"No, I'm not asking anything of you. You wanted to know why I brought you here? It's true, at first, I wanted to use you as a weapon to save this world, even though the real truth was that it was mostly my own personal revenge."

Then he looked at his own hand, the withered ring on his finger, and said softly:

"But then, I watched you. You weren't perfect: you lied, as a kid, you played pranks, you hid your feelings. And yet…" He paused. "You live your life fully, never looking back. You fight for the people you love. You dream alongside the people you love. And you'll always be like that, because that's what your parents from the other world instilled in you same as the people close to you here, through this war. So there's my answer: I just want you to do what YOU want to do. You'll be strong enough to leave this world, if you want, with the people you love, thanks to the power of teleportation. And if it comes to it, I'll destroy myself even if it keeps me from reuniting with the ones I miss. I won't hesitate to teleport straight into chaos itself, blowing up my soul and everything I have left along with the Observer, and disappear forever. I don't care either way."

Then he smiled broadly:

"That's what living means, Aiden. Never regretting your choices. I regret plenty of mine but this one, I don't regret at all. If you don't want to be part of saving this world, then let me handle the rest, and live. Live your life the way I would've loved to, without anything holding you back."

I stayed silent at these revelations. I'd thought I was just some pawn, fattened up like a pig for slaughter, meant to be sacrificed to save a world but no, I'd literally just been told I could say no.

But…

Did I want to? Even though this world was harsh, with schemes and murders seemingly around every corner, it was also the place where Calanthe had died, where Mousesack had died the birthplace of Geralt, Triss, Yennefer, Vesemir, Lambert, Eskel, Dandelion, and… Ciri.

I smiled, amused, genuinely wanting to know the truth about myself. Looking at Hisié, I said with a smile:

"I've decided. I'll deal with the Observer, alone or with help not because I want to be a hero, but because I love this world. I love the people by my side. This is the place where Ciri was born, where Calanthe, Mousesack, the commander, and the rest of Cintra's army rest. And it'd be disrespecting them to walk away like a coward. So, Hisié tell me what I need to do. I'll defend this world, even if my name's never known for it, not out of heroism, but because of what I believe in."

He stayed silent a moment, staring at me, then said, smiling:

"You're just like your father. You really are a..." He leaned his head in, holding back whatever he was about to say, then continued: "Very well. Honestly, it's pretty simple."

He conjured three orbs those belonging to the other gods and said:

"When the Observer was imprisoned, the other three orbs scattered across this world. They need to be found, along with their bearers those who embody the values each one represents." He pointed at my chest. "You already carry the winter orb inside you. For now, it's still a child, but it'll grow alongside you."

Nodding, I smiled softly, thinking that Ciri and I would finally get to travel together. I asked:

"Will that let us defeat the Observer?"

He nodded.

"If you bring all four orbs together, like you saw, the orb becomes a miniature planet, and with it, you'll literally control the old magic itself. You'll be able to push back chaos, strip it of all its power in this world and that way, the Observer will lose its greatest strength, and can finally be defeated."

I asked:

"And your daughter?"

He stayed silent a few seconds, then said:

"Don't worry about that. I'll take care of it. For now, I'll hold on until the very end. Don't forget: only six years left. Find the orbs, bring them all together, and don't worry you'll get the chance to find out where the four of us were born."

Then Hisié conjured an ice sword and said, smiling:

"Now, on to the part I like best."

I stepped back slightly and said:

"What do you mean? Why'd you conjure your sword?"

Hisié calmly spun the blade and said:

"What do you think? I'm going to train you." But before I could say anything, he continued, serious: "You don't actually think that even with your power fully unlocked, you could beat Lycaon if he tried to stop you from escaping?"

I looked at him, unsure, and said:

"I'm not strong enough?"

Hisié sighed and, in an instant, without me even managing to move, he was right in front of me, blade pressed to my throat. He said calmly:

"Aiden, you're in the big leagues now. So no, that's not enough nowhere close. And it'll take however long it takes, until I decide you're ready."

The moment he turned around, I tried conjuring a dagger to strike him from behind but with a simple snap of his fingers, he summoned a block of ice that blocked my strike, then another against that same wall, which sent me flying into a tree, making me wince in pain. Looking at me, he smiled and said:

"You've still got a lot to learn, Aiden."

General POV

For some time well, Aiden eventually lost count, since Hisié had explained we were inside his soul, where only his spirit truly existed, meaning he couldn't die. Aiden underwent an extraordinarily intense training regimen under Hisié.

It started simply: a straightforward duel, fair and square. The result? Aiden got beaten down, again, again, and again to the point it looked less like a real fight and more like a methodical thrashing.

Over the weeks that followed, without Aiden even fully realizing it, something started to shift. Hisié no longer just cut him down without a second thought: he'd correct his guard with a single word, snap his feet back into proper position with a sharp kick, deliberately slow certain attacks to give him time to figure out where to place his blade. Aiden learned to read an opponent's weight before the strike even landed, to stop wasting movement swinging at nothing, and above all, to stop scrambling back up blindly after every fall instead, to first take stock of what had just taken him down. Hisié stayed demanding, almost merciless, but each defeat started feeling a little less like a beating, and a little more like a lesson.

Aiden, getting up once more, still aching after yet another loss, said:

"Why do you keep doing this?! You can see this isn't getting us anywhere!"

Hisié looked at Aiden on the ground, struggling to stand, and sighed:

"Aiden, what do you actually know about winter, besides ice?"

Aiden frowned, thought it over, and said:

"That it's cold? So… ice, snow? Maybe temperature?"

Hisié smiled, amused, and conjured several scenarios, explaining:

"Your view of it is far too narrow. Winter is so much more than ice and snow it's also a set of concepts."

He began creating a body in front of which Aiden could see a massive wound. Using his power, one could freeze the blood pouring out of it, or even gradually slow the heart, holding it in a perfectly cold stasis to slow its beating or, conversely, spike that same cold suddenly to trigger a surge of adrenaline in that same body.

Then, ending the spell, he stepped over to Aiden and placed a hand on his chest. Aiden felt his limbs go numb, losing all sense of touch entirely. Hisié said calmly:

"You can also freeze the nerves controlling an opponent's different senses. And you don't even need to touch them directly: a simple wound inflicted by your magic acts like corrosion on them. The moment someone's touched by your magic, you become like a virus spreading through their body, seeking only to freeze their vital organs completely."

Time kept passing.

The entire area was now blanketed in ice and thick fog. Aiden was sweating cold droplets, his heart beating very slowly through sheer concentration to maintain an extremely low temperature — then, all at once, he'd flip that same temperature, forcing an adrenaline surge through his own body to dodge Hisié's projectiles more easily.

Watching this, Hisié nodded and said:

"Let's move to phase two. Winter can also be considered silence silence, or the illusion born from fog."

Hisié waved a hand, and a thick fog enveloped both Aiden and himself. Several Hisiés spoke at once, from every direction:

"Which one's real? Figure it out yourself, Aiden. Trust your power."

Every one of the different Hisiés' footsteps made absolutely no sound only total silence could be heard. Unsurprisingly, Aiden got completely outclassed.

Time kept passing.

Aiden summoned a massive ice porcupine, launching spikes in every direction to strike all the Hisiés at once, shattering them.

Aiden smiled, having targeted one Hisié in particular, who dodged with a simple tilt of the head, smiling:

"You finally got me? So?"

Aiden laughed and said:

"Over the course of our fights, I noticed you always make this slight hand gesture, almost impossible to catch but that's because you have to use a gesture to move your clones around."

Hisié nodded and said:

"Yes. But you don't have to do the same with enough training, you'll be able to keep directing your illusions through thought alone."

Hisié sighed and said:

"I would've liked to keep teaching you more, Aiden but I've already taken up far too much time. With everything I've taught you, you should manage just fine for quite a while. Just know that winter isn't only ice there are countless uses for it, depending on your imagination: it can become a mental spell inducing seasonal depression, for instance, or even draw the heat out of metal, forcing armed soldiers to drop their weapons from the cold, and much more besides. After all, winter is also considered death itself but you'll understand that on your own. For now, training's over, and I'm willing to let you go."

Aiden smiled, looking at his own hands, and said:

"So how long did all this training actually take? Because after all our fights, I honestly feel solid."

Hisié answered calmly:

"Just three years."

POV Aiden

Nodding, still pleased with my training, I suddenly froze, in disbelief:

"Wait, you said…"

He nodded and repeated:

"Yes. Three years."

I froze completely:

"WHAT? That's THREE YEARS? How's that even possible?!"

He explained calmly:

"Ah, no. The ritual that brought you here took place in 1263 it took Lycaon that long to gather everything needed. As for the girl in the cage, don't worry: she was freed by Lycaon, as part of our contract. But the training was necessary the dangers coming your way will be far more dangerous than anything you've faced so far. And don't worry about your body, either."

He pointed at my chest.

"You just need to feed on old magic for everything else. You can live without eating or drinking. And you were being bathed by Lycaon's soldiers."

I clenched my jaw and shot back:

"But the others are waiting for me at Kaer Morhen, they're gonna be worried!"

Hisié nodded.

"Don't worry. Right now, in that cave, Vesemir's watching over you I asked Lycaon to send a letter. It's been three years, and he's stayed close to you the whole time, sometimes relieved by Lambert, sometimes by Eskel, for months at a stretch. The three of them have been taking turns, this whole time."

I stayed quiet, my heart warmed by that news but frowning, I asked:

"And Geralt? And Ciri?"

He fell silent a moment, then said:

"Sorry. I can't tell you."

I frowned, worried:

"Can't? Or won't?"

He sighed.

"Can't. Don't forget, I'm not as powerful as I used to be I can sense what's happening around me, because we're bound together, but that's all."

I found it strange that he hadn't said anything about the fact that neither Ciri, nor Geralt, nor even Triss or Yennefer had come to see me but I figured it was probably because of Ciri's training at Kaer Morhen.

But I asked quickly:

"Wait, so why do I still look 15, here?"

Hisié explained:

"It's pretty simple: only your soul came here, so you were 15, at that point. Don't worry even though it'll take a few days to readjust and fully recover everything we worked on together, you'll get it all back quickly. The body can forget but not the soul."

Hisié opened a portal and said softly:

"Anyway, Aiden, never forget: at any point, you can say stop, decide you don't want to save this world anymore, and I'll handle the rest. Never feel forced into this."

I nodded but I already knew I wasn't going to do that, that I'd keep going. I was mostly worried about Ciri: three years since we'd seen each other, she must have grown so

much. Then, just as I was about to step through the portal, Hisié said:

"Aiden. The old magic can't bring back the dead, and Lycaon knows that. When he said you'd be the one to reunite him with his wife that means you'll have to kill him. This is your first real trial, if you agree to his request to bring them together."

I stopped dead at the portal's edge, those words suddenly making sense in my head. Then I stepped through the portal, returning to the real world.

POV Hisié

Watching Aiden disappear, heading back to the real world, I looked at the white sun, then felt an eagle land on my shoulder, rubbing its cheek against mine. Gently stroking its feathers, I said softly:

"You didn't want him to see you? You've watched him all these years he's not someone who judges."

The eagle lowered its head, ashamed. I sighed, watching it keep its head lowered, then looked at the sun of the White Frost's prison, and said simply:

"Let's believe in Aiden. And even if he fails, I'll pull him out of this world by force, along with the people he loves. For once, I'll make a selfish choice and if I can save him, then I'm fine with dying for good, without ever seeing Tuilë again."

Then I smiled at the eagle and said:

"And don't worry we'll get your body back, Morniel. Besides, I'm sure you like that eagle form, your mother's own animal."

(And yes, the big twist: Aiden spent three years inside Hisié's soul and now, he's come out far better trained, both in combat and in magical skill! Don't worry, this'll be one of the only times that much time skips by all at once now that Aiden's an adult with clear goals, I've got a lot more freedom in my writing.

Know that we're getting close to the end of Act 0.

The first pillar of this world is now in place I'd love to hear what you think about how I'm rebuilding the Witcher universe, and if you have any questions, don't hesitate

to ask.

And if you want to talk about The Witcher in general, or about my fanfic, because you've got ideas to share, here's my Discord: .zerce or if you can't find me, send me your own Discord handle and I'll add you.

Have a good day, and a good weekend!)

37: Chapter 36 : Lycaon

POV Aiden

Opening my eyes again, I felt I was still lying on the ground. Sitting up, enormous soreness ran through my body, and I easily noticed the change: I was already taller, my center of gravity completely different. And yet, lifting my shirt, I didn't look like someone who'd been starving for three years old magic really was incredible.

Then I heard footsteps and saw Lycaon walking toward me, saying:

"So you're finally awake."

Nodding as I got up, I spoke in a deeper voice, coughing slightly, not having spoken in a long while:

"Yeah."

Then I heard, behind me, footsteps I recognized easily after all, a witcher's footsteps are pretty distinctive. Turning around, I smiled and pulled Vesemir into a hug, saying:

"Vesemir."

Vesemir laughed, hugging me back, and said calmly:

"We let you out, and you end up in impossible situations, kid you're really just like Geralt." Then he patted my shoulder, smiling, relieved. "But it's good to see you back in good health, all things considered."

I smiled and said:

"You got all the information?"

Vesemir looked at Lycaon, waiting off to the side with a smile, surrounded by the other werewolves, and said:

"Yeah. I'll admit I was surprised, at the time and you missed a lot. I'll fill you in on the road."

Nodding, Vesemir started walking toward the exit, saying, "Let's go, kid." But I stopped him:

"Sorry, Vesemir, but there's still something I need to do."

He frowned, but I'd already turned back toward Lycaon, and said:

"Hisié told me everything. You sure about your choice?"

Lycaon stayed silent, then said after a moment:

"Aiden, have you ever loved?"

I looked at him, surprised, but thought it over there was nothing like that in my memories and said:

"Not that I remember."

He smiled, then, looking at Vesemir, asked:

"And you, witcher have you ever loved a woman?"

Vesemir, arms crossed, wasn't hostile after all, over these three years, Lycaon had hosted him, Lambert, and Eskel, so I could tell from his eyes he wasn't hostile, just still wary. He said:

"Yes, I've loved a woman."

Lycaon nodded, looked at me again, and said:

"The old witcher can confirm it for you: when you love someone, Aiden, it's something so beautiful it's impossible to escape it. Sometimes, all you want is to always be near her."

He looked at his people and said:

"Unfortunately, I couldn't join her right away. I owed Hisié a debt. You must have seen the war, where I fought against him, despite everything when he was still strong enough to defeat me, he didn't. He simply asked for a contract instead, telling me that one day, I'd understand what it means to love."

He sighed, wistful:

"I agreed to help the goddess because she promised a future for my people. Werewolves are inevitably seen as monsters mind you, I'm not saying every werewolf is a saint, but we never got the chance to prove otherwise to the world."

I was curious about one thing, and asked:

"If you survived, did Thúrlas too?" He shook his head and said: "He survived Caladwen's spell, that's true but he was killed later, at Toussaint, by another bearer of Aerondight."

Maybe that… I asked:

"Can you tell me more?" He shook his head with a smile:

"No, because that's something I promised Hisié. My only role was to lead you to him, and to ask you to reunite me with the woman I love. But all I can tell you is that whoever killed Thúrlas was a king among kings, one of the finest warriors this world's ever known though, as always, the best fall at the hands of those closest to them, since they're often the weakest against them."

I wanted to know more, of course, but seeing his face, I knew I wouldn't learn anything else. I asked instead:

"Hisié explained it to me but do you actually want this? You're going to leave your people…"

He laughed and said:

"My people are strong. And besides, who says I'll die? Don't think I'm just going to let you cut my head off without a fight I'm still a warrior, after all." Then he looked at me, smiling: "But promise me one thing, Aiden: if I die, take care of my people, and lead them for me."

I looked at him, completely stunned, and said:

"Wait, what? I've got nothing of a leader in me, and they'll never want someone like me I've got no experience, and…" He cut me off:

"True. But experience comes with age, and…" He smiled, mysterious: "As for your qualities as a leader, trust me, I'm sure you have them."

Then, without waiting for my answer, he looked at his people and said, raising his voice:

"Listen to me, all of you!" Every werewolf turned to their leader, and Lycaon continued: "Today, a sacred duel will take place! My dear brothers, if I die under this brilliant witcher's sword, I ask you, as my final order, to follow him."

Naturally, voices rose in outrage none of this had been planned but Lycaon raised his voice: "ENOUGH!" Then he calmed down and said softly: "I know many of you can't picture a future without me, since I've always been your protector, your leader. But I'm tired. I think anyone here can understand that I want to be with her again."

Then he laughed, seeing his people's sad, silent faces, and said:

"Why the long faces? If I lose to this witcher, it means you'll be in good hands. And if I win, it just means I'll stick around a bit longer, until I find a successor to protect you."

Then he clapped his hands together, shaking the whole cave, and the werewolves began stomping the ground in a rhythm like a war drum. Vesemir, behind me, moved to help, but I said, smiling:

"Thanks, Vesemir. But like he said, this is my fight and deep down, I promised someone I would."

Vesemir was about to say something, but stopped, then said, smiling:

"You and Ciri really wear me out but fine. Show me, Aiden." Vesemir walked off to join the werewolves, arms crossed, still worried despite it all.

Then my eyes settled on Lycaon, still smiling, his muscles bulging, an even more powerful ice sword forming in his hand and my shirt, now far too small, tore off, leaving me bare-chested, fairly muscled, a few scars visible. I said, smiling, because for a warrior, it's best to answer with blades:

"Lycaon. Ready for your last dance?"

He laughed and charged at me.

General POV

Aiden hadn't expected that kind of speed from Lycaon his eyes could barely keep up. After all, it had been ages since their last fight, and given Lycaon's wounds, he should have been weakened.

But if this had happened a few years earlier, Aiden would never have been able to dodge like that. This time, his body tilted perfectly, dodging the claw that would have torn out his throat, and in a split second, Aiden's fist landed square in Lycaon's ribs.

His fist was coated in a layer of spiked ice, and Aiden managed to land at least eight strikes in a split second against Lycaon's ribs, who growled in pain before grabbing Aiden's arm, twisting it, and hurling him away.

Then, despite his twisted arm, Aiden matched Lycaon's speed, evenly.

The ice sword clashed against Lycaon's claws, sparks flying with every impact, but it was easy to see the whole area growing denser, like fog.

The minutes passed in that exchange of blows, the ice sword striking Lycaon's claws. Of course, for Lycaon, that barely mattered his eyes always managed to track Aiden, to the point that, catching an opening, he sank his teeth into Aiden's arm, making him growl in pain. But Aiden retaliated, grabbing Lycaon's head and smashing his knee straight into his chin, leaving shards of ice embedded in the wound, blood running down his neck.

The two fighters pulled back. Aiden's arm was bleeding from the bite, but Lycaon wasn't much better off his neck bled slightly, and his body was riddled with wounds from Aiden's ice.

POV Aiden

I breathed fairly easily despite the open wound. I could feel Vesemir behind me, worried but applying a thick layer of ice magic to stop the bleeding, I smiled. Despite the fact Lycaon had been on the goddess's side, purely for his people's future, I found it hard to hold it against him.

After all, a leader has to make hard choices for his people's future. But something made me hesitate before reaching that conclusion, and I asked Lycaon:

"Why'd you say I'd make a good leader, Lycaon? I've got nothing to do with leading anyone, and I know myself I'm selfish. If I had to choose between the people of Cintra, say, and the people close to me, I…"

I stopped myself right there. It was true I'd agreed to help Hisié save this world, and I didn't regret that. But why, ever since Lycaon had brought up being a leader, was my heart pounding this hard? Normally, I'd have said, without hesitation, that I'd always save the people close to me first. And now, I…

Lycaon, seeing my uncertainty, smiled and said:

"Why the hesitation?"

Strangely, in that icy fog where only our silhouettes stood out, I felt like I was genuinely questioning myself more than answering him. I said, sincere:

"I hesitate because… because I'd have said, without hesitation, that I'd always protect the people close to me first. But now… when I think about the people of Cintra, who must be lost, confused I'm not saying I want to protect everyone, be some hero to the people, just…"

Lycaon finished my sentence for me:

"You feel like you're sensing what was missing?" I nodded, and he continued, straightening up: "There are two types of leaders: the one who's a tyrant, and the one who's too soft. But there's a third kind the one you'd never hesitate to follow, the one who, if he asked you to march to your death, no one would hesitate, because that leader never hesitates to be the first one on the front line, even alone. A leader is nothing without his people, and it goes both ways."

He laughed, his fur growing denser, his aura more concentrated, and said:

"Aiden. Show me who you really are. Drop the title of witcher, of Hisié's heir just you."

Then, at even greater speed, he slammed me to the ground, making me cough up blood, and grabbing my head, shoved it into the cave wall's rock, leaving me slightly dazed.

But gritting my teeth, I locked my legs around the arm holding me and, without hesitating, snapped it, making him howl in pain. He kicked me away with his legs, sending me stumbling to the ground, my head ringing, blood trickling from the wound.

Me? A leader? I laughed at my own disbelief at the idea. Looking at my hands, I sighed softly, thinking it all over. It's true who am I, really?

I was Ciri's servant, but is that really me? Even though I loved that role, deep down I knew it was mostly for my own survival even if I care about Ciri enormously.

I became a witcher, and even though I love it, even though I'd do anything for the people close to me, was that really my own choice? Now that I think about it, I've never really chosen what I wanted myself. Every time the promise with Ciri, that was a choice we made together; but every trial along the way has always been someone else's choice.

Then I smiled, free. And for a split second, in my mind, I saw a blond-haired man smiling softly, in a fatherly way, and I heard these words:

"Be yourself, my son. Stop hesitating. Don't let anyone doubt your choices, and fully accept your life."

Then I opened my eyes again, smiling, my eyes glowing like light in the dark. And without even realizing it, I'd conjured Aerondight, made of ice. Walking calmly toward Lycaon, I saw him look surprised, smile, and charge at me at an even greater speed but this time, I simply tilted my head to dodge and teleported behind him. His left arm hung suspended in the air; turning around, gritting his teeth over his lost arm, he twisted my neck.

But what he held in his hand was only a mirage, created by the fog from the very start. Lycaon finally noticed the cave had transformed into a snow-covered forest, and looked at me:

"How?"

I simply smiled, reappeared behind him, and dealt him a massive wound to the chest, making him bleed heavily and drop to his knees. He tried to sweep my legs out with his but that too was a mirage and as he searched for my trail again…

It was already too late. My sword was at his throat. He stared at me in silence, then smiled sincerely and said:

"Did you find yourself, Aiden?"

I stayed silent for a few seconds, then said:

"Yes. I'll find out about my true birth, my parents' names. But I'll always keep my first family in my heart the values, the friendships I made, all of it shaped me, and I'll always stay myself."

Then I smiled naturally and said:

"I don't know if I'll be a good leader, but you're right: I'll never hesitate to be first on the front line, even alone. I'll never sacrifice my people, or the people close to me. If I have to choose, then it'll be with a weapon in hand and even if I have to stand alone against the whole world, I will. That's the man I'll be. And it's entirely my own choice."

Lycaon laughed and said:

"Your father would be proud of you…" Then, sincere: "Take care of my people. That's my last request, as their leader but also as just a werewolf: protect them."

I nodded and said calmly, as the fog dissipated, letting everyone who'd lost sight of things catch up with what was happening the werewolves staying silent:

"I swear it, in my name, Aiden of Cintra: from this moment on, your people will be under my protection. And if I have to go to war to protect them, I will."

Lycaon laughed and said:

"Then I entrust them to you."

Then I drove my sword into his heart, my ice freezing him, killing him without pain. The werewolves all knelt in silence, and I said simply:

"May you find your beloved. Rest in peace, Lycaon."

POV Lycaon

As I felt the gentle blanket of death settle over me, I quietly closed my eyes, knowing Aiden would be exactly what my people needed for their future and that I'd finally get to join you.

Opening my eyes, I saw a plain of ice, and I saw Hisié, his face still impassive. I said:

"Still looking after the dead?"

He nodded and said:

"Yes. Even with the Observer to deal with, I'm still the god of death."

I smiled, amused, but said sincerely:

"Can I go see her…"

He nodded and pointed behind him, toward a portal where I could see her her, but also other werewolves and friends I'd known over the years, and also…

I looked at Hisié and said:

"That must be hard."

Hisié looked at the portal, where only the souls of the dead rested. He could see Augusta and Yávië playing chess, and above all Tuilë, watching Hisié with tenderness but he looked away and said simply:

"I'll join them when the time comes. For now, Aiden and this world need me to keep holding on, even if it means suffering."

I stayed silent, then said:

"He'll get there. I'm sure of it. And we can share a drink together sometime, what do you say?"

He laughed softly and said:

"I'd like that, Lycaon. Now, go join her."

Nodding, I started to leave, but looked back at Hisié, who never took his eyes off the portal, and said sincerely:

"Thank you, Hisié. Despite everything we did, you're giving us the chance to see our loved ones again." And for the first time, I bowed respectfully and said sincerely: "Thank you, Hisié. We'll all be waiting for you, and we'll share a meal together, while the others bring peace to this world, where we failed."

Then I left without looking back. Arriving through the portal, I pulled Lily into my arms, holding her close, crying, and she laughed tenderly, wiping my eyes, saying:

"I missed you."

Lily smiled and kissed me and for the first time, I felt light, without a single weight left on me.

38: Information

Sorry, I'm too wiped out today to write a chapter, but to make up for it, there will be one on Sunday.

Anyway, thanks again for the comments, Power Stones, and general feedback on my fanfic it really warms my heart. See you tomorrow.

Just a heads-up: the assassination of Vizimir is coming up, and Aiden is going to meet a certain Radovid along with Vesemir during their journey back to Kaer Morhen.

39: Chapter 37 : Radovid

POV Aiden

Pulling my sword from Lycaon's heart, dead with a smile on his face, I made it vanish, sighing with exhaustion. I stepped back slightly, but felt Vesemir steady me from behind, sighing, but with a smile:

"You know, the more I watch you, the more you remind me of Geralt."

I laughed, straightening up I was sore all over and said:

"Is that a good thing?"

Vesemir shrugged and said:

"Yes and no. But this isn't the time or place to get into it." He said that because the werewolves were approaching us, Valerius the werewolf mage and Garrick the muscular werewolf leading the way.

I expected at least some resentment, or uncertain looks but what surprised me was that they didn't hesitate for a second to kneel before me. Garrick said calmly:

"The sacred duel has been fulfilled, and the victor has been named under our ancestors' watch. You are our lord."

I was surprised they accepted this so readily, without the slightest anger especially since Lycaon seemed to have been deeply loved within this community. I said, uncertain, my heart pounding harder watching them kneel like that:

Why?

Collecting myself, I asked, without stammering:

"Valerius, Garrick those are your names, right? Why accept this so easily? This duel's supposed to be so sacred, I expected you'd resent this decision."

Valerius looked up and said:

"My lord, of course some of us feel sorrow. Lord Lycaon was our leader for years, and to some, almost a father. But…"

Garrick struck his chest, over his heart, with a wide grin, finishing Valerius's sentence:

"I'm sure wherever Lord Lycaon is right now, he's drinking with our ancestors, reunited with his soulmate, all while still watching over us. And besides, why hold it against you? You respected him throughout the whole fight, and you never once looked at us with fear or disgust."

Valerius smiled slightly and said:

"I promise you, you're one of the rare few who doesn't look at us that way. Unfortunately, most people, the moment they see a werewolf, automatically see danger and monstrosity."

Vesemir, beside me, crossed his arms and said, sighing:

"That's not really their fault they don't really understand monsters. Even I was caught off guard by a whole werewolf community."

Garrick shrugged and said to Vesemir:

"That's true, master witcher. But we've always been like this."

I sighed and said:

"Unfortunately, we witchers are the line between monsters and humans we understand you, because we were taught to. But humans have very little real information about you, and those in power are sometimes all too relieved to have a common enemy, unfortunately."

Valerius nodded and said:

"It's easier to blame a werewolf for killing a family than a lord for coveting land out of greed."

Silence settled, but I gestured toward the other werewolves, wanting to hear their thoughts:

"What do you all think? I want to hear from you, even if Valerius and Garrick speak for you. I promised Lycaon I'd be your leader, and… I think it's better I get to know you for who you really are, rather than what I've been taught."

One of the young werewolves raised his hand and asked:

"My lord, is it true human women are born not virgins, because they like getting taken by soldiers, since people say they've got good stamina?"

I went speechless, and everyone turned to look at the child who'd asked this. His mother, seeing this, clamped her hand over her son's muzzle and murmured, though everyone still heard it, mortified:

"Sweetie, where did you learn that?"

The son, confused, said:

"Well, it was during a conversation between you and Papa, in your room. You said you two had never been like those human women born not virgins. Then I heard something creak."

The werewolf mother turned bright red with shame and outright covered her child's mouth, looking at me, utterly panicked but me, I was dying laughing. I don't know why, with everything I'd just learned and everything going on, this bit of lightness made me burst out laughing, to everyone's shock. Wiping my tears, I said:

"Sorry, kid. But like you, I've got zero experience with that, so I can't answer you."

One of the werewolves stood up, shocked, and exclaimed:

"My lord doesn't have a mate?!"

Then the other werewolves exchanged worried looks and started crowding around me, accidentally shoving Vesemir aside, bombarding me with questions about what I looked for in a partner which, strangely, made me smile and laugh even harder, even though I carefully avoided the gazes of the female werewolves staring at me oddly. Sorry, ladies, I prefer the human form.

A few hours later, evening fell, and most of the werewolves were busy preparing for the journey. We stood on a hill, a bit further from the cave Vesemir, me, Valerius, and Garrick looking at a grave marked with Lycaon's name, beside another, older grave, marked: Lily.

Staying silent, I prayed he could finally feel the warmth of the one he loved. I looked at Garrick and Valerius, behind me, and asked softly:

"Did he come here often?"

They nodded, and Valerius said:

"Yes. Every day, at the same hour. When we asked him why, he said it was the hour of their first kiss."

Nodding, I thought it over for a moment, then, closing my eyes, I began channeling my winter magic, creating a beautiful ice flower, which I placed between the two graves. Resting my hand on the ground, I said:

"Don't worry about anything anymore."

Then, standing up, I looked at Valerius and Garrick and said:

"I'm entrusting the troops to you. Don't forget the plan: head to Kaer Morhen, and tell Lambert clearly that you're coming on my behalf. If he doesn't believe you, tell him I know his secret about the succubus-hair aphrodisiac he'll know it's really me."

I heard Vesemir sigh behind me: "Bunch of kids." But Valerius nodded, and Garrick said, thumping his chest:

"Yes, chief. Nothing will happen to them, we swear it."

I nodded, but just as they were about to leave, I asked:

"By the way why can you use magic, Valerius? And you, Garrick, why are you so much stronger than a normal werewolf?"

Valerius stopped walking and said:

"It's because I received Lord Lycaon's blood." Garrick nodded, saying the same. I asked, confused:

"How's that work?"

Valerius explained:

"It's pretty simple. Lord Lycaon carried the blood of an ancestral wolf bloodline, and he could give his blood to strengthen other werewolves. But of course, there's a risk we

call them 'offspring,' kind of like with vampires: if a higher vampire gives their blood to a human, that human becomes a vampire's offspring, enslaved to that same vampire. But if the offspring then drinks the blood of the vampire who turned them, they become a higher vampire themselves though it's a risk for the original vampire, since it means creating a potential enemy capable of killing them."

I nodded and thanked them. Once they'd left, I thought it over: if this worked for werewolves and vampires, would it work for witchers too? After all, like Lycaon, I carried old magic within me, so could…?

Vesemir patted my shoulder and said:

"You're wondering if you could give us your blood, to strengthen us."

I looked at him, surprised, and said:

"How'd you know?"

He laughed and said:

"Aiden, I've seen a lot in my time, and I raised those three troublemakers Geralt, Eskel, and Lambert so I know how to spot when someone's thinking about us. And we all know you carry old magic, so connecting the dots, you probably figured you could strengthen us, didn't you?"

I stayed quiet, me who thought I was so unreadable. He continued, smiling:

"Don't look so surprised, it's just experience. Either way, know this: none of us need it."

But I shot back:

"Yeah, but if it works, it could help you all survive longer, more effectively. I don't need to be unique if it means the people close to me have to risk dying just because I selfishly kept this power to myself."

He smiled and started down the hill toward the horses, saying:

"Aiden, that genuinely warms my heart to hear. You don't need to worry about us I'm not telling you not to think it over yourself, just that, for us, we'll never demand anything from you." He patted my shoulder. "Aiden, like you said yourself, we're a family now I won't hide it anymore. Witchers are getting rarer by the day, we've gotta stick together.

And even if none of the others will ever say it to your face, none of us mind standing against the whole world, if it comes to that."

He sighed, looking up at the moon, and said:

"Before, I'd have stopped you from taking on this kind of leadership role I'm old school, believer in witcher neutrality. But I have to face facts: whether it's you, Geralt, Lambert, or Eskel, that neutrality doesn't really serve much purpose anymore. And watching you, it hit me clear as day."

He looked at me seriously and said:

"Aiden, here's my last piece of advice, drawn from all my experience. I regret a lot of things, in my life but there's one thing I've always done: stayed true to my own values. If you want to be a leader, do it. If you want to be a king, do it. If you want to be king of the whole world, do that too." He tapped my chest, right where the Wolf School medallion rested, and said: "You've had this medallion in your possession for a while now but today, with what you just did for these people, with the leader you just became right in front of me, I can finally say you've truly earned it, far beyond just a training certificate. And that means you didn't just earn our training — you earned the four of us. Because if you ever want to be king of the world, the four of us will help you get there. And even if you become a tyrant, we'll stop you but we'll never kill you, because you're family."

Then he patted my chest, smiling, and heading back down the hill, added:

"Now go on, smile. You just managed to make an old fossil like me realize witcher neutrality is a thing of the past."

I stood frozen for a moment, then, holding the Wolf School medallion in my hands, I smiled, closed my eyes to take in a deep breath of the cool evening air, listening to Vesemir's footsteps fading away. Opening my eyes again, I looked up at the moon and said:

"Hisié, I don't know if you can hear me or not, but I'm coming to confirm my choice again: I'm saving this world. There's just too much I care about now."

Then I walked down the hill, a more natural smile on my lips, already thinking about our reunion with Ciri, Geralt, Yennefer, and Triss at Kaer Morhen.

Reaching the bottom, I saw the werewolves bow as I passed, then heard hooves galloping toward me. Seeing Nocturne charging straight at me, I broke into a huge smile,

and bracing against her massive muzzle rubbing against my head, I laughed and said:

"I missed you too, girl."

Nocturne whinnied, and I patted her belly, saying:

"Did you put on weight?" Garrick, who'd been looking after her, came running over and said:

"That's normal, my lord, considering when you got, uh…" He clearly hesitated to say "kidnapped," and skipped past the word: "Anyway, Lord Lycaon specifically ordered us to take extremely good care of your horse. She got the best ingredients, the best hay."

I shook my head, amused, and saw Valerius approaching, carrying a sword wrapped in a towel, Vesemir chatting with him near the horses. Reaching us, Valerius unwrapped the sword and said:

"It's not much, but it's a short sword that belonged to Lord Lycaon."

Taking the short sword, I studied it honestly, it was beautiful. I looked at Valerius and said:

"Thank you so much. I'll take good care of it." He nodded, glanced at Garrick, who nodded back, and Valerius pulled a magnificent dagger from a portal, saying respectfully:

"This is the dagger that belonged to Lady Lily. Our Lord Lycaon had ordered it be given only to whoever succeeded him to always remind them of his promise, but above all, to say that he'll always have something to protect, where he himself failed."

I fell silent, taking the dagger carefully. I could tell right away it was a grandmaster-quality blade, and I was stunned even Vesemir looked shocked, since grandmaster blades were extremely rare. He asked:

"What is this dagger?"

Valerius looked at us and said:

"This dagger was the wedding gift Lycaon had intended for Lily, but he was never able to give it to her. All I know is that it belonged to the very first elven queen."

I stayed silent. The very first elven queen did that mean Caladwen's mother? This dagger dated back to time immemorial, then, and given how delicate the crest was, it

had to be elven in origin — though that was just my own guess. Valerius added something that shocked Vesemir even further:

"The dagger is made of moonstone."

Vesemir said, stunned:

"Moonstone?! That's a lost material purer than silver!"

I looked at Vesemir and asked:

"Is it really that precious?"

He nodded and, studying the dagger seriously, said:

"It's a stone that's almost entirely vanished from existence. Legend says only elves who knew a certain moon chant could summon it, under a full moon, and only in very small amounts. Unfortunately, the texts describing it were lost, and moonstone disappeared along with them. Aiden don't tell anyone about this. This dagger is made of moonstone."

Nodding, I tucked the dagger behind my back, beside my short sword, in the black sheaths I'd been given. Grabbing a leather armor set, I geared up, mounted Nocturne, and faintly heard Vesemir mutter behind me:

"This kid's aging me more every single day."

I laughed lightly, urging Nocturne forward, and said to Vesemir:

"Won't make much difference, Vesemir you've already got a full head of white hair." He sighed, amused. I looked at Valerius and Garrick and said, serious:

"I'm leaving the rest to you. We'll head through Redania to reach Kaer Morhen as fast as possible. You all take the paths we can't ride through on horseback, avoid the main roads as much as you can, and we'll all meet up at Kaer Morhen."

They nodded, and all at once, Garrick, then Valerius, struck their chests followed by every other werewolf, who paused what they were doing to do the same, even the children, all saying together:

"Yes, my lord!"

I sighed, smiling, and looking at all of them, said:

"Take care of yourselves, all of you. We'll have a drink together, at Kaer Morhen."

Then, clicking my tongue, Nocturne broke into a gallop, Vesemir on his own horse beside me, carrying us away from the werewolf tribe.

We'd already been riding for several weeks straight. Vesemir had explained we were near Blaviken, so we'd had to take a huge detour through Redania, passing by Tretogor, to reach Kaedwen.

Vesemir had told me the story behind Geralt's nickname, the Butcher of Blaviken that's why we'd avoided the town. I sighed, thinking Geralt had once again tried to play the hero for some innocents but strangely, I felt like I was looking at myself in that story, so I didn't say anything.

As we approached Knotgrass Meadow we wanted to avoid Tretogor by crossing the bridge near Drakenborg we caught the smell of blood and battle smoke in the distance. Frowning, I looked at Vesemir, who just nodded, and we galloped toward the fight. We found several Redanian soldiers battling men in black hoods. The Redanian soldiers were losing ground, busy defending a large tent. Dismounting, I armed myself with my short sword and dagger, Vesemir drawing his steel sword behind me, letting our horses run off away from the fight.

Over those weeks of travel, I'd been training with Vesemir in dual-wielding, short sword and dagger. Even though it was still far from perfect, thanks to the adaptive training style of the Wolf School, I'd managed to develop a style of my own not perfect yet, but good enough.

Seeing us arrive, the attackers' leader pointed his sword at us, and four men broke off to charge at us. The first swung for my throat, but I slid easily aside, having formed ice under my soles for extra agility, without anyone noticing, and drove my short sword into the man's throat. Another tried to strike me from behind but leaving my sword lodged in the first man's throat, I simply dodged by crouching down and drove my dagger into the man's groin, making him scream in pain; I finished him off by sinking the dagger into his throat, retrieving my short sword from the first corpse at the same time. One glance at Vesemir confirmed he'd already killed the other two.

Seeing us arrive, the leader panicked our presence was already driving up the body count in his ranks and just as he was about to shout the order to retreat, an arrow pierced his throat, making him cough up blood before collapsing, dead. I glanced at the archer: a rather well-dressed man, though what stood out most was his build extremely tall, with a fairly round silhouette. But no time to dwell on him: most of the attackers were already routed, and within minutes, they were all dead.

Wiping the blood off my weapons on the attackers' clothes before sheathing them, I saw the round man approach us, flanked by the Redanian soldiers. Vesemir kept his sword drawn, out of caution, without showing any hostility behind me. Seeing my witcher eyes, the man looked surprised, before saying, face impassive:

"A witcher? Pleasure to meet you. I'm Sigismund Dijkstra."

Vesemir frowned and said:

"Dijkstra? Head of intelligence services for His Majesty Vizimir?"

Dijkstra looked at Vesemir and smiled, almost pleased:

"The very same." Then his smile faded, and I clearly caught the hostility in his voice: "Well that was the case. Unfortunately, the late King Vizimir has passed. Or rather: was assassinated."

I was stunned, as was Vesemir, but there was no time for questions: a young man, dressed like a prince, stepped out of the tent and looked at his soldiers coldly, without a trace of emotion. He pointed at one, still shaking from the battle, and said simply:

"You, there. Your name."

The soldier, trembling harder, said:

"Dorick, Your Highness."

He nodded, walked over to him, patted his shoulder, and said:

"Dorick. Do you know you made a mistake?"

The soldier shook his head, snot running from his nose the young man's gaze made him shake like a leaf. Then, without warning, the young man pulled out a dagger and plunged it into the soldier's throat, again and again, in front of everyone, saying:

"No! I'm no longer just a prince I'm your king! And a king must be protected by his soldiers, not by crybabies!"

After several minutes of stabbing the already lifeless body, he tossed the dagger to the ground, pulled out a handkerchief to wipe his face, then looked at the other soldiers and said calmly:

"Toss him in the mass grave. No need for a proper burial."

The trembling soldiers nodded. The young man then walked toward us, staring at us. I could see Dijkstra's lips pressed tight, before his face went impassive again. He said:

"Your Majesty, you didn't have to, I..."

But the young man answered calmly, without even looking at Dijkstra:

"Oh really? That's exactly what you and Philippa always taught me. Now be quiet I'd like to talk with the witchers."

Stopping in front of us, I could easily tell Dijkstra had a lot more to say, but was holding back. The young man spoke, looking between Vesemir and me:

"Two witchers? You'll do. I need two witchers to run a secret investigation I know my father didn't just die at the hands of some mediocre elf. There's more to this. I want you to investigate."

He smiled a smile that was anything but pleasant to look at and added:

"By the way, witchers, before you refuse: I am King Radovid. Even though, officially, it's the regency council Philippa included handling things for now, know this: I am the king, and no one will decide otherwise. So, you accept this contract, don't you?"

(And there it is, the big assassination event! Just so you know, there'll be two important moments covering this one from Aiden's point of view, one from Ciri's because, for those in the know, a lot of you already know what really happens in 1267.)

40: Chapter 38 : Tretogor and the Prelude to the Thanedd Isle Ball

(Yo! We're getting close to the end of Act 0 just so you know, what follows is going to be a bit different, since we'll be following two points of view at the same time: Aiden's, and Ciri's. You're probably wondering why?

Well, I'll tell you: it's because at the end of Act 0, the two POVs are going to converge to kick off Act 1!

Just know I never could've imagined my story would get this much positive feedback, or comments from you all this full of curiosity, and above all that you'd be so genuinely invested in my story.

Anyway, thank you all sincerely, and enjoy the read!)

POV Aiden

I frowned hearing that, and glanced at Vesemir, who nodded and spoke first, saying calmly:

"I thank Your Majesty for the offer, but we'll have to..."

But Radovid raised a hand and said, in a cold tone that wouldn't hear another word:

"No need to waste your breath, witcher. I'm not waiting for your permission. Either you do it, or you'll be branded as witchers who worked for Nilfgaard, and I promise you the entire North will turn its back on you. So I'll ask again: you accept, don't you?"

We'd stayed silent up to that point. Maybe I was jumping to conclusions too fast, but watching a young man butcher his own guard for shaking with fear of death you didn't need to be blind to understand the person standing in front of us was insane. And if, by his own words, he'd been taught by that manipulator Philippa…

Stepping forward, I smiled falsely and said:

"You're right, Your Majesty. But as you know, even if we can't refuse, you'll still need to pay the price. Of course, you're free to refuse but even though I don't know your council well, I'd guess, knowing how nobility works, that if the future king uses his authority to force strangers into service without paying them, that'll leave a stain on your reputation. And I'm sure Your Majesty wouldn't be pleased if that happened, would he?"

Honestly, even though it was risky, and it risked sinking us deeper into the mud that is politics, there was no point backing off. I'd promised to move forward, and I would. Running this investigation would also let me get a read on the state of the world, and especially the war during the trip, Vesemir had told me that apparently, at Sodden Hill, Nilfgaard's army had been repelled, saving a strategic foothold for the northern kingdoms, despite heavy losses.

Either way, it was mostly for the information. Even though Vesemir knew the state of the world, he didn't know everything, especially the decisions made at the top something I'd need to think more about going forward.

Radovid stayed silent a moment, then said, face impassive:

"I should cut out your tongue, witcher, for that tone but you're still useful to me. Very well, you'll get a thousand crowns if you find the truth about my father's murder. And know this: I need irrefutable proof."

Then, without waiting, Radovid headed back into his tent, saying:

"Dijkstra, be a good servant, and give them the information they need. Farewell, witchers."

He stepped into his tent. Dijkstra stared at it for several seconds; I could see his hands clench slightly, though he said nothing. He looked at us, then gave a nod for us to follow. We followed him toward his personal tent.

His tent was fairly extravagant animal-hide rugs scattered across the ground, various pieces of clothing lying around, but it was mostly the fairly high-quality bed and the sheer size of the tent that stood out. With a wave of his hand, he gestured toward some chairs, where we sat. He grabbed a bottle and said, pouring three glasses:

"So, what do you think of our new King of Redania?"

Vesemir spoke calmly:

"I'd say fairly special."

Dijkstra set the glasses down on the table in front of us, downed his in one go before pouring himself another, and laughed, saying:

"Yeah, that's the word, special…" Then he looked at us and said: "All right. What do you want to know, before you head off?"

Vesemir started:

"For starters, what do you actually know?"

Dijkstra took a sip before setting his glass down, wiping the wine from his beard, and said calmly:

"For now, the assassin was an elf in Nilfgaard's service. Those southern bastards love recruiting damned elves who think Nilfgaard will hand them land, just like their ancestors got promised. But between you and me, I'm sure there's more to it."

He swirled his glass and said:

"The late King Vizimir was one of the finest rulers wise, charismatic and he just gets assassinated that easily? Bullshit. That's like asking a whore not to catch a disease, it's impossible. There's more to this conspiracy, especially since rumors about Princess Cirilla had been spreading more and more among the mages over at Aretuza Academy King Vizimir wanted to go there himself to check it out."

I froze slightly. Ciri wasn't at Kaer Morhen? I instinctively looked at Vesemir, who avoided my gaze. I pressed my lips together, clenching my hand under the table, hiding my disappointment mixed with anger: no one had warned me. I understood it was probably because I'd had other things on my mind but the least he could've done was tell me.

No, Aiden. Don't think about that right now. For now, it's the information, then finding Ciri. Don't worry about her, I'm sure she's grown even stronger.

Looking at Dijkstra, who was watching our silence, I said:

"Do you believe those rumors? After all, the princess of Cintra disappearing is a windfall for everyone, isn't it?"

He laughed and said:

"Of course it's a windfall after all, few people know it, but it's true. I'm sure Nilfgaard's already aware. As for us, we've confirmed, through my own source, that Cirilla really is at Aretuza which works out perfectly for His Majesty Radovid."

At those words, I clenched my hands tighter, but said calmly, face impassive:

"I see… Why do you think there's a conspiracy behind the late King Vizimir?"

Dijkstra looked at me, smiling, and said:

"Witcher, I've been in the intelligence business longer than you've been old enough to understand it. So even if His Majesty got assassinated that easily, that damned elf got far too close to the king, and killed him with far too much ease. I'm sure there was support coming from that famous council led by the celebrated sorceress Philippa Eilhart."

Dijkstra stood up and said calmly:

"Witchers, do you know Philippa?" Vesemir shook his head, same for me. Dijkstra said nothing more, then continued: "Philippa. She's as beautiful as a rose but a rose has thorns, and hers are poisoned. Just know this: from my experience, and from who actually benefited from the king's assassination, there's only one person: Philippa, who, thanks to it, managed to gradually push me out of power, inventing some flimsy excuse to get the king away from the capital and, oh what a coincidence, the king got attacked in less than a day."

Dijkstra placed his hands on the table, looking at both of us, and said:

"Here's what I'm proposing: along with the rest of my men, you'll infiltrate Philippa's lab at Tretogor, and find evidence there."

Vesemir asked a question:

"And how protected will we be?" Dijkstra laughed and said: "You won't be protected at all. If you get caught, I don't know you." Vesemir shot back, cold: "So, disposable pawns." Dijkstra shrugged: "Wasn't my call, it was the king's. So, do you accept the plan?"

Vesemir looked at me, thinking it over from what I remembered, Philippa was vain, arrogant, but extremely intelligent, and I suspected Dijkstra didn't fully trust us either. But maybe we'd get important information out of this, and maybe even the chance to force Philippa, if it really was her, to at least work with us. If I had to make myself

valuable, show her I was worth even more, that could come in handy. Then, standing up, Vesemir following, I said:

"Very well. How do we contact you?"

Dijkstra nodded and said:

"A little bird will find you at the Starry Night Inn, once it's safe."

Nodding, I headed out of the tent with Vesemir, but stopped before leaving, looking at Dijkstra, who was watching us go, and said:

"Quick question: about Princess Cirilla what would happen if you got your hands on her?"

Dijkstra looked at me, raising his eyebrows, and said with an amused smile:

"Why that question, witcher?"

I looked at him in silence and said:

"No reason. Just curiosity." Then, leaving the tent, clenching my fists, one single word stuck in my head: bastard.

POV Dijkstra

Watching the witchers leave, I wiped the smile off my face and walked over to my desk. I wrote up a message, wrapped it around a dove's leg, and sent it off. I watched the dove fly away, having already given my men orders to keep those witchers under constant watch once they reached Tretogor the younger one especially.

I smiled without meaning to, rubbing my face. I found that witcher interesting, even though he hid it fairly well the micro-expressions on his face when I brought up Cirilla, and the fact that, by the end, he'd let it slip they were connected somehow. I could only think of one name close enough to the princess: the famous knight who'd survived by her side.

But thinking about the growing pile of evidence pointing to Philippa, working with someone else, having orchestrated the king's assassination, I swore to myself I'd kill her even if I had to shut my heart off toward her to do it. As for this Radovid, growing

crazier by the day, I didn't know how Philippa had raised him as a child, but that boy needed a leash otherwise, I didn't dare imagine the future.

POV Aiden

We rode toward Tretogor with Vesemir, who asked me:

"What are you thinking about?"

I didn't look at him he was behind me and said:

"When exactly were you planning to tell me about Ciri?" Vesemir sighed and said: "Aiden, I…" But I cut him off: "No, forget it. For now, we focus on the mission, then we find Ciri. That work for you, Vesemir?"

He nodded and said:

"Very well." Then he continued: "You believe this Dijkstra?"

I laughed lightly and said:

"For the most part, he was telling the truth, that's for sure. But he already knows the culprit or at least has strong suspicions about who it is, and if you ask me, the real killer is Philippa. Which raises the question: why hasn't he acted yet? I see two possibilities: either she's genuinely more powerful than we think, which would surprise me, because I'm sure we'll be watched the moment we get to Tretogor or Philippa had someone else with her for this assassination, and it wasn't just some noble, but probably a king, or even another mage."

Vesemir looked at me, surprised, and said:

"How can you piece all that together from one conversation?" I shrugged and said: "When I was a kid, Queen Calanthe taught me politics and strategy, alongside Ciri, along with how to read micro-expressions. I still lack some self-control I'm sure he noticed I reacted when he mentioned Ciri, which probably made him suspicious about who I really am. And to answer your question, it's pretty simple: if he's stayed a famous master spy without ever slipping up, it's because he's extremely good at what he does, which means he'd never trust anyone that easily. Conclusion: he's definitely going to send his men to watch us."

Vesemir shook his head, amused, and said:

"Kids grow up fast, huh."

I smiled slightly, staring at the moon, and said:

"Sometimes I wish I hadn't grown up so fast. But that's life, I guess."

Vesemir stayed silent a moment, then said:

"We'll find Ciri, Aiden. Don't worry."

I said nothing but I hope so, Vesemir. I really do.

POV Ciri

Looking at the moon, my head resting on my knees, I hope to see you again, Aiden. I miss you so much. It's been so many years since we've seen each other, I've got so much to tell you, whether it's about Geralt, Triss, Yennefer, Margarita, or that strange voice in my head.

The voice said in my head, at that exact moment:

"Strange? Should I thank you for that, Ciri?" I laughed and said: "I don't know, I can't call you anything else you still won't give me your name."

The voice apologized, saying:

"Sorry, it's not time yet, I…" I cut it off, standing up, and said: "I know, I know, not time yet, blah blah blah." Reaching my mirror, I fixed my hair back into a ponytail properly I'd really grown, already 15, huh. Closing my eyes, I thought of him.

The voice spoke softly:

"You love him that much, huh." I didn't answer, and heading toward my door to leave, I saw Lydia, about to knock. Honestly, over the years, I'd gotten to know her despite her strange obsession with Vilgefortz, she was a sweet girl, and a friend.

Yes, a friend. She'd shown me her real face, and told me why she was cast out but honestly, it didn't scare me at all. Plus, she was a beautiful painter; she'd painted me several times. Our conversations often circled back to me and Aiden, and her and

Vilgefortz and above all, I knew she never revealed anything, because a few months back, I'd arrived early to Vilgefortz's lab and overheard their conversation.

Flashback

POV Ciri

Just as I was about to get noticed, I stopped behind some shelves, hearing Vilgefortz's and Lydia's voices. Vilgefortz, examining his potions some of which held my blood asked calmly:

"How's it going with Cirilla? Have you managed to get closer to her?"

Lydia, a bit more timid, said softly:

"Yes, sir, but I…" Vilgefortz cut her off: "Good, you're doing fine work, Lydia. Keep it up, and try to manipulate her into ditching that damned witcher who keeps getting in my way and it's only getting worse since Yennefer recovered from her injuries. Now I've got these three damned witches, that Triss, Yennefer, and even that damned Margarita, on my back too, on top of the witcher. It's driving me up the wall. So do as I say."

Lydia fell silent, then said quietly:

"But Ciri's kind, why would I do that, I…" Vilgefortz cut her off, slamming his hand on the table, saying coldly: "Kind? Does she even know about your real face? I'm sure she doesn't, otherwise she'd have already pushed you away." Vilgefortz stepped closer to her and, stroking her cheek, murmured: "I'm the only one who loves your true face. Don't forget, Lydia, that I am…"

But just as I thought Lydia was about to fall for it again, she pushed Vilgefortz's hand away, crying, and, gritting her teeth, said:

"She knows my face, and she's accepted it. Excuse me." She left the room in tears, without a single glance at Vilgefortz. I'd managed to hide before she walked out, and once she was gone, I heard Vilgefortz say coldly: "Filthy bitch. You're worth no more than a dog."

I gritted my teeth, thinking simply: bastard.

End of flashback

POV Ciri

I smiled at Lydia and said:

"How are you doing?" Lydia smiled and said: "Lady Margarita invited me for tea with Lady Merigold. They want to talk with me do you think I should wear something nicer? It's my first time being around such talented sorceresses, so I…"

I laughed, taking Lydia's hair, grabbing a hair tie from my desk drawer to pull it into a ponytail, and said softly:

"Don't worry. Margarita and Triss are incredibly kind, they just want to know more about my friend. Don't stress, okay?"

Lydia nodded and, taking my hands, said softly:

"Thank you, Ciri… I… I've never had a real friend before. Well, if you'll let me call you my friend." I smiled softly and said: "No, you don't get to." She looked at me, shocked, and before sadness could take over, I said: "I'm your best friend, not just your friend. So quit moping, okay?" Lydia smiled, nodded, and left happy.

That's when Vilgefortz arrived, Geralt and Yennefer following behind him. Lydia greeted Geralt and Yennefer respectfully, and didn't even glance at Vilgefortz as she left which made me smile, because Vilgefortz, even though he showed nothing, was seething with rage, I could tell.

After all, the voice was right: Vilgefortz had been using my blood for years now, but nothing was really moving forward on his end and me, I was getting a ton of use out of his resources. My teleportation kept improving, and I'd only told Geralt, Yen, and Triss about it, but I could feel myself starting to see an action a few milliseconds before it happened. It was a well-kept secret, but either way, my bloodline kept getting stronger. I'll get to see you again soon, Aiden.

Crossing my arms, I said, amused:

"So, Vilgefortz, still having trouble stomaching the idea of Lydia becoming a real woman?" Vilgefortz answered coldly: "If a bitch thinks putting on clothes makes her human, let her have her fun." He wasn't even hiding his hostility anymore, and neither was I, since I said simply: "Still a bastard, huh."

Yen shot back, shrugging, smiling with disdain:

"What do you expect, Ciri, Vilgefortz is like a eunuch he claims to know everything, but I'm sure aside from his mother's breasts, he's never touched a pair in his life." Geralt held back a smile, arms crossed. Vilgefortz didn't respond to Yennefer's remark and said simply: "No need to come tonight. The ball's happening this evening, so I need to get ready for the main event." He said it with a smile that made me uneasy, then left without another word.

Geralt watched him go, then smiled at me and said:

"Feel like coming to the party?" I shook my head and said: "No, honestly, all those fake smiles wear me out, you know that." Geralt shrugged, and I said, teasing: "At least you'll have a date with Triss for the evening."

Yen laughed and said:

"You're so right. You should see his face when Triss forces him into a doublet." I laughed along with her, much to Geralt's misfortune.

POV Vilgefortz

Blowing up my desk in a fit of rage with a spell, I thought: how dare they mock me, when I know the true history of this world?!

Chaos will soon be within my reach. All I need to do is kidnap that damned princess and bring her to that thing called the Observer, and I'll finally have the power I desire. I'll become the most powerful sorcerer this world has ever known, and...

A voice interrupted my rage sarcastic:

"Still blowing everything up, Vilgefortz? You sound like a child."

Regaining my impassive expression, I turned around and, looking at the woman, said:

"Philippa. Just a small experiment gone wrong. Did the assassination go smoothly?"

Philippa laughed coldly and said:

"Good thing I was there. That elf you gave me was garbage were you trying to make me fail, or what? Either way, the plan's moving forward: no more of those traitor mages

allied with Nilfgaard. Don't forget to capture Ciri for Radovid that little pawn will be perfect for the first mage-ruled kingdom we'll govern."

I smiled and said:

"Indeed. Everything's ready, don't worry."

Poor, foolish woman. She has no idea I've contacted Nilfgaard myself. I wonder who'll come out on top, her faction or Nilfgaard but either way, I intend to claim Ciri for myself alone. Poor, poor foolish woman.

41: Chapter 39 : Philippa's Laboratory and the Banquet at Thanedd

(I'm just writing this little thank-you note to reader Gabbu_Xul, who showed me that it really would be better to justify the three years. So today, if you go back and look at Chapter 35: "Aiden's Choice," you'll see it's been revised I added in the training he went through with Hisié, a narrative choice that makes more sense going forward. This way you understand why Aiden came out so much stronger after being trained nonstop for three years by Hisié that's what forges combat experience as well as a lot of his powers. Of course, I haven't forgotten my other readers who felt it was a shame he wasn't actually trained during those three years: well, there you go, it's fixed now.

And the second reason for this note is also to tell you: don't hesitate, like Gabbu_Xul did, to point out directly anything you find inconsistent, or even anything you think should be revisited. I love this fanfic and I really want you all to have the best time reading it.

Anyway, enjoy the read, and thanks again!)

POV Aiden

Drinking my glass at the tavern, Vesemir and I could see through the window that Tretogor was crawling with guards patrolling, looking pretty on edge, if I do say so myself.

Vesemir, finishing oiling his sword, said calmly, "Looks like the guard's pretty on edge." I nodded and replied, "Either Dijkstra sold us out, which is a possibility, or it's simply because Tretogor is naturally on high alert. After all, if we have to guess what the council in charge knows, they must have found out Radovid isn't dead."

It had been several days since we'd met with Dijkstra, and unless he thought we were weak, from the moment we arrived in Tretogor and more precisely at the inn he'd

pointed us to I'd noticed people watching us.

How did I know? Only thanks to Hisié's training. Ever since he trained me, I've come to understand the concept of winter better and better, and it gives me an enormous advantage, especially in this season: I can detect body temperatures, a bit like a snake with infrared vision, except it isn't in my eyes it's everywhere around me.

I don't sense heat directly, but its absence the cold that it pushes back. So the moment a living being is somewhere, I feel it in the way their warmth pushes the surrounding cold away. And that same presence, that same pocket of warmth, had stayed in the same spot for three days while we waited for Dijkstra's messenger. You didn't have to be a fool to figure out what that meant, and honestly, I'd expected as much Dijkstra doesn't trust anyone.

Vesemir looked at me and said, "We still haven't talked about what you're going to tell Geralt."

I sighed and, looking away from the window, said, "Did you have to bring it up?" Vesemir nodded, and resting my hand against my mouth, I said, "Honestly, I don't know. Do I hold it against him for not telling me anything? Yes. Do I hate him for it? No. I understand why he did it, but that doesn't mean I can just accept it."

Vesemir sighed and said, "You know he did it to keep you from getting in the way of your own goals, since you would've wanted to go with them." I nodded and said, "I know, no need to remind me. But I would've liked to at least be told that's the only thing I hold against him. I'm not saying I need to know everything he does, but at least about things like that, I would've liked to be informed."

Vesemir nodded silently, and a quiet settled over us for several minutes, until someone sat down beside us, hood pulled low, and said, "A little coin for these unfortunate gentlemen?"

Vesemir said nothing, but I studied the man's face: even caked in mud, it was recently applied mud, and despite the stench coming off him, I caught a faint whiff of lavender. Not entirely sure, but I thought I recognized Dijkstra's man, and I said, "Sorry, no."

The man's brow furrowed, visibly annoyed, and he stood up abruptly, knocking over Vesemir's empty glass as he snapped, "Bloody mutants!" before hurrying out of the inn. Vesemir sighed as he righted his glass, then felt something inside it. Looking closer, he pulled out a scrap of paper and read, "Apparently it's happening tonight at 10 p.m. The servants' door will be unlocked, and we'll have exactly five minutes to reach Philippa's laboratory."

I sighed, but nodded, and after paying the innkeeper, we got up from the table. I felt the people watching us rise right behind us. I exchanged a quick glance with Vesemir, who nodded, and we headed into an alley. I then felt the group split in two: one encircling us while the other stayed hidden. Then one of the men pulled back his hood, revealing he was an elf and in the same instant, we noticed several archers had us in their sights. The elf said, "Vatt'ghern, give us that paper."

I shook my head and said, "Honestly, no, and you know it." The elf shrugged and signaled his men to fire. With a simple snap of my fingers, I conjured a sphere of ice around Vesemir and me, and glancing at him, I said, "I'd like to avoid a bloodbath, that work for you?" Vesemir nodded, and I filled the sphere with fog. The moment I felt the arrows stop against the ice, the fog spread quickly through the whole alley, wrapping the elves in illusions I had to keep sustaining by hand I wasn't skilled enough yet to control them with thought alone. Taking advantage of the confusion, Vesemir and I slipped away down a side passage, weaving deeper into Tretogor's maze of streets until we were sure we'd lost anyone following us.

"That business with the paper backs up what Dijkstra suspects," I said once we were safe, catching my breath. "A document tied to Vizimir's death, demanded by elves that fits with the idea of a scapegoat set up in advance." Vesemir nodded without a word, clearly thinking the same thing.

A few minutes later, waiting for nightfall, I was leaning against the wall of a dark alley that reeked of vagrant piss, my eyes fixed on the servants' exit of the castle. I said, "By the way, you also think it's not a coincidence that an elf killed Vizimir, and that the ones who tried to attack us were elves too?" Vesemir shrugged and said, "It's been years since I stopped believing in coincidences."

I laughed lightly, and silence settled again. The hours passed, night fell with an intense chill setting in, and at exactly 10 p.m., the servants' door opened without anyone stepping out. After a glance exchanged with Vesemir and a nod, we pulled our hoods over our heads and slipped through the door, swords drawn. Inside, a map along with a note "a gift from a friend" showed the way to Philippa's laboratory, located in the castle's basement. We went down the staircase hidden behind the main one, and the atmosphere changed almost immediately.

After all, the moment we stepped in, we were already in a far more luxurious setting, and now the air smelled of dampness while the crackle of torches could be heard. Reaching the basement, we stopped at Philippa's door, and frowning, I said, "Be careful, that was the easy part. Behind this door I sense intense magic probably magical traps, or Philippa herself. Ready?"

Vesemir nodded and said, "Whenever you are." Then we stepped into Philippa's laboratory and dropped to the floor to dodge a fireball.

POV Geralt

I winced, tugging at my doublet way too tight for me when I felt hands wrap around me from behind and heard Triss's soft voice say, "You look wonderful, Geralt."

I smiled despite myself and said, "Sure, but know that I hate wearing this getup." Triss laughed, and as I turned around, I found her in a gorgeous gown with emerald earrings. Dazzled by her beauty, I simply said, "Wonderful."

She smiled and whispered in my ear, "I know. Don't worry, by the end of the night I'll let you tear it off." Then she took my hand, and we left her chambers to join the ball.

Arriving there, I had trouble hiding my disgust: the rumor about Ciri kept spreading further, and now everyone was staring at us, Triss and me, with greedy eyes after all, the rumor claimed, oddly enough, that we were the ones who'd brought her here.

I muttered under my breath, "I hate these parties where everyone whispers promises with a knife behind their back."

Triss sighed and rubbed her hand against mine, saying gently, "I know. Come on, let's go find Yen and Margarita over there." We nodded and ignored the people trying to approach us Triss politely brushing them off with a smile. Reaching Yennefer, she smiled and said, "Triss actually got you into a doublet? Nice work, Triss."

Margarita laughed softly, sipping her drink, and said, "Yennefer, I think you should stop teasing Geralt." Triss laughed too, and I sighed before being surprised to spot someone standing beside Margarita and Yennefer: even though Lydia had changed, I hadn't realized she'd make such an impression. Noticing my gaze, especially on her mask, Lydia smiled kindly and said, "You're probably curious about the mask." I nodded, and she continued without a trace of embarrassment, "Like Ciri, and even Lady Yennefer and Lady Margarita, I'm no longer ashamed of being afraid of my own face. But I wear this mask so I don't make things uncomfortable for those who wish to talk with you."

She laughed, a little sheepishly, and added, "Honestly, I was going to slip away, but Lady Margarita specifically asked me to stay." Margarita nodded, gently rubbing Lydia's back, and said, "And you were right to listen. Don't you dare think you're in our way we're all grown enough to choose who we want to be close to."

Yen nodded and said, "Margarita's right. And even though I've barely talked to you, if Triss and Margarita vouch for you, that means you're a good person." I smiled at Yen and said, "Wow, Yennefer of Vengerberg speaking such a lovely truth." Yennefer shot me a cold look but said nothing, taking a sip of her drink as she watched the dance floor.

Still smiling, amused by Yen's cold look, I turned to Margarita and said, curious, "We've barely talked, in spite of all the chances we've had."

Margarita smiled and said, "Of course, I don't mind getting to know Merigold's man better. How can I help?"

I smiled a little, mildly embarrassed by the phrase "Merigold's man," but said, "Why did you agree to put yourself in the crosshairs? After all, I'm sure you figured out who Ciri is a long time ago."

Margarita took a sip of her drink, then said, "You're right, I already had my suspicions. But why did I risk it? Because she was my student, and that's enough for me. I will always do everything I can to protect my students, no matter what politics or plotting is going on to me, teaching is the future."

I nodded and said, "Thank you for the answer... and for looking after Ciri. She's a handful, I can vouch for that." Margarita laughed and said, "Yes, but I appreciate her spirit."

Triss, who preferred to listen quietly, content simply to be near the people she loved, heard the music starting up. She looked at me and said gently, "Care to?" I sighed, but let her lead me along.

POV Yennefer

Watching Geralt and Triss dance, I... I still felt a faint fondness for Geralt, even if I didn't say so. But I knew it was fading, because even now, watching the two of them dance, all I felt was joy for Triss, happy to see her so radiant despite everything.

I wondered how Aiden would dance. I smiled a little, amused by the thought, when I heard Margarita say, "It's rare to see you smile, Yennefer." I glanced at her sideways and said, "I'm not a golem, I'm still human."

Margarita nodded, smiling, then added, "You're right. It's sad that we mages plot so much these days instead of teaching the next generation." I shrugged and said, "Our

times force us into it." Margarita nodded without saying anything more, but at that exact moment, after the dance ended, the door opened, and I saw Philippa, accompanied by Vilgefortz and Francesca, heading toward a particular corner of the ballroom, where a cluster of mages dressed in black, hoods drawn, stood waiting.

Setting down my glass, I said calmly, "Margarita, get Lydia somewhere safe, something's about to happen." I stepped toward Philippa and her group. I wasn't alone: Tissaia moved to stand between the two sides, while Geralt and Triss caught up with me.